hunger hurts, starving works

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/28858188.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Catra/Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra), Light Hope (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Fluff, Romantic Fluff, Slow Burn, friends to idiots to lovers, Anxious Adora (She-Ra), Lesbian Disaster Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra) in a Suit, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)'s A+ Parenting, Mild Hurt/Comfort, Light Angst, apologies to fiona apple, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Mutual Pining

Language:
English

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Iorek's Catradora Unputdownables

Stats:
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by petty_labelle

Summary

"Look, can I ask you something? It's your birthday so I don't know if you've set any boundaries on hook-ups but…"

"Hooking up?" And then Adora just can't stop, "Oh, no, I'm not hooking up. I mean. I have, but not now. Not, uh, a thing I do really. Um...yeah."

Catra is kind enough to try to hold back her smile.

"Well, you just made this super awkward," she breathes out. "I was gonna ask if your friend was single. You're hot and all. But every word out of your mouth has been a total bummer, not gonna lie."

Adora has died and gone to lesbian hell. She always knew it would come to this.

—

Adora Gray's life is on track, just the way she likes it – ever steady, no surprises. And then Catra Morgan crashes her birthday party and turns everything upside down by dating her best friend Glimmer and making Adora fall for her.

That's fine! Adora is not panicked at all, thank you very much. She has some detailed, multi-step plans to ignore her growing feelings and navigate this all. But Catra, and her past, have a pesky tendency of showing up and throwing everything for a loop.

Hunger hurts
But starving works
When it costs too much to love

Notes

aka some early 30s dorks fall in love and refuse to talk about it ever. Featuring: Catra in a lot of suits, some Glitra content, a bunch of cute non-dates, and a wild cub.

Rating will definitely change but not for a long time.

Posting on January 19 in honor of Adora's birthday, which sets the stage for our first meeting.

A Slow Burn. An Acquired Taste.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Yes, Adora Gray knows that it's a completely hack move to say that clubs suck. Now, with that acknowledged, clubs *suck* .

The lighting is too low and Adora's night vision is shit so she keeps bumping into those low stools, which are the only seating. That's not access-centered! She's pretty sure at least. Also the bass feels like she's getting heart palpitations. The drinks are expensive, even though everyone's buying them for her tonight.

It's her birthday. Adora's never been a birthday person. She got bounced around a lot as a kid and never had foster parents who paid much attention or time to make friends. By the time she was a teen and had some more stability, her foster mother wasn't much interested in celebrations. Or, really, fun of any kind.

Once adulthood hit, Adora mostly associated birthdays with going out to celebrate other people and having to talk to too many strangers. Her friends are all so likable and they have rec teams and co-workers and childhood besties and exes that she has to mingle with once or twice a year. Friend groups blending is unbelievably awkward.

Adora herself doesn't have many friends. Just that handful of folks she met in college and works with now. Also, she refused to throw a party this year so she should have been suspicious when Glimmer suggested they get drinks after work. But she's always a naive fool when it comes to Glimmer so that's how they ended up at a club at 7:00 pm, just Adora, her less than 10 friends, and the bartender that's still trying to set up and doesn't appreciate being stopped every five minutes to make a vodka soda. So this clubbing experience is particularly maudlin and awful, even by her standards.

Everyone else seems to be having fun though at least. Bow and Glimmer are dancing and keep trying to drag her into it. Perfuma's having an *excellent* time, her eyes so red that Adora wishes she could ask her for an edible just to zone out. The other random folks from work seem fine too. It's just Adora, trying to hold a fake smile so hard that her face hurts, who is feeling miserable.

“Oh, shit. Is this a wake?” a raspy voice whispers from the doorway. “Scorpia, you didn't tell me somebody died.”

“That's funny, Wildcat!” Adora recognizes the very loud voice of Perfuma's girlfriend. “But also very hurtful. Maybe try not to make that joke to anyone else?”

“I gotta be me, Scorp.”

It's a nice voice. Like a Natasha Lyonne-type.

Ooh, top ten crushes of Adora's teens and early twenties. She spends the next few minutes crafting this list in her head. It's been a coping mechanism since she was a kid – zoning out of anxious situations by cataloging random facts and info. It's a good way to burn time until it's acceptable to leave.

“What can I get you?”

“Hmm?” She glances up and the bartender is looking at her strangely.

“To drink,” they clarify. “How can I help you?”

“Adora, stop trying to buy your own drinks!” Glimmer screams from the dance floor.

If there were other people here, this would be deeply rude. Adora can’t help her disapproving head shake at her friend.

“Don't worry! I've got it,” Scorpia yells. Heavy footsteps start padding up to her. “Happy birthday, buddy!”

Adora has just enough time to turn around before Scorpia lifts her up into a huge hug. Adora used to think that she herself was pretty strong. And then she met her friend's girlfriend Scorpia six months ago and nearly had an identity crisis.

“Thanks,” she squeaks out, short on breath.

“Jeez, Scorp. I was just kidding about the wake thing. Don't actually kill the poor girl.”

If Adora was on her feet, she'd probably be startled and topple over another stool. The newcomer must have silent footsteps. Or, she realizes, they're in a loud club and she's tipsy.

Scorpia lets the blonde go, immediately rubbing the back of her own neck with a pincer in embarrassment.

“Sorry about that, Adora. Just excited! Thanks for inviting me! Hope it's okay that I brought my best friend. This is Catra.”

With her pincer, she gestures to the right of her. Scorpia's dressed in a suit, which isn't unusual for anytime they meet her after work. Adora usually thinks she looks quite handsome in her professional clothes, especially with her undercut.

But holy fucking shit, Scorpia looks like she's wearing basically rags next to the fucking *supermodel* she brought with her. A lean, bronze cat hybrid with two different colored eyes (one cerulean, one *gold*), wild curly brown hair, and way too cool posture, who's wearing the absolute hell out of the grey windowpane suit and black button-down combo that she's sporting. Adora's always hated black dress shirts on people – it makes them look like they smell like Axe body spray – but Catra pulls it off.

Adora feels as if she looks like a middle school sub next to Catra.

“Hi!” Adora greets her, voice sounding several pitches too high. She swallows and tries to not fully embarrass herself. “I'm Adora. Nice to meet you, Catra.”

She half-smirks in response. “You too. Happy birthday. Let's get you a shot.”

Catra turns to the bartender before Adora can reply. It sounds like she orders shots for a crowd four times the size of their group. All tequila. Adora hates tequila after a terrible freshman year experience in college. She also doesn't do shots.

“None for me, thanks,” she tells the bartender. “Can you just get me a vodka soda please?”

“I can’t interest you in just one shot?” Catra asks.

When Adora looks at her, she’s so shocked by being examined in that intense gaze that she freezes up for a second. She has to shake her head to force herself to snap out of it. Catra just tilts her head curiously and smiles wider.

“I bought the good stuff,” she sing-songs.

Adora shakes her head, maybe a bit more firmly than she needs to to get the point across. “No, I’m alright.”

She’s surprised that Catra immediately drops it and shrugs. When she turns to the bar to pay for their drinks, Catra drops her credit card. It’s gold and it’s so heavy that it lands with a thud on the bar.

Oof. Adora always forgets that Scorpia’s friends are all rich lawyers and tech people. Of course Catra looks so great. She’s had everything handed to her. Like those major donors Adora's spent the last two months trying to court, getting rejected by wealthy assholes that have no idea of the real needs of folks who don’t have their cushy lives.

Adora, drowning in debt, gladly accepts the free drink that Catra passes her. She says thanks to be kind and then promptly turns away from her and goes to the dance floor. It’s probably the last place she’d like to be but it’s the only viable option. Unfortunately, that gives Glimmer the opportunity to pull her into an awkward

three-person dance triangle with her and Bow. Adora sways poorly and tries to make sucking down her cocktail into a dance move.

"Who's that girl Scorpia brought?" Glimmer asks. "She's hot."

Adora makes a non-committal sound. "Her friend. Said her name was Catra."

Bow coos. "That's such a cute name!" He's doing some sort of body roll situation that's very distracting.

Glimmer's looking at Catra so Adora thinks it's safe to take a second glance. Huge mistake. Catra's just staring back at them quizzically, while she holds a tray of shots that Scorpia's fumbling to hand out to their friends. Adora sees Catra say something to her buddy then jerks her head in the direction of the dance floor. Now they're heading over with the remaining drinks. Nowhere to hide anymore.

"Stop panicking," Glimmer whispers to her harshly. "Why are you panicking? It's your birthday. Can we have one nice day where you're not absolutely *hopeless* around an attractive woman?"

There's a lot of ways to go with this. For some reason, Adora goes with a horrible lie. "She's not attractive."

Glimmer and Bow laugh directly in her face. So the first thing Catra sees when she walks over, looking like everyone else in the world should just *give up* on suits altogether, is Adora's friends cruelly shaming her.

They exchange introductions and shots while Adora stands there, pretending to be a tree. Just a tree on the dance floor. Pay it no mind.

"Adora, you have to take a shot," Glimmer tells her, suddenly noticing the foliage that appeared next to her. Bow nods enthusiastically. Adora declines. "Come on. It's your 33rd birthday. That's a lucky number."

“I don’t think it’s *lucky* in any cultures,” Adora absently replies. “Lots of religious connections though. Some bad. Also it’s a thing in numerology but I never understood any of that when your one ex tried to explain it to me.”

Glimmer groans. A shot is placed very close to Adora's mouth. People don’t usually decline offers from Glimmer Moon for a reason. Adora takes the shot to avoid any conflict. Catra’s right – it’s the good stuff and it goes down smoothly.

“That’s the only one for tonight,” she tells Glimmer sternly. She finds it’s important to set clear boundaries with her friend. They won’t be heard but there’s hope for maybe one day.

Scorpia disappears with the tray. Adora’s not really sure how this happens but somehow she ends up dancing with (really, next to, awfully) Bow, while Glimmer and Catra fall into conversation. Her friend is laughing loudly and standing way closer than necessary to the newcomer soon. By the time that Adora’s sweating and her feet are starting to hurt (thanks, 33!), the other two are dancing and staring at each other intensely.

“I’m gonna go catch my breath!” she yells at Bow, loud enough that she thinks it might startle Catra and Glimmer.

It does not. Bow is kind enough that he accompanies her back to the rest of their group. She sees him glance back a few times towards the new coupling though.

The next hour goes by in a blur thankfully. Classic party stuff. People talk about work. Make awkward conversation about what they’re watching or reading or doing on the weekends for fun. Adora answers when asked but doesn’t get too engaged. She tries to list as many episode names of her favorite shows in her mind as possible. She’s calling a cab at 9:30 on the dot, already emotionally preparing herself for surge pricing.

Eventually, she takes a break from all the hanging out to grab a cup of water. The club is starting to fill up now so it takes her a bit

longer than her last trip to get a drink.

“Birthday girl,” she hears Catra say behind her. Completely unconcerned with all the other people waiting elbow-to-elbow for service, Catra pushes her way next to Adora. “Having a good time?”

“Yeah, it’s cool.” Adora aims for casual. She’s never pulled off casual and Catra’s amused face tells her that she overshot it once again.

“Cool,” the other woman repeats back to her. “Let me get you a drink.”

“Just water please.”

“No problem.” Catra, of course, just sticks out her hand and immediately a bartender is there.

“So, you’re a Capricorn, right,” she starts up again as they take their glasses back to where everyone else is congregating. Adora just nods. “You don’t believe in numerology. Do you believe in astrology?”

The blonde fights to not roll her eyes. She’s sure the stars and everything are important to lots of people but it’s always been a little too woo woo for her. Also, a lot of people get really turned off if she says she’s a Capricorn. It’s kinda an unfair rap.

“Not really,” she shrugs.

“Well, you’re the cardinal earth sign so that makes sense,” Catra smiles.

Adora feels like she’s being made fun of. But not in a mean way?

“Yeah, that’s more than I already know,” she replies.

“What’s your issue with astrology?”

“Mostly that people use it as short-hand now instead of getting to know each other. Or use it as an excuse for their behavior. Though, my favorite is how broad all of it is but somehow deeply resonates so much with each individual person, no matter how different they are. I had a friend once who got her moon and venus signs incorrect for years because she misremembered what time she was born and she claimed it changed her life when she learned her ‘correct’ chart.”

Catra gives her a look that she can’t quite decipher. Then shrugs with a chuckle and looks away to sip her drink.

Great. So the game plan for talking to this deeply gorgeous woman is to ramble and offend her beliefs. Adora’s trying to think of how to...well, not necessarily *backpedal* because she’s not wrong, but smooth things over maybe, when Catra glances back at her. She’s biting her lip just a bit and for the first time, Adora notices how long and sharp her fangs are. She hopes her sudden intake of breath isn’t audible. Cat hybrids have really good hearing though, as some cursory research has taught her.

Catra licks her lips next. “Look, can I ask you something?” Adora dumbly nods. “It’s your birthday so I don’t know if you’ve set any boundaries on hook-ups but…”

This stunning being wants to hook up with her? That feels impossible to believe. No, that never happens. Adora doesn’t make a good first impression. She knows this about herself. She’s a slow burn. An acquired taste. Also, it’s almost 9:30 and she should really get out of here. Plus, economic justice or something. She doesn’t totally remember what her point was earlier. She might not still be breathing.

“Hooking up?” she almost chokes on the words. And then she just can’t stop, “Oh, no, I’m not hooking up. I mean. I *have* , but not now. Not, uh, a thing I do really. Um...yeah.”

Catra is kind enough to try to hold back her smile.

“Well, you just made this super awkward,” she breathes out. “I was gonna ask if your friend was single and if you’d instituted a rule about no one going home with anyone until you’re safely in bed or something.”

With her drink, Catra motions towards where Glimmer is talking to a circle of their acquaintances, everyone enraptured by her story. Catra gives Adora a onceover with her eyes.

“You're hot and all, like a gay angry Brandi Chastain. But every word out of your mouth has been a total bummer, not gonna lie.” She manages to say this all kindly somehow. “Shimmer has a spark, though. That's kinda my type – mouthy femmes. In every sense of the word.” Catra finishes with a wink.

Adora has died and gone to lesbian hell. She always knew it would come to this.

“I want to get drinks with you some time though and hear the full list of things you’re annoyed by,” Catra adds. “You’re pretty funny. Not intentionally of course.”

Adora forces herself to laugh. That’s an apt description. Catra’s not being rude. Catra asked her to hang out. It’s much easier to focus on this instead of how mortifying the rest of this conversation is.

“N-no,” she stammers. “Glimmer’s single. Completely free to date whoever she wants. People can leave together whenever the spirit moves them.” What the hell is she talking about?

Catra looks at her oddly, which is understandable.

Adora’s alarm goes off on her phone. It’s officially her scheduled time to exit her own birthday celebration.

She places her empty glass on a table, telling Catra, “Getting drinks sounds fun. I’ll get your number from Scorpia. I gotta head out though. Thanks for coming.”

She’s sure all of those words come out in one long sentence but she just waves to Catra as she grabs her jacket stealthily and leaves. This isn’t weird because she’ll never see Catra again.

Adora sees Catra again the next Sunday. Glimmer had gathered everyone together for what she claimed was ‘brunch’ but was actually bar food and beers in a new brewery. It was a really nice space. Adora found reading the specifications of all the beers to be a good distraction from interacting with other people.

She was seated towards the end of an indoor picnic table with Perfuma on the left and Bow directly across from her. Glimmer and Catra were at the other end but she could hear every single time that the former laughed. It didn’t make sense for this sound to be suddenly grating to Adora but it was.

Apparently, at the end of her party, the two did not go home together but they had exchanged numbers. They texted throughout the week. Adora’s pretty sure that this last-minute brunch was just an excuse for Glimmer to see Catra again without asking her on a real date. The issue with both working with her best friend and living in the same building as her is that Adora’s heard a lot about Catra in the past week. She actually sounds like a super cool person. Funny and smart and candid. Deeply out of Adora’s league, so good for Glimmer.

Adora excuses herself when she sees that the brewery has games. She’s playing Pac-Man alone when Catra joins her. Thank the Gods that she has the decency to not be in a suit today. Instead, she’s in an oversized grey crewneck sweater and tight dark blue high-waisted jeans. Adora thinks she looks so cozy and cute so she has to shove that thought down before Catra can read it on her face. Adora’s outfit, she realizes, is oddly similar.

“We look like girlfriend twins,” is what the other woman opens with.

Adora chuckles, without looking away from the game. She's decided that it must be the suits that are so intimidating.

"It's a common weekend uniform, I think," she replies. "I like your sweater. Looks super cozy."

"It is!" Catra's very excited to confirm. "I own it in like 6 different colors."

"Do you do that a lot? Buy a bunch of the same thing?"

Catra pauses to consider this. "In non-work clothes, yeah sometimes."

"I own about 15 copies of the same outfit. It's almost all I wear. So easy."

Catra leans against the game machine, placing herself in Adora's peripheral vision. "That little black blouse, gray trousers number you had on last week? What are you? Like the lesbian Steve Jobs of non-profit executive directors?"

Adora immediately is eaten and dies. In the game, to be clear, but possibly also in reality. Catra remembered what she was wearing last week. Catra knows what she does for a living.

"How do yo-"

"Glimmer told me," Catra says. "Well, she was telling me where she works and then she had a whole tangent about how you founded a leadership development space for youth in the system and what a genius you were, yada yada. I guess the uniform is part of the genius persona."

"It's just easier. I'm usually in a hurry. It's nice to be efficient."

Catra just nods with a smile.

"Do you want to play?" Adora asks. Catra's eyes light up in a way that makes the blonde think she might get teased a bit, until Catra

decides to nod instead and move to the controls. Adora steps back to give her space.

"You know, when Glimmer told me about you, I made a rude assumption," Catra shares. She's effortlessly doing much better at the game than Adora was.

"Yeah, what was that?"

"Well, I didn't *say* anything to her but I...I guess I assumed that you were this fancy white woman with a savior complex who started this charity to rescue a bunch of marginalized youth from 'the streets' or whatever." Adora's about to open her mouth to loudly protest, when Catra continues. "But I looked you up. I mean, yeah, you've got a PhD and everything but I found a couple articles where you talk about growing up in the system and some of what you went through."

Though the game's still going, and Catra has more than doubled Adora's score, she stops and turns away from it, leaning back on the console to face Adora.

"I'm similar. Grew up in a foster home my whole life. Have a fancy degree too now, though." She pauses to consider. "Is it weird that I'm glad to meet someone who kinda went through similar shit?"

Adora can't fight her small smile. "Not weird at all. Um...same, I guess, for me."

Catra smiles in response. "Cool. Do you play Connect 4?"

"Can I be completely honest with you?" Adora asks. She's not sure when she decided to feel a whole lot more comfortable in Catra's presence but she's going with it.

Catra nods.

"I am absolutely vicious in Connect 4," Adora tells her with a straight face, somehow.

“No shit?” Catra pretends to be wowed. “Well, this I’ve gotta see.”

Catra’s in her office. Not like in Adora's actual office where she works, but Catra’s in the building. In the lobby, just hanging out and waiting for Glimmer to be done with work so they can have their second official date. The first, which Glimmer spared no detail on, was drinks at some cutesy place that she picked. The second one is dinner at a place that Catra’s picking and Glimmer has been so excited about it that she won’t shut up. Bow’s been twitchy all week.

Today, Catra’s wearing a caramel-colored three-piece suit with a white shirt and tan chelsea boots. She looks so out of place sitting on their fraying couch in their horribly lit lobby reading two-year old magazines. When Adora has to walk by, which she delays for as long as possible because of the suit and the person wearing it, Catra immediately looks up and catches her eye. Adora had watched 4 other people walk by. Catra hadn’t looked up a single time then.

“*Hey*, Adora,” Catra draws out those two words like honey.

“Hi,” she returns. Catra’s wearing glasses today, thin round gold rims that should dim the effect of her eyes but somehow just spotlight them instead.

“In a hurry?”

Adora shakes her head. “I have to check in on a couple instructors but I have a few minutes.”

Catra motions for her to sit. They shoot the shit about their weeks, random things happening in their lives. Nothing too deep. If Adora doesn’t look directly at Catra, she can allow herself to remain mostly calm. The cadence of Catra’s voice is pretty soothing actually. She’s not a fatalist like Adora but she’s realistic and honest, even kind in her own way. It’s a fascinating mix.

Glimmer eventually interrupts them to announce she’s finally done with her last bit of work and ready to go. Adora and Catra both look at their watches and realize that it’s been 45 minutes since they sat down to talk.

“Fuck!” Catra yells. Then she immediately looks around to make sure none of the youth are there. “Sorry. I didn’t mean to keep you so long.”

Adora shrugs, like this isn’t the first time that this has happened to her, “Not a big deal.” She’s just already processing how she’ll stay an hour late to make it up to everyone. It does not matter that no one else likely noticed or cared about what just happened.

Glimmer looks like she wants to ask why Adora is acting so uncharacteristically. But she takes one look at Catra and abandons her best friend of 15 years.

“Okay, good night, Adora!” She literally pulls Catra from the room.

“You should actually call me about that drink,” Catra yells over her shoulder.

Chapter End Notes

so this is mostly falling slowly in love, freaking out about it constantly, fluff, and navigating some very light drama. it's probably the softest gayest thing i've written in a long time.

will usually update on fridays until my other multi-chapter fic is done. the chapters for this story are a lot shorter (and there are so many more, oh god why) so i hope to move to bi-weekly updating when i'm down to just one story.

Putting in the Work

Chapter Summary

Bow panics. Catra reaches out.

Chapter Notes

thanks to all the folks who read and engaged with the first chapter!

we're easing into it in this one. lots of talking, lots of texting, lots of bow-torturing.

The fake org Adora founded is called Leadership Advancement Project cause that's a bunch of vague words that don't tell you anything. Anyway, I realized Catra mocks the acronym but no one's even said the name of the place so it makes very little sense.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra and Glimmer have scheduled their third date for Thursday. Adora tunes out the details cause Bow is in the kitchen, slamming pots and pans. She doesn't think it's intentional, just that he's maybe so stressed that he can't figure out hand-eye coordination.

Third dates aren't a big deal. But Glimmer is so... *enthralled* by Catra or something that it's rattling Bow big time. It's not really just infatuation. There's clearly some sexual tension. Mostly Glimmer's just very interested in discussing specific phrases that Catra said to her and what they might mean or a gesture that she made or some thrown-out fact about her life. It kinda sounds like Glimmer isn't sure if she wants to *date* Catra or she wants to *be* Catra when she's all grown up. They're all expected to play pop psychologists to this person they barely know.

Bow has had it. He refuses to say anything though, just pretending to go through with cooking dinner.

“Then she texted back ‘I bet you’d look amazing in that’ but, like, literally 2 seconds later,” Glimmer says. Adora lost the thread of this conversation so far back.

“What do you think she meant?” is the go-to follow-up.

Glimmer balls her fists and slams them down on the couch next to her. “I don’t know! Like, is she saying I should get the outfit? Is she saying that she’d like me to wear it for her?”

“Maybe she’s just saying you would look nice in it if you were really interested in buying it?” Adora offers. “You did say she was pretty straight forward, right?”

“Well, yeah,” she agrees. “But what if that’s just how she comes off and it’s not really her? I feel like she’s more mysterious than I originally thought. I never thought I’d be into that but it’s kinda hot not to always be 100% sure what she’s thinking.”

It sounds kinda like Bow throws a pot across the kitchen. Interesting that Glimmer doesn't seem concerned about knowing what he’s thinking.

“You should probably text her back,” Adora suggests. “And I’ll go help Bow with dinner.”

Glimmer’s on her phone before Adora even finishes her sentence.

In the kitchen, Bow is, well, distracted. She’s pretty sure that he was making roasted chicken and vegetables, Adora's favorite. There’s no food on the counter or in the oven.

“Can I give you a hand?”

“No, it’s all under control.” His voice is strained and he won’t turn around from where he’s facing the empty, probably not even turned on oven.

Adora approaches him slowly and places a hand gently on his back.

“How are you doing with all this?”

Bow glances at her with a grimace. “It’s fine. I mean, it’s *not* . But it kinda has to be, you know?”

Adora nods.

She realized maybe two weeks into knowing Bow and Glimmer, who had been best friends since pre-school, that they were in love with each other. She almost never realizes things like that. That’s how obvious it was.

Over the next few months, she learned that Bow definitely knew how he felt about Glimmer, but didn’t want to risk de-stabilizing a friendship that had been a keystone of his life for so long. She learned that Glimmer felt something though she couldn’t quite articulate it and she would never act on it unless Bow made a move. Adora had lived through over a decade of them pining for each other. It was surprisingly chill and not overwrought. They had both casually seen other people and nothing like this had ever happened before.

“You seem maybe a little more annoyed than other times,” Adora points out.

“I know!” Bow whisper-shouts. “I don’t know why. I mean, yes, Catra’s like the coolest person that Glim’s ever had an actual thing for. I just feel like she’s already picturing Catra in her life. We talked about renting a cabin for a long weekend and she said she wondered what Catra would wear to the country.”

Well, shit, now that’s all Adora can think about too. Maybe an off-the-shoulder flannel? Do they make that?

“I think she’s having fun and she wants to keep the fun going,” Adora tries to excuse away.

Bow seems to consider that. He makes some progress towards dinner by actually removing the food from the fridge at least.

"Do *you* like Catra?" he asks quietly.

"...I think she's attractive," Adora replies. This is all she will allow.

"Glim says she asks about you all the time. Just like how you're doing, what your interests are, how you feel about whatever Glimmer's complaining about."

That's normal, right? Then why does Adora feel like she's breaking out in a sweat?

"Hmm."

"I don't know if it means anything. Like maybe Glimmer was telling me that to let me know she's not 100% fully into the relationship?"

"It's only been a couple of dates," Adora reminds him. "Let's all work on directly talking to each other and not guessing what everyone's secret thoughts and feelings are, maybe."

This is not hypocritical because she has avoided thinking about Catra's motivations, including just now that she's learned Catra *asks* about her, by pretending that the woman doesn't exist. Bow and Glimmer should give that a try.

"Work is slowing down a bit," Bow comments. "Think you might start dating again?"

Adora laughs. "I think the people of this city are still scarred from the last time. The horrors I subjected them to – hours of awful, rambling small talk. The world's most uninspired date ideas."

"The escape room could have been cute."

"I swear I didn't know she was claustrophobic!"

That gets a genuine chuckle out of Bow at least and they're able to move onto making fun of Adora's failed attempts at romance. He starts to actually make dinner and by the time that Glimmer

enters the room, talking about Catra's responses to her texts, they've both calmed down enough to just ignore her until she decides to call Perfuma for advice.

"I mean, she's dating Catra's best friend," Glimmer reasons. "She'd know best."

"True," Adora replies.

She considers telling her friend to direct all Catra-related quandaries to Perfuma but the idea of knowing nothing about the woman bothers her too much for some reason.

A couple of days later, Adora awakes from her typical night of anxiety-riddled sleep to texts from an unfamiliar contact.

Unknown Number
1:41 am
Say I found a place that has GIANT connect four
Could I lure you out with free drinks?
Perfuma gave me your number btw i was getting grays waiting

Adora
7:12 am
I think you could pull off grays

Does it sound flirty? Maybe? She blames it on the early hour. She's half-asleep so she can't be held responsible for her text responses. Besides, Catra would look so fucking distinguished with gray hair, in her suits and her glasses.

Adora gets up to go for a quick run before work. By the time she's back and getting into the shower, she sees that there's new messages.

Catra
8:09 am
I'm flattered. Honestly, I've always wanted to go grey so I feel really seen right now

Adora
8:11 am
I know you're being sarcastic but I'll accept that i unintentionally affirmed you nonetheless.
I see you. I hear you. You are welcome here.

Catra
8:26 am
Well, now you're just being a dick

Adora
8:29 am
I hope you're not texting and driving. It's very dangerous.

Catra
8:31 am
Yes! I love to start my human interactions with reminders about car safety
Tell me the one about 10 and 2

Adora
8:34 am
Do you know the statistics about text-related accidents?
Because I will send you several articles

Catra
8:36 am
Woah woah, I don't usually get to the dirty talk so early
I'm seeing someone right now
I don't think they'd approve of the sexy safety content you're trying to show me

Okay, this was definitely flirting but bringing Glimmer in as a speed bump. Before she could let herself fall into the trap of wondering about Catra's motives, Adora closes her phone and goes back to getting ready for work.

It was a fine day and nothing too awful happened. Classes were going well. They still only had 4 full-time staff folks though so

anything that wasn't done properly or needed special attention, had to be taken on by one of them. Adora usually drew the short straw. Or rather, Adora usually volunteered herself to do it, often without telling others that she was adding more stuff to her plate.

It was still relatively early in the year but she was already beginning to feel a little burnt out. Glimmer and Bow weren't doing much better themselves and the Catra-sized hole in all of their conversations was keeping them from really talking more deeply with each other, decompressing, replenishing their personal capacities.

And so, Adora decided, what the hell?

Adora
3:28 pm
So this is annoying and I apologize
GIANT connect four sounds amazing
You wouldn't happen to be free tonight, would you?

She didn't have time to panic over whether or not this was a good decision.

Catra
3:29 pm
Left me hanging all day
and then come back with demands to meet in THREE hours?
Yes, Adora, lord and liege, I can take you tonight after work

Because logistics are Adora's greatest passion, she forces Catra to help her come up with a plan to prevent drunk driving. They'll both leave their cars at work, take cabs to the bar, their respective homes, and then back to work tomorrow morning. She makes Catra send her the address and a short, scheduled part of her late afternoon is spent reading reviews, picking out what she wants from the food menu, googling unfamiliar words on the beer menu, and trying to decide which section of the bar is the best to sit in.

Totally off-handedly, Adora mentions to Bow and Glimmer, once she can get them both in the same room, that she and Catra are doing a 'getting to know you friend hang'. She's not sure why she felt the need to phrase it that way. Or why she's nervous under Glimmer's searching gaze suddenly.

Their faces have a lot of questions; fortunately, their mouths don't open to ask them. Glimmer gives her a strained smile and an awkward hug. Bow gives her a thumbs up and a punch on the arm that seems oddly genuine and relieved.

Adora gets there early because punctuality is important and because her anxiety manifests in really specific ways, don't judge her. There's a handful of people there already. Adora has plenty of time to look at booths and long tables and high tops and decide which is the best, based on proximity to the bar, space needed for games and food, distance from other patrons, and any drafts that might come through the door or overhead vents. After a quick survey, Adora is content that she's found the perfect table and plants herself there to review what she's learned about beer and how it can be utilized when selecting one of their many taps here. Who knows? Maybe Catra will be impressed.

Catra strolls in 12 minutes after their agreed upon time and does not acknowledge that she's late. She's wearing a hunter green suit with a gold silk blouse, colors that remind Adora of the comfort of a nice fall day. She will now also not be mentioning that Catra was late.

Catra doesn't say hello. She just sits down and jumps right in. "I hope the food is okay here. I noticed you didn't eat anything off that greasy menu when we went to the brewery."

Again, Catra noticing things about Adora. Her face starts to heat up.

"Yeah, thanks for thinking of that," Adora chances a smile at her but Catra's responding grin is too beautiful to look directly at for long so she has to quickly avert her eyes towards her menu.

“What’s your food thing?” Catra asks.

“Boring and lean? Mostly meats and veggies, low carb, low fat, low grain. I got into it when I was playing sports in school and never broke the habit.”

Catra tsks sadly in response.

“Guilty pleasure foods?”

“Dark chocolate sometimes. Vegan ice cream. Alcohol.”

“You poor, lost child. What sports did you play?”

Unconsciously, Adora feels her biceps flex. Catra definitely notices or else she sees a delicious plate of food walk by Adora’s arm at the exact same time cause she stares in that general direction for a minute, almost beginning to drool.

“Basketball, football, softball. I tried a few others but those are the ones I kept up with for years. Every once in awhile, I’ll convince myself that joining one of the queer leagues will give me a chance to meet more people, maybe get some dates. Doesn’t usually work out though.”

“Really?” Catra seems very skeptical.

Adora shrugs. She feels like she can be real with this woman.

“I don’t make a great first impression. I can’t really cram all of the things people should like about me into 45 minutes. Especially not into 5 minutes when you meet someone and have to garner their interest immediately. I’m also just not in a lot of people’s desire spectrum. Current company included. I was never the right kind of softball dyke or the right kind of social justice queer.”

“I can’t imagine that you don’t encompass the whole of many women’s desire spectrum,” Catra replies, running her eyes all over Adora.

Adora isn’t too down on herself or looking for sympathy. Besides, she wants to know more about Catra instead of having the woman try to make her feel better about her dating life.

“What about you? What’s your food stuff? Guilty pleasure foods? Sports?”

Catra must hear the eagerness in her voice because she smiles, before taking a moment to think.

“Hm. Don’t give me salad unless you want to fight. I'm lactose intolerant but I wasn't raised to be a quitter so," she shrugs in a silly way that Adora almost finds too charming. "I love seafood and steaks and rice and beans. Really, all meats. Guilty pleasures? Once or twice a year, I’ll eat some overprocessed awful food that I always wanted as a kid but couldn’t afford. Whenever I bake at home, I end up eating the entire dessert by myself in less than a weekend.”

“You bake?” Adora asks with some surprise.

Catra points an accusatory finger. “People are always so shocked when they learn that! Why do I not look like a baker?”

Adora shakes her head, not finding a real answer.

Satisfied, Catra says, “I believe you were the person who warned me against painting people with a broad brush instead of getting to know them.”

“Hey, I’m putting in the work here,” Adora teases.

Catra gives her a pleased smile. “That you are.”

“So you bake?”

“My court-appointed therapist suggested it when I was in high school,” Catra replies. “Apparently focusing on cookie dough is a good substitute for punching handsy straight boys in the face.”

There's...a lot in that sentence and they haven't even ordered drinks yet. Adora decides to just move past it.

"How about sports?"

Catra makes a brief face that Adora can't figure out. "I was a pretty decent skater, went to State in track, did gymnastics and dance for years. Briefly dabbled in volleyball."

"We were both very busy kids."

"Yeah," Catra nods, "seems like we both had plenty of reasons to not be home."

Adora nods too, a knowing look passing between them.

Then a random question comes to her that she's been dying to figure out. "You're a lawyer. How are you so free? You get out of the office before us *and* you had this whole evening open?"

Catra smirks. "Delegation. I am a grand master at delegating tasks and project managing."

Adora can't even wrap her head around this. " *How* ? I spend most of my time buried in work."

"Stick with me, kid, and I'll teach you my ways," she says in a tone that's suggestive enough to make Adora's mouth go dry. "You didn't hit me up just to talk about work, did you?"

Catra sounds almost disappointed. That can't be right.

"I honestly just wanted to hang and blow off steam." Adora pauses and then feels like she should add on, "Focus on some games and...getting to know you better."

Catra leans forward on the table, getting a bit closer to Adora. "Good. Me too."

Catra
10:17pm
Here's the thing

Adora
10:18pm
Oh no

Catra
10:21pm
Ok, be like that
i won't tell you what the thing is

Adora
10:21pm
Ok. hi catra. Hope you had a nice day today.
What's the thing?

Catra
10:22pm
I'm going to start my own colony.

Adora
10:25pm
...are you in a cult?

Catra
10:27pm
No, i'm a queer separatist.
I'm inviting you
With those arms, we'll be able to have wood and shit

Adora
10:27pm
I think a lot of that is in the lats

Catra
10:28pm
Well, how are your lats or whatever the fuck that is?

Adora
10:28pm
Pretty decent.

Catra
10:28pm
I can’t believe you corrected me just so you could brag about your muscles
You in or nah?

Adora
10:33pm
Who else is invited?

Catra
10:34pm
Did you just ask ‘who all gone be there’
About my fucking separatist queer colony
Invitation rescinded
Dream killer
This is what i get for being nice to people

Adora
10:36pm
This was you being nice???

Catra
10:39pm
Fuck off
I should’ve known it would end like this
I just realized the other day that you’re such a jock that you named your org LAP
Like you couldn't think of a non-sports word
You don’t even do sports work!

Catra
12:08am
Shit sorry, did I piss you off?

Are we close enough that I can mock your life's work yet
It's really important work

Adora
1:15am
We're called LAP cause systems-involved youth are being LAPPED by privileged kids

Catra
1:17am
Bravo
You absolutely made that shit up just now
Can't even hate

Adora
1:17am
What are you doing up?

Catra
1:17am
Pretending to try to sleep
Ate some snickerdoodles that i shouldn't
Having a staring contest with my cat

Adora
1:19am
Cat?

Adora, buried under the covers in bed but nowhere near asleep, sits up to see what picture Catra's just sent. She does not hold her breath. When she opens the image, she sees the fluffiest, angriest gray cat. They look pissed off from possibly having been woken up for this photo op.

Adora examines the background, in a way that could be considered curious and not creepy. The cat is on a very plush looking plaid comforter. She can just barely see what appears to be the leg of Catra's pajamas, a baby blue that looks too precious

to be something that her friend would wear non-ironically. Adora *thinks* they're friends now, at least.

Adora
1:21am
The floof!

Catra
1:23am
Yeah
they're a dick

Adora
1:23am
Aren't all cats?

Catra
1:24am
Hey
Watch it
I know where you work

Adora
1:25am
Yeah, I should probably go to sleep
So I can make it to said work tomorrow
Goodnight, Catra

Catra
1:25am
Night, Adora
Sweet dreams
Ugh I thought I could pull that off but its too creepy
Ignore

Chapter End Notes

the next chapter is called 'sex date.' truly, what more can i say than that?

Sex Date

Chapter Summary

> Glimmer and Catra are having a fourth date. Bow and Adora are having a breakdown.

Chapter Notes

> Yooo, thanks to everyone for all the kind comments on the first couple chapters. Everyone is here for mess and I respect that.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Obviously all four of them were on a path towards destruction.

Okay, maybe Adora isn't really involved in any way. From the outside, this is clearly about Bow and Glimmer and Catra. Adora's just the weird nosey dyke in the corner, eavesdropping.

So fine, the *three* of them were on a path towards destruction.

As a general rule, Adora didn't meddle in people's lives. She'd done it in the past, thinking she had a better perspective because she wasn't as involved or that she was able to be more objective or whatever other excuses she'd made up. People were never grateful like they should be. She'd lost more than one friend over trying to be helpful.

Adora had already decided that the best way to deal with this was just to let the other three figure it out and provide emotional support when requested.

When Bow asked if he should confess his feelings to Glimmer, Adora told him to follow his heart. Vague and couldn't be directly traced back to her.

When Glimmer asked if Bow was acting weird, Adora suggested she talk to him since she'd known him the longest and the best. Classic response.

When Catra asked her what her deepest irrational fears were, Adora spent two hours texting her arguments about immersion therapy, the weirdness of brains, and how birds actually are terrifying because they can fly into your skull and kill you with their beaks. Not mentioning Glimmer or Bow and not getting involved in any way.

So yes, maybe she did have opportunities to intervene but it wasn't her place. When the frantic texts started from Bow, she answered but mysteriously was now too busy to go to their apartment (up two flights of stairs – so far!) and too booked at work to talk during the day.

Bow spiraled for two days. Glimmer and Catra's 4th date was later this week. Nothing definite was decided but. Having known Glimmer for so long, both she and Bow knew that Glimmer had particular little rules about dates. Usually no kisses on the first, unless the person seems really genuine and into her. By the third, she was fine with full-blown makeouts.

On the fourth date, Glimmer usually gave the green light for sex.

In other news, Catra had mentioned noticing Adora's arms. Which was probably an opening for Adora to compliment her but she overthought it. The idea of missing 100% of the shots you don't take is only applicable if you're even in the godsdamn game. Adora was not. Catra was going to have sex with Glimmer. She tried being happy for them but that felt weird so she thought it was best to just erase all of that from her mind. If only Bow would *stop texting her about it* .

On the day of the actual date, Adora nearly worked from home to avoid Bow. She felt guilty about all the work she has to do and chickened out at the last minute. Thankfully, her lateness means Bow's attempt to carpool with her is thwarted.

He’s waiting in her office when she arrives though, playing with the edges of his crop top polo. His eyes are absolutely bananas, wide, bright red, and flitting all over the place.

“Morning,” Adora greets, like she doesn't have a clue what's happening.

Bow makes an impatient face and closes the door behind her. “Morning, Adora. Everything okay?”

“Yeah, just moving slowly today.”

He looks at her strangely, like he’s waiting for more. When she doesn’t add anything, Bow continues, “Glimmer’s taking this really seriously. She spent all of last night cleaning and creating a *mood* .”

“You can’t change what Glimmer’s going to do, Bow,” Adora sighs. “You can change what your response is. How would you like to respond?”

She realizes she sounds a lot like the therapist she saw for a couple years. Maybe that money wasn’t completely wasted.

“I don’t know!” his voice sounds so strained. “I don’t know why this is even such a big deal. I’m not a possessive person. Just...is the window closing? I’ve spent all this time trying not to ruin everything and by the end of this year, Glim could be moving in with Catra or something.”

Adora gets up from her desk and hugs him because she doesn’t know what else is appropriate in this situation. She assures him that things will be okay but only if he talks it out with his roommate and best friend, probably *before* she has (what Adora imagines will be mind-blowing) sex with Catra.

But she’s trying not to think about *mind-blowing* or *sex* or *Catra* in the same sentence ever.

Judging by Bow's deeply agitated face every time she catches him in the hall throughout the day and his increasingly frantic texts into the evening, he does not talk to Glimmer.

At home, Adora is multi-tasking to keep herself busy. She's doing some administrative work on her laptop, watching a college women's basketball game on tv, and cooking supper. Maybe she'll mop later or clean out her fridge. What a thrilling evening. Much more productive than a sex date, anyway.

She's barely made it past the first step of dinner prep when someone knocks. It's probably Bow, who will bring with him all of the mess that she's trying to gracefully hurdle over. The knock is kinda weirdly musical, though. And Bow never knocks because he and Glimmer don't understand boundaries and made themselves keys to Adora's place literally the day after she moved in three years ago.

Maybe it's a delivery? The knock happens again, much louder and more insistent, before she gets to the door.

When she opens it, Catra's standing there, leaning against the frame. She's wearing a wool vest and trousers in a chocolate brown that almost matches her hair along with a light pink short-sleeved dress shirt. This is the first time Adora's ever seen her arms and it turns out that Catra's not slouching on the gym as she likes to pretend.

She cocks her head and smiles lazily. " *Hey* , Adora."

"Catra, hey," she hates how breathy she sounds. "Want to come in?"

After her friend enters, Adora glances out in the hall, just to make sure Bow isn't hiding around the corner or anything weird.

Catra looks kinda out of place in Adora's space. Everything here is so utilitarian, no frills, almost no decoration. Not a lot of color. Adora would like to consider it 'minimalist' but she just really doesn't have the need for more personality in her apartment.

Catra standing there in the middle of the open kitchen-living room area seems like an interior decorator on a home improvement show, surveying the house before the complete demolition and reno.

“Sorry to interrupt,” she says, glancing around.

Adora’s never seen her nervous so she isn’t sure what Catra’s tells are. But her ears are kinda low, her tail’s waving steadily, and she has her hands shoved deep into her pockets.

“Nothing to interrupt,” Adora laughs lightly. “Just some work and about to start dinner. You want a drink? Water, red wine, beer, seltzer?”

“Wine would be nice,” Catra responds.

Adora heads into the kitchen and she follows. It’s really not surprising to see her survey the room and all of Adora’s cookware before immediately getting comfortable and jumping up to sit on the island, right next to the blonde’s laptop.

As Adora finds a glass and hopes that her open bottle of wine isn’t so old that it’s turned to vinegar, she tries the most casual opening she can think of.

“Were you in the neighborhood?”

Catra quietly snickers. “Yeah, something like that,” she replies dryly. “I was upstairs with Glimmer. Is it okay if I talk about that?”

They’ve never really talked about Catra and Glimmer, not since the first night they met. Adora turns to take a good look at her. She can see the distress now, the way Catra’s body seems a little on edge.

“Yeah, of course,” Adora replies, handing over the wine. She pours herself one too cause hopefully it’ll give her the courage to hear more about this relationship that she's not at all envious of.

“Well, your friends are fucking weird.”

Adora laughs, maybe a bit too loudly. Catra’s responding smile is almost relieved.

“I made reservations for dinner, like we had agreed, but then Glimmer invited me to come over instead. But I got there and the vibe was fucking *grim* , dude. Like, for a minute, I thought this might have all been some long con to use me as a ritualistic sacrifice.”

Adora shakes her head. Catra's been watching too much true crime.

“Bow would never allow blood on the furniture.”

Catra chuckles. “That’s not reassuring, ‘Dor!”

Nickname. Catra gave her a nickname.

“Sorry, Cat,” she tries to mimic her tone. “Then what happened?”

“I don’t know. Bow was there and I got the feeling that he was definitely asked *not* to be. Glimmer barely had time to show me in before they were whisper-arguing everywhere. Look, I’m cool with poly shit but I’d like a heads up about what kind of drama I'll be navigating.”

“Oh, they’re not together,” Adora tries to clarify, knowing that this is probably where she should stop talking.

“For real?” Catra doesn’t seem convinced. “Lots of mixed messages then. Bow certainly was acting like I was trying to fuck his girlfriend.”

“Did he throw you out?” Catra didn’t have a coat or anything when she came to the door, but Adora couldn’t imagine Bow losing it that much.

"No! That's the weirdest part!" She slugs back the rest of her wine and Adora refills it without a word. "First, he acted like he wanted me to stay and we'd all have a group hang. Glimmer wasn't fucking having that. Then, she said maybe I should leave and we could reschedule but Bow was spouting off hangout ideas. But! When I offered to leave, they *both* felt bad and Glimmer suggested that maybe I wait outside for a minute and give them a second and she basically crowded me until I was out in the hallway. With no jacket or my phone or keys."

It takes Adora a short while to picture this all, her two best friends rushing around their apartment in a panic, refusing to actually say what's bothering them both. Catra trapped in the middle and then pushed out the door like the oblivious third party in a rom-com.

She laughs, long and loud. At some point, Catra joins in.

"How'd you end up here?"

"Ugh, Glimmer mentioned you lived in the same building at one point. I had to find your name on the mailboxes in the lobby."

"Want some dinner?"

"I'm gonna be here that long?"

"Very likely. When they fight, it gets mixed up with a bunch of other unresolved arguments from forever ago. Bow used all of her shampoo once and it descended into a fight about how he forgot her 19th birthday. Which turned out to not be true – Glimmer was misremembering. It lasted two days though."

Catra sighs. "Yeah, bring on the food then. Guess I better make camp for the night."

Adora nods and turns back to the oven, taking the moment to check her phone, which is lying on the counter. There's a message from Bow that makes no sense, just a bunch of letters and 'freakingout!'

She starts making dinner, while listening to Catra talk about her day, mostly waxing poetically on the restaurant that she'd made reservations at, listing all of the dishes on the menu that she was looking forward to. It would be an easy transition for Adora to suggest Catra take *her* there one day instead. She focuses intently on properly trimming her asparagus to keep that thought out of her head.

Adora's about to place the steak in the pan when Catra stops her story mid-sentence to say, "You better season that if you expect me to eat it."

"I did season it," she replies with a frown.

Catra's off the island and standing less than an inch away from Adora. She reaches around the blonde and examines the meat. Adora looks to her for confirmation and Catra just shakes her head grimly.

Adora's forced to watch in shame as Catra re-seasons the steak with a generous amount of salt and pepper.

"This is a nice cut. Show it some fucking respect."

She drops it into the pan and continues closely supervising. After a couple of minutes, Adora moves to flip it.

"Don't you dare! Adora, that thing is still gray!"

With a laugh, Adora asks, "Do you want to take over?"

"I'm a guest. You're supposed to show me hospitality."

"You're right. I'm sorry. Is there anything else I can get you?"

Catra shrugs. She's so close that Adora can practically feel her shoulders rising and drop against her back.

"I'll go watch the game. Where's your comfiest blanket?"

“On the chair in my bedroom.”

Catra starts to walk away immediately. “Make sure the steak’s actually brown on both sides. *Medium rare* . And for the love of the Gods, please don’t cook the asparagus until it’s mush. A quick, hard sear is fine.”

Adora knows how to cook. She just didn’t realize she was doing it incorrectly for years.

When dinner’s ready, they eat on the couch in front of the game. Catra actually enjoys the food. She won’t let Adora add any condiments though, but she’s right, the steak’s done so perfectly that it doesn’t need anything. Catra heckles both basketball teams and identifies each lesbian to Adora, in case that information is helpful. She bases these assumptions on how they run.

It’s deep in the third quarter, when the front door opens suddenly.

“Well, Bow ruined my sex date and I can’t find Ca-” Glimmer freezes when she sees them.

Adora’s on her feet in an instant.

“Hey, Glim!” She’s using her lying voice, which is weird cause she's pretty sure she's not doing anything wrong.

“Heeeeey,” she draws out in response, eyes taking in Adora, Catra, the empty plates, Catra wrapped in Adora’s favorite blanket. “...What’s up?”

“Sex date, huh?” Catra smirks, her tail thumping slowly but steadily against the couch.

Glimmer returns the devious grin but blushes. “Sorry about all of that. It’s jus-”

Catra interrupts. “No need to explain. Doesn’t feel like it was about me at all. Can I go up and grab my stuff? I imagine I’m not

staying over tonight."

Glimmer laughs awkwardly. "Uh, no, probably not. Staying over, I mean."

They look at each other for a long moment.

Adora clears her throat. "I'll grab your stuff, Cat. You two can take a moment to talk."

She runs out of her own apartment before they can say anything.

Upstairs, Bow is acting strange. He's disappointed that she's not Glimmer but at least relieved that she's not Catra. After a bit of explaining on Adora's end, she picks up Catra's stuff and waits patiently for Bow's side of the story.

All he says is, "We talked. We're not *done* talking yet. But I guess she was worried about Catra. Can you apologize to her for me please?"

When Adora returns to her apartment, Catra and Glimmer are both laughing hysterically on the couch. They quiet down when Adora enters, glancing at her with a weird shared look that makes her feel oddly out of place. She starts clearing plates to give herself something to do, while they hug tightly.

Adora pretends not to watch them share a short kiss, Catra's clawed hands framing Glimmer's round cheeks to hold her. It's brief but even busywork isn't enough to distract her from how *charged* the kiss seems.

Glimmer sounds a little dazed when she says, "Uh...Sorry. Again. We'll talk soon, okay?"

Apparently just a short peck from Catra's lips has the power to put a full-grown woman in a stupor. That's not intimidating at all.

"Everything okay?" Adora asks, once they're alone again.

“Hm. Remains to be seen,” Catra says. “We've got some stuff to figure out later.” Catra sits back and relaxes into the couch, cocooning herself into the blanket. “Shame about the sex date, though.”

Adora can *feel* Catra watching her out of the corner of her eye and has to hold her breath to not make a move. It takes her far too long to think up a rebuttal that she thinks Catra will enjoy.

She keeps her voice mild when she says, “Who knows? The night’s young.”

Catra snorts. “I just got rejected, Dor. At least wait until the sheets have cooled.”

Chapter End Notes

> Chapter 4 preview - you can't run away from your problems on a treadmill. Everyone's talking about Catra and Glimmer and...Scorpia?

Emotional Support Hat Trick

Chapter Summary

> Adora's not the 'feelings' guy. Don't tell Bow, Glimmer, and Catra that.

Chapter Notes

> oh, don't mind me. just trying to pick up the mess that these gays created.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“I don’t understand,” Adora says. “Any of this, really.”

Glimmer offered to come with Adora to work out. Glimmer hates working out. She either feels guilty, is trying to butter her friend up, or she’s having a breakdown and this is a cry for help. A combination of all three is very possible.

So far though, Adora’s just been an audience of 1 for Glimmer’s directionless musings on Bow, Catra, and the nature of relationships in general. On the treadmill next to Adora, wearing a shimmery pale pink tracksuit and moving at a very slow trot, Glimmer huffs.

“Well, I know how Bow feels but I don't actually know if we're on the same page about what comes next. And then with Catra…”

Adora holds her breath, which is very hard to do at the pace she’s running. She has yet to hear a clear idea of what any of them are planning.

“We can’t just have one conversation and be done with everything,” Glimmer explains.

“Why not?” She tries to keep the frustration out of her voice.

“The queer by-laws state that there must be at least 8 hours of mutual processing. We can’t upset the rich history and traditions that’ve been handed down to us.”

All of those words are awful.

“So what are you doing now?”

Glimmer shrugs. “I don’t know. Catra and I texted. We talked on the phone a little bit. I think we’ll probably meet in person when we’re super sure what we're doing.” She pauses and glares out the window. “I guess, what I *want* us to be doing, really.”

Adora nods like she understands. She doesn’t, not really. It definitely seems difficult to be in Glimmer’s position, having two amazing, caring, attractive people who want to be with her. That’s never once been *Adora’s* personal experience but it must be emotionally and mentally taxing.

She’s rarely jealous, especially of Glimmer. Lately, she’s been working on channeling this new feeling into healthy productive things, like color coding her expenses and setting a new personal record for deadlifting.

Glimmer peers over at her as Adora speeds up on the treadmill, trying to burn off the odd stress in the pit of her stomach.

“Has she said anything about me?” Glimmer asks. She’s open and self-conscious in a way that Adora hasn’t seen her in a good while, very different from the fiery fierceness that she’s been cultivating for years.

“Not much,” Adora answers honestly, already a little out of breath. She and Catra do a magnificent job of talking all around this whole situation.

“She’s surprisingly chill about this all.”

The blonde nods. “That’s kind’ve her whole...vibe, I guess the youth say.”

Glimmer fights a derisive smirk. “The youth,” she repeats to herself, clearly mocking her friend. Louder, she says, “I’m relieved about that, don’t get me wrong. If she was freaking out, this would be an actual fucking disaster. But deep down? Kinda feels like she wasn’t totally invested.”

“It was only a few dates,” Adora points out. “Were you?”

Glimmer scowls and that feels like answer enough.

“How are you planning to figure out what you want?” she inquires.

Glimmer just groans.

“I-I don’t know, okay!” she answers, throwing her hands up in the air. “What would you do?”

No. No no. Adora isn’t qualified to give out advice on romance or making decisions in a timely manner.

“What am I saying?” Glimmer asks herself, apparently coming to her senses. “You’d probably make a pros and cons list.”

“I’m not that predictable,” she replies, just as Glimmer says the same thing in a mocking tone. She does her full Adora impression and everything, lifting her nose up in the air, setting her jaw firmly, narrowing her eyes, and making her voice monotone.

Adora just speeds up in response.

“So,” Glimmer continues on, “Pros.”

“I don’t think this is a good idea,” Adora mumbles. It feels...rude? Private? Counterintuitive to her continued denial of Catra as a sexual being?

“It’s fine,” Glimmer assures her. “Why don’t you list a few pros about Catra? You two are friendly, right? That’ll be helpful.”

Adora speeds up again. She actually probably can’t last long at this pace. With luck, she’ll pass out and Glimmer will let this go. This is Glimmer Moon though, so she’d probably just revive Adora and ask her to stop playing around and take this seriously.

Good things about Catra?

“I don’t think I’m an objective observer.”

“Yeah, I bet,” Glimmer returns dryly.

“Because I’m friends with both Catra and Bow,” Adora adds.

“That’s actually the definition of being objective in this context. You like them both.”

“Catra. is.” Adora reluctantly starts, trying to drag this out as long as possible. “A really good listener, actually. Supportive. Fun. Smart and hilarious.” Intense but in an exciting way. Surprisingly silly. *Warm* , which Adora wouldn't have expected.

She might have trailed off and zoned out there at the end.

“Uh...you want me to list cons?” Adora offers, pretending that she's discovered any yet.

“Nope. That’s...really all I needed to hear,” Glimmer says, sounding a bit sad. Her eyes on Adora are soft and fond.

“So, did that help with your decision?” Adora asks, ignoring that completely.

The answering sigh makes her lower the treadmill speed for the first time and focus on her friend. Glimmer can be a bit much most of the time but this is a real issue and not the many ‘issues’ that she and Bow cook up, like the debate on whether they were too old to still have twinkle lights or the interventions they’ve organized to get Adora to download whatever app of the week they’re obsessed with.

“Adding dating feels like it would be putting a lot of pressure on me and Bow’s relationship,” Glimmer admits. “We really only get one shot at this. If it doesn’t work out, we’ve known each other too long to just go back to how it was before. What if we don’t get it right?”

“You’re not getting married tomorrow. I think you just have to start with figuring out what you both want out of your relationship right now. Needs, expectations, boundaries. And then you...take a baby step.”

This is trash advice. The problem is that *Bow* is the relationship advice person. Adora is the person who reminds you that you should start a 401k or helps you move. Unfortunately, it seems like they've all collectively decided to blame Bow for creating this whole disaster. Adora's never been more grateful for him.

Glimmer takes a second to nod, taking in Adora’s words.

“You’re right,” she says quietly. “I just need to focus on what I really, genuinely want. What do I want to have in my life?”

Instinctively, Adora glances at the controls to raise the speed again. She fights it though, she’s proud to say. Instead, she reaches over and pats Glimmer’s hand.

“Do you want to leave and get drunk?”

Glimmer’s big purple puppy eyes look up at her with so much gratitude. “You’re so good to me.”

“Don’t decide you want to date me too,” Adora jokes.

“I’ve seen you freak out while trying to choose food at a buffet, you straw-headed worrywart. There’s no chance of that.”

Adora laughs with fake relief and turns off the treadmill to begin some light stretches.

“So, you’re gonna let Catra down easy soon?”

Glimmer smirks, beginning to walk away, “I think you’re just going to have to be a little more patient.”

Adora follows, *affronted* . “What does *that* mean?

Glimmer just giggles.

Catra
10:23am
Taking a poll
Has the existence of douchey shuffleboard bars ruined the sport?

Adora
10:49am
I wasn’t aware of this trend
I imagine modern technology ruined the sport maybe?

Catra
10:53am
What’s your preference?
Floor or table?

Adora
10:58am
...you’re still talking about the game, right?

Catra
11:01am
Tonight after work?

When Adora shows up at the address that Catra sent, she’s relieved to find it’s just a moody, local dive. It’s fairly narrow and the bar itself is made of dark old wood, like this place was built a few decades ago. Not seeing Catra anywhere, Adora scoots through the front room to find a larger space in the back with a shuffleboard table against the right-side wall.

After those texts, she honestly wasn’t sure what to expect. Irrationally, it felt like there might be a 50% chance that she was

visiting Catra's apartment for the first time. She was too nervous to look up the address and prove herself right. Or worse, realize she was wrong and then have to admit to herself what she'd been secretly maybe kinda hoping for.

"I've never played this before!" Adora tells Catra, when she shows up late. The blonde knows she sounds too excited for this, and that it's at least partially due to how Catra looks so nonchalantly confident strolling in.

Today's a blue suit day, like Catra's eyes need any damn help standing out. A game is a welcome distraction.

"It's a lost art," is all Catra says in return.

She explains the rules twice and Adora is still sure that she's making them up as she goes along. They have to break for 10 minutes for Adora to look up the *actual* rules online, much to Catra's feigned outrage and cries of betrayal. She'd feel bad about how much time they spend on this if literally anyone else in this bar was interested in playing this ancient game.

Adora plays very thoughtfully, trying to get all of her pucks into safe zones where she hopes that Catra will ignore them. Catra throws like a wild woman, knocking Adora's pieces all around the board and ensuring their mutual loss.

"Catra!" she yells on the third time it happens.

The first and second times had been written off as mistakes or overexubance. This is clearly war.

Catra smirks in response. "Guess I don't know my own strength."

Adora falls for this and glances down at Catra's arms. They're covered by a flowery pale blue shirt, a rare pattern from her, that is so cute with the dark blue blazer she hung on the back of a stool earlier. But Adora can see her flexing slightly, lean muscles straining a little against the fabric. When she glances back up at Catra's face, her friend is fighting valiantly to hide a grin.

“I’m gonna grab a beer,” Catra says, giving her an out. “What do you want?”

“Just a seltzer.”

“You’re not drinking?”

Adora makes a face. “I’m still kinda hungover. I took Glimmer out last night.”

They'd ended up going a little wild, much to Adora's embarrassment. Glimmer had recounted Bow’s full confession of his feelings for her until they were both in drunken tears over how wonderful he was.

It’s Catra’s turn to make a face now, going bashful.

“Did you want to talk about that?” Adora asks.

Catra sighs, “Only if you’re okay with it.”

“You know, I *will* take a beer now,” comes out quickly.

When Catra returns from the bar, Adora has been mostly successful in giving herself a pep talk about how everything’s fine and she has no stake in any of the choices that people around her are making with their lives and their mouths. Catra interrupts this inner monologue by knocking her shoulder into Adora’s to grab her attention. Their hands touch as Catra passes her the beer and the lies Adora just told herself go flying right out of the window.

“Did you know I dated Scorpia?” Catra asks, before taking her turn and continuing their game.

“No,” Adora says, truly shocked. It makes it a bit hard to focus on her next turn. “I can’t see that.”

Catra just laughs. “Yeah, neither could I. Probably why it didn’t work out. We met freshman year of college. I said hey to her cause she looked super gay, which was mind-blowing to me, of

course. Then I had this giant, awkward scorpion kid following me around everyday."

She pauses for her turn, somehow bumping Adora's last puck off the scoring triangle and landing them both in the gutter. Zero points for them both.

"You know the object is to play to *win* , right?" Adora asks. "Not just play to ensure I lose along with you."

"This is your first time and suddenly you're a shuffleboard expert? I'm applying a variety of strategies. You just don't know it yet. Come on."

Catra places her hand on Adora's lower back to guide the blonde to the opposite end of the table for another round.

Adora distracts herself from the contact by asking, "What happened with you and Scorpia?"

Catra takes her turn first. "Not much of anything. We went out a few times and I realized it wasn't meant to be. I think she was more into the idea of me without actually knowing me. So I avoided her for weeks and then I apologized and she started following me around again, but just as a friend. I didn't even really have my baby gay sexual awakening until two years later."

Adora's well aware that she's an adult. So she's also aware that she shouldn't be feeling all sorts of things just at the sound of Catra's voice saying 'sexual.'

"And you've been best friends since?" She makes a big show of shooting her puck and intentionally *not* bumping Catra's.

"Yep." With impressive control, her puck gently stops right next to Adora's. "We've even been roommates a few times."

Adora's so busy thinking about that, that she doesn't pay much attention to her and Catra's next shots. Scorpia was kind and blonde and buff. Was Scorpia just not Catra's type either?

“Why did that come to mind?” she asks.

“Just been thinking about it lately,” Catra answers lightly. She shrugs and then shoots her last puck.

Which part, Adora wonders. The breakup or dating a friend?

Well, there’s really no need to worry too much about it now cause she’ll probably be ruminating on this when she should be sleeping tonight. Adora goes to shoot her last puck as Catra watches her closely.

For the first time, she understands the depths of the other woman’s cunning. Catra’s managed to sneak most of her pucks behind Adora’s and is even using one to block another from any possible attacks. Out of the corner of her eye, she can see a smile full of fangs. She just lets the last puck fly, hoping for the best. She takes out one of Catra’s at least.

“7 for me, 0 for Dor. I’ll let you keep score. I know you love it.”

Adora’s embarrassed to admit that she does.

“So, Glimmer...?” she starts, unsure of how she could even help.

Catra shakes her head softly. “I’m gonna try this wild idea where I just talk to her directly.”

“Innovative,” Adora jokes to hide how deeply fucking relieved she feels.

Bow sets a beer in front of her. Adora fights the urge to vomit.

“Oh, no! Did you want vodka?”

“Gods, no!”

People seated at the bar next to them startle and shoot her a dirty look for yelling.

Bow had stopped by her office earlier that day and practically begged for Adora to join him and watch football. Bow hates football. It's too brutal and slow. The matchup tonight is actually a pretty good one and Adora kinda wishes she had been invited by Catra instead, who she imagines has a really silly system for deciding which players are the gayest or have the best shoe collection or something else random.

Three nights out in a row is something that Adora's never done, not even in college or her 20s. She feels just a little bit like death warmed over.

She accepts the beer anyway, already thinking of how much extra time she'll have to add to her next few workouts to make up for how bizarrely she's acted this week.

Bow has the decency to look remorseful when he turns to her with pleading eyes two minutes into the first quarter. As she imagined, they're going for an emotional support hat trick this week.

Bow's never struggled to understand his own feelings. At least, not from the outside. He'll probably just want to hear Adora's thoughts on Glimmer.

"How is Catra doing?" he asks.

"Um. What?"

"Is she okay? You two have been hanging out pretty regularly, right?"

Adora shrugs. "We've seen each other a couple of times, yeah. She's, uh, fine?"

Bow nods. Then he smiles, before patting Adora on the back.

"That's nice. New friend!"

Bow turns back to watch the game.

“I was thinking of getting into crocheting,” he says after a minute.

“Oh?” Adora asks, completely lost. “I hear it’s something good to do with your hands while you watch tv.”

“Exactly! And think of all the cute scarfs and stuff I could make for everyone.”

And it continued on, the two of them talking about a hobby that Adora never understood, like nothing else important was happening in their lives.

Bow reaches and pulls Adora’s beer in front of himself. He gets the bartender to replace it with a seltzer.

Mutual denial. Man, Bow really gets her.

Chapter End Notes

> coming up in chapter 5: decisions are made, clothing is bought, cats are appeased.

Quality Adora Time

Chapter Summary

> Glimmer is mature (according to her). Adora and Catra go shopping. Approval is granted.

Chapter Notes

> Happy Friday! Here's an unusually long chapter.
>
> Not really a content warning, per se, but Adora's got some low self-esteem things that show a lot more in this chapter. I think she's great, everyone in this story thinks she's great, but we're gonna see more of her struggling to believe and accept that.
>
> In other news, Co-Star's How to Seduce a Capricorn (third slide) felt like a spoiler for both this whole story and my entire life.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer spends 45 minutes of the workday sitting in Adora's tiny, drab office, once again recapping her most recent conversations with Bow. She now thinks everything he does is the most romantic thing that's ever happened.

"He got up early to make sure my mug was washed," she says with awe. "Isn't he the best?"

That feels like it's just one level about common courtesy.

"Yep," Adora replies, trying (and failing!) to ignore her friend and finish this grant report.

Glimmer then spares a full 20 seconds in her unending monologue to say, "Oh, I saw Catra. So that's done. Anyway-"

"What happened?" She was never going to be able to finish the report with Glimmer there anyway. Might as well take a short break.

Glimmer shrugs. "We talked. I apologized. We agreed on being friends." She's obviously antsy to get back to discussing Bow. Almost as an afterthought, she adds, "She also apologized but I didn't think you two were that big of a deal."

"Uh," Adora coughs. "What? What 'you two'? ‘You two’ what?"

"Hanging out. She said it happened organically, it was innocent, blah blah. I made her promise that you'll name your first born after me."

Glimmer's being too blase. It *was* innocent and organic.

Oh, Gods. Hearing Glimmer talk about it out loud makes it feel very different.

Adora starts spinning very quickly. "Look, I'm sorry. I wasn't trying to overstep. We really are just friends. If you feel uncomfortable with-"

"My Gods, Adora. You're too old to act this undignified."

"We're the same age."

"Exactly. And I'll be the mature one and say I know you'd never act like a scumbag. You hung out. Who cares? I meant what I said about the baby name though." She suddenly looks very serious, in that way that only Glimmer can over something theoretical and impossible. "I *will* follow up." Immediately, she drops back into the wistful tone that's now reserved for talking about her new relationship. "Anyway, and then in the *shower* , Bow-"

Nope. "Don't you have those contracts due today?"

"Oh? Yeah. Fine. I'll leave you alone to freak out."

"I'm not going to freak out," Adora yells after Glimmer as she leaves, but her voice is already nearly screeching so no one believes her.

“We’re gonna be pals,” Catra explains as Adora struggles to focus on her dinner. Her tone is very light for someone who’s recounting their recent breakup.

“That’s good? Is that what you want?”

Catra looks at her silently for a moment then attempts to smile.

“Yeah. We think that’s what’s best for everyone. Honestly, we’d kinda been dancing around it since the start.”

Catra probably already knows that Adora’s been updated, since Glimmer’s never kept a secret in her whole life. Even so, Catra’s version of events is somehow already more telling.

“Hmm? What’s that mean?”

“It was still early,” Catra replies, “But we weren’t all in and we agreed that we wouldn’t have been able to get there, with or without the...outside factors. No hard feelings, though. We cleared the air on literally everything.” Almost to herself, she whispers, “She’s so fucking nosey.”

“How does this all make you feel?” Adora asks awkwardly.

She does obviously care about Catra so she needs to hear the answer, no matter how it irrationally feels like it could be potentially devastating. Catra bites her lip while she thinks, a fang peaking out adorably.

“This is gonna sound weird but I’m happy for her. For both of them. I’ve been in love a couple times. I’ve *never* been in love like those two idiots are.”

Adora nods with a smile. Bow and Glimmer *are* really cute and happy together, whenever she can catch a moment where their faces aren't conjoined or they're still endlessly processing.

"You're being really cool about all this," the blonde comments.

"This isn't even in my top *three* of relationship drama, Dor."

"What's number one?"

"I tried to make my girlfriend jealous by hitting on our couple's therapist. She turned me down by kindly informing me that they were fucking and she took fidelity *really serious* ," Catra deadpans. "To be fair, my regular therapist had tried to warn me about the signs but, honest to Gods, I thought they needed so many extra one-on-one sessions cause my ex was a shitty fucking communicator."

The corners of Adora's lips twitch against her will. "Gods!"

"It's fine. You can laugh. It's pretty hilarious now."

Adora politely only laughs a little. Catra smiles patiently at her.

"My dating history reads like a lesser Etherian tragedy. So, yeah, I've got a high tolerance for fuckery. Plus, I like you. I like your weird friends for some fucking reason. Bow was a class act and even took me to dinner to make amends." Catra pushes the food around on her plate, thinking for a moment. "It's been awhile since people have been so aggressively nice to me."

The two of them sit in silence for a moment, just enjoying the meal that Catra 'supervised' Adora cooking, while the blonde mentally examines her friend's words. Catra's a secret softie underneath her suits and other armor.

"Why don't *you* date?" Catra asks.

"Uh...what?"

This is probably just friendly curiosity. So Adora shouldn't start internally panicking like she's in an interrogation. She does anyway.

"You're kind and caring and smart," Catra continues, like she's stating facts that are not controversial in any way. "Unintentionally funny. A good time when you aren't thinking too much. People should be falling all over themselves to submit an application to fuck you."

"Busy," Adora grunts out trying to bury herself in her plate. She's already making plans for an exit strategy from this conversation. Go to the kitchen and refill her water. Excuse herself to the bathroom.

Bow and Glimmer have been occupied a lot lately, understandably. Adora gets lots of texts from them and way too many details at work but it's honestly nice to have a reprieve from being an awkward third party to their shenanigans.

She's been spending more time with Catra instead, which Glimmer is weirdly supportive of. Very chill hangs, Catra calls them. She comes over to Adora's place to correctly teach the blonde how to prepare dinner or they go to the movies or they get drinks. Catra's actually the first friend that Adora's had in a long time who wants to do these one-on-one hangs with her, especially outside of a crisis, instead of group outings or making her be the third wheel.

If they were kissing or holding hands, they would basically be dating.

Adora shifts awkwardly. Now dating's the only word she can think of, running on a loop in her head. Mocking her.

"Wait, why are we talking about this now?"

Catra ignores her question. "We're all busy, Adora. You're not special just because you've appointed yourself savior of the world. Why are you *actually* not dating?"

When she fidgets weirdly again, Catra puts her fork down and turns to her.

Moving a clawed hand to Adora's knee, Catra tells her, "I know we haven't known each other super long, Dor, but you can tell me shit. I'm good with secrets. And besides your deplorable cooking, I don't judge."

"You make fun of everyone in every single show or movie we watch."

"I don't judge in *real life* ," Catra amends. "Going on TV is basically asking for it."

"It's not anything terrible," Adora begins. "I *am* busy. I told you it's hard for me to meet people."

"Sure. There's setups and plenty of other options. Glimmer could sell you off for a dowry."

"I've...always been busy. I was really focused on school for a long time and then I was focused on LAP for a long time. There's not a lot of time left over for other big commitments and I don't want to disappoint anyone." That last part stings a bit, getting a little too close to the real truth.

Catra eyes her skeptically. "You always have time for me."

Adora takes a sip of water in a futile attempt to not blush. Yes, she makes time for Catra. It's actually surprisingly easy now that she has the smug bastard helping her with work issues. Catra is really good with reminding Adora when she doesn't have to do a bunch of extra tasks or when she needs to leave someone else alone to figure out things for themselves.

And also, maybe getting to see Catra is a good motivator to set better boundaries at work and say no occasionally.

"I do. You make it easy though. You help me with stuff. We don't have to do a lot of planning. It doesn't feel like a chore." She

pauses. “I don’t think I’m saying this correctly.”

“No, I get it,” Catra says but her voice sounds less light than before. “I’m convenient.”

Adora puts her fork down too and turns to Catra. “What I mean is, I *really* like spending time with you so I make that time.”

Catra makes a sound that she’s never heard before. Like a very quiet trill. Feeling much less worried now, and feeling very silly about that, Adora goes back to finishing her food.

“So if you have less work, I have even more quality Adora time? Good to know.”

LAP has a gala coming up. This is absolutely horrific. Every year, they end up spending too much money on a stupid party, the venue, the drinks, the food, and it never feels like a good enough payoff. So Adora spends the whole time leading up to it worrying and pulling her hair out then the entire actual evening talking to people who don’t get the work and don’t even donate. It’s exhausting.

Glimmer and Bow seem to be guilty about their new romantic relationship and all the time they’ve been spending together, which they’ve channeled into putting lots of energy into the gala. Perfuma’s been helping out too, along with the small group of dedicated volunteers that pitch in each year.

And then there’s Catra, who Adora is *certain* must be behind on her own work now. Not only has she taken over a bunch of the gala tasks, after assigning herself as *Chair* , a position that she made up, she’s also got her assistant, Mermista, working on it nonstop.

This gives Adora an opportunity to learn a lot about Catra. Turns out she knows everyone, or at least every queer person in the city. She’s frightening when she wants to get something done. But she can also be cloyingly sweet if she needs something. She’s a

great leader and an amazing motivator. She pronounces gala as ‘gay-la’ and Adora’s tried to figure out if it’s a joke and she’s really starting to think it’s sincere.

Adora has also learned some things about herself. When she thinks someone will actually finish something, she doesn’t have a problem letting go. Relishes it, even. She needs to learn more about building long-term partnerships for annoying moments like this gala, or hire a charming genius like Catra. Also, she has a crush on Catra. She can admit that now.

They’ve been spending a lot of time together. Catra lets Adora pretend that it’s work but sets a firm time for when ‘work’ ends and they can just hang out. They’ve added lunch meetings to their usual socializing. Catra insists on taking her to very unnecessarily fancy restaurants where people do business lunches so they can talk about fundraising progress. The self-appointed Gala Chair has asked her firm and a bunch of her friends’ companies to purchase sponsorships and has her assistant following up with all of their usual donors. Somehow, Catra also got an ex to give them a great deal on a venue, another ex to do the catering for cheap, and someone that’s not an ex but is apparently equally complicated to help with rentals. She needs basically none of Adora’s guidance but neither of them mentions this when they’re ‘working’ together.

Catra’s gotten more...handsy. They hug a lot. Catra loops her arm through Adora’s when they walk in public. She often looks like she wants to do more, especially when they’re relaxing on the couch together. Catra’s always leaving space for the other woman to join her under her blankets but Adora never has the guts to do it.

She actually had to research it to see if this kind of physical touch was common with cat folks or if Catra was just into her. It could possibly be both, but she’s still afraid to talk to someone reasonable, like Perfuma or Bow about this. Glimmer is out of the question obviously, with all of her teasing smiles and not-at-all-subtle remarks about Adora and Catra.

A week before the big event, Catra picks Adora up from work to take her shopping. She knows this is a trick. Catra is making her con face and definitely not driving in the direction of the nicest mall.

"I'd like to remind you that I don't need any clothes," Adora tells her. "And more importantly, I can't *afford* any new clothes."

"I'd like to go over your personal budget sometime," Catra offers. She gets an indignant gasp in response. "Not everything's about you, Adora. Maybe I just want to browse."

"Uh huh." She looks at the open map on Catra's phone. "At this fancy dress shop." A thought hits and she almost feels disappointed. "Are you not wearing a suit to the gala?"

Catra's smirk is so broad that Adora can see it, even though she's facing the road.

"Don't worry. I have a new tux, gorgeous velvet with a shawl collar. This is an amazing excuse to wear it. We're just...having fun today."

Adora has no idea what a 'shawl collar' is but her friend's eyes light up when she's describing this suit. Catra knows a lot about clothes and fashion. Even her car is some fancy trendy thing. She's truly so far out of Adora's league that it's laughable. And very pathetic that Adora can't let go of this stupid middle school crush.

The store Catra takes her to is...a lot. Glimmer would love it honestly, which is usually a sign that Adora's in the wrong place. It's going for a rich hippie party girl vibe that she finds totally disorienting. She doesn't want to offend Catra, though, so she tries for a smile.

"This place is the fifth circle of hell," the other woman whispers. "But they sell good shit. Trust me."

Catra leads her around the room, absently touching everything. She keeps her eyes on Adora the whole time, rather than on the merchandise. Every couple minutes, she asks if the blonde's seen anything that she likes. After receiving several no's, Catra finally just begins picking up dresses and asking if Adora's into them.

"None? You don't like anything here?" Catra's clearly trying to not seem frustrated.

Adora shrugs. "Sorry. I just can't picture you in any of them."

Catra turns to put a dress back, mumbling something to herself. Out loud, she tries, "Maybe don't think of *me* in it? Just think of something that looks good."

This is a trap.

"You're not buying me a dress, Cat."

"Of course not," she waves dismissively. "Now, do you like any other colors besides black and gray?"

Adora tries to think. She's not good under fashion-related pressure.

"What color is your tux? Maybe that'll inspire me."

"Ooh!" Catra begins to fidget excitedly, her tail speeding up its movement a little. "Don't laugh at how gay this is, but it's purple. Like a really deep purple."

Adora might accidentally make a face. She doesn't look good in purple. But! They're not buying her a dress so that's fine.

"We'll aim for a lavender," Catra suggests. She immediately begins pulling Adora towards light purple cocktail dresses and a few evening gowns. All of them are way too extravagant.

Eventually, the two of them argue until they settle on a long sleeved wrap dress that Catra's not very excited about, an off-the-

shoulder sleeveless satin number that she enthusiastically insists on, and a ruffled nightmare that they both agree is horrible but absolutely have to see Adora in. She tries on all three, figuring that at the very least, this will give her ideas of what style she should look for on sale at the mall or at a thrift shop. Catra nearly comes into the fitting room with her but decides to wait outside when they both get too flustered.

As expected, Catra grumbles when she sees the first dress and laughs out loud at the third one. Adora tries the second one on last. It feels ridiculous to be wearing so little material in this weather, with the neck, shoulders, and upper back unprotected in this dress. Mostly, the amount of exposed skin makes her feel super awkward in her body.

"Cat," she calls out softly. "Can you come in here?" It'll be bad enough to show her friend. Adora can't imagine anyone else in the store seeing her in this.

Catra's there in a flash. "What's wr-"

She has the presence of mind to close the curtain behind her before she completely freezes up. Except her tail, which starts going bonkers.

With a frown, Adora asks, " *Gods* , is it that bad?" She takes a second look at herself in the mirror, turning her back to Catra.

She lets out a quiet growl, something Adora can't remember her ever doing before. She turns back quickly to make sure everything's okay.

"Fucking hell, Dor," Catra whispers. She must notice her tail for the first time cause she reaches back and grabs it with one hand. "Well, thank the Gods you didn't wear this out into the store. You would have driven every other shopper out in shame."

Adora laughs nervously. "You can't be serious. I look absurd, Catra."

“You just look tense. Just try to relax, weirdo.”

But she steps closer to Adora, which does not help her calm down at all. Catra places her palms on the blonde’s shoulders and turns her back to face the mirror. Clawed hands begin to slowly run up and down Adora’s arms. It’s surprisingly soothing until Adora realizes that what’s really lulling her into a false sense of peace is the quiet, steady purr coming from Catra. Adora knows she’s already addicted to how vocal her friend’s been today.

“That’s better,” Catra whispers. Adora nods, even though she has no idea what she’s referring to. “Maybe try opening your eyes.” It sounds like she’s smiling.

Adora hadn’t noticed that she’d closed them. When she looks back in the mirror, she does look a lot more comfortable in the dress. She catches sight of Catra standing next to her and imagines them at the gala, her on Catra’s arm. The disadvantage of such a revealing dress is that she can see herself blush all the way down to her chest. Catra laughs and moves to rest her chin on Adora’s shoulder.

“Does that mean you like it?”

“I love it,” she whispers. Then a little louder adds, “I’ll have to find something like this that I can afford.”

“So you’re sold on lavender?”

This would be smooth if she could get through it without stuttering, she knows. “Y-yeah. As the ED and the gala chair, we should probably match, right?”

Catra just holds her gaze in the mirror, still smiling. “This is embarrassing – I completely forgot to buy a ticket. I could be your date?”

Adora imagines that her pure panic must be what makes Catra’s grin dim a little. So she rushes to nod and say, “Definitely, yes.”

To her relief, Catra lights up again.

“Cool. I’ll pick you up and everything. Now, come on. Get out of this and give it to me and then you can get dressed.”

Adora does as told and by the time she’s out, Catra’s hovering near the store’s front door, holding two large shopping bags.

Their next stop is a building she’s never seen before. Catra doesn't even use the map so she can’t snoop. They leave the bags in the car.

In the elevator, all Catra says is “Don’t make a big deal out of it, okay?”

Adora doesn't have time to ask what before Catra lets her into an apartment. She tries to take in as much as she can – the huge, pristine chef’s kitchen, the extremely comfy looking couch in the living room, the view of downtown from the balcony, the huge king size bed in a bedroom that’s large enough to fit Adora’s entire apartment. This is *Catra's* place.

Catra takes her straight into the closet. It looks like something one would see in a magazine, racks and racks of suits and outfits and shoes and accessories.

When Adora looks at Catra, she just repeats, “You said you wouldn’t make a big deal out of this.”

“I didn’t actually agree to that! You should know how verbal contracts work, of all people.”

With a chuckle, Catra begins looking at a section of the closet that’s scarves. She pulls out a couple shawls and folds them over her arm.

“Do you have shoes?”

Does Adora own shoes? Yes. Would they be acceptable to wear to a fancy event with Catra? No, not all.

She shakes her head and Catra immediately pulls her over to the shoe section.

“Honestly, with my claws, we might end up being the same size. Grab something in silver or gold or...black maybe?” And then Catra exits and leaves her alone.

It takes her a while to go through everything cause there's many pairs. Catra's told her that she doesn't even really like wearing shoes. Completing that task, Adora decides to snoop around a bit. There’s a pajamas section, which is so fucking cute. Catra does indeed own several pairs of baby blue pajamas, in an old-school style like someone’s dad. They’re all monogrammed. This doesn’t feel like real life.

Adora’s stopped in her tracks, though, when she sees what’s directly behind the PJs. Lingerie in a variety of colors and materials. Including some elaborate looking leather harnesses. She maybe zones out a little just….imagining things.

“Anything catch your fancy?”

The blonde jumps in the air, the shoes in her hands flying everywhere. Catra’s chuckle is so low that it sends shivers up her spine. Adora chances a glance at her and she looks deeply pleased with herself.

Adora tries to cover but can’t imagine that it sounds convincing at all. “Sorry. Just admiring...your *pajamas* .”

“Yeah, that started as a weird inside joke when Scorpia and I were in the dorms and now it’s my life somehow. Sure there wasn’t anything you wanted to borrow or...get a closer look at?” Her voice drops again towards the end of her sentence.

Adora starts picking up the shoes as a distraction, just shaking her head. She has to brush past Catra to get out of the closet and try to get some air in the huge bedroom. She works on avoiding thinking about how close she is to Catra’s bed.

On said bed, there's a couple gorgeous gold necklaces, a bracelet, and a few pairs of earrings laid out on top of the shawls.

It all comes together. Finally. She's honestly a little embarrassed that she didn't catch on earlier.

"Di-did you buy me that dress? Catra!"

Adora's not angry, just overwhelmed. She moves to take a seat on the bed and then doesn't feel like that's appropriate.

"Relax, dummy," Catra replies. Of course, she doesn't look concerned about this at all. "I mean, take a seat on the damn bed and also chill out."

Adora sits as told. It's the softest bed she's ever been in and she wants to stay there forever. Catra goes back into the closet and grabs a small duffel, where she begins putting all of the accessories for Adora.

"Yes, I bought the dress. And a couple more, just in case. If you hate them, you can take them back."

Adora groans. "You didn't have to do that."

"Yeah, I know. I *wanted* to."

With a sigh, the blonde tries to level with her, "Look. I'm not a... *refined* person, okay? I-"

Catra interrupts with a laugh. "I know who you are, Dor." She sits on the bed too, not leaving much space between them. "I'm not trying to change you. I just want you to be comfortable and have fun. I thought choosing what to wear would be easier if you didn't have to think about it. So we just took care of it."

Adora nearly cries from how thoughtful that is. She *is* really fucking relieved that she doesn't have to spend a whole weekend shopping and trying on a million things, Glimmer getting increasingly frustrated with her.

But shit. That dress was $1,200. That's more than she pays for rent each month. And Catra's bought her other pieces.

"Don't freak out about the price!" Catra says quickly. "And don't do something ridiculous and try to pay me back."

"But Cat-"

"Nope. You do so much, Dor. You spend all your time taking care of everyone. Just let me take care of you."

She crushes Catra in a hug, whispering thanks into her hair. When the arms around her waist begin to pet up and down her back, they linger in the embrace for a little longer.

After several moments, they're interrupted by a sullen meow coming from behind Adora. Catra lets go of her to glance at the grumpy, fluffy gray house cat who has suddenly now appeared next to the pillows. Melog, she'd learned over text. They look surprisingly expressive in person. *Judgy* .

"Really, dude?" Catra asks. They narrow their eyes at each other, seeming to have a familiar silent conversation. Catra loses when Melog makes an angry sound. "Fine."

She gently pushes Adora to lay back on the bed, while the blonde tries not to panic.

"Uh, Cat? They don't seem to like me and you're putting me in a pretty defenseless position right now."

"It's fine. They just want to give their approval of you."

Catra takes her friend's hand and places it at the base of her own mane. It's as soft and thick as she had imagined, not that she actually *had* imagined this at all, not really. Adora isn't sure what gets into her but she begins immediately petting and massaging, shifting her fingers through Catra's hair and stroking the fur on the nape of her neck. It isn't long before Catra's eyes close slowly

and the sound of her purr reaches Adora. She’s not sure if she’s ever made anyone feel this good.

Melog starts fidgeting, kneading the bed. Carefully, eyes still narrowed, they move towards Adora and then settle onto her lap. She pets them behind the ear until they purr in tandem with their owner.

“Approval granted?” she asks Melog.

“You basically have free reign of this bed now,” Catra mumbles, her tail tentatively moving to wrap around Adora’s wrist and hold it in place.

Chapter End Notes

> i couldn't let all that glitra mess go too far, sorry. honestly, the real love triangle is between adora, catra, and adora's own awkwardness.
>
> this story kinda has four distinct arcs (aka different awful things that i do to adora for no reason). this is the end of the first one and the beginning of the second, which is literally all fluff. cause soft gays are soft.

Princess and Her Lord

Chapter Summary

A gay-la, a conversation, and cookies.

Chapter Notes

thank satan it's friday.

also thank **you** for all your kind comments and fucking weird and hilarious comments and kudos and everything else.

warnings? not really. low self-esteem. a bizarre discussion of a particular kink. someone working so hard to lie to themself that i was vicariously embarrassed for her.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The gala isn't awful, thanks entirely to Catra. She basically takes care of every piece that Adora's ever complained about. She has someone edit and refine all of Adora's talking points and her pitch speech. It's probably the clearest Adora's ever described the work and she's only vaguely annoyed that they removed all of her very important statistics. No one ever cares about statistics.

That afternoon, Catra even surprises her with two hair and makeup people who come to the office to offer their services to the staff.

"This is the best thing that's ever happened to us," Glimmer squeals.

Bow's already examining the eyeliner options.

"Catra's a very generous friend," Adora remarks. "Is this too generous? I feel kinda guilty."

" *Friend* ?" Glimmer repeats. "I've never had a friend spoil me like this. What have I been doing wrong this whole time?"

"Just enjoy it, Adora," Bow replies, ignoring his girlfriend. "Please. Catra obviously wants to do this and you deserve it."

Adora nods, still feeling a little reluctant. That must show on her face because Glimmer smirks at her.

"You know, Bow, we never fully ruled out becoming a triad." She doesn't take her eyes off Adora the entire time.

He glances over at her quickly in confusion. Then a look passes between them and Bow smiles slowly.

"I mean, we do deserve to be spoiled, too." Bow abandons the makeup to focus on the blonde. "What do you think, Adora? Should we invite Catra to be in a throuple with us?"

An embarrassing "huh?!?" is all that comes out.

They both crack themselves up. Adora is happy that they're together, maybe just not at this moment.

"Don't worry," Bow says, finally composing himself.

"Catra's moved on anyway," Glimmer teases.

The two of them spend the next hour torturing Adora with this joke, dropping hints as they pass her office or misusing their internal messaging system to try out throuple names. They land on 'Glitrow'. Adora never manages to not freak out, even though the name kinda sounds like the world's worst electronic dance party or a drug you take to get rid of a skin condition.

Adora tries to convince Catra that they have to be at the venue very early to help out with setup but only gets a laugh in response. Her *date* (!) shows up only 45 minutes in advance, telling Adora that the point of paying staff is to have them actually cover everything.

Catra, of course, looks fucking stunning. Adora drops a full file folder when she appears in the doorway of her office, smirking roguishly.

Her thick mane is pulled up in an intentionally messy high ponytail. The tux is as gorgeous as she described it, a rich dark purple velvet that only she would look good in, perfectly tailored and hugging her curves. She pairs it with a crisp white shirt and a black silk bow tie, which are more traditional than Adora expected.

She'd barely been able to be a functioning person around Catra in a suit. Catra in a *tux* is an experience that Adora had not properly prepared for. It's a sight that belongs in a movie about a jewel heist, not standing in front of Adora and looking at her expectantly.

"You begged me to come early and you're not even dressed?"

"H23r$*dfkjn," is the sound Adora's pretty sure she hears from her own mouth.

Catra's smirk morphs into a full toothy grin.

"It's nice, right?" she asks, pretending to smooth down her jacket.

"Come on, Adora," Bow says. "Let's get you ready!"

She startles at his voice. On Catra's right is Bow, in his shiny silver suit and signature crop top, and Glimmer, wearing a pale pink sparkly tight dress with long sleeves that stops a couple inches before her knees. The stylist has teased Glimmer's hair so it's curly and wild and they're both wearing some very bright eye makeup.

They look like they're going to a New Year's Eve party and not a boring work function. So how did she miss that they were standing there *the whole time* ?

“Hurry up. I want to see which dress you chose,” Catra adds. She’s still smiling and Adora maybe gets lost a little bit, trying to reboot her brain and remember how to smile back.

“Fucking useless,” Glimmer whispers before dragging the blonde from the room.

“This is a disaster,” Adora sighs.

As soon as she got home from their shopping excursion, Adora had decided on the lavender dress, since Catra seemed so taken by it. It's still gorgeous but somehow fits her all wrong now. That's even more apparent with the way that her hair is pinned up – her shoulders are too broad, her chest is too big, and on and on. Glimmer’s tried adding all the jewelry that Catra loaned her but it’s hopeless.

“It’s just bad lighting,” Glimmer argues. “Everything looks awful in this bathroom. I’ve been telling you that for years. Do you think Catra raised enough for a remodel?”

“That’s a massive misuse of funds, I’m pretty sure,” Adora replies. “Were my boobs always this big?”

“Yeah, you’ve just been hiding them. What an exciting day out for them!” She leans right into Adora’s chest to say, “Long time no see, little buddies!”

Adora swats her away and pushes her out of the room.

She takes a moment to try to center, like Perfuma would suggest. When that fails, she tries to remember the last thing that was calming. Gentle claws on her arms and a purr rumbling against her back.

Slightly more relaxed, Adora still feels like a schlub playing dress up, but when she walks out, Catra, Bow, and Glimmer all stop talking and just stare.

“I can’t *believe* you bought this, Catra. You’re the architect of your own demise,” Glimmer stage-whispers with a smirk.

“Adora, you look amazing,” Bow sings sweetly.

Catra just nods dumbly in agreement. She’s seen Adora in this dress already so the blonde isn’t quite sure why it’s still having this effect. But she can’t help but be thrilled by the slim possibility of being wanted by Catra.

Once they reach the gala, it’s Adora’s turn to be stunned. The place is gorgeous and it actually looks *fun* for a change. More like a fancy dance party than a stuffy fundraiser. Somehow Catra got them the lounge at a hotel that she swore was the coolest in town. Adora would still like to be home by 11:00 if at all possible, but she doesn't think she’ll be miserable the whole night.

Looking at the hors d'oeuvres, the decorations, the silly photo booth, she turns to Catra.

“Are you sure this is under budget?”

Catra just laughs. “You are truly pragmatic. Yes, we’re under budget and we’ve already hit our fundraising goal. You can just relax and schmooze.”

“I don’t think I can do those two things at the same time.” Adora takes another look around. “I can’t believe you did all this. Thank you. You don’t know how much this means to me.”

“Anything for the kids or whatever,” Catra mumbles, looking away shyly.

The schmoozing sucks but it’s bearable. Catra doesn't leave her side all night, letting herself be led by Adora all over the party. Catra insists they move arm in arm, but every once in a while, a clawed hand moves to the small of her back to guide her around the crowd and Adora can't help the small shiver that goes through her body. Unsurprisingly, everyone is charmed by her companion

and Adora can’t stop beaming every time someone tells them how nice they look together.

All of her usual supporters are so excited that the gala isn't insufferable for once. She gets to meet a lot of new people, apparently all from local law firms and businesses that Catra has ties to. Adora hadn’t actually fully grasped how much money her date had brought in until she was introduced to literally dozens of people eager to meet her, learn more about LAP, and tell her how glowingly Catra talked about her. She pretty much has a permanent blush all night.

Most excitingly, Adora gets to meet Catra’s elusive friends. Catra is mortified by this. Entrapta, a tech genius so confident that she wears *coveralls* to the party, mentions that she knows all about Adora cause their mutual friend won’t stop talking about her. Mermista, Catra’s assistant, says something similar but in a much more direct way. It's hard to hear over the music but Adora's pretty sure she asks if they're fucking.

Scorpia and Perfuma coo lovingly when they see Catra and Adora together.

“Wildcat!” Scorpia yells. “Oh, gosh. You two are just so cute together. I knew you’d hit it off! I told Perfuma – I said, ‘Adora and Catra would mak–’”

“Sweetie,” Perfuma interrupts with a smile. Her eyes are unusually stern, though. Scorpia takes a second to catch on before she theatrically mimes zipping her lips. “You both look lovely. Go have some fun before your big moment, Adora,” she adds with a wink.

Scorpia squeals through her zipped lips. A couple of people behind her are forced to duck the excited swing of her tail.

Catra’s idea of fun is hiding by the bathroom for 10 minutes and critiquing everyone’s outfit to distract Adora from her nerves.

The speech goes well enough. Adora only stumbles a little, though Catra claims that it isn’t noticeable at all and that she was

appropriately inspiring. Adora makes sure to give a huge thanks to Catra, which just makes her blush bright enough to show through her fur.

When people finally stop coming up to her and focus instead on the open bar, Catra pulls Adora to a quiet spot in the corner.

"How are you?" Catra's checked in every few minutes. This is annoying when Bow does it. Catra makes it seem endearing.

"Still fine," Adora giggles. "You?"

"I'm having a blast," she responds with a smile. "What do you need? Water? More food? A cocktail? Bathroom break?"

Adora shakes her head. She wants something but feels a little silly about it. It's not something she usually indulges in.

"Do you want to dance?" she whispers.

Catra glances around the room. "Yeah, but no one's asked me yet."

"Hey!" Adora says, tugging on the jacket of her tux. " *I'm* asking."

" *Are* you?"

Adora playfully huffs. "Catra. Would you please dance with me?"

"Duh," she replies easily. "Anything for you, Dor."

"I'm not good at it so lower your expectations completely."

"I've seen you trip over thin air. I think I'm adequately prepared. Just relax. I'll lead." And Catra carries her off to the dance floor.

It's as awkward as she'd expect. Catra's amazing, moving lightly on her feet and actually keeping to the beat of the fast pop song. Adora's all over the place, trying not to flail and hit anyone or step on Catra's toes. They keep a respectable distance between them, like a middle school dance.

A slightly sexier song comes on, with deep bass that has Catra's hips moving a lot more. Adora's pretty sure she just stands still and watches in a trance. Until Catra grabs her hands and pulls them close together. Claws take hold of Adora's hips and begin to move her to the beat, drawing her further and further into Catra's space.

Catra smells like cedarwood and cloves or something musky and classy like that. She keeps her eyes on her date's face the whole time, completely confident and natural in her movements. Adora's light-headed just watching her.

To keep herself steady, Adora wraps her arms around Catra's neck. Her hands land right at the base of the other woman's mane, the area that she had been allowed to touch the other day.

"Can I pet you here?" the blonde whispers.

"Of course, princess," comes out breathily.

"Princess?"

"Dor, you look like royalty right now. And everyone's finally treating you as such."

"If I'm a princess then what are you?" she asks with a grin, feeling a bit confident.

"Your Lady." Adora immediately blushes. Catra doesn't notice cause she's busy making a dissatisfied face. "Your *Lord* fits better."

Understandably, Adora immediately loses her footing and, quite possibly, her understanding of the world as she knew it. She accidentally grasps Catra's mane a bit harder than she intends to as strong arms lock behind her back to keep her upright.

"Sorry."

Catra lightly shakes her head, like it's no big deal. But when they begin moving together again, they're pressed much more firmly

against each other, chest to chest. Hip to hip. Close enough that Adora can feel the light purr coming from Catra through the thin material of her dress.

It feels safe, being held by Catra in this way. It also feels very risky, like this is too much to hope for.

When the music transitions back to a faster song, it’s both a relief and a heartbreaking travesty. Catra frowns cutely but Adora takes a step back, trying to cool down with some deep breaths.

“Water?” Catra asks.

Adora gives her a relieved smile and a nod.

“Come on, princess.” She puts her on Adora’s lower back to lead her towards the bar. “Let’s find a warm spot afterwards. You’ve been shivering all night.”

“I have something to tell you.”

Catra looks up with a start. They’d been reading side-by-side in silence for the past hour on Adora’s couch. It’s a Saturday but Adora had finance reports to review and Catra had offered to keep her company. So far though, she just seemed to be scrolling true crime memes. Catra's sense of humor was weirdly terrifying.

“Are you in trouble? Do you need a lawyer? Is that why I'm here?” She’s not using her *actual* panic voice, which makes Adora a bit calmer. Just her fake panic voice that’s always somehow charming and cute.

That throws Adora off a bit already.

“I'm attracted to you,” she blurts out. This isn't how she practiced this all week.

Catra smiles enigmatically. “Is that what you have to tell me or is that why I'm here?”

Adora scowls. It's hard to predict Catra's responses under normal circumstances so she shouldn't be surprised by how nonchalant the woman is treating this very serious issue.

"Oh, I'm sorry," Catra says, not sounding remorseful at all. "Is this bad?"

It all comes out in one big rush. "I don't want to make things weird between us. And I don't want to make you uncomfortable. I realized what was happening and I'm such a bad liar that I felt like I should probably just be honest with you. You're really important to me, Cat, and I don't want to fuck this up."

Catra's smile finally slips, probably overwhelmed by how much Adora just escalated herself. She furrows her brow a bit, tail just slowly weaving in the space between them.

"Dor. You do realize that I'm a giant homosexual, right? It's okay to be attracted to me. Encouraged, even."

"Yeah, I know it-. Wait... *encouraged* ?"

Catra waves a hand dismissively. "It's fine. I thought you were. I'm attracted to you too."

Adora blushes. Catra's basically a goddess – she's gorgeous and brilliant and fancy and always smells nice. The blonde always manages to feel like a big, dumb brute next to her. So Catra finding her physically appealing strikes her as literally impossible.

"Re-really?"

"Duh. Have you even *seen* yourself? We're both fucking hot." Catra rolls her eyes with a half-smirk.

"But Glimmer-"

"I don't think someone I went on *three* dates with before she found her true love gives a shit if we find each other attractive."

That’s a good point. Adora relaxes into the couch and lets that sink in.

Okay. Catra thinks she’s cute. That’s good...right? She told Catra about her crush – well, she copped out and said it was just an *attraction* , but she came clean anyway. And Catra is attracted to her.

Is that all? It took Adora 3 months of constantly hanging out to sort out those feelings so she hopes that’s all.

She looks up from her thoughts and catches Catra staring at her, eyes searching.

“What?”

Catra seems nervous, which is strange because Adora’s the one here being weird.

“Is there...anything else you want to tell me? Or ask me maybe?”

Adora shakes her head. This is too much. She starts to reach for her finance reports, something familiar and comforting.

Catra sighs and leans back into the couch, looking uncertain.

“Okay.” She looks away for a moment then takes a deep breath. More collected now, she tells Adora, “Okay, well, let me know if that ever changes.”

Changes how?

“Like…?” Adora isn’t sure if Catra’s thinking what she thinks she’s thinking. Adora is aware that she’s also no longer making sense. “...okay.”

“Okay,” Catra repeats before wincing. She mutters facetiously, “We’ve got 16 years of post-secondary education between the two of us and we can’t come up with another word.”

Adora laughs awkwardly. She is not embarrassed necessarily and she is certainly not calm by any measure, but she’s some place in between that is not normal and she doesn't know how to begin to identify it.

Catra, as always, senses her discomfort. A tail brushes against her forearm gently, the soft stroke helping to ease some tension.

“It’s alright, Dor. This doesn't have to change anything. Unless you want it to.”

“Cool.” She leans her arm closer to Catra, encouraging her tail to keep petting her.

“Cool.” Catra repeats. Her voice sounds tinny.

But Adora shoots her an anxious grin and Catra gives her a slow, reassuring smile.

“Now that that's settled, do you want to start a true crime podcast about lesbians getting catfished with me?”

“Cat, I don't understand most of those words.”

“Okay, finish those boring reports cause I have hours of horror stories to read you.”

Later, cleaning up alone after the dinner that Catra commandeered when she was displeased with the lack of flavor layering, Adora takes some time to just breath. She doesn’t want to overthink the conversation but she indulges herself in wondering if she could be okay with things not changing between them.

Also, all the internet romance stories Catra had read to her made dating anyone else seem like a nightmare, which Adora allows herself to think that maybe her crush did on purpose.

"What do you think she meant?" Adora asks.

She knows that she sounds like Glimmer a couple months ago. She doesn’t care – this is serious and she needs help.

Glimmer smirks. “Why does that sound so familiar? I seem to remember someone reminding me that Catra is pretty straightforward.”

Adora scowls. This isn’t the answer she wanted. Though at this point, she’s spent so much time with Catra that if anyone knows how to unlock any secret meaning in her words, it’s Adora.

“Is there anything you want to ask me? Let me know if that changes,” she repeats Catra’s words yet again. “That could mean anything, right?”

She gets a frustrated sigh in response.

“Are the two of you having fun?” Glimmer asks instead. For a simple question, it feels weirdly loaded.

Adora nods and then pretends to focus on petting Melog.

“You were cute at the gala,” she continues in the same leading voice.

Adora swerves out of convo by directing Glimmer's attention back to their surroundings. “That would look great on you.”

Her best friend clearly doesn’t want to drop this but can’t resist the siren song of a cute shirt. They're in Catra's closet cause Adora went in to say hello to Melog and Glimmer followed to peek around. She gave some excuse about looking for the bathroom but didn’t even invest enough effort to finish her own lie.

Adora found Melog lounging on the huge bed and rolling around cutely. The cat jumped into Adora's arms to burrow as soon as they entered, while Glimmer made a beeline towards the clothes.

She's focusing on a whole section that appears to be slinky tops for going out and skirts that look like they're barely made of

enough material. Adora's never seen Catra in anything like this. Does she...is this an *option* ?

“Are you two snooping?” Catra's raspy voice asks, cutting into Adora's rapidly devolving thoughts.

She jumps a tiny bit, startled. Melog cuddles in closer, seemingly wanting to comfort their new best friend. Catra notices and makes a sound that's a half-trill, half-growl. In response, Melog narrows their eyes and just clings more to Adora.

“Are you two in a fight?” she asks, looking back and forth from the cat to their owner.

“Don't be ridiculous,” Catra says quickly, in a way that tells Adora that they definitely *are* .

“Cats are territorial,” Glimmer interjects casually. Before Catra can say anything, she moves on. “I didn't realize you were a shopaholic. I mean, I should have guessed, but do you ever even *wear* most of this?”

“It's aspirational. One day, a handsome woman will offer to take me out and I'll have an excuse to put on something besides work clothes or sweats.”

“Hopefully *soon* ,” Glimmer mumbles.

Catra shoots her a look that's uncharacteristically bashful, ears lowered against her head, even while her eyes scream bloody murder.

They're interrupted by Bow yelling, “Time for icing!” from the kitchen.

“Don't steal anything,” Catra warns before leaving. “I've catalogued every single item.”

“She hasn't worn half the shit in here,” Glimmer whispers. “How many shirts do you think I could hide in my purse?”

Adora immediately exits, not wanting to be implicated in whatever theft is about to occur. Glimmer tries to follow her quickly, failing to hide the sparkly shirt hanging out of her pocket.

"Put that back," Adora hisses.

"Why did you invite us here if it wasn't to pad my wardrobe?"

"You said you all wanted to be better friends!"

Glimmer rolls her eyes. "If you have a question about Catra, you have to just *ask* her. Bow and I are no help. I want to steal everything in here and Bow's trying to figure out if he can move in and live in that kitchen. I saw him looking up squatter's rights when Catra turned her back earlier."

"Oh, suddenly you're all about direct communication?!"

"You're the worst whisperers in the history of Etheria," Catra calls from the kitchen.

Adora glances over to see her staring at them intently while Bow ices cookies like a professional pastry chef.

"What are you even talking about?" she continues.

"Adora has a question she'd like to ask you," Glimmer offers.

Before Adora can point out all the smuggled shirts on her person, Catra responds, "Yes, Dor?"

Nothing. Absolutely nothing comes to mind. Not a single lie, not even a fake question that she could play off. She looks to Glimmer for help.

That was always going to be a grave mistake.

"How hot would someone have to be for you to let them spit in your mouth?" Glimmer asks casually.

Catra looks at her with pure shock and confusion written across her face. Then she slowly glances over to Adora with a raised eyebrow.

The blonde's mouth opens in horror, her head shaking back and forth dumbly.

Catra saves her from further embarrassment by turning back to Glimmer. "Can you join us in the kitchen for a quick meeting?"

The purple-haired menace is pretty proud of herself when she strolls in, but at least she tucks the shirt a bit further out of sight.

Whispered shouting with a bit of hissing starts floating out of the kitchen. Even Bow joins in. 'Fuck is wrong with you' and 'have any chill' are the only phrases Adora can make out clearly.

She looks down at Melog with their sweet face nestled in the crook of her shoulder.

"You're my only true friend."

"Stop trying to steal my cat and get in here. Your gross healthy snacks are finally cool enough for you to try."

The kitchen doesn't seem like a very safe place, mostly cause the whisper-fighting has barely died down to a quiet lull. But the cookies smell too good to pass up and Catra made a batch specifically for Adora. A healthier alternative to the chocolate abomination that they're all excited about, an oat cookie with cranberries, sunflower seeds, and cinnamon. It's delicious and wholesome and the cookie of Adora's dreams.

Melog is reluctant to get down and let Adora free her hands, though. For a creature that's usually half-conscious, they're surprisingly aware of when they're about to be abandoned and they dig their claws deeper into Adora's shirt every time she tries to deposit them. She ends up having to carry them with her to the other room.

“Any advice on extracting myself from Melog?”

Catra finishes setting out way too many cookies for 4 people. They look like they were professionally baked.

“Everyone knows you don’t pick up a cat unless you don’t have anywhere to be for the next few hours,” Catra replies. “Come here.”

Adora moves closer, expecting to have the kitten taken away.

Instead, Catra orders, “Open your mouth.”

Adora flusters. She doesn’t want to kink-shame or anything but she’s never...and in front of her friends?! And also, *what* ?! The context is all wrong!

She manages to stutter out, "L-l-look. What Glimmer said... *I* would neve-...I mean...if-if *you* -"

"For a cookie," Catra adds firmly. "Really starting to regret inviting you all over."

"Too late," Glimmer tells her. "We know where you live now. We'll be here all the time."

Adora wonders how long it'll be until Glimmer weasels her way into a key.

Still apprehensive, the blonde opens and Catra shoves half of a cookie inside. Catra impatiently waits for her reaction, staring intensely. It's heaven. The flavor, the softness, everything is perfect and Adora gets all warm inside knowing that Catra made it just for her, even though she herself will never touch ‘that healthy hippie nonsense’ as she calls it.

Appeased, Catra joins the other two in having dark chocolate cookies topped with a chocolate ganache and sprinkles (clearly Bow’s doing). Just looking at it gives Adora a toothache.

They’re all moaning and groaning about how good it is. Fakers. Adora will not be tempted.

“Just one bite,” Glimmer urges.

“I don’t like my sweets too sweet!”

“It’s balanced,” Bow argues, defending his recipe.

“Open,” Catra orders again.

Adora parts her lips just a tiny fraction but that’s enough for Catra to push a quarter of the baked good inside. That strategy was a mistake because she ends up with frosting all over her mouth.

It’s so good. Better than it should be really, and Adora has to fight to not instinctively compare it to the other batch, which now feels bland and one-dimensional in her memory. She doesn’t even like chocolate that much.

Against her will, a groaned “fuck” comes out of her mouth that makes Catra straighten up while her tail starts weaving with interest. Adora tries to look away quickly, since she’s licking around her own mouth like a goober and that could come off as...suggestive.

There’s enough mixed signals. They don’t need any more.

“Missed a spot,” Catra says, voice sounding just a little huskier than usual.

Catra reaches over and gently wipes her thumb across the edge of Adora’s upper lip. Before sucking it into her own mouth. Without breaking eye contact with Adora. Fucking hell.

While she’s sure her voice is two octaves too high, Adora does manage to say, “I better go wash up,” before fleeing from the room and the butterflies in her stomach and, likely, her dignity.

“Well, it was nice to know Adora. RIP,” Glimmer laughs behind her.

Chapter End Notes

like a real party, i was excited to buy new clothes and get ready and then lost interest in being at the actual party very quickly.

chapter 7 preview! emotional roller coasters and also actual roller coasters.

Two Stray, Feral Cats

Chapter Summary

> Catra meets another cat and thinks ketchup doesn't belong on hot dogs.

Chapter Notes

> well, i finished my other fic, wicked games, yesterday so i'm moving forward with updating this fic twice per week. expect tuesday AND friday posting from now on. this is a good week to start cause chapters 7 and 8 have a similar vibe and then 9 and 10 come in next week and kick adora right in the knees.
>
> also, yesterday's wicked games and today's chapter introduce a very similar character...
>
> warning - if reading about someone else's amusement park-induced anxiety causes you anxiety, then maybe skip from the entrance to the park down to "photo?".

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora has a 9-step plan now. She’s going to try to sort out how she feels about Catra, she’s going to try to pay really good attention to how Catra feels about her, she’s going to maybe ask Perfuma’s thoughts, and then the other 6 steps are just random fantasies she has about Catra falling for her. The 9th step is Catra, hopefully, confessing her feelings for Adora cause the blonde's sure that she wouldn't be able to take the leap first.

Adora doesn't want to tell Glimmer about the plan but feels obliged to give her some kind of a heads up.

“I..uh, I'm trying to figure some stuff out,” she announces while they’re eating lunch together.

Glimmer barely looks up from her sandwich. “Like what? Wardrobe update? How to ask for help? Better coping mechanisms?”

“...why did you have that list ready?”

“I think I'd make a really good life coach,” she explains with a shrug.

Well, that's frightening. Glimmer Moon yelling at people about what's wrong with them comes to mind. Though, at least she'd be getting paid for it, instead of doing it with no consent or compensation like now.

“With Catra, I mean.”

“Oh! Great!” Glimmer smiles and puts down her food to fully focus.

“You're fine with that?” Adora asks with some surprise.

“I'm your best friend. Of course I'm fine with that.”

“And if anything ever happened...?”

“Please Gods, can something happen?” she throws her hands up in the air in exasperation. “I'm about two seconds away from abandoning you two together in the woods to get you to actually talk about your feelings.”

It's pretty unclear why that's the strategy. But that's classic Glimmer.

“Catra and I are fine. We talk plenty. We've established a friendship that exists outside of this embarrassing dance that you two are destined to do forever. If you don't want to make a move, you're gonna have to find a better excuse than my feelings.”

“I’m not looking for excuses!” Adora argues.

“Well, they're certainly not looking for you so. Get. It. Together. Girl.”

So fine. Adora mostly got the green light to move ahead with her plan. She was tempted to use the project management app that Catra made her download to capture all the steps but realized that Catra was very likely to open the app without notice just to make sure Adora was following her advice so that wasn’t safe.

As part of the plan, Adora decided to try to take Catra to do more things that she enjoyed so Adora could see more of Catra’s life and figure out if they made sense together. She could imagine Glimmer telling her that she was overthinking this. She did not care.

Also, she was pretty interested in trying to do something for Catra, who spent so much time supporting Adora. It would be nice to take care of her for a change.

Unfortunately, encouraging Catra to pick more things for them to do was frightening. The woman’s idea of fun – *real* fun, she’d say with a wicked twinkle in her eye – was always way out of Adora’s comfort zone. Go to that weird bar that gives you a bat and lets you smash tv screens. Eat edibles and go to the aquarium. A nighttime tour of an abandoned train tunnel.

“You know I didn’t grow up classy,” Catra shrugged. “You shouldn’t be surprised by this.”

“You’re literally trying to take me to the wrong side of the tracks though.”

Catra vowed to keep trying. Adora was afraid of that.

After a couple days, she came up with the perfect idea (her words) and wouldn’t let Adora out of it. Mostly, because she told all of the staff at LAP who let it leak to the kids. Catra had a client who owned the largest, and most dangerous, in Adora’s opinion, amusement park in the city. Apparently, he was so wrapped around her finger that when she asked for free tickets for 50 kids

in foster and group homes, he had them sent over along with food vouchers and arcade credits and passes to skip the lines.

The amusement park. She couldn't use work as an excuse to get out of it. Catra made it clear that it could only happen if she and Adora went, though she suspected that the woman wouldn't *actually* back out of it if she herself did.

If Adora wasn't so shocked, she would have been impressed at being harangued into this.

"You can't say no," Catra reminded her with a fang-filled smirk. "Everyone's *soooo* excited."

As expected, once Glimmer and Bow were involved, they gave Catra lots of 'helpful' ideas of how to coordinate this more easily and suddenly she had volunteers for transportation and supervision. And shirts. Catra got *shirts* made for Gods' sake.

So there Adora stood on a Saturday morning in early spring, wearing a silly navy blue tshirt with LAP's logo, pretending to smile and be excited as she greeted the kids while they entered the park. Catra was 'supervising' Mermista, who had a clipboard and was actually doing all the work to make sure everyone had a buddy and all of their necessary accompaniments.

She felt a bit bad for Mermista but she also knew that on top of a salary that was likely higher than Adora's, Catra absolutely spoiled the woman with free meals and clothes and all sorts of treats to make up for all the silly tasks she had to do. And once everything was settled, Mermista would be able to hang out and have fun too. She even got to bring her boyfriend. Adora thought he said his name was 'Sea Hawk' but she was certain that she misheard.

The kids all seem fucking thrilled.

"This isn't leadership development," Adora mumbles through her forced smile.

Hands land on her hips from behind. “It’s socialization,” Catra murmurs in her ear.

“Someone could die, Catra.”

She just laughs in response. “If anything, the rides are extra safe today. Injuring a bunch of orphans would be terrible for business.” That’s not comforting at all.

She turns Adora around to face her. If possible, since Adora’s confession, Catra’s been even more in her personal space. It’s both hot and confusing.

Catra also wears a tshirt, which looks out of place on her. It’s probably two sizes too small and tied at the waist. Adora can’t even look at it straight on and remember her own name. Thankfully, it’s mostly hidden under an oversized dark gray cardigan and a thin midnight blue denim jacket that matches her tight low-rise jeans. Adora didn’t realize they could be *stylish* or anything so she just threw on sweats and a hoodie.

She can’t even fucking get *started* on Bow and Glimmer who both cropped and bedazzled their shirts and managed to make a whole outfit happen. She refuses to stand near them, not wanting Catra to compare her to the two of them. At least Scorpia and Perfuma have the decency to dress like regular people forced to wake up early on the weekend.

Once most everyone is inside and settled, Catra tries to grab her hand and lead her away.

“I’m waiting on my buddy,” Adora argues.

“ *I’m* your buddy, dummy.”

“No, I mean one of the youth.”

“Nope. Too many volunteers. Guess you’re stuck with me.” She leans in so close that Adora gulps audibly. That just makes Catra smile and lean in closer.

“Miss Adora, is it too late?” a tiny voice asks, out of breath.

She turns to see one of the younger kids rushing up to her. They left the door on the van wide open and the driver has to get out with a grumble to close it. They don’t even look back for a second.

“Finn, no running today please,” Adora admonishes. “It’s not too late though. What happened? Did you oversleep?”

“No time to tell you!” they yell.

They grab her hand and try to lead her into the park, much like Catra had done. She turns back to her friend to triumphantly show that she has found a buddy after all. Only to find Catra looking oddly at Finn.

Oh, right. Adora had wanted to find a good time to do this, ever since she saw the young cat in one of their courses. They were only around 7 but whip-smart. Small, kinda like Catra, and had very similar coloring, if only a slight shade lighter. Their hair was more of a blonde wavy mop though with a bushy blonde tail to match.

Catra had mentioned before that she hadn’t really ever known another cat person. A wolf, a fox, various other reptiles. Adora really wanted to warn her before she ever saw Finn.

Finn glances back when they realize she isn’t moving. Adora tries to reach a calming hand out to Catra. But Finn nearly shrieks when they see her, which makes Catra hiss. So now Adora’s standing between two literal stray, feral cats.

“What’s your problem, kid?” Catra asks. It’s not hard but maybe a bit colder than Adora would speak to a child.

Finn’s ears flatten against their head.

“Sorry!” Catra mumbles quickly. “I didn’t mean that. What’s your name?”

“Finn,” they say quietly. “My pronouns are they and them.”

Catra smiles, a little amused and surprised. Adora’s never seen her smile this softly before. She wants to hug her but thinks she should probably let this play out.

“I’m Catra. She/her.”

Finn looks amazed. “Your name is Cat?”

“- *tra* ,” she emphasizes, but Adora knows from experience that Finn’s going to do whatever they want. This likely includes calling her Cat for the rest of the day.

They walk up to Catra slowly, assessing her tail, her claws. They get on their tiptoes to try and look up at her eyes and ears.

“Woah,” they whisper. “You have cool eyes.”

“Uh, thanks?” Catra glances at Adora like she doesn’t know what to do next. Adora shrugs in response. “I like your...hair. Your tail’s pretty cool too.”

Finn brightens up considerably. “Thanks,” they chirp. “Can you take me inside now?”

Still holding Adora’s hand, they reach for Catra’s.

“Sure?”

She slowly lets this hand-holding happen. It occurs to Adora that Catra’s never really interacted this much with any of the LAP youth.

“Finn can be our third buddy,” Adora says in a voice that she hopes is reassuring. “It’ll be fun.”

They’re tiny. They’ll be a good excuse not to go on any of the most terrifying rides.

“Oh, no!” she hears Bow shout. “Finn’s *my* favorite. I already signed up to be their buddy.”

When Adora looks up, Bow and Glimmer are giving Catra a very intense look, like the three of them are all in on a secret. Finn frowns and looks back at Catra for confirmation.

“Yeah, Finn, we thought you were our favorite too,” Glimmer says in a fake sad voice that would only fool a child.

“It’s okay, buddy,” Catra tells them. “Bow and Glimmer are a lot more fun than Miss Adora, right?”

Reluctantly, they nod. Catra has to stifle her laugh.

“But we can go on a ride together,” Finn replies, hopeful.

“Yeah, I’ll find you and hang out,” Catra says. “Promise.”

She means it, it seems. This is somehow making her impossibly more attractive to Adora.

Finn agrees to those terms and lets go of their hands to move towards Bow and Glimmer. Before they head in together, Finn stops and looks back at Catra.

“What’s your favorite thing here?” they call out. “I-I’ve never been.”

“There’s some go-karts and I think I finally figured out how to break them and make them go twice as fast.” The excited gleam in her eyes matches Finn’s exactly. “I’ll show you how to do it.”

“No, she won’t,” Adora yells.

‘Yes, I will,’ Catra mouths to Finn and they skip into the entrance, dragging their new chaperones with them.

With no children to look after, Adora’s forced to follow Catra into the park. It’s pandemonium, like she imagined, all screaming and

speeding rides. She thinks Catra will remember her reluctance to do this and start with something easy.

Catra leads them directly to the biggest rollercoaster there, a monstrosity so tall that Adora can't see the peak once they're up close to it. Besides the drop, there's loops and twists to boot. She can't possibly be serious about this.

"Oh, I totally am," Catra tells her. Adora was so panicked, she didn't realize inside thoughts were audible.

"I can't do this."

"You have to," she nods sagely. "Trust me, Dor, it's easier if you do the biggest one first. All of the other ones are a piece of cake after that. Plus, you want to ride it before lunch or else you'll puke as soon as you step off."

The rest of her protests go unheard. Catra isn't interested in the statistics of how many people are injured each year in amusement parks. She perks up at some of the horror stories of what happens to them, but assures Adora that she'll research that on her own later. When Adora decides that the best way to avoid this is just to stop moving, Catra wraps both of her arms around Adora from behind and uses the blonde's ensuing mental shutdown to maneuver her into the line. Because of their dumb express passes, they don't even have to wait to get on.

"It'll be fine," Catra assures her, strapping them both in.

"Oh, hey, guys!" she hears behind them. Two rows back are Scorpia and Perfuma, waving wildly. So Adora will have witnesses to her death.

Catra waves back but Adora can only manage a grimace. She must already be starting to look a little green cause their excitement immediately changes to concern.

"She's fine," Catra pipes up. "Tell her the ride is safe."

"Oh, totally, buddy," Scorpia agrees. "Safe as houses. Wow, that's a random saying. Entrapta looked it up for us last time. The history of injury, not the saying. Anyway, it's incredibly safe."

"Yes, Adora," Perfuma agrees. "Catra also forced me to ride it last summer and it was quite safe." She pauses. "I *was* sick after…"

"I told you not to eat that veggie burger before!" Catra defends. She turns back to Adora, "You'll be fine, princess."

Adora begins looking for the exit immediately. But it's too late. She hears a metallic click and they're locked in. Sheer panic rises in her throat.

Catra loops their arms and takes Adora's hand. If she wasn't sure that this will increase their chances of horrible injury, Adora would be elated about this contact.

Then, Catra leans over so close that her lips practically touch Adora's ear.

"You have to let go and relax," she whispers.

"That's really not my thing," Adora groans.

"It's gonna be really uncomfortable if you try to fight. Trust me. Don't try to brace yourself, just let your body go with the movement of the ride."

"I can't do that."

And even though they're on a death trap, Catra lays her head on Adora's shoulder. Like they're just sitting on the couch to watch a movie. Against her will, Adora practically melts.

The ride chooses that moment to begin.

The ascent isn't awful but the anticipation starts to get to her in the 20 seconds it takes to go up. Catra nuzzles her neck until the grip on her hand softens a bit.

“Close your eyes,” Catra whispers in a voice so low that it gives Adora goosebumps. She does as told. “Don’t open them til I squeeze your hand again, okay?”

Adora nods, mostly still lost in the feeling.

The ride stills for about a second. Before she can brace herself for falling, Catra raises their adjoined hands in the air. And then everything drops from underneath Adora. She hears Catra maniacally cackle and tries to focus on that sound instead of the sensation of being thrown out of an airplane. The hand in hers begins squeezing frantically and Adora opens her eyes to see that they’re only about 6 feet from the ground now. Catra keeps their arms in the air and nuzzles into Adora’s neck again.

There’s a loop-de-loop. A twist that turns them upside down for a few moments. The whole thing really happens so fast and Catra’s so distracting that Adora manages to find it extremely thrilling. It’s over before she knows it.

At the end, Catra turns to her with the broadest smile.

“Fucking amazing, right?”

Adora can feel how red her face is, how she still hasn't fully caught her breath. The restraints unlock and Catra has to pull her out cause she’s a little wobbly. Once they’re by the exit, Adora can’t help herself – full of adrenaline, she whirls Catra around to face her and grabs both of her biceps to keep her in place.

“I didn’t die,” Adora whispers frantically. She thinks she might be smiling. “That was *terrifying* .”

Catra’s still laughing. She pulls Adora closer by the collar of her hoodie unless the two of them are pressed together.

“Were you truly alive before it?”

“I wouldn’t go that far,” Adora chuckles. “But yeah, that was something.”

“Don’t worry – we’ve got plenty of more to ride. Now, come on, I want to see how embarrassing you look in the photo.”

“Photo?”

Adora didn’t realize this was a thing – commemorative pictures from the ride. She looks terrible in the photo, like she’s just been frightened by a ghost. Apparently Catra knew exactly where the camera was because she’s smiling and flipping it off with the hand that’s not in Adora’s, face still nuzzled in the blonde’s neck.

The silly souvenir photos are ridiculously expensive but Catra tries to buy one anyway. It takes Scorpia and Perfuma to convince her not to, preserving some of Adora’s dignity. They of course look very cute and precious in their picture.

Catra drags them all to the next ride, a slightly less intimidating coaster. It continues like this until lunch, since she seems to have the whole park memorized and all of her favorite things flagged. Adora must admit that the rides themselves get less terrifying but the intimate contact with Catra does not.

Scorpia and Perfuma break from them to go on some cheesy water ride that Catra refuses to try. They catch sight of Bow and Glimmer heading to the food court with Finn. Catra is surprisingly excited about this.

“You eat here?” Adora asks, puzzled. Catra enjoys a good meal like no one she’s ever met before.

“The food is awful but it’s all the shit I never got to have as a kid so I’m going to eat until I puke,” she replies.

High off the good time, Adora decides to try her hand at flirting a little. “That’s a shame. You look so cute in this outfit.”

Catra stops and turns to her, pulling her close by her hoodie again. She smiles slowly, almost seductively.

“You get to hold back my hair, you lucky girl,” Catra whispers.

Thank the Gods she's basically holding Adora steady right now, cause the blonde nearly swoons at the tone, completely ignoring Catra's actual *words* . And then Catra cackles and runs up to the counter. She doesn't even ask if Adora wants anything.

Adora moves over towards her two other friends. They had been heading to order when they stopped for Adora and Catra. Now they just stand there and look at her amused.

"Finn," Glimmer begins, "why don't you wait in line with Catra? She'll get you literally anything you want."

They end up getting down on all fours just to sprint faster towards her. There will now be *two* vomiting cats, Adora imagines. Bow and Glimmer, meanwhile, lead her to a table. It's unclear why they look so mischievous.

"Sooooo," Bow starts and Adora now finally understands what's happening. "Are you two having a cute day?"

Adora refuses to react the way they clearly want her to, all bumbling embarrassment and rosy cheeks.

Instead, she shrugs casually, "It's more fun than I expected."

"Catra's great," Bow offers, voice sounding very *leading* .

"Yeah," Adora nods. "We have fun. It's pretty amazing that she did all this for the kids and she was a *dream* with the gala."

"She's a good egg," Glimmer adds. "She damn near worships you and she treats you well."

Adora can tell that they're ramping up to give her advice about Catra. Since they got together, the two of them have convinced themselves that they're relationship experts. If Adora has to hear them talk about how 'it's okay to be afraid to make a move if you don't know how the other person feels but it's so worth it, blah blah', she's going to gag them.

Oddly, instead, Bow says, “I’m really happy for you two.”

“Yeah, it’s about time that this happened,” Glimmer agrees.

When realization hits Adora, she chokes on literally nothing.

“ *What?!* ”

She turns around to make sure Catra’s too far away to pick it up with her sensitive hearing. She’s still in line, chatting away with Finn, ears facing forward.

Lower, Adora clarifies, speaking way too quickly, “Do you think we’re dating? We’re not dating.”

Glimmer and Bow exchange a strained look with each other. Bow seems to lose the silent argument.

He begins by clearing his throat. “Adora,” he dramatically pauses to make sure he has her full attention. “You took her as your date to a formal event. Wearing matching outfits. That she purchased for you. You told her you liked her. Then you told her to pick a date where you can do something she likes.”

“You’re dating,” Glimmer summarizes.

“No,” Adora is proud that her voice comes out calmly. Because inside, she feels like she might pass out. “She came as my *date* , not necessarily *on* a date. I told her that I was *attracted* to her, not that I was... *interested* . And this was supposed to be a friendly outing for me to gather more information. Plus, it’s not really a date if both of you and everyone from work is here.”

They’re about to protest when she continues, “Honestly, I’m not really even sure why we’re *friends* . It’s not like I have anything to offer Catra. She’s amazing and funny and well-connected and successful. And *gorgeous* . She’ssofuckinggorgeous.” She says the last part almost breathless.

Glimmer jumps in before she can sound like a total creep. “Adora, you’re a great friend. From what I’ve learned about Catra, she's been alone a lot. She has plenty of folks in her orbit, but she doesn’t let people in easily. After Scorpia, you’re probably closest to her right now. You’re steady and solid and a lot of people need that. And sure, she’s got a nice life but you’re no slouch either – you’re doing something important in the world.”

Bow jumps in to add, “You’re beautiful and you’re thoughtful. You've got the hugest heart and everyone loves you. Catra would be lucky to have you.”

Only some of those things feel true about Adora. She is indeed steady and solid. Boring.

“Catra likes exciting things. I’m not fun. I’m not, like, an entertaining, cool person like you, Glimmer. You’re the last person she dated.”

“Look, I never really wanted to tell you this, but I'm pretty sure I was her second choice the night we all met. Honestly, it was truly an honor just to be nominated.” She says the last part while glancing over at Catra’s figure.

Adora looks over at Bow, expecting him to be at least a tad jealous, but he’s doing the same. Fair. Catra is very attractive.

“You can’t possibly mean she was into me,” Adora protests.

“She asked you to get drinks that night,” Glimmer reminds her. “And pretty much right before each one of our dates. In hindsight, it was probably a red flag that I was never jealous.”

Bow confidently smirks, just a little.

“It’s not like tha-” Adora stops when she hears Finn’s voice, babbling all kinds of questions about the food.

“No, you don’t get to put ketchup on your corn dog,” Catra replies.

“But it’s my favorite,” Finn tells her with a smile.

“You’re incorrect,” she says, as if that should win the argument.

“I’m gonna do it,” they respond. “I’ll let you try it if you’re nicer.”

“I just bought you 20 pounds of junk. I’m practically a saint.”

“And you’re taking me to the go-karts,” Finn agrees.

Catra drops the overflowing tray of gross greasy amusement park food on the table and whips around to Finn. She crouches down so they're closer to eye-level.

“Listen to me,” she says firmly but in a kind voice. “Remember. Never negotiate against yourself. If you’re trying to get something from someone, don’t agree with them. You’re ruining your own argument. Do you know what you should have told me instead?”

Finn thinks for a moment. “About all the stuff you didn’t let me buy?”

“Exactly!”

They high five. Yes, Bow coos and Adora nearly cries.

Catra sits next to Adora, with Finn on her other side. Without another word, they dig in. Finn puts ketchup on their corndog, much to Catra’s disgust.

“What did you two talk about in line?” Adora asks.

“Cat’s teaching me to become a lawyer,” Finn replies with a mouth full of food.

“It seemed like a good idea after they asked me how to hotwire a car,” Catra adds, mouth also full. When she swallows, she whispers to Adora, “Kid’s fucking hilarious.”

“Cat’s gonna buy me a suit,” they announce.

Catra tries to shove a fry into Adora’s mouth against her will.

“That was mostly a joke about their court date after they steal that car. I gave them my card just in case though.”

Somehow, Bow and Glimmer are lucky enough to get a reasonable amount of food. Adora tries to pick out whatever is healthiest but that’s a losing battle.

She’s still worried about Catra and Finn getting sick so she convinces all of them to do the low-risk attractions, the haunted house, some 3-D shooting thing, and a couple arcade games. As cliched as it is, she still tries to win a prize for Catra who mocks her so mercilessly for being such a sap that Adora completely fucks up and loses. Finn insists on Catra giving them a pickeyback ride to the next game and the cuteness of that sight more than makes up for Adora’s disappointment.

Together, the two cats move around at light-speed, with everyone else struggling to keep up. Spotting another terrorizing coaster, they both run up to it. When Adora reaches them, they have matching disappointed frowns.

“Kid’s too short to ride,” Catra huffs. She doesn’t even offer to go without them.

“Ferris wheel?” Bow suggests.

Catra doesn’t look convinced. She glances at Finn, who doesn't seem to know what it is though.

“It’s kinda scary at the top,” she explains to them. “Really high up.”

“Let’s go!” and they rush off.

When the others get there, Adora’s surprised that Catra and Finn are patiently waiting, instead of just jumping on. Finn takes Bow and Glimmer’s hands and leads them to the entrance. It’s not until Adora and Catra watch them get into their car that she sees the

look that Finn's giving the older cat. Right before the bar comes down, they wink and give her a thumbs up.

"More subtle, kid," Catra whispers. With their ears, Finn picks it up clearly and drops their hand.

Adora tries not to mention it. How close Catra sits next to her in the car is a good distraction to panic about instead. The woman is *plastered* to her side. When Adora raises an eyebrow, Catra shrugs.

"I'm scared," she says, never sounding more confident in her life.

Adora laughs and puts her arm around Catra's shoulder. In return, she looks a little surprised but purrs very quietly.

"It's like high school," Adora remarks.

Catra chuckles at her, "You were the jock who took girls on the ferris wheel?"

"I wish," she scoffs. "That was my cheesy, embarrassing dream. To have this girl I was crushing on wear my letterman jacket and take her on the ferris wheel and kiss."

"Why didn't that happen?"

"I was too busy trying to be valedictorian and play sports and be on student council, etc. She was too straight. Or maybe she just wasn't into me. I'm still not really sure which."

"Hmm," Catra hums. "What was she like?"

"Oh, she was a total badass. The opposite of me. She was a gymnast and she smoked cigarettes behind the school. She had a bellyring and Bow's fashion sense, weirdly. She always wore a croptop or a shredded shirt with denim cutoffs usually and a leather jacket."

"Honestly, I'm in love just hearing about her," Catra replies.

The ride continues on slowly, them coming close to the top.

“What were you like in high school?” Adora asks, very curious. “Wait! Can I guess?”

She’s sure what she has in mind is either going to be spot-on or Catra’s going to fling her from the car, dozens of feet to the ground.

Catra tilts her head so she can see Adora’s face more fully.

“You’ll never get it.”

Adora smiles smugly.

“I know you’re just trying to psych me out. You were super emo in high school. I bet you had really straight bangs but left the rest of your hair all wild. You wore all black. You wrote poems about death.”

“And I will never, ever let you read them,” Catra replies, completely shameless. “Good guess.”

“Was not a guess,” she murmurs. “Did you have a girlfriend?”

Catra laughs in a mirthless way. “I had an online girlfriend who I could only talk to at school cause we didn’t have internet at home. Still don’t know what she actually looked like...or if she was even a teenage girl. I kissed two girls, one on a school trip and one under the bleachers during track practice. I spent the whole time worried Weaver was gonna freak out and skin me alive or something.”

She’s mentioned her foster mother a few times before. Adora’s got enough experience to know that the woman was more than just *unpleasant* but Catra’s never mentioned anything specific enough to confirm that hunch.

Carefully, she says, “You do a lot of stuff now to make up for lost time it sounds like.”

Catra tilts her head to catch Adora's eyes again. "Maybe I'm nourishing my inner child or something more healthy than what you're making it sound like."

"I'm not judging," she replies quickly. "Just curious."

Catra shrugs. "Honestly, this is probably too dark for a ferris wheel ride but I didn't really imagine I'd make it this long." Adora knows that feeling. "So yeah, I know I'm lucky and privileged to be able to have all the shit I always wanted now – security, food whenever, a place I own, space to just be myself – and I make sure to enjoy it."

"...you *own* that apartment?!"

Catra just hushes her and tucks further into Adora's side.

"You should use your other arm too. I'm really *really* scared." When Adora wraps her other arm around Catra, she continues, "It's just stuff. It doesn't matter as much as it used to. The nostalgia is nice though sometimes. Comforting. In my old age, I'm starting to appreciate comfort and calm, for a change."

Adora just nods in understanding. Catra starts purring and doesn't stop until they have to get off the ride. Finn's giving her a thumbs up as they exit.

Catra allows herself to be convinced not to tamper with the go-kart. Adora isn't sure if she actually does know how to soup up the vehicle but she reasons that it's better not to try for Finn's first ride.

They continue on like that for the rest of the day, she and Catra breaking off sometimes to go their own way or other groups joining for a bit. By the end of the day, Finn has a sugar crash and Adora has to carry them back to the van. Half-asleep and grumpy, they refuse to let go of Catra's hand the entire time.

Chapter End Notes

i'm sure nothing in this chapter will ever come up again...

Just a Hint of Sandalwood

Chapter Summary

Adora saves Catra. Twice. The weirdest Saturday morning.

Chapter Notes

happy friday! this feels like the queerest chapter so far to me. is it the basketball? i don't know but probably.

all of y'all in the comments: i love adora.
also y'all: is she gonna be married to catra with 5 kids and still thinking they're just friends cause jfc adora??!??!
a couple of y'all: catra is just as much of a disaster. we need to raise awareness of this.

i see zero lies anywhere there.

there's some stuff at the end with prescription drug use which is mostly harmless but it starts after the 2nd vertical line. you can jump from there down to "you have a very rude visitor" if you want to skip it.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Spring meant that more of the rec leagues were starting up again at the local community center. Adora still didn't have time to consistently join one but she agreed to a game when one of her former teammates, Netossa, insisted that they needed a sub. Just one game, Adora promised.

When she casually mentions it one day, Catra gets maybe a little too excited. She claims it's about the possibility of watching Adora fall multiple times but that doesn't seem to be the complete truth. So Adora invites her. This is good. She's good at basketball kinda and Catra seems to like her muscles so it's a good excuse to show off. Maybe tease her a bit.

Adora probably should have realized that she'd never be able to one-up Catra.

The blonde wears the tightest racerback tank she can find, leaving a lot of her upper body on display, and a pair of basketball shorts that are a bit more fit than she'd usually go for. She's stretching when Catra arrives, which at least gives her an excuse for how red she gets in the face.

Catra enters and immediately struts up to her, distracting Adora and most of the other women on the court. She's in acid-washed cutoff jeans, a vintage band t-shirt that's cut into a crop top, and a black leather jacket to top it all off. Adora probably won't remember what her high school crush looked like ever again.

" *Hey* , Adora," Catra practically purrs.

Adora attempts to stand up from a lunge as coolly as possible.

" *Hey* , Catra," she parrots. She makes sure to flex lightly as she steps closer and gets a quiet trill for her efforts. "Nice outfit."

It's the understatement of the century.

"You think so?" Catra smiles. "Wanted to try something new. Got inspired the other day."

She does a small twirl to show off the look and Adora's tongue almost falls out of her mouth when she sees how the shorts just barely cover Catra's ass.

The front is no less distracting. There's a sea of fuzzy midriff that Adora can't quite take her eyes off of. She wants to buy real estate and live there forever.

"Netossa mentioned we could use one more person," Adora mumbles absently. "If you're down. I could probably find you some gym clothes."

And then she almost slaps herself in the face for suggesting that Catra should ever change out of this outfit.

“Nevermind. You’re good here,” Adora continues.

“If you say so,” Catra replies. “Honestly, I’d do anything for you, Dor, but I’m not trying to sweat today. Not in *public* , at least.”

Catra smirks and very slowly removes her jacket. The shirt apparently has lost its sleeves and most of the sides, leaving even more fur and a surprisingly dainty-looking black lace bra exposed.

Adora doesn't even notice when tipoff’s about to start.

Another miscalculation – since Adora’s on the court for most of the game, Catra has a lot of time and space on the opposite benches to be approached by every other woman in the building. Every single time she looks over, someone’s trying to chat Catra up, raking their eyes over her barely-covered body. To her relief, Catra seems to politely shoot down each one. But Adora spends so much time distracted that she gets hit in the head with the ball twice and misses more than a few shots.

“Looking good, Dor!” Catra cheers each time, cackling loudly.

“Get your head in the game, Gray,” Netossa whispers. “Can you and your girl stop eye-fucking? You damn near made *Huntara* blush.”

When she wasn’t being hit on, Catra had been watching the court closely but Adora wouldn’t say it was quite that...intense.

She plays a bit better after that, thinking it was her last chance to impress Catra. It occurs to her that maybe it was a bit immature to try to use her old moves from high school. And that they didn’t actually work back then either. But Catra *did* wear that outfit, so maybe she's fine indulging Adora a bit here.

At the end of the game, Catra rushes up to her and throws her arms around Adora’s neck, not seeming to mind at all that she’s

gross from all the exertion.

“I’m sweaty,” the blonde laughs, only sorta trying to push her away. She pretends not to notice Catra sniffing her and trilling again.

“I've made a terrible mistake,” Catra whispers in her ear.

Before Adora can question that, she sees Huntara, the giant purple muscle-bound center from the other team coming over towards them.

“Oh, hey, Blondie,” she greets.

She knows Adora’s name. It’s been shared many times. Adora is pretty sure this is just Huntara’s power move.

Like a reflex, Adora wraps her arms protectively around Catra’s waist.

She tries to muster up all the confidence she has to ask, “What’s up, Huntara?”

“Just wanted to chat more with the kitty. Didn’t realize she was taken.”

Adora smiles down at the woman in her arms as smugly as possible. She doesn’t even care that Huntara could crush her like a grape.

“Are you taken, Cat?”

Catra just hides her face in Adora’s sweaty neck. A tail swats up near her nose, a clear sign to stop being intentionally difficult.

Their third wheel grunts impatiently.

The blonde shrugs at Huntara. “Guess so.” When Huntara walks away, Adora can’t hold back her laugh. “Not your type either?”

Catra pulls back to glare at Adora. “What’s with you and that?”

Wanting to steer away from the landmine of all of her insecurities, Adora pivots the attention back to Catra.

"You turned a lot of heads in this outfit," she jokes.

"Look, I told her I came for someone else but she didn't care to listen." She leans a bit closer, pretending to be thinking of something. Catra head's back on Adora's shoulder when she whispers, entirely too suggestively, "Maybe cause I told her that my plan for tonight was to go home and play with my little pussycat."

Adora doesn't even have an appropriate amount of time to be scandalized. With a final pleased trill, Catra has her arm in one hand and is reaching for her gym bag with the other, rushing out to their playdate with Melog.

Catra
10:46am
I fucking hate this plan
Are you still on your way?

Adora
10:52am
Well, it was your idea so...
And yeah. I'm getting dressed.
What are you wearing?

Catra
10:53am
Right now?
Just a hint of sandalwood
;)

Adora
10:55am
Is that a clothing brand?

Catra
10:59am
...
Nevermind
I regret everything

When Adora arrives at the apartment, Catra's wearing a pale green canvas jumpsuit with the long sleeves and pant legs rolled up. On her feet are cute little off-white high-top canvas sneakers.

"Well, now I definitely don't get your text," Adora opens with, shoving her hands in her cozy beat up jeans.

"It's my cologne," is all Catra says, avoiding Adora's eyes. And then she locks her door and heads down the hallway quickly.

Halfway to Catra's car, Adora finally goes, " *Oh!* "

"There it is," comes out in a drawl.

Catra opens the passenger side door for her, like a gentlewoman.

"Why are we going to the farmer's market all the way in Thaymor? It's 45 minutes away."

"Trust me. I'm not any happier about getting up this early on the weekend," Catra replies, settling into the driver's seat. She starts the car and lowers the windows to let some air in. "It's not really about the journey. Entrapta's latest invention exploded or something and she's bummed. I'm just giving her some quality time with Darla to cheer her up."

"Who's-"

"Darla!" Entrapta's nasally shriek interrupts.

There's ringing in Adora's right ear. Probably because Entrapta's head is shoved into her window, pigtails hanging loosely across the blonde's lap. The woman's eyes are practically *frenzied* , wide and wild as she glances around the console.

Her smile slowly fades as she notices Adora.

“You’re in my seat,” Entrapta tells her with a sudden deadly calm.

“Oh. Sorry?”

The social contract we all agree to as vehicle passengers says that whoever gets there first gets to ride up front. From the little she knows about Entrapta, Adora imagines that social contracts are not something she bothers herself with.

The blonde looks at Catra who just rolls her eyes.

“Trapta. Be nice please.”

“I'm sorry,” she says flatly. “Hello, Adora. It's nice to see you again. Thank you for allowing me to join your date.”

Adora looks to Catra for help again but she's useless. Catra has put on large tortoise shell sunglasses which shouldn't affect her *hearing* . But she seems committed to staring straight ahead and pretending Entrapta hasn’t spoken. With no other options, Adora scurries out and gets in the back.

Entrapta squeals, “Darla!” and jumps into the passenger seat, where she immediately starts inspecting the car.

With a patient smile, Catra turns around to explain, “Entrapta is ‘close’ to Darla.” She momentarily lowers her sunglasses so that Adora can see her dramatically raise both eyebrows.

Entrapta’s too busy running her finger along the dashboard to notice.

As an engineer or whatever it is Entrapta does, Adora’s pretty sure she makes more than enough money to afford her own Darla. But maybe she’s just taken with this particular car. It seems best not to inquire more closely.

The entire ride is filled with so much rambling about Darla that Catra has to blast music to tune it out.

Adora leans up next to her to whisper, "Why don't you just let her drive?"

" *Drive* ? I barely trust her to operate a spoon."

Out of the corner of her eye, Adora sees Entrapta's hand slowly edging towards the steering wheel, not worried at all that the vehicle is currently in motion.

Mercifully, they make it safely to the farmers' market, where they meet up with Scorpia and Perfuma. The one in Thaymor is much bigger than their local market, a long, sprawling strip full of people, mostly lots of couples and kids.

Scorpia gets excited about everything from the grit and ingenuity of the local farmers to the craftsmanship of the folks selling goods. Perfuma buys a few things, some weird looking eggplant and some okra, but is very quiet, which is odd. Catra casually loops her arm through Adora's and they wander slowly behind the trio, just kinda taking everything in.

Pretty quickly, Entrapta gets distracted by a vendor and runs off without a word, Catra and Scorpia dutifully following behind her quickly.

"It's nice to see you outside of work," Perfuma says once they're alone.

"You too," Adora agrees. They don't hang out much anymore, not like buddies.

She and Perfuma had met in college, along with Bow and Glimmer. They'd always been in the same circle of friends but had never been super close. Glimmer had the strange idea that the hippie blonde harbored a bit of a crush on Adora in school. Regardless, she'd always been extremely supportive of Adora and when LAP opened, she jumped at the chance to come on board

from the start. It had been challenging for a while, thanks to their very different styles. But Perfuma was a good friend; she and Adora just exist on completely different wavelengths.

“Seems like you’ve been a bit less stressed lately,” Perfuma says.

See ? Adora would never say anything like that to someone.

“Yeah, things have been good,” she responds. “I’ve been getting more help with work and spending more time with friends.” Or just one friend.

“I’m so happy to hear that,” Perfuma tells her with a warm smile. “A lot of the tension has really drained out of your shoulders. It’s been lovely to see you a bit more comfortable.”

Perfuma lets it lie for a whole two seconds while they walk in silence.

“If I could suggest just one thing?”

Adora cuts in. “I’m not interested in yoga, meditation, or journaling.” This is a common conversation for them.

“...Generative Somatics? Forward Stance?”

“No!” A pause. “What’s that?”

“Transformative practices.”

“Perfuma,” she groans. “I don’t need transformation. I’m pretty fine the way I am.”

The other woman leads her off to the side, walking between two stands. Adora isn’t sure what’s happening or how she’s the only one behaving normally on this outing.

“Make a fist,” Perfuma instructs. When Adora doesn’t move, she repeats it more firmly.

With a small scowl, Adora holds her right hand between her and Perfuma and balls it into a fist, palm side up. She's not sure how but this is probably a trick. Maybe she's just been spending too much time with Catra and Glimmer, though.

"Hold on tight," is all Perfuma says. Reaching over quickly, she tries using her fingers to pry Adora's clenched hand open.

"What are you doing?"

"You're stronger than I realized," she replies. Her voice sounds all giggly and flustered.

Is this some weird game? This feels like something you'd play with a child. It's silly but she also desperately doesn't want to lose.

Adora's barely begun to put in effort when Perfuma gives up.

"That was hard. When our muscles are closed and clenched, they're quick to stay that way when they're met with force."

Perfuma patiently waits to make sure Adora understands. With a metaphor so on the nose, it would be hard not to.

"Now," she continues. "Shake it off and make another fist."

Adora does as she's told. Perfuma's hand gently slides under hers, cradling around it to hold the weight.

"Let's try a different approach. We'll try supporting the fist instead," Perfuma suggests.

It goes how Adora suspects, since she's familiar with Perfuma's analogies. Smiling kindly at her, Perfuma holds Adora's hand until she's tired of keeping it balled into a fist. It only takes a couple minutes and Adora seriously considers practicing this at home until she has the will to prove Perfuma wrong. For now, she reluctantly relaxes her grip.

It's all very silly. And also, "What is this supposed to mean?"

“Sometimes instead of bracing for impact, we should roll with the momentum of the stressors that come our way.” She begins massaging the tension from Adora’s hand. “We welcome new and different experiences into our lives. We acknowledge the patterns that have protected us in the past, thank them for how they have served us, and let them go.”

It’s a little too woo for her tastes. But it reminds her of Catra and the rollercoaster. Of Catra’s raspy whisper, urging her to relax and let go.

She doesn’t have to imagine Catra’s voice for long.

“Why are you two hiding back here and holding hands?” Catra asks, appearing suddenly next to them.

“Fucking hell, Catra!” Perfuma screams while dropping her hand and jumping in the air. Adora’s never seen her so alarmed.

Catra couldn’t care less. She narrows her eyes suspiciously as Perfuma struggles to slow her breathing.

“You didn’t answer the question.”

“I’m going to catch up to Scorpia and Entrapta,” Perfuma mumbles instead and quickly breezes past Catra with a final reassuring smile.

“Transformative practice,” Adora says with a shrug.

“Oh….did it work?”

“I don’t think it’s immediate, Cat,” Adora says with a laugh.

Catra grabs her hand and uses it to pull her back onto the walking path, returning to strolling through the market.

“Sorry I invited you out for the weirdest Saturday morning ever.”

Awkwardly, Adora says, “Sorry that Entrapta falsely implicated you in dating a mess like me.”

Catra growls, short and low. She tugs on Adora’s arm, stopping her dead in her tracks. A family with a stroller behind them grumbles their annoyance but Catra’s so zeroed in on Adora that she doesn’t even seem to notice.

“Well, now you have to say something nice about yourself,” Catra orders.

Yes, *now* it’s the weirdest Saturday morning.

“What?”

“I let you trash yourself enough. You have to say something nice now.”

“You’re not serious. Cat?”

“I’m always serious.”

“You’re never serious.”

“That’s besides the point!” Catra shoots back quickly.

“You’ve been spending too much time with Perfuma.”

”I’m not the one who was just playing pattycake with her next to the cheese stand,” she says, tilting her head slightly. “Something nice. *Go* .”

Catra looks like she’s not backing down. She’s so hot when she’s serious. Fine.

“I’m loyal,” Adora says stiffly. Praising herself isn’t exactly something that she can just do on command. Or otherwise.

“That’s boring. Something better.”

The blonde thinks for a second. “I’m really good at solving problems.”

“You are. What else?”

“You said one thing,” Adora replies, crossing her arms.

“I didn’t actually. You’re not a very good listener.”

“I’m a great listener!”

And while there’s no good setting for this absurd conversation, doing it here right now definitely makes them look like a cliched lesbian couple fighting in the middle of a farmers’ market. Adora is mortified.

“See, another nice thing,” Catra continues. “Think you can dig up one more for me?”

Adora scoffs with a smile. “I’m pretty good with my hands?”

Catra’s stern expression falls. It looks like her brain shuts down a bit, her face going slack and her eyes going to Adora’s arms and hands.

“I-uh...” Obviously Adora meant that she was good with, like, building Ikea furniture. Not-not anything *else* . But Catra’s almost blushing. Just a little.

It’s certainly a bit of an ego booster. She tries to give Catra a reassuring smile but it definitely comes out all cocky.

Full of unearned swagger, Adora says, “I mean, yeah, I haven’t gotten any complaints before.”

Catra looks back to her eyes, clearly intrigued. “Really, *princess* ?” There’s a challenge in her tone. “ *I’ll* b-”

“There you are!” Entrapta squeals, suddenly reappearing. “Catra, the tiny baked goods person crashed their credit card machine

and they refuse to let me fix it. Give all of your cash to me."

"Entrapta!" she yells, clearly frustrated.

Her friend doesn't even blink. "Oh, should I say 'please'?"

"No-"

"Are you sure? I'm fairly certain I should have phrased it as a question."

"Fine! Here." Catra removes all of the cash from her wallet and hands it to Entrapta. It's way too much money for mini-cupcakes but Entrapta happily takes it and runs away.

Adora's not sure how to pick up after the interruption. It feels like the moment has passed and whatever confidence she briefly possessed has deflated considerably.

"Uh. Good exercise. Thanks for that." She keeps her eyes trained on the ground as her hands start to nervously fidget.

"Hey," Catra says quietly, gently sliding a palm into Adora's. "I know you don't believe me, but I see all the ways that you're amazing. Someone would be really lucky to have you. And I never lie so don't insult my integrity by trying to deny it."

It takes her a moment but eventually Adora just sighs. Everyone's committed to being supportive today. It's no use fighting it.

"Well, I don't want to compromise your integrity. So I'll just say...thank you."

"Cool. Now use those muscles for good and help Entrapta carry $200 worth of cupcakes back to the car. I'm afraid of what'll happen if I leave her and Darla unsupervised with that much sugar."

Catra
11:29pm
hey
dor
can say
I want to know so much more about yuo

Adora
11:34pm
…
What's happening here?
Are you ok?

Catra
11:37pm
maybe
some loss of functions

Adora
11:37pm
Are you drunk?

Catra
11:45pm
No
i seem druk?

Catra picks up on the fourth ring.

" *Heeeeey* , Adora." Her speech is a little slurred. She doesn't sound drunk. She certainly doesn't sound sober though. "Miss you."

That's...not what Adora is expecting to be greeted with. Especially since they'd seen each other less than 48 hours before. And also because it wasn't one-sided. She shakes that out of her head, now sitting fully upright in her bed, where she'd been responding to low-importance work emails.

“Ar-Are you okay? Where are you?” Adora was trying very hard to keep her voice calm, even if she was pretty worried already.

“‘m home,” Catra returns quietly. Her voice is…’ *dreamy’* is really the only way Adora can think to describe it. Catra mumbles something else that she can’t quite pick up about “separating space and time.”

“Uh,” Adora tries to think of what’s a good investigative question since Catra obviously isn’t in a mood to be more forthcoming. “What did you do tonight?”

There’s some rustling from the other end.

“Worked late. Ate junk.”

“Did you have some wine?”

“No.” It’s almost like she’d sound exasperated if she had more energy. “No wine.”

“Okay…”

“I’m not supposed to drink with it anyway,” Catra says and there’s more rustling.

That’s odd.

“Drink with what?”

“What?” she parrots back after a pause, genuinely sounding like she has no idea what they’re talking about.

Adora sighs. It’s late but not horribly late. Catra’s about a 30-minute drive away. Maybe she should just go over and confirm that everything’s okay.

Then a very out-of-nowhere fear strikes her. What if Catra isn’t alone? There’s a lot of rustling and background noise. She

definitely seems distracted. It’s completely irrational, yet Adora can’t stamp the feeling down.

“Catra?” she asks tentatively. “I’m gonna come over and make sure you’re okay. Is that alright? Are you by yourself?”

A 'mmrp?' is all she gets in reply. There’s another pause, where Adora is increasingly certain that Catra is pushing some random girl out of her apartment in a rush.

It sounds like Catra drops the phone. And then Adora gets a notification that she wants to switch to a video call. When she answers, Catra’s hilariously holding the device too close to her face, like someone’s mom.

She tries squinting her eyes, her pupils all large and round like a kitten’s.

“You wanna come over *at night* , Dor?” Catra smirks.

She kinda reminds Adora of someone trying to tell a dirty joke for the first time. The intent is there but the delivery is fumbled just a little.

In order words, this shouldn’t make Adora flustered, but of course it does.

“Just to check on you. You’re acting suspicious,” she clarifies quickly.

“ *You’re* acting sus,” Catra replies.

She places the phone down carefully and her gigantic closet becomes visible around her. Adora can see that she appears to just be hanging out in there alone.

“What are you up to?”

Catra glances around, like maybe she doesn’t entirely know.

“Getting rid of some clothes. You want some?”

Adora laughs, though she’s still very very confused. “We’re not at all the same size, Cat. What aren’t you supposed to drink with?”

“...what?” She pulls a chunky gold sweater over her head, smooths it down for a second, and removes it quickly. This apparently gives her a second to catch up to the question cause she responds dismissively, “Oh, my sleeping pill. It’s fine. No drinks. Nothing happened though. Still awake.”

That actually explains a lot. Adora looks at her face a little closer. She does seem more zombie-like than usual. It’s probably one of those prescriptions where people end up sleep-walking into their kitchen and eating random food in the middle of the night or something.

Catra angles the phone a bit more, presumably on one of the many, many shelves in her huge closet and then wanders further into her wardrobe. Unfortunately, this gives Adora a full-body view of the oblivious woman.

That sweater had been the only thing she was wearing.

She’s now looking at Catra’s fully naked profile. It’s only a weird back/side angle at least but that is *plenty* . Adora can clearly make out how the stripes on Catra’s arms also show up on her ribs. The definition in her shoulders. Basically, her full as-

Adora’s heart stops but somehow her hand is still animated enough to cover her eyes.

“Catra!” she squeaks out. “You’re not wearing clothes!”

Through the gaps in her fingers, Adora can just barely see her glance back at the phone without a care.

“Duh. You’ve seen me naked before.”

“I absolutely have not!” Adora argues.

She'd certainly remember that if it had happened. Catra would remember it too cause the blonde imagines she'd turn into a full gay wreck.

"No?" She can hear, but thankfully not see, the smile in Catra's voice. "Lower that hand and we can fix that."

Adora's never heard Catra's voice so low and it is absolutely doing things to her.

"I don't think that's a good idea right now, Cat."

"Why'd you video me at midnight if you didn't want a show?"

" *You* videocalled *me* !"

"...really? Well, shit."

There's a sound of rustling and Adora takes a risky peek back at the screen. Catra's pulled on a huge charcoal sweater that goes almost down to her knees. She's basically drowning in the material and it looks so comfy that Adora's simultaneously jealous of it and deeply relieved that Catra's covered up. She lowers her hand from her eyes.

"Dor," Catra says, sounding kinda lost. "I think I forgot to fall asleep."

She always wants to take care of Catra, who usually fights this tooth and nail. Maybe she'll be more amenable all hopped up on sleeping pills.

"Yeah, looks like it," Adora agrees with a warm smile. "Why don't you go lay down and we can talk more?"

She lies back herself, hoping that Catra will mimic her.

"Are you in bed like a good girl?"

It’s an innocent question. Catra’s husky, half-asleep voice makes it sound almost pornographic though.

Adora gasps quietly before she can stop it, that voice igniting a fire inside of her.

She hopes Catra’s too out of it to notice. So of course Catra freezes whatever she’s doing in her closet and tilts her head in that way that Adora’s come to love. She licks her lips absently, oh-so-slowly stepping closer to the camera. Like she’s stalking prey.

She looks Adora in the eyes.

“Did you like that?” she whispers with a rasp. Adora has to end this immediately. “Is it my voice?” Catra pauses to grin wickedly. “Or you want to be my good girl?”

Both, if Adora’s being honest, are helping her discover all sorts of new things about herself. She has to put a stop to this though, out of a deep sense of propriety.

“Catra!” she tries to sound scandalized.

Very much on brand, the only response is a very devilish chuckle.

“You know, in college, I thought about reading dirty audio books for cash. Chickened out though.” Catra captures Adora’s eyes with a look so intense that it gives the blonde goosebumps on her arms. She notices Catra’s hand has moved to slowly caressing her own collarbone. “I could read you something.”

“Nope!” Adora’s fucking amazed that she doesn’t stutter. Think of de-escalation tactics. Firm, gentle voice. “Cat-”

“You wanna come over instead?” Catra interrupts. “I was thinking of going for a run but-”

“Please don’t do that! Have you learned nothing from all the true crime shows you make me watch?”

Catra's already heading to the shoe section, presumably to find some trainers.

Adora will never be able to get there in time if she decides to actually leave. She's not even wearing *pants* for fuck's sake! Catra will probably be arrested for indecent exposure and then her career will be ruined and it'll all be Adora's fault for getting distracted by a silly phrase.

A last ditch idea occurs to her.

"I'm having trouble falling asleep too, Cat. Why don't you get in your bed and tell me how comfy it is?"

It's dumb, she knows. But Catra's not exactly functioning at her usual near-genius level. 'Comfy' is pretty much always her desired mood anyway.

Catra makes a very quiet questioning purr. She tries to stand still to consider this and sways just a bit.

"You want that?"

When Adora nods vigorously, she follows the command. It's a complete blessing that she actually remembers to take the phone with her.

The process of settling into the bed is not short at all. Melog doesn't appreciate being awoken and Catra misjudges her own strength when she tries to pet them. They swat at her in return and the two hiss at each other for a while, until Catra apologizes and professes her love for them, nearly in tears. Then she can't figure out how to unmake the bed and pull back the heavy comforter so Adora has to talk her through it.

Finally laying down, Catra sets up the phone on her nightstand to face her, pulls the heavy blankets up, and tucks herself in. She wiggles with her eyes closed for a bit, in the cutest fucking way. When she opens them to see Adora again, Catra gives her a

content purr. She’s buried all the way up to her neck in a blanket cocoon and Adora’s heart bursts.

“Is it nice?” the blonde asks with a quiet giggle.

“Fucking luxurious,” Catra sighs. “I need three more comfy layers and a thundershirt.”

“We’ll go shopping this weekend,” Adora promises, trying to quiet her laugh.

Catra whines, sounding small and drowsy, “Tell me a story.”

“Fake or real?”

“Don’t care, Dor. Just wanna hear your voice.” Who knew Catra could be so needy and sweet?

That makes Adora stumble a bit but she’s able to remember, more or less, the plot to a silly horse movie that she loved as a kid so she just retells that. Catra’s too busy purring to make fun of her for being a ‘horse girl,’ as she’s fond of calling it. Pretty soon, the purr turns to a deep snore. Adora only keeps the call going for a minute or two before her own eyelids are drooping and she has to hang up.

Adora’s between scheduling meetings and approving monthly expenses the next day, when Glimmer pops her head into her office. She does not look happy.

“You have a very rude visitor,” Glimmer informs her, before disappearing immediately.

A second, not familiar, voice replies, “And a very rude assistant.”

A short young woman with a blue-colored bob appears in her doorway. She’s dressed in business casual and holding her phone up strangely. There's an oddly familiar canvas bag on her shoulder.

Adora can hear Glimmer grumble as she walks away, “I’m the godsdamn Administration *Director* .”

“Hi?” the blonde says. Before she can ask more, the girl turns her phone around. On the screen is Catra.

Her phone must be propped up on her desk somewhere because Adora recognizes her office and Catra’s wearing her gold-rimmed glasses that she only uses for work. Those plus the navy blue pinstriped suit she has on is a lot for Adora, but she refuses to swoon in front of the stranger standing before her.

“Catra?”

On the screen, she looks up from the paperwork on her desk.

“ *Hey,* Adora. I know you almost never answer your cell during work hours so I made Frosta call me. Say hello, Frosta.”

Adora looks up at the young woman, ‘Frosta’ apparently, who just sighs angrily.

Catra’s mentioned her fiery intern before, mostly to say how much the law student reminds her of herself when she was younger. She says it in such a fond way that Adora was looking forward to meeting the girl. Catra had very much downplayed Frosta’s quiet rage, it seemed.

She continues on, “Thanks for saving me the other night. Last time I forgot to go to sleep, I texted my ex ‘you tryin to get in this V or nah?’ so you thwarted a possible disaster.” She laughs while Adora’s not sure how to process any of those words. “I owe you one. Sorry for being so annoying.”

“You weren’t,” Adora says quickly. “Thanks for trusting me to help.”

Catra gives her a brilliant smile, eyes soft and playful. “Always. I gotta go though. Bye, Dor.”

The call ends before Adora can fully get her bearings. Frosta not-too-gently tosses something on her desk. It's a tupperware, full of roasted vegetables and potatoes and chicken. When she gently opens the lid, the scent of tarragon fills the room.

"She got up early apparently," Frosta grumbles. "She stressed that this is for *you* and not whatever a 'glitter bow' is."

She turns to leave swiftly, apparently already over this interaction. At the doorway, Frosta pauses, turning back with a deep, long-suffering sigh.

"Mermista and I talk – *no one's* gotten the treatment that you've gotten. I've been Catra's intern for 2 full years and I've certainly never had to make a delivery in the middle of a huge negotiation. Good luck with her. She's a walking horror show...but she deserves someone nice."

She exits without another word.

Catra had worked late the night before and still woke up early to do something kind for Adora. Yes, the signs were all there that she cared very deeply for her friend.

And Adora was nice. Anyone would be lucky to have her, Catra had said. It was getting harder to keep coming up with reasons to exclude Catra from the list of possible 'anyones'.

They clearly both had a lot of feelings for one another. An admitted attraction. They were a good complement to each other. Adora was dependable and consistent and provided safety; Catra was adventurous and assertive and pushed Adora in all the right ways.

It was important to be sure before moving forward, though. Just 8 more steps to go. But at least Adora had a new and updated step to add to the list – deciding the perfect time and strategy to tell Catra how she felt.

Chapter End Notes

obviously the true issue is that the plan needs, like, several more steps. this chapter had been shorter but i was needing more entrapta. i'm not sure if catra actually collectively calls them 'glitter bow' or frosta just misheard but i was into it either way.

chapter 9 preview: you know that part in the story description mentioning catra's past? yeah, about that...

Shoot Her Shot

Chapter Summary

Adora decides to shoot her shot.

Chapter Notes

i went through and responded to all y'all's amazing and silly comments right before posting so that i could remember a better time where we were happy. cause the next couple chapters are the darkest pieces of this.

oof, warnings. all the warnings. there's angst. i don't even like angst. there's no specifics about abuse but it's super heavily implied. so if you need to skip, start at "excellent" and jump down to "can we call a timeout".

also, because this chapter has a legit villain, there's some deadnaming and mispronouning. never thought i'd write that cause, you know, i get enough of it in real life but i really hit the throttle on her being trash.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora was proud of the progress she was making on her plan. She, of course, couldn't tell anyone else for fear of being absolutely roasted alive. But inwardly, she thought she was really starting to make some in-roads and was excited about how things were moving. The past few weeks, she and Catra had both gotten a little bolder with the boundaries of their friendship.

The weather was warm now and everyone wanted to hang out more, gently forcing them into what definitely was feeling like double- and triple-dates with the group.

First, drag queen trivia with Perfuma and Scorpia at Catra's favorite queer bar where they'd slaughtered everyone and the two hosts complained about the "happy couple" and how everyone

hates "gorgeous brilliant people in love". Adora noticed that night that even Catra blushed along with her. Their prize for 1st place was free drinks so they were beyond tipsy by the end of the outing. As they left, Adora had never wanted to kiss someone so badly but reasoned that she should re-evaluate when they were both sober.

Then there was a concert for some band that Adora had never heard of with all of their friends, where Catra danced the whole time, not seeming to pick up on or care about all the people around her gawking. Instead, she tempted Adora into joining her and they swayed together for the rest of the night, her back pressed firmly against Adora's front. The music, the trippy lights, and Catra in her arms, all gave the night an almost hypnotic feel. Glimmer kept hinting for her to make a move; at least, that's what Adora assumed her cartoonishly blatant hand signals meant. But it already felt so magical – no need to rock the boat.

The cherry was, ironically, strawberry picking at Bow's insistence. Catra got bored immediately and corralled Adora into carrying her on piggyback up and down the rows of fruit, while Glimmer and Bow frolicked and had an impromptu photoshoot. The clandestine pics they got of Adora and Catra giggling with each other at the couple's expense made them look deliriously happy and completely in their own world together. Catra made Glimmer send her the photos. The next time Adora went over to her place, one of the pictures was printed and in a small frame next to Catra's bed. She refused to let Adora ask about it but she was looking a lot redder under her copper fur.

So Adora's decided to skip a few steps of her plan. She knows it's impulsive, throwing caution to the wind like this, but truthfully, it just feels so right. Maybe Bow and Glimmer's rants about the perfection of Catra and Adora together are starting to break through to her. Maybe Perfuma's gentle (though not *subtle*) reminders about not being stubborn, breaking out of old patterns, and being open are starting to make sense. Maybe thinking about Catra's low voice whispering that she's a good girl is still playing in a loop in her mind. For all those reasons, and the one million

times Catra has made her heart pick up speed, Adora decides to ‘shoot her shot’ as Catra would say.

Glimmer and Catra are right – Adora is kind’ve a catch. She’s attractive, in that pretty basic way. She can be funny. Sometimes. She’s kind and patient and honorable. She started a whole fucking organization, for Gods’ sake! She *is* a catch, she just needs to remind herself of that and stop downgrading herself to ‘kinda’. Catra is already aware that Adora works a lot and doesn’t know how to talk about feelings. Just because those were issues with other girlfriends before doesn’t matter; Catra’s not them and she always wants to support Adora instead of trying to change her. And Adora could totally grow into those things! One day probably.

She’s going for it! What’s the worst thing Catra can do? Laugh in her face probably. Adora will live. Catra made her watch a terrible tv movie about a woman whose internet girlfriend was really her high school worst enemy playing out a long revenge con. So, you know, her life could be worse? She’ll survive the embarrassment.

Adora wants this conversation to be direct and low-key. If she has 1.5 to 2 beers, she’ll have the courage to say it. Just look straight in Catra’s very distracting eyes, try not to get lost, and ask her to go on an actual date.

Glimmer thinks Adora should profess her *love* . Adora thinks she should maybe block Glimmer’s number finally.

Today’s the day though. Adora thought about wearing something special but realized that she didn’t have any suitable clothes, other than her usual outfit. She wanted to pick up flowers or something but didn’t have the time. Yes, this plan is already off the rails but it’s still very salvageable. She’s wrapping up her last tasks and Catra should be there any moment to pick her up.

“Excellent. You’re not busy,” a voice observes, even though Adora literally has a stack of papers that she’s clearly zoning out while reading on her desk.

The presence makes her skin crawl a little, instinctively. She glances up and it's that awful woman. Ugh. Adora doesn't know her name but she's seen her around before. So tall, so deathly pale that she's almost blue, so ostentatious in her dark red gown.

The woman runs one of the group homes and in the past, Adora's seen her picking up kids from the program. It had been several months though, so she was hoping that that was the last of her. How unfortunate that she's now standing in Adora's office and there's no way to escape her.

"Sorry, I do have a deadline. Do we have an appointment scheduled, Miss…?"

"Weaver," the woman supplies. She turns her nose up at the prospect of having to be scheduled in. "This will only take a moment."

Pushing further into the room before Adora can protest, she brandishes a small white paper in her hand.

"What is the meaning of *this* ?"

Weaver hands it over for Adora to examine. It's a business card with Catra's name and info. A little well-worn, with dirt and stains and spots where it's crumbled.

"What exactly is the problem?" Adora asks, confused.

"I found this hiding in my ward's possessions. Felicity says she got it here."

It takes Adora a bit of time to piece together who she's talking about. And then a bit longer to figure out how to navigate this without disrespecting Finn or outing them to their guardian. Though, it's possible that this asshole already knows Finn's *correct* name and pronouns and is doing this intentionally. Either way, she'll have to tread lightly, keeping the kid's safety at the top of her mind.

She tries the easiest route, "If I remember, they got it from an adult on one of our outings. Just a harmless gesture, I think. In case they want to be a lawyer when they grow up."

"I'd hardly call that person *harmless* ," Weaver replies, narrowing her eyes. "Are these the kind of people interacting with the children here?"

It's very clear what answer she's expecting.

"I'm sorry," Adora says with what she hopes is a small, placating smile. "Could you tell me what exactly is your concern here?"

"I'm allowing Felicity to attend your program to *enrich* her mind, not have it poisoned by...untoward ideas."

Adora furrows her brow. "Like lawyers?"

Weaver narrows her eyes in annoyance.

She truly has no idea what the hell this woman's issue is. If anything, she should be happy that Finn's connecting with adults who have gotten out of the system and managed to stay out. Though, if the woman is as big of an oddball as she seems, maybe knowing her kid has access to a lawyer freaks her out. This just makes Adora more curious.

"People who practice *improper* lifestyles," Weaver hisses.

Oh. Adora looks at the card again. Sure, maybe if Weaver looked Catra up, she'd be able to find out more about her. The blonde wasn't really sure if Catra's queerness was something she'd stumble upon though, just laying around out there on the internet.

Why was something feeling like it should click for her, though? Something about the card, that day at the amusement park...

Weaver . 'Weaver would skin me alive' or something like that, Catra had said.

Adora tries to hide her reaction, her widening eyes and quickening pulse. Cause, no, this has to be statistically impossible. That's such a common last name that this can't possibly be the same horrible person who raised – and as far as Adora can guess, *hurt* – Catra. Can't be her standing in Adora's office complaining about Catra. Can't be her that has custody of Finn.

"I-" she stumbles.

Fuck. This is a bad time for Adora to remember how fucking queer this whole office is, herself especially. There's no way that Weaver's going to leave Finn in the program if she finds out. Meeting her now, Adora thinks they definitely do need to stay – this is the only way she can keep an eye on them and make sure they're okay at Weaver's place.

She tries to start again, more collected, "I-"

This time, Adora's interrupted by Catra's voice coming down the hall towards them.

"Yeah, yeah, I know the way, Sparkles."

This could not be more of a fucking catastrophe. They have safety protocols for situations like this, but those are supposed to be for the youth, not full-grown adults about to be potentially retraumatized. She can't really alert anyone else without overplaying her hand with Weaver.

Weaver must still recognize Catra's voice, because the woman's whole demeanor stiffens even more.

"Excuse me a second," Adora says to her quickly, rushing to intercept Catra in the hallway.

"Ms. Morgan?" the blonde calls out, lightly.

Catra stops and frowns when she looks at Adora, who must be a floundering mess.

As quietly as she can, Adora whispers, " *Please* follow me, Cat," knowing that it'll be picked up only by her ears.

Adora tries to move them in the direction of Perfuma's office. This seems like the safest bet to pause things and keep them under control.

"Ah," she hears behind them. "Here she is now. *Catrina.* "

Adora acknowledges rationally that it's an odd time for her to learn that she didn't even know Catra's full name. It makes her wonder how much more she has no idea about.

Next to her, Catra stops cold. She looks to Adora, eyes wide and questioning, almost child-like in a way. It's only there for a second, before they shutter and turn icy with rage.

Catra whips around to Weaver, claws already unsheathing. Adora steps in front of her, just in case things escalate. This puts her directly between Catra and Weaver, which feels like a very dangerous place to be.

"Ms. Morgan," Adora starts, focusing Catra's attention on her. "I'm dealing with one of the guardians of our *youth* . Can you meet with Perfuma instead?" She tries to plead with her eyes, hoping Catra will understand. Hell, hoping that Catra isn't so triggered that Adora can even get through to her.

Thank the Gods for Perfuma. Catra's not backing down and has started to look past Adora at Weaver, almost daring her former guardian to say another word. But Perfuma appears quietly at her shoulder. She's smiling at Adora like she clearly has no idea what's happening but is more than happy to take the reigns.

"Catra, let's check in quickly," she suggests.

Before Catra can respond, Adora strides back to Weaver and practically shoves her back into her office. She closes the door. Locks it just in case.

Weaver's creepy face is oddly smug. “Your alley cat just drops by unannounced?”

“Ms. Morgan is a donor.”

It's not a complete lie. It's just not the complete truth. Adora rationalizes that there's a difference and it's acceptable because of the greater good. She's worried as all hell about Catra but she's willing to focus on saving one cat at a time.

Weaver raises an eyebrow. “A donor?” She looks at the card on Adora's desk again. “So she does well for herself?” There's something akin to a quiet wistfulness in her tone.

“I believe so,” Adora answers unsurely. She doesn't get this woman at all. “Catra seems to be fairly successful. She got a client to cover that daytrip completely and she's raised a substantial amount of money for us. She really cares about our mission. This visit was unusual – just delivering another donation in person. Generally, our donor base isn’t allowed regular access to the program participants. Safety and confidentiality precautions.”

Weaver might be thrown off cause she just hums in acknowledgement. This is a good time to strike.

“I think it would be a good idea to enroll any children in your care in more of our courses actually. Our program evaluations consistently show improvements in grades, decreased disciplinary actions at school, and increased pathways for careers.” Adora grits her teeth and forces the next part out, feeling like an absolute scumbag for appeasing this woman. “ *Felicity* , in particular, could probably use more outlets for their energy.”

“That is true,” Weaver agrees. She steels her gaze, examining Adora then nods slowly. “Perhaps that is a good idea. She’s currently the only child in my care. She could have a very promising future with more guidance.”

Adora attempts her most charming smile, stomach churning. “I agree completely. Let me take you to our Program Director, Bow,

who can help with the additional enrollments."

She rushes back to the door, listening out for Catra's voice. There's nothing. That's a good sign, right? Adora even takes a peek out into the hallway but it's pretty quiet now. She's able to hurry Weaver into Bow's office and leave her there, making excuses about deadlines.

The next stop is Perfuma's office. Maybe she can grab Catra and leave. Obviously, their plans for the night are completely on hold but Catra's safety is the top priority now.

The office is empty though, lights turned off and door locked. Adora can feel her panic rising. Catra needs her and she has no fucking clue where she is right now. She rushes around the rest of the LAP space, checking in every room. Through sheer luck, she's able to corner Glimmer coming out of the restroom and ask what she knows.

"That woman looked like the godsdamn cryptkeeper, Adora," Glimmer mutters. "Try to make sure she never comes back, okay? She scared the living shit out of Catra. Perfuma had to leave early to take her home."

Adora runs out before she's even sure Glimmer's done speaking. She spends the short drive over completely freaking out. A consummate rule follower, Adora's never broken as many traffic laws as she does that night trying to get to Catra. All of her attempts to call go ignored which only serves to make her speed faster, running past the door person and letting herself in.

The first thing Adora notices about the apartment is that it smells good, oddly. Like dinner.

"Hi," she starts tentatively, closing the door behind herself. Catra and Perfuma are both on the living room couch, so focused on their laptops that they don't even look up at her. Scorpia, however, pops her head out of the kitchen.

Adora's never seen her look so flustered, hair mussed, eyes wild. She's the only one acting reasonably right now.

"Hi, buddy! Thank the Gods you're here. Catra, look! Adora's here." Scorpia sounds as panic-stricken as Adora feels.

When Catra still doesn't do more than give a quiet 'mmrp', Scorpia sighs and returns to the kitchen. Adora begins to move slowly over to the couch.

"Cat?" She gets only a raised eyebrow in response, not even a glance. Adora takes a second to think of a different tactic. "You're letting Scorpia cook?" *Adora's* never allowed to touch the kitchen there, except to fill the dishwasher. She didn't realize there were different rules for everyone else.

"It's just meat and potatoes," Catra mumbles, absently. "Not even you could screw that up. Plus, if we didn't give her something to do, she'd just be barreling around here, slowing us down."

"Meat and potatoes is my favorite," Adora says, teasing. Catra's never passed up on an opportunity to make fun of her and Adora's not sure what else would grab her attention right now.

"Duh," Catra replies, still not really engaging. "Only you would want something so boring."

"So *classic* ," Adora corrects. Might as well rip the band-aid off now then. "So Weaver's evil incarnate-"

A deep growl starts up in Catra's chest. Perfuma finally has to put her computer down to place an arm on her friend's shoulder.

She gently suggests, "Perhaps it's time to take a break and hear what Adora has to say."

"I can do both," Catra mutters darkly. "Go on, Dor."

Adora shifts uncomfortably from one foot to another. The lack of context she has here is really unsettling.

“She came by to complain. But I did get her to sign Finn up for more courses with LAP. That way, the instructors and staff can keep an eye on them. See if there’s anything feeling like a flag and then intervene as necessary.”

With a completely empty tone, Catra responds, “That’s great.”

Perfuma tries to be encouraging. “Why don’t you tell Adora more about your concerns?”

Catra pauses on her computer for a second. When she looks up, Adora can tell for the first time that she’s been crying, dried tear tracks lining the fur on her face. They hold each other’s gaze momentarily, Adora trying to convey as much care and understanding as she can. But Catra falters, returning to her laptop.

“It’s too early for that,” she whispers.

Adora’s shoulders slump. Catra had secrets, sure, but she’d never outright refused to divulge anything to Adora.

“Maybe you can tell me what you’re working on?” She tries to sound more hopeful than she feels.

Catra glances at Perfuma out of the corner of her eye, who takes that as her cue to answer.

“Catra is looking through legal databases for anything she can find on Weaver, her business, or her associates. She’s asked me to check with my network of social workers to see if anyone’s ever raised any flags about Weaver.”

Perfuma pauses, a little nervously, like maybe she isn’t supposed to say this next part.

“Catra would like to get Weaver's home shut down.”

The returning growl means she *definitely* wasn’t supposed to tell Adora that part.

The idea is probably justified, but it doesn't strike Adora as a long-term solution.

"That's fine," she comments, "but what next? We can't guarantee the next place Finn goes is somewhere better. We also don't have proof of anything."

This is futile, Adora should know. When she's upset, Catra rarely wants to hear solutions in the moment. Adora usually has to wait a while until she cools off to suggest ways to address the problem. Until then, it's usually best just to swaddle Catra in blankets, feed her, and let her rant.

Nothing about this situation is sitting well with Adora, though. They need to separate the two different issues – Catra's very real past trauma and Finn's unconfirmed current harm.

"Maybe we should think this through," Adora tries.

For the first time since she arrived, Catra's eyes focus fully on her. Her nostrils flare. Her claws seem to be unsheathing themselves against her will.

"I don't need you to come in here and try to control the situation, Dor. By the way, next time you think I'm having a crisis, try talking to me. Not doing damage control."

"I'm sorry," Adora says immediately. She really is. She wanted to be there for everyone and she made a choice that hurt the person closest to her. But, "I had to do what I thought was best to handle it."

"I don't need you to handle it! It would have been good if you thought of *me* first. Asked me how I wanted to handle it. You don't always know what's best, Dor."

"I know it would be a bad idea to be rash right now," she returns. "Any mistake could make things worse for Finn."

"I know that!" Catra says quickly. She puts the computer aside and stands. "That's why we have to shut Weaver down immediately. Who knows how many other kids she's-" Catra catches herself.

"You don't have to tell me what happened," Adora feels like she should clarify. "I just want to help you. And help Finn. Weaver says she doesn't have any other kids right now."

Catra narrows her eyes, moving closer to Adora.

"What else did she tell you?"

The blonde swallows thickly. Everything Weaver said of importance was to trash Catra.

"Adora? Why was she even there?"

She vaguely notices that Scorpia's footsteps are behind her and Perfuma's stood and moved next to Catra. She looks to them and they're no help at all, both bracing themselves for the outburst that they can all feel coming.

With a sigh, Adora reluctantly admits, "She doesn't want Finn around a bunch of queers."

Catra hisses, taking a step forward until Scorpia gets closer to Adora.

"Of course she doesn't. She made it sound like she was looking for me – did she find my card?"

Adora nods. The sound that comes out of Catra is somewhat a mix of a dark chuckle and a growl.

"And you what? You got her to sign Finn up for more. What did you say – how much you love being *straight*?!"

Adora already felt like shit, like she'd sold them all out. This wasn't fucking helping either of them at this point.

She just shakes her head.

“Gods, Adora, did you even stand up for yourself?”

“Okay,” Perfuma interjects, taking a deep breath, “let’s all remember that none of us are the problem. Weaver is the problem. Let’s refocus and try to communicate what’s coming up for us so that we can figure out a way to move forward.”

“What’s coming up for me,” Catra says, eyes blazing, “is that Weaver’s a hateful piece of shit. And Adora’s too cowardly to admit who she is.”

“It wouldn’t have helped anything!” She’s certain this is true. Weaver needed gentle force in the right direction, not to be confronted on her core beliefs. That would have just escalated everything and further isolated Finn. “I can’t jump into every little thing half-cocked with no plan.”

When Catra attempts to step closer to Adora this time, Perfuma softly grabs her by the elbow.

“What? Like I do?” Catra asks.

“That’s not what I was implying.”

“Can we just call a timeout real quick?” Scorpia tries.

“Maybe it wouldn’t be the end of the world if you took a chance every once in a while,” Catra says pointedly, completely ignoring everyone else.

“I don’t want to fuck up everything!” Adora replies.

She starts to think of their plans tonight, what she was going to say. Catra's not just angry about Weaver, Adora knows; it must feel like Adora denied who Catra was to her. Everything’s starting to spiral together.

“Cat, can we just talk alone in your room? For a minute?” It’s said quietly.

Catra’s ears swivel to hear and then flatten down against her head.

“Why?” she says back just as sofly. She wraps her arms around herself like she’s bracing for something.

Perfuma clears her throat.

“Scorpia and I are going to step out on the balcony for a short while. Just let us know if you need anything.”

Then they disappear, leaving Catra and Adora standing in the living room a couple feet away but miles apart from each other.

It’s awful. The way that Catra’s looking at her, how hurt she is. How the words that Adora was so excited to say tonight feel bitter on her tongue, threatening to spill out now. Threatening to ruin everything.

“Did you explain why I was there? Who did you tell her I was to you?” Catra asks softly, sounding so small.

Adora wants to hug her but knows she can’t now.

“A donor,” she admits.

Catra nods shortly. “Is that what I am, Dor?”

It’s complicated to try to explain what Catra means to her. In the best of times, it’s muddled and uncertain. Somehow both too big and not enough. Right now, under this microscope that Weaver just added to it, it’s like some unknowable cosmic event that she can’t piece together. She barely understands how she feels. She thought she knew how Catra felt. That doesn’t help describe exactly what any of this *means* though.

Tentatively, she responds, “Um...I wanted to talk about that tonight actually.”

Catra barks out a mirthless laugh. “What a convenient answer.”

“I-I don’t know what else to tell you.”

She does. She could tell Catra the truth. She doesn’t know what it is but she could say something. Take a risk like Catra’s asked her to.

She could say that Catra’s one of the most important people in her life. She could say that she’s never felt closer to anyone before.

Adora could say that she's in way too deep, that she’s fallen for Catra.

Instead, she just shrugs and sighs, looking down at the floor.

“Get out.” Catra sounds eerily calm.

Her eyes snap back up to Catra, who looks completely closed off.

“...what?”

“I have things to do, Adora. *Leave* .” She bares her teeth and stalks back to the couch, before picking her computer up again.

Adora waits a couple minutes but Catra doesn’t relent. She knows it’s best when she gives her friend some time to cool off. So Adora says goodnight, turns, and leaves before Catra can see the tears welling up in her eyes.

Chapter End Notes

> i'd like the record to reflect that i am not happy about this either. my last fic has a chapter titled "did you just shoot shadow weaver in the fucking face to defend my honor" and that's how i'd like to remember her. being shot in the face by she-ra magic.

my biggest regret is that i didn't find a way to shoehorn some melog in here. they would have been a grounding force.

A Hole They Didn’t Know Was There

Chapter Notes

> i appreciate that y'all were into the angst from last chapter! hope you're interested in some more cause i leaned into full-blown wallowing. this is a little shortie to help shuttle us along.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was only supposed to be a couple days.

One time, only a couple months into hanging out, Adora had forgotten to call Catra when she promised. So they didn’t talk for like 24 hours. Adora finally realized that she should apologize when she didn't get a response to her texts. Afterward, Catra acted like it hadn’t been a big deal. (It should be noted that after the apology, Catra suddenly regained the ability to reply to Adora's texts.)

She wasn’t sure what the fall-out would be for this situation with Weaver, but Adora thought she’d give Catra until the weekend before reaching out. They’d text a bit. Catra would still be pissed. Adora would go over and they’d talk and it would be done.

The same night as their fight, Adora texted Catra to say that she was sorry, that she cared about her friend, and that she’d give her space like Catra had asked. She wasn’t surprised when she didn’t receive a response.

Two days later, she sent a message saying that she had spent the time apart reflecting on what Catra said and would like to talk in person. It was slightly shocking when she never heard back.

And so it continued like that for weeks. Adora texted, called, left voicemails, tried to send messages through Glimmer, Bow, and Perfuma. Catra never reached out. At one point, Adora stopped by

her place but the door person made it clear that she wasn't allowed up under any circumstances.

She knows that Glimmer and Bow talk to Catra but they refuse to tell her anything. Perfuma tries to give advice, telling Adora to be patient and to be open to listening, but she doesn't offer more than that. It's so fucking frustrating, feeling like Catra is so close but not being able to know anything about her. Adora finds herself constantly wondering what Catra's thinking or feeling. If she'd be amused by this dumb thing Adora did today. How she's sleeping. What happened with her plan for Weaver. Who she's dating.

Bow's been trying to get Adora to go back to therapy. He thinks she's depressed and needs deeper support right now. He doesn't get it, Adora knows. He's had Glimmer his entire life and they've never had a huge rift, one that felt like it might be an obstacle they couldn't overcome.

Adora didn't realize how devastating it would be to not have Catra in her life. She's only known her half the year but they'd both managed to push their way into each other's lives and fill a hole that they didn't know was there.

Or at least, that's how Adora feels. She realizes that she has no idea how Catra feels about her, especially now.

Catra unsettled her, in a good way. She laid waste to all of Adora's carefully crafted plans, pushing her out of her comfort zone and out of her own head. Adora never thought she'd enjoy being challenged to grow like that but Catra did it with such love and care that she always felt safe. Safe to fail. Safe to fall. They gave each other a place to belong for the first time. Without it, Adora just feels adrift.

Missing Catra physically hurts. Adora's stomach is always in knots now. She stopped going to the gym and going for runs, which was probably a dumb mistake cause now she feels like she barely even knows her own body anymore. Half the time, Adora doesn't know what she's doing. Everything feels very far away, like she's

watching her own life through a boring, depressing tv show. Work is awful but she powers through it on autopilot. Besides that, she’s not able to do much else. Bow and Glimmer make an effort to spend time with her, but she isn't very good company, barely speaking unless it's to ask about Catra.

Everything at LAP is still running as smoothly as usual except for one glaring exception. Finn stopped coming to the program. They never quit formally and every time she's tried to get in contact with Weaver, she hasn’t heard back. As summer started, courses got more intensive, particularly for kids who didn’t have to attend summer school. She expected to see a lot more of Finn, but it seems like Catra was right after all. After several weeks, Adora looked into it more and Weaver's house was apparently no longer operating.

Adora had screwed everything up over nothing probably.

Scorpia's birthday is coming up. No one’s mentioning it directly because it's pretty obvious that Adora isn't invited.

At first, she thinks that's out of character for Scorpia, picking a side. But Scorpia’s also very loyal and if Catra hates Adora then Scorpia and everyone else hates her too.

“No one hates you, you fucking drama queen,” Glimmer says. “You and your almost girlfriend had a fight. You’re taking some space. Scorpia’s probably respecting that.”

“And she knows you hate parties,” Bow points out. “She might just be doing you a favor. Remember you’re working on not catastrophizing?”

Adora just barely pauses on spiraling about how no one likes her and she’s going to be ostracized and have to move to another city and make new friends. She sucks at making new friends. Catra’s been the last exception to that in like 15 years.

“Listen,” Glimmer calls out. “What if we go catch a movie instead? Or go to that German beer hall and play cornhole?”

Bar games are *Adora and Catra’s* thing, though.

“No, you’re already dressed. I don’t want to be a burden.”

Bow and Glimmer look very cute. Adora intentionally overheard that Scorpia’s birthday is at a speakeasy and they’re both wearing muted colors for once in their life. Though to be fair, Glimmer’s black cocktail dress is still sequined and Bow’s wearing a crop top under his dark red blazer.

They complement each other well.

“I’m so happy you found each other,” Adora tells them.

“Oh fuck, are you crying?” Glimmer asks with some shock.

“No!” Adora replies, but she’s blubbering now.

Glimmer and Bow exchange a quick look and then they’re both encircling her, wrapping Adora up in a tight hug. They ignore her gasp.

Adora’s never been a touchy person. She hugs her friends but since she sees them all the time, it’s not really necessary to do it with each greeting or anything. Really, until she met Catra, Adora didn't enjoy physical touch very much. But that seemed to be one of Catra’s love languages (including, really, all of them) and Adora learned to get used to it. Came to love it. Misses it so much.

Realizing the multiple ways that she’s longing for Catra brings a new wave of tears to Adora’s eyes.

“Come on, big girl,” Glimmer whispers and she and Bow start to maneuver the blonde out of the living room and into her bedroom, without breaking their group hug.

Bow manages to only walk into a wall once.

They get her down onto her bed.

“I have work to do.”

“It’s 8pm on a Saturday. No, you don’t,” Bow says sternly.

“You’re burning out,” Glimmer points out (yet again). “You have to take a break. Bow’s gonna drag your TV in here and we’re gonna watch Golden Girls.”

“Is there ice cream?” he whispers.

“We’ll order some. Find out where she hides the booze.”

“No,” Adora says firmly. Her voice is a little stronger and clearer now but she’s not moving. “Go to the party. It would mean a lot to Scorpia.”

It takes a lot of effort but she disentangles herself until all three of them are lying side by side. Full-size beds were not meant for this. She’s an adult woman who still has the same small bed she bought when she was in grad school. Of course Catra doesn’t want to be with her. How had she even deluded herself into thinking that?

Adora lays face down in the bed so neither of her friends can see her start crying again.

A weight softly lands across her back. There’s a nice, calming scent of cocoa butter and earthy spices.

Slowly, she calms down enough to realize that she’s being silly about the bed and the bar games. She’s worried about Finn and Catra and she’s never felt more powerless in her fucking life.

“Alright, tapping in,” Glimmer says. The weight shifts and it’s replaced a couple moments later by what is definitely Glimmer lying her full body on Adora. Her toes tickle at the blonde’s calf. The sequins poke into Adora’s back a bit.

She waits until she hears Bow’s footsteps leave to whisper, “I ruined everything.”

“You’re both in an impossible position.You should try actually talking, like I’ve suggested only a hundred times. And we’ll keep an eye out for Finn. We’ve given other orgs a heads up. Maybe they’ll show up somewhere soon, in another program or a different home. Sadly, we’ve got plenty of experience with this, right?”

Adora is too tired to do more than barely lift her head for a short nod. Glimmer softly brushes the hair away from her face.

“Hey, you did the best with what you had, okay? And look – now you get to write new security protocols. That’s exciting.” Glimmer’s being only medium-level sarcastic.

“Uh huh."

Adora finished that a month ago. She’s just been pacing out her debut of new projects so no one knows how much she's actually been working, which is basically 18 hours a day now.

“Everything is gonna be okay, Adora. I know it doesn't feel like it but trust me.”

Glimmer had said a lot of things as usual but she had managed to be correct about one – it definitely didn’t feel like things were going to be okay.

Chapter End Notes

> writing about someone being sad cause they stopped working out was the most fictional thing i've ever had to imagine. like, it's easier for me to think about what space and portals could be like than it is to fake a character's interest in going to the gym.
>
> since none of this story is written from catra's point of view, i wanted to give some insight into what she's been doing these

last few weeks - it's just listening to bon iver's cover of "i can't make you love me" over and over again. i hope that really enhanced your story experience.

Mine

Chapter Summary

A reunion.

Chapter Notes

ahhh, thank you for all the comments! folks were really feeling the heartbreak. i imagine that catra's listening to "cranes in the sky" by solange all morning before this chapter starts.

look, i don't waste time around here (except, all those examples of when i totally do) so this just dives right in.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra
1:13pm
halp

Adora
1:19pm
Hey, are you okay?
What's wrong?
How do you want me to help?

1:28pm
Catra, please
What's going on?

Adora is pretty proud of herself for showing the restraint to wait almost 10 minutes before sending more messages. She waits another couple minutes before calling. 3 unanswered calls and increasingly bonkers voicemails left later, it seems like a good idea to just head over to Catra's place.

She doesn’t want to ask Perfuma or Glimmer and have them meddle so Adora sneaks out of the office. At least she has the presence of mind to call Mermista and make sure that Catra isn’t at work; what’s odd though is that the assistant tells her that Catra is out all this week and the next.

Adora tries to think of what she wants to say to Catra. Should she immediately apologize? Should she let Catra speak first and hear what she needs? Would it be okay for them to hug? Would Catra even want that?

It meant something that Catra had reached out to Adora when she needed help, right?

This time, the doorperson pays her no mind. So now Adora is lightly pacing outside of Catra’s door, trying to get her nerves together. She understands that Catra’s in need so it’s important for Adora to shove down all of her own anxiousness before accidentally bringing it all into whatever this situation is. *Catra’s* needs are what matters; Adora doesn’t want to make that mistake again.

With a deep breath, she knocks before letting herself into the unlocked apartment. She’s not really expecting an answer but in the past, Adora always liked to give Catra a heads up. The place looks strangely dark for the middle of the day. Catra loves to nap in sunny spots so it’s concerning that all of the shades are down. It’s also freezing, even though they’re in late summer, the AC probably cranked up to full blast.

“Cat? I’m here,” Adora calls out. She leaves her shoes at the door and goes to the kitchen to grab two glasses of water.

“Miss Adora?”

She spins around quickly to find Finn, of all people, standing in the doorway of Catra’s guest room and nearly drops both glasses. They’re...well, honestly, Adora’s never seen them look so good. They look rested and well-fed for a change.

“Finn!” To say she's shocked doesn't quite capture how out of place this all seems.

Catra's met them exactly once. Now they're here. In her home. What the hell has happened while she's been ignoring Adora?

This is the kind of rash thing that she wanted to avoid!

“Wha-what are you doing here?” she asks, trying not to alarm them by freaking out.

“They brought me and Cat said I could stay,” Finn replies. It seems so simple coming out of their mouth and Adora imagines the truth is probably a hell of a lot more complicated than that.

Finn is wearing pajamas that are a bit too big for them, the sleeves and pant legs rolled up several times, expensive-looking headphones around their neck. The kind that block out noise, probably for their sensitive ears.

“Is this your room?” Adora asks.

They nod with a huge smile. “It’s big! Cat says I can have more stuff. We have to go to the store again. But she’s sad.” They frown dramatically.

Adora decides to focus on any urgent needs that she can fix. This is what she’s good at.

“Are you hungry?”

Quickly, Finn’s returns to their usual, overly animated self.

“We had donuts for breakfast! And Cat said we can get pizza delivered when I’m hungry! I just have to ask and she’ll get it.” They say it like the rules were definitely a lot different with Weaver.

“What are you doing in your room?”

Finn points to the headphones around their neck. “Cat showed me how to watch tv on this big phone. There’s a lot of shows.”

Adora, of course, would like to look into the educational value of these shows, but makes a mental note to worry about this later.

“Okay, seems like you’re all set up. Do you need anything?”

Finn shakes their head. “Can you help Cat, please?”

She switches both waters to one hand so she can ruffle Finn’s hair. Hopefully it comes off as reassuring cause Adora’s not actually sure she can be of any help here yet. Not until she’s feeling a lot less confused and overwhelmed.

“I’ll try,” she says, honestly. “Just knock if you need anything, okay?”

“Tell her that I fed Melog,” Finn adds. Adora glances around them and Melog is indeed stretched out in their bed, asleep.

This will all be really cute, Adora thinks, once she recovers from the initial shock probably.

She makes sure to take another breath before she lets herself into Catra’s room. She doesn’t bother knocking, knowing that Catra probably heard the entire conversation she and Finn just had. Adora’s not wrong – when she walks in, Catra’s wrapped up in her blanket cocoon on the bed with her back to the entrance, but her ears have swivelled back towards the door.

Adora’s not sure what to say until she walks around the bed and sees Catra’s face. There’s obviously bigger things at play here and it doesn’t feel like a great time to open with ‘I missed you and want you. Why haven’t we talked in two months? *Did you steal that child* ?!’

Placing both glasses on Catra’s bedside table, Adora ducks down to catch her eyes. She's never looked smaller, buried under too many blankets in her huge bed. Her ears lay down against her

head and Adora notices that she has bags under her eyes. She's thinner too, cheekbones standing out a bit too prominently. Adora has to stamp down on all her instincts to immediately take Catra in her arms and promise she'll fix everything.

"Hi," she says instead.

It's a strange relief when Catra quietly replies, " *Hey* , Adora." She lifts her head out of the blanket a bit more so she can see. "Thanks. For coming, I mean. You didn't have to. I, uh, didn't mean for you to drop everything and rush over. Just got overwhelmed by your questions pretty quickly."

"Of course I did. I'm always here for you, Cat. You know that."

"Promise?"

Adora nods slowly. "I promise. What's going on?" She takes a seat on the bed, trying to leave plenty of space between them.

That's never been acceptable to Catra.

"Get in the bed, dummy," she mumbles. When Adora doesn't move, trying to figure out if that's the safest thing to do for everyone, Catra burrows deeper under the covers. "Or don't, if that's weird. You don't have to if you're still angry with me."

Adora's pulling her shirt off before she even thinks about it. She's not necessarily *angry* with Catra, doesn't think she could ever truly be. Adora was annoyed and didn't agree but wasn't upset with Catra herself, more with being ignored. Besides, right now, her friend's obviously in a bad place and she'll do whatever she can to support. The pants come off next. She doesn't have time to be embarrassed cause Catra needs her now.

Now sitting on the edge of the bed in only a sports bra and boyshorts, she asks, "Do you have anything I could put on?" When she glances back, Catra's a lot more alert than she was just a few moments ago. "Sorry – I remember the rules. No outside clothes in bed."

Catra had told her this before but Adora had never actually had a reason to deploy this knowledge until now, usually suggesting they relax on the couch or someplace that didn't put her mind and heart into overdrive.

“There’s workout clothes in the closet, maybe,” Catra replies. “It’s warm under here though, you probably won’t need anything. Plus, you’re always like a furnace.”

“Good,” Adora laughs. “Cause it’s freezing in this apartment.”

Catra lifts up the corner of the blanket, signaling how she feels about Adora getting dressed, so the blonde slides in quickly. It really is freezing. That’s her excuse for why her nipples are hard, not because Catra’s eyes are on her so intensely.

She sits down a few feet away, just to keep some space for a second.

“I want to know everything about what’s happening,” Adora begins. “But I need to say something.”

Catra sits up slightly, pulling an arm from under her blanket to prop her head up.

“You’re so important to me, Cat. I know I screwed up.”

Catra opens her mouth so Adora barrels ahead to get this out.

“But completely shutting me out was hard. I’m 100% down to help you out in any way. I hurt you, but you should know that you hurt me too. At some point, we’re going to have to talk about that and hear each other out.”

“Well, I was about to give you a lecture for apologizing when *I* was the one who acted like a real piece of shit. So I’m proud of you.”

Catra scoots closer, stopping just a foot or so away.

“I shouldn’t have freaked out on you, Dor. You were trying and I just panicked. I wanted to reach out but I really fucking lost it, spiraling about the home. Doing all this research. I, uh, kinda disappeared into it for a while.”

The fact that she did the same thing with work isn’t lost on Adora. Thinking about how miserable they both seemed to be pushes her to close the distance.

She reaches out to pet Catra on top of the blanket. Catra grumbles in that way she does when she's feeling needy and wants more. She moves from under the blanket, pushing Adora until her back is against the headboard, legs stretched out in front of her. Catra shoves her head into her lap, burrowing into Adora's stomach and thighs.

Okay, maybe *now* Adora has some time to be embarrassed. She probably should have worn at least one more layer. Maybe a shirt so that furry face isn’t directly rubbing against her abs. When Catra starts to purr though, Adora closes her eyes and leans back, letting the sound rumble through her body and relax her.

Adora's never been exactly effusive with her words. Yet, here with Catra against her and the purring calming her nerves for the first time in weeks, she leans down and whispers, “I missed you so fucking much.”

The purring gets even deeper and louder. “Me, too.”

“What happened, Cat?”

The sound dies.

“Not with... *us* ,” Adora adds quickly. “Let’s focus on the present. Seems like a lot’s changed.”

Catra audibly exhales. “Yeah, that’s the other reason for the radio silence. Fucking Weaver died. Was *dying* for a good while actually, really dragging it out to be difficult.”

Adora takes a second to let that sink in. That's definitely a surprise. The woman was horrible but Adora's never really wished harm on anyone before.

Catra adds, "I wasn't responsible if that's what you're thinking."

Adora can't help it. She laughs.

"No, that thought hadn't crossed my mind. Forgive me if I'm a bit skeptical now that you've mentioned it though." Adora realizes she doesn't know what to do with her hands so she buries them in Catra's mane. "What happened?"

Catra shrugs. "Apparently she was sick. That's why she wasn't taking more kids in. I don't know what made Weaver think that *I* was the appropriate choice for this, considering that my whole childhood she told me I wasn't worth shit, but apparently she made me her next of kin and gave me power of attorney."

She pauses to sniffle, the only sign that she's crying. Her voice sounds so distant, trying to recount this while putting on a strong face.

"There was a nurse and her creepy 'associates' and making sure someone was watching the kid. Lonnie flew out and helped for a while, once I broke down and finally tried calling some of the other folks who were raised with me. The asshole even left me the home, along with all her debt and back-owed taxes. I've been trying to sort through it but it's a fucking bitch."

She adds as an afterthought, " *She* was a fucking bitch."

"And Finn?"

For the first time, Catra shifts so she can look Adora directly in the eyes.

"Oh, that's the best part," she says sarcastically. "She left them in my care. I spent all of two seconds with child services and a family court judge and they decided that being a cat and a well-

off attorney was enough reason to not fight Weaver's wishes, since technically I'm family and all. They fast-tracked my approval to be a foster placement. The social worker dropped Finn off a couple days ago. Weaver left 'instructions' before she died, supposedly. It was just a sticky note that said 'you're welcome'."

Catra incredulously throws her hands up.

"What the fuck is that? Even her last words were just to fuck with me!"

Adora wipes away the tears that have formed in Catra's eyes. That only makes her dip her head down and hide again in Adora's tummy. It's heartbreaking to think of Catra going through all this alone, Weaver's games, this new responsibility, her own complicated grief.

"I don't know shit about taking care of anyone," she mumbles against Adora's skin.

"You take care of me all the time, Cat," Adora tells her, smoothing down her wild hair. "Does everyone know?"

Glimmer and Bow certainly hadn't mentioned anything about this. Not that they had given many details anyway, but this seems like a big thing to leave out.

"No," Catra replies firmly. "Scorpia and Perfuma know a little. Entrapta, too, and they have some idea at work. Everyone else thinks I'm just distant cause I'm sad about you. I mean, I *am* . It's just...not the only thing I fucked up."

"Come here," Adora whispers. She shifts them so that she can lay down on her side and takes Catra into her arms. "I'm sorry, Cat. I promise to be here for whatever you need. I don't care that we were fighting. You can always call me and always count on me. You know that, right?"

Catra nods. "Can you bring the burrito back?"

With a giggle, Adora wraps them both in the blankets fully. Catra pulls them closer and Adora notices that she's only in a thin tank top and bike shorts. They're touching in as many places as possible but that doesn't seem like enough for Catra cause she fidgets to intertwine her legs and wrap her tail around Adora's waist, like she expects the blonde to try to leave. She tilts her head towards Adora's hands until they're back in her hair, making more needy little sounds.

Adora fights the urge to tell Catra how much she misses her again.

"What do you need, Cat? I'll do literally anything you want."

She means about the home and Finn, but understands that their current position might be sending some confusing signals.

"Just you," Catra sighs. "My friends offered to help. They're not you, though."

"Mermista said you took two weeks off."

She groans in response. "It seemed like the best idea. But all I've done is lay here. Poor kid's probably bored out of their mind."

"Honestly, I think they're just loving the freedom. Oh, they wanted me to tell you that they fed Melog."

"Of course they did," she replies with a smile. "They're better than *me* about that. Though, when they discovered that Melog uses a catbox, they lost their mind. So I'll probably have to potty train them again. Is 7 too late for that? That feels like something you can do for us."

Adora laughs because she's fairly certain that Catra is kidding. "Fine. What else?"

"I don't know. Maybe just reminding me of the basics this week? Food, sleeping, getting up occasionally. I'm supposed to take them shopping. All of their stuff was in one trash bag. School

starts up again in a couple weeks and I don’t even know where they go.”

Which probably means that Catra didn’t register them anywhere. That’s fine. It’s stressful to Adora, actually, but solvable.

“I’ll make a list.”

“Of course you will,” Catra teases. “I bet you’ve already figured out 30 things that I forgot.”

“That’s what you love about me.”

“It’s *one* of the things.”

Feeling a bit flustered by that, Adora decides to just push through.

“I’ll figure a bunch of stuff out. Work is slow – can I work from here this week?” When she gets a nod, she continues, “You’ll let me take care of everything? Of you?”

Catra doesn’t speak or move for a long moment, leading Adora to think she overstepped. She’s been there for less than 10 minutes and she’s already pushed Catra too far – jumping into her bed, trying to take over her life.

“You know I can do this,” Catra says. “But yeah, it would be nice if you could. For me.”

A job. Adora loves a job. Something tangible to help with would be perfect to focus on.

“Okay, good. I'm organized. I can be decisive….sometimes. I don't let things fall through the cracks.”

“Relax,” Catra mumbles dryly. “It’s not a job interview. You're already hired. Also, it doesn’t pay and I don’t offer college credit.”

Ignoring that, Adora replies, “I just want you to know that I care about you and I'm taking this seriously.”

Catra sighs but it sounds more wistful than exasperated.

She’s patiently entertaining Adora when she responds, “Fine. You’ll make your task list. How are you gonna manage me?”

“Well, that's easy. I know everything about you. Cuddles, junk food, bad TV, and just being allowed to be sad, right?”

Catra moves her face into the crook of Adora’s neck and shoulder.

“Gods, you’re always so good to me.”

Her voice sounds guilty. Adora knows they’ll have to talk about their fight at some point, but it can take a backseat until things are a bit more figured out.

She doesn’t want to bring this up but she knows she has to.

“How are you *feeling* ?”

Feelings have never been something that they’re very good at but Catra’s usually better at understanding hers, at least. And Adora knows from experience that she can be enticed into sharing them with enough badgering or bartering.

“Empty,” is all Catra says.

So Adora just holds her tighter. After a few moments, the dam breaks and she can feel Catra trembling in her arms as her neck gets soaked.

“She was awful to me. You can’t even imagine. About me being an ‘ *animal* ’. About me being queer. All of my ‘ *unnatural* ’ urges. And now she’s dead and if I’m not empty, I’m so fucking angry, Adora, that I feel like I could rip the world in two with my bare hands. I don’t know how to *be* right now.”

Adora nods. “When my dad died, my real dad who gave me up when I was little, I just shut down for 6 months. I was walking and talking and working but I had so many feelings that I couldn’t even begin to describe them, let alone figure out how to have them, navigate them, tell other people.”

She pauses to tuck Catra further against her neck. “You can feel however you need to feel, Cat. You have amazing friends who’ll support you.”

Adora really hopes that Catra hears this.

But in case she doesn’t, “We’ll make you and Finn wellness plans today. You ever done that?”

Catra shakes her head no.

“It’s just a way to share what your needs are in a situation. So like, if you know you’ll need someone to make sure you and Finn get 3 meals each day for the next two weeks, you can write that and ask someone for that specific support. I’ll walk you both through it and we’ll figure all this out together. I won’t overwhelm you with a lot of extra stuff. This’ll help us tap in your friends, plus Bow and Glimmer and Mermista and Frosta, even.”

“I don’t want everyone to know.”

“They won’t have to. Like, maybe Mermista just needs to know to keep everyone away from you during this time and to intercept calls from whoever’s helping you with taxes and debts so you can work on that when you need to. Or pass it off to Scorpia. Perfuma can know what your needs are with Finn and work with their social worker to get everything sorted out. It’ll be easier once we know what you need and I can coordinate everyone to support their individual part. No one will have to know more than you want them to.”

Catra sniffles quietly for a few moments. “I’m a fucking mess, Dor. You were right, I could’ve fucked that kid’s life up. And now I have

them here and I can't even get out of bed. I'm an awful person. Why the fuck did I think I could do this?"

Adora holds her tighter.

But Catra continues on, fully spiraling. "I destroy everything. I always push people away – I tried to push you out of my life and you're the best thing that's ever happened to me. You're this incredible person who's so perfect and special and I'm acting like a damaged fucking nightmare. I sent you one word and you came back and you're taking care of me. I don't deserve you."

The deep belly laugh that springs out of Adora is completely unexpected and she can't control it. It's very inappropriate based on what they're talking about currently, Weaver being dead and all. She tries to apologize but it's swallowed up by her guffaws. Really, everything Catra's saying is pretty ludicrous though.

"You don't deserve me?! Kitten, I've spent this whole year telling everyone how fucking amazing and magical and brilliant and giving and thoughtful you are. And how I have nothing to offer you. I'm so fucking grateful you trust me to support you right now."

Catra moves so she can see Adora's, now blushing, face.

"Kitten?" Her tone is indecipherable, low, kinda curious, and something else entirely that Adora can't place.

It's now Adora's turn to try to hide her face, shoving it onto Catra's shoulder and into her hair.

"I call you that in my head sometimes. I'll stop if you hate it."

"I'm your Kitten?" Her tail unravels from Adora's waist and is now thumping against the bed. She must feel very vulnerable.

Adora's a little thrown off by the 'your' there. She wasn't implying that Catra was hers in any way. Yes, it sometimes feels like that but she tries not to be possessive. Gods know, she certainly

doesn’t think Catra owes her anything, not just cause of the last two months. Catra’s... *wild* and free. Adora loves that about her. But Catra is also here, in Adora’s arms, and *giving herself over* , it feels like.

This is a good time to take a chance.

“You’re my Kitten,” Adora confirms. She feels like this deserves an offering in kind. “And I’m your Dor.”

“Yes,” Catra breathes out with a sigh. “ *My* Dor. Mine.”

Maybe that settles some of those questions about who they are to each other.

“Don’t talk about my Dor like that, by the way. She’s pretty much the greatest person I’ve ever met. And I know a lot of people so.”

Impossibly, they find ways to press in even closer together, until all of their limbs are wrapped up in each other. Catra shifts them until Adora’s on her back with Catra stretched out on top of her.

Adora always enjoys an assessment to make sure everyone’s on the same page with a plan. Not the sexiest thing to do after...whatever it is that they just committed to.

“I know that a lot of the other stuff that came up last time we talked still needs to be processed. But I think we have a good groundwork to focus on the more immediate needs right now.”

Catra nods against Adora’s chest.

“I’ve got you, Kitten.”

“You’ll stay with me?” Catra whispers.

Adora doesn’t know if she means today or forever, but she’s open to both options.

“Of course.”

Catra shifts up a bit and Adora thinks she’s about to say something so she raises her head to pay close attention. What she doesn’t expect is a gentle peck on the cheek. It happens too too fast – the sensation of Catra’s soft lips on her skin, close enough to smell her shampoo, smoke from cigarettes that she’s probably hiding, and her quintessential Catra smell that Adora’s missed so much, all musk and sandalwood with just a hint of flowers.

That peck will have to do for now, though. Catra’s grieving and overwhelmed and Adora intends to fully behave herself.

“Thank you,” Adora says like a complete doofus. Catra snickers quietly at her and then they settle into comfortably holding each other in silence.

At some point, someone's stomach growls. Finn had been promised pizza and Adora needs to let her coworkers know where she is because Glimmer will absolutely convene a search party if she’s gone for more than 2 hours. She tries to explain this to Catra, who’s not having it.

“No, you’re my Dor,” Catra grumbles against her chest. “We have to make up for all the lost time.”

“Two months,” Adora replies. She’s not agreeing, she’s just *sorta* feeling similar. “You can really hold a grudge, you know?”

Catra scoffs. “I was panicking, not just being petty. Trust me, you'd *know* if I had a grudge. I got into a fight with Kyle and I haven't spoken to him in four years.”

“Who’s Kyle?”

“Exactly.”

Eventually, Adora does have to call work. Mostly cause Glimmer starts texting and doesn't stop for 25 minutes straight.

When Glimmer answers, she's breathless for some reason, like she's been running all over the office, even though Adora very clearly stated in her text that she had left and wouldn't be back. She didn't say *where* she went because it felt too complicated. That was probably a mistake.

"I swear, Adora Priscilla Gray, you better tell me where you are right this second or I'm-"

"Is that your middle name?" Catra asks. She pauses to think. "No, I've gone through your wallet. You don't have a middle name."

Adora doesn't have time to ask why exactly Catra would go through her wallet before Glimmer jumps in.

" *CATRA* ?!"

The video call notification is immediate.

"Answer or she'll be over here in 15 minutes and I'm not getting out of this bed," Catra says.

On the screen, Glimmer's standing in Adora's office with Bow and Perfuma trying to shove their way into the frame.

Adora's incredibly grateful that Catra allowed her to get up and put on a tanktop and shorts earlier, even if it was just to open the door for the pizza person.

In their tiny square in the corner of her phone, she can see the reflection of herself pressed against the headboard once again, Catra lying with her head in Adora's lap, and just the edge of the pizza box that an off-screen Finn is trying to balance on Catra's shoulder.

She turns down the volume just in time to cut off the collective squeal from the other side of the call.

Shit. Adora was focused on trying to get her friends not to put out an APB and didn't really think about accidentally giving them the

wrong impression about her relationship status. What if Glimmer says something mortifying? Which is basically guaranteed at all times.

When it appears that the trio has calmed down, Adora turns her sound back up.

“How did this happen?!” Glimmer screams.

“It’s not what you think,” Adora says quickly.

She glances down at Catra for her input. If they’re going to tell people about Weaver, it should be her call, after all. Instead of answering, Catra angles the camera to her left.

“Finn!” Bow shouts, slightly quieter than his girlfriend. Confusion falls over both of their faces.

The younger cat’s ears perk up and they turn into an even bigger bouncy smiling mess when they see who's calling.

“Bow!” Finn yells back. “I just ate a pizza with *all* of the toppings.”

It was actually only about 5 toppings, cause Catra has a lot of feelings about what is ‘appropriate’ to put on a pizza, but they were too happy for Adora to ruin the illusion.

Bow tries to give an encouraging smile but his eyes are starting to look panicked.

“iwasn’treadytobeanuncle,” he whispers through clenched teeth.

Catra wisely swivels the phone back towards Adora.

“Lesbians,” Glimmer hisses. “What kind of U-Haul bullsh-”

“Okay,” Perfuma interrupts firmly. “Adora, we’re glad to see that you’re fine. Catra, good job for finally reaching out for help.”

Catra’s tail stops idly moving on the bed and tucks down between her legs. Like a reflex, Adora’s free hand goes down to stroke her

mane. Fussing quietly, Catra repositions her head until Adora's fingers are right below her ear. The blonde doesn't hesitate to begin gently scratching.

"Perfuma will fill the rest of you dummies in on what's up," Catra tells them. "But Adora's not missing, just being held hostage here."

Her eyes are starting to droop and there's a quiet purr in her voice that Adora figures she's probably trying to hide from their audience.

"Does Adora have to pay her ransom in kisses?" Glimmer asks with an annoying grin.

That's a good enough excuse for Adora to say goodbye and hang up quickly, seconds before the rumble against her leg grows.

Catra barely startles when a tiny ear is pressed against her back to investigate the sound. Finn looks up at Adora with wide eyes, like she just made magic happen.

"Miss Adora?" It doesn't seem like they're quite sure what they're asking for though.

"You can just call me Adora now. If you want. Are you feeling sad, Finn?"

They hesitate a second and then nod slightly.

"I'm sorry," she tells them. "But you're...okay?"

"Social worker says they were fine," Catra says quietly. "She looked like she hadn't slept in a year though so what the hell does she know?"

"We'll find someone for them to talk to. I'll add it to the list."

"Come here, kid. I'll show you how to con humans into doing whatever you want."

Finn lets the pizza box fall to the bed and scrambles over Catra and onto Adora’s other side.

They watch attentively as Catra flicks her ear. It takes a couple tries, they stick out their tongue in concentration and everything, but they manage to softly flick their ears at Adora.

She dutifully reaches over to give them scritches.

Finn doesn’t purr, not really. They make a sound that’s a bit closer to a baby bird that Bow would absolutely lose his mind over.

“Now,” Catra instructs, “look at Adora and ask for a bike.”

“Cat! Can you try not to be a bad influence?”

“It works best with Bow,” she whispers to Finn.

Catra reaches over and moves a couple pillows so they can sit more comfortably. Absently, Finn’s tiny claws start to knead the blanket as they lean further into Adora’s palm.

There’s a soft pad onto the bed and then Melog’s sitting near her feet, narrowing their eyes in jealousy.

Chapter End Notes

> okay, maybe catra was doing slightly more than just listening to "i can't make you love me" on repeat. but it was just, like, ordering donuts and listening it to simultaneously.
>
> yeah, if i can't shoot shadow weaver in the face, i will just let her die slowly.
>
> no one's finished apologizing. they're gay. they have to have several more conversations where everyone politely plays the martyr but also adora goes "but for real, what the fuck is up?"

Such a Lovely Family

Chapter Summary

Lots and lots of talking. Lots and lots of shopping.

Chapter Notes

happy friday! here's some fluff, some light angst, and more fluff. a flaf, if you will, except that sounds kinda gross.

i continue to be very grateful for and extremely amused by the comments. these dummies will process more (and they'll make more mistakes, like so many more mistakes ffs) and there will be cute cat family adventures. some of y'all called that like 5 chapters back, which was really impressive honestly.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora arrives on a Friday morning to help out around the apartment and try to get some work done remotely. Well, as much work as one can do with a trio of cats climbing all over them.

She lets herself in, carrying muffins that she picked up from a bakery near her place. Double chocolate for Catra. Blueberry for Finn. Cranberry oat for herself. Maybe it'll entice the other two out of bed at a reasonable hour.

Finn's barreling towards her as soon as she walks in, moving way too fast.

"No running please!" she begs, but they bump into the door, slamming it shut and circling her before they can pull themselves into a hard stop a couple feet in front her.

"Dora!" They're out of breath so they've obviously been rushing around for a while. Maybe giving Finn more sugar isn't a good idea. "Cat-"

They’re cut out by a voice from the hall, “No snitching!”

Finn dutifully closes their mouth, tail swaying playfully behind them. One look at the bakery box in Adora’s hands, though, and their eyes go wide. Their tail freezes.

“Morning, Finn,” Adora says quietly with a smile. “I brought muffins again. Want to tell me what’s going on?”

It’s important that Adora does not *explicitly* say that she’s bribing them. It’s just heavily implied. She wouldn’t want to set a bad example.

Finn glances at the box, at Adora’s eyes, and then over their shoulder to the hall to make sure Catra isn’t there.

Then they whisper something so quietly that it’s definitely impossible for Adora to pick it up.

“Hey!” an offended Catra yells from her room.

Since they technically did do what was requested, Finn leaps up in the air towards the muffins. Adora barely has enough time to hold the box over her head before their tiny claws swipe up near her shoulder.

Catra knows nothing about parenting, they’ve learned. Adora has a PhD in early education. Since legally, she is no one to Finn, she’s decided to follow Catra’s lead on discipline. This includes letting them run wild all over the apartment and jungle gyms and toy aisles. And now, Adora apparently.

She knows her own former foster mother, with her rigid rules about ‘appropriate’ behavior, would deeply disapprove.

With a tight smile, Adora tries to politely ask, “Finn, maybe don’t jump on people unless you ask if it’s okay?”

“Are you still being weird?” Catra calls. “Just tell them to knock it off. You’re the adult.”

Finn clearly senses they're not on the same page and takes advantage of that, trying to launch themself in the air again. A claw gets a little closer to her face, not quite reaching their loot.

It's enough of a near-miss that Adora gasps. A couple inches west and that would have been her eye.

"Knock it off, bud!" Catra yells, voice kind but firm.

Instead of another attempt, Finn throws their arms around Adora's waist and nuzzles into her leg.

"I'll tell you what Cat did," they whisper.

"Last week, I bought an ugly wine cart in the middle of the night," Catra admits. "I'm not gonna be shamed in my own home for my ambien purchases, just so we're all clear on that."

Finn still attached to her leg, Adora finally gives up waiting on Catra to come out and moves towards the kitchen, balancing the kid's extra weight easily. There is indeed a gold bar cart on wheels sitting in the middle of the room. It matches nothing. The box to return it is not nearby.

Great, now they have an ugly cart cause Catra forgot to go to sleep again.

Except, Adora reminds herself, she doesn't live there. She's just been there most days for the past week while trying to figure out what Finn and Catra need and how to help them. As Catra predicted, it pretty much involves making sure they eat and begging them to bathe.

She's about to set the muffins down when Catra emerges from her room.

Draped in some sort of soft, gray silly-looking cape poncho over black tights, she moves towards them, trying to pretend to be nonchalant. Adora sees what Finn was *actually* going to tattle about.

Catra's long, unruly mane is gone. Instead it's been replaced by short, still unruly waves cut into a cute little pixie style. Adora is shocked because she just saw Catra last night at dinnertime. And also because she remembers the name of a haircut. Probably Glimmer's influence.

The older cat had idly asked a couple days before if she should cut her hair. She hadn't been showering or combing it much and it was starting to become a whole situation. Adora couldn't picture her without her signature locks but was smart enough to say that Catra would look great regardless. That seemed to be the end of it.

Without her mane, Catra's eyes stand out even more. So bold and striking and expressive.

Adora doesn't feel the box slipping from her hands but she hears Finn dive under it and cheer.

"Sleeping pills?" is all she can say.

"No, I had a crying fit at 2am and decided that I needed a change." Catra runs her hand through it self-consciously. "Probably shoulda used scissors instead of my claws, though."

"I think a haircut is a recognized stage of grief," Adora replies. She takes a moment to really look at it. Then she makes the mistake of imagining Catra with this haircut in one of her suits. "You look amazing."

She realizes she sounds a bit breathless and cringes internally. Catra's grieving and vulnerable. Adora has sworn to herself that she'll respect that and back off. Not that she was being anything resembling *forward* a couple months ago anyway.

Catra steps closer and gives Adora a relieved hug.

"Hi," she whispers.

“Morning,” the blonde returns. She wraps one arm around Catra’s back and the other around her shoulders, hand stopping at the nape of her neck. Gently, Adora lets her fingers reach up to caress the short locks there.

All of the tension that Adora hadn’t even noticed Catra was holding melts out of her body.

“You really like it?”

Adora nod is quickly met with a deep purr.

From the floor, Finn makes a weird sound like they’re trying to get food out of their throat. A quick glance down confirms that that might be true since they’ve managed to take at least one bite out of each of the muffins. But they’re watching the two adults intensely.

“Practicing,” Catra supplies. “They can only purr when they’re sleeping. They want to try to do it when they’re awake. Impress all the kids when school starts back up.”

Adora makes a very silly cooing sound that Finn takes as approval to finish the rest of their baked goods.

“ *One* muffin, please. Don’t you want to share with the rest of us?”

“You have to be more stern,” Catra tells her quietly. “Talk to them how you talk to me.”

“This *is* how I talk to you.”

Catra pulls back to narrow her eyes at Adora. Then she agrees with a shrug.

“Well, don’t be afraid to just reach down there and wrestle your breakfast away,” Catra suggests.

Finn makes a sound that they probably think is a growl. It's really just them saying "grrr."

There's probably bananas or something that Adora can have instead because this is too precious to disturb.

"You're a capable, self-assured grown ass woman. Don't be punked out of your muffin."

"That feels weirdly homophobic but…" Adora starts to untangle herself.

"They do have claws that can cut through most materials, though," Catra adds absently.

When Adora freezes, she just laughs.

"Dor, you work with kids. You can't be afraid of one."

"I've never had to interact with them at home," Adora tries to whisper.

"Grrr."

Barely restraining a laugh, Catra holds her hand out towards Finn without looking away from Adora. Finn relinquishes immediately and Catra hands the blonde 70% or so of cranberry oat muffin.

"Go get set up. Don't you have a call in a few minutes?"

Roughly about 45 seconds after her video call ends, Adora hears the bedroom door open. The third bedroom was an office that Catra never used but Adora's been really enjoying the sunlight and the view while she works. Typically, someone comes in to nap in the small spare bed or on the edge of the desk, but the latter is usually just Melog. *Usually* .

Catra comes around and sits on the corner of the desk, pulling her legs up until she's holding her knees. She drapes her dramatic cape thing around herself.

This must be Catra's proudest purchase, a fashionable excuse to wear a blanket.

Her " *Hey* , Adora" doesn't have its usual confidence.

"Hey," she responds, running a hand down the shin closest to her. "What's up?"

"Kid had a sugar crash so they're down for a bit. Have a couple minutes for me?"

"Always." She opens her arms expecting Catra to want a hug.

Instead, Catra shakes her head gently. Adora lowers her arms dumbly, trying to look as if she isn't already prepared to begin panicking at a moment's notice.

"I realized last night that I never really apologized," Catra mumbles. "Not really. So. I'm sorry."

Adora goes to open her mouth and is cut off when Catra adds, "Dude, I'm grovelling for your forgiveness. I have to say a whole thing."

Dutifully, the blonde closes her laptop and moves the chair back just a few inches so she can face Catra better.

"I was upset. But I shouldn't have gotten so angry with you. Or personal. That was dirty. It was your work and it wasn't really my business. And then I left you twisting in the wind for weeks, which was fucking awful of me. You deserved better than that."

"I'm sorry, too," Adora tells her quickly. "I'm sorry for moving ahead without asking for your guidance or checking in with you. You're the survivor. I should have listened to you."

"Yeah, that would have been all the wrongs to do. And in front of Weaver? She would have had a fucking field day. You did what you could. I should have handled it better."

"Me too."

Catra shakes her head like she doesn't know why Adora's apologizing but it feels like she should own her part of this. And there's something Adora's more interested in hearing than 'sorry'.

"Why *didn't* you ever respond? Even just to say you couldn't talk?"

The cape goes over Catra's head for a moment but she comes back out promptly.

"I was pissed. And then I was sad and overwhelmed with everything happening. And when she finally died, it felt too late, like I'd completely lost you. So I just kept hiding from it. Old patterns, you know?"

Yeah, Catra's certainly triggered Adora's old patterns of blaming herself and replaying all the ways she messed up in her head on a loop.

"You didn't do anything wrong," Catra says, almost like she can read the blonde's thoughts. "I shouldn't have treated you that way. I just...I was...scared. Once the grief hit, everything felt fucking impossible."

"And telling the doorperson I wasn't welcome?"

Catra shakes her head. "Weaver had my card so I had to alert the security here and at my office. She was liable to show up anywhere and…" she stops with another shake of her head, like she can't even imagine the depths the woman would have gone through to torture her more. "I just did a full lockdown on unrequested visitors. Honestly, with everything going to shit, I completely forgot about it."

With her head, she motions in the general direction of Adora's body. While Adora's only half-sure that she knows what Catra's asking for, she nods anyway. As expected, Catra somehow manages to get from the desk and into Adora's lap without her feet touching the floor. She just kinda slinks from one surface to

another, pausing briefly to balance on the arms of the chair until she's curled into a ball on Adora's thighs, head lying on the blonde's shoulder.

Adora can't see her face when she begins to whisper but she can feel Catra's ears flatten against her head.

"I kept imagining what would happen if I saw you. If you just showed up. At first, it was too much and I'd fight and convince you I was right. After a week, though, all I could imagine was being with you like this. Telling you about Weaver. And you leaving because it was too much."

Adora shifts so she can wrap both arms around Catra.

"Is that why you told Scorpia not to invite me to her birthday?"

Catra groans in response. "You greatly overestimate the amount of control I have over the idiots in my life. *Scorpia* decided not to invite you because she's firmly on your side and thought I was going to cause a scene and yell at you or something. I don't know where she got that idea."

She pauses for a moment.

"I mean, except all those times she's had to pull me out of screaming matches. But that was *years* ago. I haven't even been *allowed* in a sample sale in half a decade." For a second, she sounds a bit more like her regular self, idly complaining.

"You know I'd never do that, right? Just take off cause I thought you were a lot."

It takes a moment but Catra nods.

"So can we agree on something?" Adora asks. "If we're ever feeling too much and we can't talk, it's fine to take a break. But it's our responsibility to come back and finish things. I think we owe that to each other."

“Adora Priscilla Gray wants to talk about feelings?”

“That’s not my middle name!” she says with a small smile. “But yeah, I’m learning to appreciate processing. Sometimes.”

“Well, then. Deal.”

They sit in silence for a few minutes, just holding each other.

“I really am sorry I hurt you,” Catra says quietly. “I thought I had a better handle on things. I’ve been working on myself or whatever for so so long and Weaver comes back and suddenly I’m 8 years old again, so fucking alone and scared.”

“You’re not alone, Cat.”

“Neither are you,” she says pointedly, like Glimmer probably gave her a full update on how Adora was coping.

“It felt that way for a while,” Adora admits. “Everyone kept not so gently suggesting that maybe I could use some work on myself. I just sorta...broke apart.”

Adora would like to keep going. She really would. Explain more, push both of them a bit more. But this is already feeling emotionally exhausting and the day has barely started. Catra must sense it as well.

“I’ll let you get back to work,” Catra tells her. “When stuff calms down, we’ll talk, right? About...everything?”

Adora shifts down to look at her. Something in Catra’s eyes makes it pretty clear to Adora that she means this whole mess they’ve been wrapped in for months, even before Weaver came in like a storm. Gods, they haven't even begun to scratch the surface – all the things Adora wanted to say to Catra that night, her whole plan. It feels like a lifetime ago almost.

“Yeah. When you’re more settled, maybe?”

Catra nods then she basically mewls, a sound Melog makes when they want something. Adora's never heard it from her before. When the blonde doesn't move, Catra does it again.

With a chuckle, Adora gives in to a guess. She pets Catra gently on the head, enjoying the feel of short hair between her fingers.

"You don't need my permission or whatever," Catra starts, "but it's okay for you to be mad. If I were you, I'd be fucking pissed."

"Yeah, I remember how upset you were when I forgot to text once."

"That was a misunderstanding!" Catra shoots back quickly. "I lost my phone or something? I don't even remember so I refuse to be held accountable for that."

"How are you so impossibly stubborn?" Adora asks with a quiet laugh.

Catra pulls back to look incredulously.

"You? Of all people? Wan-"

"Fine," Adora interrupts. "We could both work on that. I think if you'd been just going about your life, having a perfectly wonderful time, I would have sent you an evenly worded but absolutely *scathing* email in 2-3 weeks."

"...did you schedule in being mad at me?"

"No!"

It was a vague timeline of when Adora could move from worried about Catra's safety to enraged by her callous behavior.

"It was kinda hard to be pissed at you when I found out the context, Cat. I'm not a doormat, though. Don't try to treat me like I am."

“I won’t,” she swears. “I promise.”

“Glimmer *fucking* Moon is a threat to national security and our entire way of life and should be treated as such.”

“Cat, it's not Glimmer's rules,” Adora reminds her yet again. “She just actually bothered to read the student code of conduct.”

How she beat Adora to that is a mystery to everyone.

“Why does an elementary school even have a code of conduct? Tell them not to eat glue or sling piss at each other and they're fine.”

She continues tearing through the racks of clothes while Finn plays with fidget toys next to her. They'll follow Catra pretty much anywhere, but Adora's still anxious about taking them to crowded places after an incident the prior week where they disappeared and fell asleep in a huge display of stuffed animals. It took over an hour to find them and she basically had a meltdown while Catra argued with the security guards about whether or not they could use the store's cameras to track them down. It ended with everyone in tears except Finn, who was excited to report what a lovely nap they'd had.

Other than, you know, thinking they’d lost a child in a giant superstore that Catra was pissed to have to go to anyway, ranting about bad labor practices and the death of small business, the transition was mostly painless. And Adora was pretty sure that Catra’s rant was just to be difficult, even if it was well researched and very correct. But their friends had all been absolutely amazing, diving into supporting in any way that they could. Having a clear wellness plan had been helpful and everyone felt comfortable in their role.

Except Glimmer. She had been asked to pick up more things at the office so Adora could continue to do more remote work. Glimmer took that on and also assigned herself as aunt, house

mother, head master, and documentarian. At least this keeps her mostly too busy to ask Adora too many pointed and way too personal questions about her and Catra's relationship.

Having some extra time had been a true blessing really. Adora was able to help set up some routines for the three of them, get Finn settled in more, and be there for Catra while she grieved. The latter involved mostly allowing Catra to use her as a human pillow, which wasn't a bad gig at all.

Melog is usually upset about it but they have Finn to lounge on now.

One of the partners at Catra's firm had insisted she take parental leave once they learned about the new addition to her family. She relented and took three extra weeks, arguing that she'd have nothing to do at home once Finn started school. In order to get Finn into counseling, they made a three-way pact, which meant Adora had to return to her therapist for the first time in years and Catra was seeing hers twice a week until she was feeling more sorted out. She'd had a bit of a backslide when Finn's counselor reported that she didn't think they'd experienced anything at all like Catra's childhood with Weaver; it should have been a relief but it brought up a lot of feelings of self-blame for the older cat.

The biggest hurdle, in *Catra's* mind, had not been being dumped into the deep end of all of her past trauma, somehow, but *school uniforms*.

Catra and Adora had tried to enroll Finn in the public school they attended the year before. Apparently, it was also Catra's former elementary school and she was convinced that many of the (basically elderly) teachers from her youth that remained 25 years later hated her and were out to get her. And Finn. She'd taken one look at some kind-looking old lady named Mrs. Anderson, turned around, and walked right out the door.

According to Finn, they didn't have any friends there and didn't care anyway, which Adora found pretty heartbreaking.

So Catra made Mermista do some research and found a private school that was kinda nearby and claimed to be more affirming of gender-variant kids. Adora is pretty certain that Catra bribed someone to get them in but at least she's excited about everything about the school. The arts program. The lack of both 'hippie bullshit' and 'preppy fuckery' as she says.

The only issue is that Catra hates the uniforms. Also, that Catra didn't realize there *were* uniforms until Glimmer pointed it out this week. They're not gendered at all, really, and pretty open to interpretation. Catra just doesn't like Finn having to dress like everyone else for some reason.

Finn, it should be noted, doesn't actually seem to care but will agree with Catra if they think they'll get a reward. The two of them are a little obsessed with each other and Adora genuinely can't remember a time when she's been happier.

So far, they've been to three uniform stores, a thing that Adora wasn't aware existed until now, and four regular kids stores. Catra hates everything in all of them. She claims none of it is Finn's style. Since Adora's known Finn, they've basically only worn hand-me-down jeans and t-shirts with a dingy bandanna on their neck or wrist. They're in second grade. They don't have a style. Pointing this out has only gotten her hissed at though, so she won't make that mistake again.

"This is all shit," Catra announces at a row of navy blue slacks. The only acceptable colors are white, blue, and khaki. Catra nearly collapsed when she heard this.

"What if we put together like a mood board or something?" Adora suggests. She overheard Glimmer say this, but obviously her friend is dead to Catra so it's okay to steal her idea this one time.

"Sounds like a lot of work," Catra mumbles. It's surprising to hear her disinterested in spending more time on fashion, but Adora knows it's just her grief talking.

“Well, maybe we can get some basic pieces until you have time to figure out more of a style.”

“ *No* . First day, first impression. It’s got to be good.” She stops suddenly, glances at a rack of tiny toddler khakis and scoffs. “Why do we as a society want our children to look like baby accountants?”

Catra glances back at Finn, who’s still wrapped up in their toy.

“Any inspiration yet, kid?”

“I like fish,” they reply. “Can my pants have fish on them?”

“We should appeal to the school board,” Catra tells Adora, like she’s taking this fish suggestion seriously.

“Or, we should pick out some blue pants, some white shirts, a durable yet comfortable pair of shoes, and a backpack that’s not falling apart.” ‘Like sensible people’, she doesn’t add.

Catra spins around on her heel and marches up to Adora. She’s expecting another outburst. Instead, Catra puts her hands on Adora’s hips and pulls her closer with a smirk.

“What’s it like to be so unimaginative? Is it fulfilling?”

“If you can’t dream too big, anything can be fulfilling,” Adora replies, matching her smirk.

“What a dark statement, princess.”

“Dora, can I have fish pants, please?” She looks down and Finn is making their sad baby kitty eyes, which usually works about 80% of the time to get them whatever they want.

Adora is growing an immunity to it, thankfully. “The rulebook says no patterns. Sorry, Finny.”

“Boo,” they grumble loudly. Catra probably taught them that.

There’s a nearby giggle. Catra and Adora look to their side, where a middle-aged red-headed woman is smiling kindly at them. Adora knows what she’s going to say before it comes out of her mouth.

“Sorry for interrupting,” she begins. “You’re just such a lovely family.”

“Thank you!” Finn beams.

Adora just gives the woman a polite nod. When this happened in the first few stores, she got flustered, to Catra’s great amusement. When Catra was having a bad day, she told a couple of people to mind their business and keep their commentary to themselves. Now, they just let Finn handle it. They’re the least anxious of the three usually anyway, given that they haven’t had much sugar yet.

The woman continues her shopping and Catra lets Adora go to reject a group of blazers. She holds one next to Finn and hangs it back up with a grim shake of her head.

With a deep breath, Catra explains, “We’ll get fish socks. They can’t possibly ban those. You didn’t look bad in the blue so I’ll order some decent ones with white trim. If I really annoy my tailor, she can have a couple finished before school starts-”

Adora tries to insert some reason here, “They don’t need tailored suits, Cat. They’re gonna just grow out of them in a few months.”

Catra continues, unbothered, “We’ll get some boring white and blue shirts but higher quality than this crap. Let’s go back to that boutique on the east side and pick up nice shoes and all the fixins.” She grabs Finn’s hand and starts walking away without even waiting for Adora.

“And fish socks?” Finn reminds her.

“That’s the most important part. Duh.”

At the boutique, Adora and Catra fight about how much she's spending on socks, ties, *ascots* (to replace the bandana, Catra explains), and random accessories that a 7 year old doesn't need. Finn's allowed to pick it all out and they want pretty much everything their eyes land on. They insist on getting *four* pairs of shoes, all of which match ones that Adora is sure that Catra owns, and each costs more than what Adora is currently wearing.

Both cats move around the store way too quickly, grabbing everything and overwhelming Adora as well as the store clerk.

"You have such a fun family," she whispers to the blonde. Adora gives her a tight-lipped smile in return.

"How young is too young to teach a kid the hanky code?" Catra wonders aloud.

"What is that?" Adora asks.

"33, apparently," Catra replies, mostly to herself. "That's a shame."

As everything's being rung up, Adora feels overwhelmed all over again. It must show in her face because Catra nuzzles briefly into her neck until she relaxes.

"Don't worry," Catra says with a wicked grin. "We'll have to do this all again in the spring. When they grow out of everything, like you said."

The next stop is supposed to be school supplies. Adora imagines this will be easy – pencils, a notebook, trapper keeper if that's still a thing, the usual. Finn spends the entire time deciding which fish-themed pencil case and lunch box is the best.

"Fuck, I have to make *lunch* everyday now?" Catra whispers to Adora.

"We'll do meal prep on Sundays. Don't worry – it's on the list."

"Gods, we'd literally starve without you."

“Cat, you’re still allowed to order your fancy lunches. I know you love them.”

“This kid’s costing me a fortune – do you even see how many pencil cases they want? I’m gonna have to cut corners somewhere. I’ll probably have to meet you by your office every day and share a brown bag lunch with you.”

Adora looks back at her. Catra’s face has a small, shy smile, like there was a bit too much hopefulness in her teasing words. Adora reaches back and links their pinkies together.

“If it’ll save you and Finn from becoming destitute, then I’d be honored,” she says. “Come on. Help me go through this list.”

“Yeah, no, I already ordered the best rated pencils, notebooks, all that shit online while you were sleeping.”

“Catra,” comes out exasperated because they’d had this conversation twice already. “Everything doesn’t have to be fancy.”

She pulls Adora pinky’s until the blonde is standing in front of her.

“Look, I know that everyone thinks I’m being extra or projecting or whatever.” Adora just raises an eyebrow. “But it’s their first time at this new place. Their first time with clothes that were bought just for them. Their first time learning about economic justice probably, once they see how the other kids act. I just want them to have the best of everything. Maybe build some confidence.”

Adora lets go of her hand to place both of hers on Catra’s shoulders.

“I know. It’s incredibly kind and thoughtful.” Catra looks down bashfully. “Can we agree on two things? That we should run more decisions by Finn. And also that they naturally have more confidence than even elite-level athletes already.”

“Yeah, it’s terrifying. They’re a Leo. Also, they sleep on their back sometimes. Those are the most frightening people.” Adora has to

stifle a laugh. “Seriously, Dor, we could be raising a tiny menace to society. Like a future super villain or something.”

Adora ignores the villain part to focus on the fact that Catra just implied that they’ll definitely be in each other’s lives for a good long while.

She pulls Catra into a hug in the middle of the store.

“Don’t even think about sacrificing me so you can get out,” Catra mumbles against her shoulder.

“I know you’d stay the whole time just so you could appear in a true crime documentary and tell your story. Your reenactment actress will look so awful.”

“Not a lot of cat actresses. It’ll probably just be a short guy in a werewolf halloween costume.”

That makes Adora chuckle which makes Catra join in. Finn, who hadn’t heard what happened at all, drags their many pencil case and lunch tote options over just to make sure that they were part of the joke.

A random store employee stocking nearby looks away from their work.

“Y’all cute.”

“Thanks,” Catra returns with a blush, disentangling herself from the hug.

The blush is a new reaction from her. Adora glances at the person and they’re *very* attractive. A short curvy femme with caramel skin, curly hair dyed honey blonde, and nice hazel eyes. When Adora looks back to Catra, she’s moved away quickly.

“Let’s see how cute she thinks we are when the kid is caught trying to poison the city’s water supply for ransom,” Catra

mumbles quietly. But Adora can hear the flustered smile in her voice.

Chapter End Notes

> catra takes a lot of strong stances (including her feelings on other people's sleep positions) and i'm not sure she actually believes any of them. she's right about the reenactment actress tho.

The Absolute Spectacle

Chapter Summary

Cats vs bows. Baby's first day.

Chapter Notes

this week's posts are full of adora trying to figure some things out, glimmer mistakenly thinking all problems can be solved by her screaming, and cats. also, LONNIE. (like, a small amount of lonnie. i fucking love lonnie.)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora rarely takes a lunch break. There's no need to. She can usually just eat at her computer while she responds to emails. With the exception of her “work lunches” with Catra, she can generally just power through the time it takes her to eat her pre-prepped meal.

She's not a robot, though. Adora takes the occasional break, especially after everyone conspired to write in her performance evaluation that she was “creating a culture of overworking”, whatever that means. Unlike Glimmer, she doesn't spend the time on her phone or harassing her co-workers. Often, Adora reads a few articles or sends Catra a text.

Today, Adora decides to spend 30 minutes doing some research. She makes a mental list of all of her clothing. And then she tries to find an affordable store to pick up a couple new pieces that’ll complement her existing wardrobe.

Like some cuter shirts. More form-fitting. Or nicer pants. A couple skirts? Maybe an actual non-sportsbra?

“What are you looking at weirdly?”

Adora startles so harshly that she punches the screen when trying to turn it off. Recovering from that brief pain quickly, her hand reaches for the correct button but it's too late. Glimmer's already standing behind the desk, peering over her shoulder.

"Oh," Glimmer says flatly. "Okay, for once, I have no idea what you're up to."

"Nothing," Adora says quickly. "Uh. I was thinking of what to get my sister for her birthday."

"Those tops are about as interesting as a trip to the gyno. Mara would never even give that a second look." Glimmer pauses in thought for a moment. "Also, you give out $50 bills every year like someone's aunt."

"Who doesn't appreciate cash?" Adora mutters before closing the tab.

Unfortunately, that means Glimmer sees the next open tab, a variety of posh underclothes.

She gasps and clasps her hands together in delight. "Are you getting laid?"

Adora rolls her eyes, grunting out, "Ugh, no!" She makes sure to avoid further embarrassment by just closing the entire window.

"Are you *hoping* to get laid? I saw Catra's new haircut. I don't blame you."

Adora focuses on pushing that out of her head.

"I just thought maybe a new style might be nice to try out. Something a bit more feminine."

Glimmer nods like she has no idea what's happening but wants to be supportive. She moves to sit in one of the chairs in front of Adora's desk.

“Can I ask why?”

Adora's eyes go wide. There was absolutely no way that she was going to admit the truth to Glimmer, of all people, a living breathing reminder of all the things that Catra’s attracted to. All the things that Adora doesn’t embody.

She hadn't thought up a cover story, though. Why would she assume that she could mind her own business in her own office without accounting for Glimmer Moon?

“My therapist suggested a change might build my confidence?”

“Yeah, asking it as a question really sells the lie,” Glimmer deadpans.

It was mostly true, but that was a fair point.

“I thought it might be attractive,” Adora admits.

“To whom?”

“To *who* ,” she corrects.

“That's certainly attractive – try fixing her grammar and see if that floods Catra's basement.”

Adora's nose wrinkles at that imagery.

“Have the two of you found some time to have an actual conversation?”

“Yes, we’ve talked,” Adora responds.

Bundled together in Catra’s bed, they’ve gone over lots of Catra’s childhood and other things that she’d kept locked away before. Adora talked too. Going back to therapy made her a little more comfortable to share a bit of her upbringing with Catra.

“Liar!” Glimmer yells, pointing a finger at Adora. “Shame!”

“Fine,” Adora huffs. “We haven’t talked...about what you want us to talk about. There hasn’t been time.”

“You spend literally all of your time together!”

“She hasn't brought it up either,” Adora says defensively.

Glimmer throws her hands up in exasperation. “So you're both still battling to be the Supreme Disaster.”

“And anyway,” Adora continues, “the timing is terrible. She's grieving, she's fostering. I don't want to force her to make any impulsive decisions just because she's afraid of losing me.”

“And while that is noble and pure, it’s also willfully ignoring how she obviously feels about you. Someone's got to take the lead here. For two very demanding people, you're both being way too complacent.”

“I didn't ask for your input,” Adora says. It's a bit more forceful than she intended but it shuts Glimmer right up.

That's good. Glimmer even looks a little impressed.

“You should tap into whatever energy that is a little more.”

“Get back to work,” Adora tells her.

“I didn’t mean with me. Obviously-”

“ *Now* .”

“Hey. What did you do to Sparkles?” Catra casually asks later when Adora enters. She doesn’t seem that concerned about it though, just barely pausing to look up while she’s flipping through a magazine on the couch.

“Nothing,” Adora replies. “What did she say?”

“She was just blowing up the group chat about how you suddenly had ‘bad bitch energy’. I honestly couldn’t tell if she was angry or

turned on.”

“Those emotions do look oddly similar on her,” Adora replies.

Finn’s door is just barely cracked and she can see them inside, reading a book upside down. The book, to be clear, is the correct way but Finn has their feet on the bed and their head on the floor, which doesn’t look very comfortable. They seem unbothered.

Adora takes this chance to pretend to idly clear her throat and move closer to the couch. Catra looks up more fully then, before tilting her head quizzically.

“New look?”

“Yeah, just wanted to try something different. Picked up a couple things after work.”

She pulls lightly at her new shirt, still in her classic black, a tight silk blouse with a pussybow and short sleeves that are ruched or something. She’s not very sure.

“What else you get?” Catra asks.

This isn’t at all how Adora expected her to react. She was hoping for excitement or a little interest, at the very least.

“A couple of similar shirts. A pencil skirt. What do you think?”

Catra blinks slowly once, then twice. This is not the slow, deliberate blink that Catra gives her sometimes when they're close together, a (unconscious?) sign of her complete trust in Adora, according to the human’s online research. This is Catra's ‘I’m going to figure this riddle out’ blink. It's much more worrying.

“You look gorgeous,” she says simply. “How uncomfortable are you?”

Adora gives a relieved sigh. “ *So* uncomfortable. What’s up with these sleeves?”

“Can I be very vulnerable with you?” Catra asks.

Maybe the outfit has grown on her. The blonde nods.

“I’m showing an amazing amount of restraint by not shredding that bow.”

Adora notices that Catra’s tail twitches and her pupils look much larger than usual. The last time this happened, Bow had left the dangling wrist strap on his videogame controller. Catra’s whole focus changed when she caught sight of it. She dropped everything, chattered, and chased him around the apartment until Bow figured out the issue and surrendered the controller to her.

“Kitten, please,” Adora begs but it’s barely out of her mouth before Catra’s leaping from the couch and onto Adora. “I have to return it!”

The two begin to wrestle, Catra becoming superpowered by her thirst for destroying fabric. They both fall to the floor, Adora yelling the whole time about not getting the shirt dirty. She quickly gives up when it’s apparent that Catra’s not backing down and just rolls onto her stomach to hide the bow.

That snaps Catra out of it. Kitties have no object permanence, right?

“Unless you’re planning on sleeping down there, this plan isn’t a long-term solution,” Catra points out. She shifts so she’s straddled on Adora’s lower back. “I’ll just wait you out. You’ll be antsy for a task to complete any minute now.”

Catra's weight feels so nice there and Adora allows herself one whole second of imagining how amazing this would be if she was face-up, they were in less clothes, and Catra put her claws away. Or put her claws away for *some* of it, at least.

Second over, Adora hastily tucks the bow down inside the shirt’s collar.

“Boo!” Catra jeers. But she must get distracted by something because her claws begin slowly ghosting over the blonde's back and upper arms. It's light as a feather but Adora's well aware that this soothing touch is being delivered by sharp blades.

After a couple deep breaths and mental reminders that she trusts Catra more than anyone, Adora allows herself to relax. Catra must take this as a good sign and starts kneading Adora’s shoulders with a quiet purr. Hopefully, there’s no claw pricks in the shirt.

“So everything has to go back,” Adora concedes.

“I’m sorry! I’ll behave. I promise.”

“No, this is a sign. I can’t have nice things.”

“Only you would take away that lesson from whatever this experiment is,” Catra says, sounding amused. “Keep the clothes. You look beautiful. You look great in everything, really.”

Adora lowers her face to the carpet to hide her blush. “You don’t think I’d look better if I was a little more… femme?”

“Mrrmp?” Catra stops kneading. “If that’s a side of yourself you want to lean into, sure. You know I support you. If that’s how you want to express your gender, I’ll even help you shop.”

She gently stands and reaches down to help Adora to her feet. Catra searches her face for a moment once they’re eye to eye.

“Just taking a wild guess here, Dor, but if you were thinking of changing only to please *someone else* , though, that would be a mistake.”

Catra takes a closer look at her. When she gets to the bow, she clasps both claws behind her back to fight the temptation, Adora imagines.

“Removing all outside influences, you’re pretty comfortable, right? With the way you...present?”

Adora nods. There's plenty of things she's *not* super comfortable with, of course. Birds. People who only drive with one hand. Open-toed shoes. But on the whole, she's had plenty of time to get mostly settled into her skin and her wardrobe, barring any 'outside influences.' Like random cute girls who make Catra blush.

"Then that's all that matters. You're perfect," Catra says, like it's so simple.

'It's just a shirt,' Adora wants to reply. But yes, if it was just a shirt then it wouldn't really be enough to garner Catra's interest anyway.

This plan was doomed from the start.

"Thanks," Adora quietly replies finally.

She follows Catra back to the couch. They settle in and relax, like Catra isn't just plotting a way to get access to the bow.

"I can't believe you intentionally went shopping," she says. "Or that you cursed Glimmer out."

"I just suggested that she get back to work," Adora argues.

"Shh. I like the story better the other way."

They both forgot how ungodly early you have to get up for school. Adora's a morning person but neither she nor Catra got much sleep the night before, tossing and turning several feet apart in the large cold bed after the two cats suggested that Adora sleep over just in case. Everyone seemed to agree that this was a great idea, even though Adora's too tall to sleep in the guest room bed and would therefore have to stay in Catra's room. The voting appeared to be *rigged* . The cat contingent currently has a lock on all votes since even Melog gets to weigh-in and, mysteriously, they always agree with Finn and Catra (as translated by *Finn and Catra*).

Adorable dictatorships aside, it should have been a fine plan. Adora and Catra cuddle plenty during the daytime so sharing space did not have to be an issue. Like at all. But Adora felt terribly awkward initiating anything similar in the dark. For obvious reasons. Catra wasn't much better, constantly switching from being curled into a tiny ball to *almost* reaching out for Adora.

After the tensest night of sleep she's had since she and Catra made up, Adora rushes into the bathroom just to give herself a distraction. When she's out of the shower and catches a glance at herself in the mirror, she looks like shit, bags under her eyes, skin blotchy.

Catra glides out of her closet looking downright *majestic* . Possibly in solidarity to Finn, she's wearing a very cute navy blue suit, except Catra's is a bit more grown up, with a cropped blazer and high-waisted pants on top of a white blouse with a *very low* neckline. Adora hasn't seen her in a suit in over 2 months now. Catra's managed to part and slick down her short hair in a way that's incredibly dashing. So it's okay that Adora genuinely does not hear the first few words that Catra says and has to ask her to repeat them several times.

With a groan, she says, once again, "Did you pack everything? I'd check but I'm lazy."

It still takes way too long to process.

After several moments, Adora replies, "Yeah. All packed." She's going to have to rush to make sure this is actually true when no one else is paying attention.

Catra glances at Adora with a very earned look of confusion. Then she glances down at herself. When she looks back up, Catra's face fills with a triumphant smile.

"Okay, I'm ready to roll then. Glasses or no?"

"Definitely glasses," the blonde answers automatically, giving away way too much.

Catra's smile grows if that's even possible.

When they pull up to the school, Adora has the reaction that she knew she would. Jealousy over how fancy it looks. Relief over how fancy it looks. Sadness for not spending a day with Finn. Elation at how much their life has changed. Glee at the idea of having Catra to herself for the whole day. Horror at the idea of having Catra to herself for the *whole day* .

Finn jumps out of the car before it's barely stopped moving, way too excited to slow down. Catra has to jump out too to catch up to them. Adora doesn't hear the catcalls until she's hastily emerging to grab Finn's backpack and lunchbox so they don't get left behind. Is 'catcalls' an offensive term to actual cat people?

Adora looks over a little further away in the parking lot, to find Bow, Glimmer, Scorpia, Perfuma, and Entrapta all excitedly waving to her. Well, Entrapta isn't waving, not really, more like just letting her hand linger lazily in the air as she looks at all of the children like they're aliens. A particularly bold kid tries to pull one of her long purple pigtails and she just widens her eyes, instead of doing anything to stop it. Adora is fairly certain that Entrapta *was* a child at some point but not with the way she's acting.

"We have an audience," Catra grumbles. "Just fucking peachy. I look like a garbage fire."

"You look like the reason suits were created," Adora teases.

"Someone's been very excited to see me out of sweatpants today," she gets in response with a smirk. "Finn, go say hello to your adoring fans."

They positively light up when they see the group of adults. Instead of going over and greeting everyone, Finn screams hellos from across the parking lot. Some of the teachers are already annoyed with them.

"Your uniform is so amazing!" Bow yells back.

He’s right. Finn looks great, even if Catra spent way too much time and money over something that’s not going to last long.

Apparently, she was inspired by vintage Etherian naval uniforms and Adora had to listen to a whole discussion about this. The dark blue material has a white trim, like Catra had promised, and she even got a fake Morgan family crest stitched in gold over the front pocket of the blazer. Finn’s white shirt has little navy details sewn into the collar. They got to wear fish socks along with their nice shoes that Adora tried to unsuccessfully get them to break in first. Catra countered that they had to suffer to look good. Like Catra, Finn looks more like a catalog model than someone starting their first day of second grade in real life.

“Okay, give us some angles,” Glimmer orders, pulling up her phone for a photo. Everyone else follows suit.

Finn immediately breaks into a number of silly poses, eating up the attention. Adora makes a note to get them into acting or dance classes. Catra’s going to make a hilarious and frightening stage mom.

Catra sighs. “As much as I can appreciate the absolute spectacle of this, we’ve got a class to get to.”

She takes Finn’s hand and pulls them away as they wave to everyone. When Adora moves to join their friends, she’s stopped by Catra’s other hand.

“Where the hell do you think you’re going, princess? We can’t meet this teacher without a normie.” Catra allows herself to glare at the blonde for a couple more seconds before tugging her into the school with them.

Meeting the teacher is brief. Ms. Spinnerella seems nice enough, a little motherly and very kind. She asks Finn for their pronouns without prompting. She’s very patient when Adora stumbles terribly over explaining that they each had different last names, after she’d addressed them all as the Morgan family.

Finn immediately tries to disappear into the pile of kids who were already there but is stopped by Catra, who whispers, “Don’t forget that it’s okay to go barefoot if you want. They have to make ‘accommodations’. Remember that word.”

They try to wrench their hand out of Catra’s grasp.

“But fish socks!” They huff, successfully getting their tiny paw free and escaping to make friends.

Adora wants to linger and make sure they’re okay but Catra tricks her into leaving by wrapping her right arm and her tail around the blonde and maneuvering two of them to meet their friends outside. Their five buddies are still hovering around their cars, in their work clothes already, sipping from to-go coffee cups. They’re kind enough to hand one to both Catra and Adora.

“This is so exciting,” Scorpia squeals. “Baby’s first day.”

“They’ve been in school for two years already,” Catra points out.

“First day with us,” Glimmer argues.

“Why are you all here exactly?” Catra asks.

Adora feels compelled to add, “Not that we don't appreciate it. Right, Cat?” She gets a noncommittal shrug in response.

Perfuma chimes in, saying thoughtfully, “This was an important day for all three of you. We wanted to be here to support.”

“I don’t completely understand this,” Entrapta admits, “but I have read that ritual and positive reinforcement are both important for development during a child’s formative years. And Catra’s grief in addition to the feeling of an ‘empty nest’ may mean she needs our physical presence as a display of our emotional assistance so as to prevent a worsening of her mental health.”

“Yeah, Trapta, I think Perfuma was trying to say that in a way that saves *some* of my dignity.” She's getting antsy under all the

sincerity. Which just means she appreciates it, Adora knows, but would like it to be over quickly.

"How 'bout brunch?" Bow interjects cheerfully, trying to drag attention elsewhere.

Glimmer asks, being no help at all, "Are places even open at 7 am on a Monday?"

They all look to Catra. Patron saint of all the best food in the city.

"Yes," she says with a put-on over the top sigh. "I'll buy you all the best Dutch baby you've ever had in your entire life." She thinks for a second and looks to Entrapta. "And tiny muffins." This, Adora understands, is her way of making amends with her friend.

The place is empty of course. It's an actual restaurant, kinda a little too trendy for Adora's tastes, but people only come in occasionally to grab overpriced coffee to go. Catra makes everyone order whatever a Dutch baby is. Perfuma tries to get eggs. That is not allowed. Catra also gets bacon for the table, which just adds to what an unenjoyable experience this is for Perfuma. She doesn't complain once the Dutch baby arrives, covered in cream and berries and stone fruit.

Catra spends the whole brunch practically in Adora's chair with her. At one point, the blonde nearly has to ask for space to cut her breakfast pastry into pieces but decides that it's not worth it to use both arms. She sacrifices her right one so Catra can wrap her tail around it. Again, Adora's missed weeks of this silly friend time and she almost gets sad remembering the fight they had once more. The constant presence of Catra in her personal space chases the feeling away this time.

It is really nice to see Catra enjoying the food and having fun with their friends in public. She's spent the past several days so low that it was starting to weigh heavily on Adora's heart. But here Catra is now, back to suits, spending $23 on what's essentially a

flat pancake, and undermining Glimmer with each breath, and it's such a fucking relief.

"Stop looking at me like that," Catra leans over to whisper. "Like I just recovered from a near-fatal disease in a Lifetime movie."

Adora lowers her head down to hide her gaze. "I'm just glad to see you looking happy."

She must have said that too loudly because she can hear Bow cooing from across the table and feel everyone's eyes on her. Catra ducks her head, digging into her food. It's hard not to think about how if they weren't in public, Catra would probably hide her face in the crook of Adora's neck, like she does when she's feeling shy. Well, as close to 'shy' as she's capable of getting.

It feels like maybe their friends want to say something. They wisely choose to go back to quietly eating, before Glimmer brings up some fall excursion she wants to go on. A cabin in the woods for a long, presumably semi-drunken and rowdy, weekend. Glimmer and Bow are extremely excited and it's easy enough for them to get Perfuma and Scorpia on board. Entrapta is not interested at all, but they're not really close enough friends with her to care anyway most likely. Next, they turn on Catra and Adora.

Glimmer's already using her 'get shit done' face.

"You two have to come," she says. "You could use the break."

Catra slowly takes another bite of food, eyes narrowing on Glimmer. "Are you forgetting about the cub?"

Glimmer waves a dismissive hand. "They can have a sleepover. Or stay with someone else."

"Finn just started a new school an hour ago. They don't have any friends yet."

“Entrapta can take them maybe?” Glimmer suggests, glancing in the purple-haired woman’s direction. Entrapta clearly zoned out of this conversation 20 minutes ago, focusing instead on her phone.

Catra gestures at this. “Yeah, no.”

Glimmer huffs in response. “Fine. Be that way.” She turns to Adora and raises an eyebrow. “You’re not missing this.”

Instinctively, Adora wants to cower under that stare and promise Glimmer anything she wants. It’s easier than fighting. She glances at Catra, who is pretending to wait patiently but she hasn’t communicated that to her tail. It’s thumping steadily against her chair.

“Finny’s still getting acclimated,” Adora says, faking a frown. “It’s not a good time for us.”

It’s honestly the perfect excuse. This wouldn't be the first time that Adora was trapped in the country with Bow and Glimmer. Drinking. Doing puzzles. Being bored out of her mind with no reception and no ability to do work. It always sounds better in theory than it actually is.

She wonders what else Finn could get her out of. Road trips, birthday parties that go past 11:00pm, bar crawls.

Clearly, Glimmer’s thinking this too. She smiles in that scary way where it feels like she’s planning something.

“We’ll work on the logistics later. Maybe figure something out that works for everyone.”

Trapped in a cabin with a hyperactive 7 year old doesn’t sound fun. Maybe Glimmer will forget? That’s just silly cause Glimmer never forgets. And never forgives.

Adora smiles tightly and nods, praying for a miracle.

With her friend temporarily appeased, they're able to finish up and let everyone get on their way to work. They're in the parking lot at their cars when Glimmer remembers that she left a scarf inside. She elects Adora to retrieve it for some reason, even though Bow is standing right next to her doing nothing. He's making a very odd face though so Adora agrees reluctantly.

She spends 5 minutes searching for this scarf, like a fool, asking the staff, checking under tables. It's of course nowhere to be found because it never existed, Adora realizes.

When she rushes back to the group, she finds them all lined up side-by-side, nearly encasing Catra in a wall of worrywarts. Except Entrapta, who's hanging off slightly to the side, glancing at Catra's car with barely restrained interest.

"Why are you asking *me* ?" Adora can hear Catra saying. She sounds a little defensive.

"You *are* harder to break but Adora's got less info cause she's so oblivious," Glimmer responds.

"Rude," Adora calls out to them.

When she reaches the group, they all smile awkwardly at her. Catra's tense, like she's waiting for an argument, so Adora places a hand on her lower back.

It's a gesture that no one seems to miss, judging by how their smiles get just a little more awkward.

"What are we talking about?" Adora asks.

"Nothing that's relevant to the *actual* Etheria that we're currently existing in right now," Catra answers quickly. Turning to the rest of them, she asks, "Don't you people have jobs? Scram."

Adora pokes her in the ribs.

“And thank you for your support today,” Catra mutters with a fleeting smile. "It really means a lot."

Back at home, Catra changes out of her suit, unfortunately, and into more comfortable lounge clothes. Adora doesn’t have any video meetings so she does the same. Catra had convinced her to once again work from home, just for today. With Finn at school, it would be her first day alone since they arrived and they were both worried about her struggling through it, though Catra refused to actually admit that she was concerned.

Actually getting any work done is a challenge, however. Adora sets up everything just the way she likes it. Catra bought her a fancy tiny couch desk once she got tired of Adora trying to use the office in the spare room. It was too far away, she complained, and there was no space for them to sit next to each other.

So Adora pulls out the desk and places her laptop, files, coffee mug, phone charger, and water bottle down, situating everything perfectly. As soon as she sits down though, Catra burrows into her side and flings the files and phone charger onto the floor with her tail. Adora has noted that Catra never seems to ‘accidentally’ knock over anything that could harm her precious living room carpet.

“Cat, please.”

“Please what?” Catra asks, claws fidgeting with the hem of Adora’s shirt.

“I’m behind on stuff.”

“Do you have a deadline today?”

Adora hesitates. She doesn’t but if she admits that, the battle’s already lost.

Catra must already sense this. “You have the rest of the week. I’m letting you go to work tomorrow.”

With a laugh, Adora dryly tells her, “How generous of you.” It’s never a good idea to negotiate with Catra, since this is her bread and butter, but Adora resolves to do it anyway. “I can wait until 10:00.”

“2:00,” Catra shoots back quickly. By then, they should be heading back to pick up Finn and she knows absolutely nothing will get done once the tiny cat is around, loudly recapping their day.

“10:15.”

“3:00.”

“Catra! You can’t go backward!”

“There’s no rules of engagement here. I do what I want!” But she finally lifts the corner of Adora shirt up and starts rubbing her face along the now-exposed tummy.

Adora’s willpower is diminishing quickly. She makes the fatal mistake of sitting back a bit and Catra quickly uses that to her advantagement. She shoves her way into Adora’s lap, pulling up the rest of the blonde’s shirt so she can fully rub her cheek along it.

“I’m starting at 10:30, whether you move or not,” Adora declares. She hopes Catra will be ready for a nap by then and put up less of a fight.

The desk is moved to the side and the tv is turned to a competitive cooking show. Once she relaxes fully into the couch and has situated Catra for optimal lap space and tv viewing access, Adora notices that they both sigh in contentment. The purring begins pretty quickly.

Not long afterward, Catra’s trying to explain what an amuse bouche is when her phone rings.

“Fuuuuuuck,” she whispers when she sees the contact but answers anyway. Catra rolls onto her back as if that’s a more

appropriate angle for taking a call from someone else's lap.

"Hey, Lonetta," she greets lazily. It's a video. This just makes Adora feel even more awkward.

The person on the other ends sighs angrily.

"Catrina, you know that's not my name."

Adora angles slightly to see who this is – she's about their age, mocha skin, long, thick black locs, a little more broadly built than Adora. She looks like she's wearing a suit. Catra showed her a picture of her foster sister, Lonnie, awhile back. She's a lot more intimidating on video, though, with her unamused, firm tone.

"Where are you?"

"I'm at home," Catra shrugs. "Got until the end of the week off. Parental leave and parental death, I guess. What up?"

"Well, I'm calling about that cause your ass doesn't respond to texts, leaving your poor family on read like a bad Hinge date you don't want to see again."

Catra rolls her eyes. "I've been busy, Lonnie."

"Yeah, those thick-ass thighs that you're using as a pillow are probably keeping you *very* busy," Lonnie deadpans, which makes Adora blush terribly. "How-"

Catra interrupts to say, "Don't ask me how I'm doing. It's the worst question anyone can ask and yet it's all that people can think to say to make awkward conversation with me right now."

" *What I was going to say* ," Lonnie begins loudly and very annoyed, "is how the hell are you letting Weaver do this to you?"

Catra narrows her eyes. "I'm not *letting* her do anything. I'm...grieving." There's an odd shame in her tone and in the way her ears lower.

“Cat, I love you.” She pauses to look directly at Catra’s eyes. “So I’m going to be real with you. You have two options – you can get over it. You can realize that this mourning bullshit is exactly what Weaver would want. For you to backslide on all your progress, go back into your dark place, and let yourself feel like *you* were the monster.”

Catra tightens her jaw, clearly not wanting to hear this. “What’s the second option?”

“You can catch these hands,” Lonnie says plainly, lazily lifting her hands onto the screen, palms facing away from it, to illustrate her point.

“If you fly 2,000 miles just to get into my face and tell me to stop feeling awful, I agree that I will physically fight you,” Catra replies mildly. With a deep breath, she adds, “I’m not doing too bad. I’ll call you back later and you can catch up with the kid. I’ve got friends helping and I’ve got Adora.”

Adora smiles a little at the casual way Catra mentions her name, like she talks about the blonde with Lonnie pretty regularly.

This is confirmed by what Catra unexpectedly does next. She briefly turns the screen to face Adora, who waves awkwardly, before turning it back again to herself.

“Holy shit, is that her? Yeah, I’d be playing this up too.”

“I’m not playing it up! You and I are just grieving in different ways, Lon.”

“Yeah, speaking of. We’re gonna take the house off your hands.”

Catra looks genuinely shocked speechless.

“It’s the least I could do,” Lonnie adds. “Since you took the kid and everything.”

“Why are you volunteering to fuck up your whole life? Do you know how much she owed?”

“It’s less than you’ll be spending on Finn over the next decade,” Lonnie replies. “Can you try not being difficult for once in your life?”

“Fine,” Catra huffs. “You get to play hero. What a rare treat for you.”

Facetiously, Lonnie asks, “How will you fill your time now that you don’t get to play martyr?”

Adora’s pretty sure they’re not fighting and this is just how they speak to each other.

“Maybe Adora can help you with that,” Lonnie says with a devilish smile.

Catra squirms a bit, which is certainly a new reaction to this particular breed of teasing.

“Is she still single?”

At that, Catra hisses, Lonnie just chuckles in return. She continues, “Well, I’ll be seeing what all the fuss is about at Christmas, right?”

Catra glances up at Adora. They two of them have not had a conversation about the holidays. Honestly, Adora wasn't sure what to expect about possible plans, since she doesn’t have any rituals or anywhere she needs to be herself. Catra hadn’t mentioned it at all but they were still a few months away.

“Okay,” Lonnie continues, impatiently sucking her teeth. “I guess I’ll let y’all work that out amongst yourselves. I gotta go, Cat.” Her voice goes softer, “You know you can always reach out to us if you need anything.”

“Yeah, I know,” Catra replies, sounding a little guilty.

“Rogelio says hi.”

“Tell him I haven’t forgot about our rematch in that dumb city-building game he forced me to play last month.”

“Girl, that ain’t a competitive game.”

Catra narrows her eyes. “It is the way *I* play it.”

“And Kyle says hi.”

Catra does not acknowledge that she’s heard this so Lonnie just says goodbye and hangs up.

“Kyle?” Adora asks.

“Fucking Kyle,” Catra mumbles.

Chapter End Notes

> once again, kyle has done nothing to deserve this. i'm not saying lonnie comes in at the end of this story and saves the day but she appears in chapters 18 and 19 and basically does that.

The Universe is Fucking Stupid

Chapter Summary

Just an intervention or two.

Chapter Notes

someone in the comments wrote this story is "slow burn self-acceptance" and that's basically this whole chapter. plus some brief mermista!

okay, this is the last bit of shopping...until chapter 18. looking back on it, there's, like, a whole lot of shopping. i hate in-person shopping, always have. don't know what i was working through when i wrote this but, uh, thank you for your patience.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer let her cabin idea go after a couple of weeks. But apparently that was only to begin planning Catra's birthday party several weeks in advance. Catra seems to love the attention and also hate that she loves it.

Glimmer won't let anyone in on the details but she likes to drop hints, that Adora's *sure* are red herrings, every other week or so. Catra refuses to take the bait so they're in a stand-off.

Adora's supposed to be on a three-way video call with Catra and Mermista to coordinate Finn's pickups but Glimmer has decided that sitting in the blonde's office and taunting Catra is the most appropriate use of everyone's time. Not the safety of a minor or anything. Catra and Mermista are starting to lose their patience.

"You have globophobia, right, Catra?" Glimmer teases. "I hope that doesn't become an issue for us. I already rented an industrial-sized helium tank."

Catra nearly snaps. “I don’-,” she pauses, takes a deep breath. Puts on an air of nonchalance. “I don’t even know what that is. So just do whatever dumb thing you’re going to do. I’ve already been invited to another party that night, but I’ll let you know if I can make it.”

Adora recognizes several lies in that statement but figures it's better to stay out of this.

Glimmer grits her teeth. “You’re missing your own birthday to attend another party?”

With a shrug, Catra replies, “Gotta keep my options open.”

“Mermista, can you make sure that Catra keeps her schedule clear that night, please?”

A long groan is all that Adora hears. She can definitely relate.

“ *Anyway* ,” Mermista interrupts firmly, “Sea Hawk can do all of the times Adora just shared. Let me know what works best for you all.”

“I don’t know who that is,” Catra says, pretending to look innocent, while Mermista heaves an exasperated sigh. “Do you mean Steven Edwin Andrew Hawkins IV?”

Catra will not let this go. It's beginning to feel like an unnecessary barrier to getting anything coordinated with Sea Hawk smoothly. The guy’s apparently related to wealth but cash poor himself and jobless. He lives on a boat that Adora imagines must be close to being condemned by the city. But he's available all the time and easy for Mermista to get in touch with since they're dating, whether she admits that or not. She had even vouched for him. So Sea Hawk is Finn’s babysitter. Finn loves it. Catra does not.

Especially the part where she has to actually call him Sea Hawk.

“Look, he *has* to go by that name,” Mermista attempts to explain again.

"No one *has* to give themselves a nickname, especially one that dumb," Catra shoots back. They're on two different screens on Adora's phone, but she knows they're just one room away from each other, intentionally yelling loud enough so the other has to hear them through the wall and be extra annoyed.

"Have you *seen* his mustache?!" Mermista asks, frustration growing.

"Unfortunately!"

"That stache *and* the name 'Steve'? He'd be way too creepy."

Catra relaxes for the first time that whole call, uncoiling the tension in her shoulders to silently consider Mermista's point.

"Yeah, 'Steve' definitely owns shirts offering free mustache rides," she responds. "Okay, fine. I'll allow it. Anyway, I'm probably here until 8 tonight. Dor, what time are you done?"

They work out Finn's transportation, feeding, and homework support schedule pretty quickly after that. Honestly, the worst part about caretaking, in Adora's opinion, might be the extra several minutes that discussions of Sea Hawk's name, singing, and possible bad influence on Finn add to all logistics talks. But Finn does yell "Adventure!" every time they buckle their seatbelt so maybe Catra's right to be concerned.

As soon as they're off the phone, Glimmer's smirking at Adora. She doesn't like that look. Lately, whenever Glimmer watches or hears Adora and Catra interact, she makes this increasingly annoying sound, like she's coughing up a trumpet. Kind of a 'huemph!'

"I've got two more minutes and then I've got some stuff to dive into," Adora tells her friend.

"Everything's going well with Finn?" Her suddenly innocent tone isn't fooling Adora.

She replies shortly, “Yep.” No need to drag this out.

Glimmer straightens up a bit. “Adora, if you could allow yourself to dream about your future with Catra-”

“Nope,” she tries to intercede.

“-how would you describe it?” Glimmer continues.

Adora sighs. Yes, everyone's tolerance for watching this trainwreck was waning but the timing was too terrible to even consider making a move.

“The woman who raised her just died. There's a lot of changes in her life right now. She doesn't need her best friend trying to fuck her. Or date her.” Or love her. Move in with her. Really, the list of things Adora’s starting to realize that she wants, and that Catra *doesn't* need, is growing longer and longer.

Glimmer makes an odd face. Like she’s been told that you can’t have something she desperately wants and petulantly is prepared to fight.

“What?” Adora asks.

Glimmer pops her tongue idly.

“I thought you'd say ‘kiss’.” Her eyes have a weirdly delighted wildness. “OMG, you really have it bad.”

For all her attempts to remain calm, Adora can’t help how her voice rises now. “Of course I do! She's perfect in literally every single way.”

That clearly strikes Glimmer as very sad. Adora knows she must sound pathetic.

“Okay. This is serious. You're right. You can't fuck this up.”

Adora makes the mistake of letting herself feel validated. It's good that Glimmer finally understands. Hopefully she can tell all of their other friends. It's just nice to be heard really.

"So," Glimmer replies, "you have to tell her ASAP."

But. "Did you listen to literally anything I said?"

"I didn't like that answer. You know I'm going to move forward until I hear a better one."

Though they've clearly blown past the two minutes that Adora was allotting for this conversation, Glimmer cracks open the office door to scream for Bow repeatedly. In the past couple of years, Adora has attempted to get her to cut down on doing this. She doesn't even have the energy to admonish her this time.

Thankfully, Bow appears quickly but the ruckus has also attracted Perfuma. Glimmer grabs both of their hands and pulls them into Adora's office so everyone can be a part of this shame circle apparently.

"This is perfect," Glimmer says. "Perfuma, I need you to weigh in on this. Adora admits that she has deep feelings for Catra." Adora makes a lot of sounds that could be a denial but are really just spluttering and stumbling so Glimmer continues, "But she thinks this isn't a good time. What do you think?"

Bow rubs the back of his head, seemingly out of embarrassment, while Perfuma takes a deep breath.

"Glim, I thought we agreed being direct with them was clearly not an effective tactic," Bow whispers.

But Glimmer refuses to take her eyes off of Perfuma.

"I'd prefer not to interfere," their friend responds.

"Well, Adora needs a push. What if nothing ever happens?" Glimmer shoots back.

Perfuma smiles patiently at her.

“Then that’s the universe’s plan.”

“Then the universe is fucking stupid,” Glimmer replies angrily.

Adora’s never seen Perfuma look so offended. Her jaw drops and an insulted squawk comes out of her mouth. Bow reaches over to rub her shoulder soothingly.

He chimes in, “Glimmer didn’t mean that.”

“Yes, I did! The universe is going to fuck this up, Perfuma. We all watched that almost happen once already. Only you can help now.”

Poor Perfuma. What an unfair amount of pressure in a situation that absolutely does not require it. Nothing’s going to happen between Adora and Catra. It will be Adora’s fault, clearly, not Perfuma’s.

“You don’t have to do this,” she tells her. “Glimmer’s just being an asshole. And a busy-body. And painfully inaccurate.”

Glimmer mutters some unkind words to Adora, while Perfuma rights herself.

With renewed resolve, she addresses Adora. “I will only say one thing.” Glimmer scoffs. “Usually I would tell people to listen to their heart.”

Glimmer is not satisfied by that. Strangely, neither is Bow. Adora, on the hand, is ecstatic. After the bait-and-switch from Glimmer earlier, it does feel nice to actually be affirmed by someone for how she’s handling her relationship with Catra.

“But, Adora,” Perfuma continues, as her smile slowly fades, “Your instincts are shit when it comes to women. You should do the opposite of whatever your gut is telling you.”

Adora is stricken by the ultimate betrayal. Glimmer and Bow both begin to laugh heartily, nodding and agreeing.

"If there's a moment with Catra and you think you shouldn't say anything, that's definitely a moment where you should speak up and tell her how you feel. If you two are hanging out in her bed – where you two spend a lot of time *cuddling in your underwear* , she's told me – and you think it means nothing, it definitely means something."

Adora's attempt to ask *why* Catra would tell Perfuma about that is overshadowed by Glimmer yelling at Adora for not telling *her* about it.

Perfuma raises her voice to be heard over both of them. "Please spare us all more of this. Let yourself just *have* something for once. You're worth it."

Something about her wording shuts them all up. It's something that Adora hadn't considered, and Bow and Glimmer are acting like it's occurred to them for the first time as well.

"That's not an issue for me," Adora denies. "I'm fine *having* things. This is about...propriety. And not messing up an amazing friendship by having feelings for someone who could never want to be with me."

Now they're all just looking at her like she said her fish was sick or something. Adora knows this is why you can never let people in on your true thoughts.

"Adora," Bow starts slowly, his voice too gentle, "You are absolutely awful at admitting when you want something. And worse at actually allowing yourself to have it."

For a professional development class once, Adora had to take one of those 'what kind of leader are you?' quizzes. Her highest score was in impulse control. Her lowest was in risk-taking. This was something she'd been irrationally proud of for years.

“You make me force you into indulging yourself in cheat day food,” Glimmer adds.

“You refused to give yourself a raise for 2 years, even though you were struggling with money, we had the cash, *and* you’d given us all annual raises,” Perfuma reminds her.

Bow’s apparently been counting these off on his fingers. “You won’t replace your car with something from this decade cause you don’t want to get ‘too fancy’. I was suggesting that you get a 8-year old, used sedan, by the way.”

It was a fancy used car! A luxury manufacturer.

Glimmer isn’t done with this embarrassing topic yet.

“And I’ve told you a million times how great you are and how Catra would be lucky to have you.”

“She willingly chooses to spend *all* of her time with you,” Bow points out.

Adora opens her mouth to respond but is cut off by Perfuma.

“Don’t say it’s just because of the things you do or Finn. Adora, we were there for her during things with Weaver and Finn moving in. The entire time, if we offered anything or even asked how she was doing, Catra would only say that she wanted you. We had to force her to reach out to you because she was so afraid that she’d lost you. She was devastated.”

“Why aren’t you having this conversation with *her* then?” Adora mutters, biting at her nails. “I didn’t make this mess alone.”

“I’ve tried,” Perfuma says, looking like she’s about to pull her hair out.

“We’ve all tried,” Bow adds. “You’re waiting on her, she’s waiting on you. She doesn't want to rush you, you don't want to rush her. Forward, back, repeat. We’re trapped in a time loop.”

"Oh my God!" Glimmer yells. She must be really frustrated to actually say each word. "You're the most stubborn, annoying people. You deserve each other!"

She storms out theatrically, flinging herself between Perfuma and Bow to get past them. Once in the hall, she wheels around and puts an accusing finger at Adora.

"And another thing! I'm not just being a busybody. I love you both. You're building a house of cards, though. If you don't actually come out with it and share how you're feeling and what you want, you're both going to get hurt. Like *hearts destroyed* hurt."

With that, Glimmer disappears.

"Unfortunately, she's not wrong this time," Perfuma says with a sigh, before she exits as well.

"Adora, I-" Bow looks like he's searching for the correct words. "Don't take this the wrong way. How are things going with your therapist?"

She doesn't think she's taking it the wrong way, so much as exactly the way that Bow meant it. Getting defensive would be giving too much away though.

Calm, even tone, no need to raise any flags. "We stopped seeing each other again. Catra, Finn, and I only agreed to two months. I did my 8 sessions, felt exactly the same, and we decided to part ways once more."

He nods like he understands how full of shit she is. "She didn't give any insights?"

No, as always she wanted to talk about Adora's childhood, her rigid foster mother Hope, her 'control issues', and how to develop 'appropriate coping mechanisms' and a 'better work-life balance'. Adora spent most of the 50-minute sessions creating to-do lists in her head to make it through.

The only piece still click-clacking around in her brain is ‘balance.’ The therapist was all about *balance* this time around. She kept insisting that Adora didn't have to change everything at once, just add a spoon of more balance to her life. She was particularly insistent that Adora not throw herself 110% into Catra and Finn like she does with work. Maybe just 80% and leave a little bit for herself.

She also had the funny little idea that Adora possibly (based on all the signs and everyone's insistence) knew exactly how Catra felt about her. And that maybe after the shit storm that happened last time she was ready to make a move, Adora's got a bad case of performance anxiety. The blonde disagreed - the timing(!), the stakes have changed, it's not just the two of them anymore, and on and on. It was safest for everyone if Adora and Catra just enjoyed the time they had together now.

"Her whole world won't turn upside again just because you want to be with her," her therapist had said.

"We don't know that for sure!" Adora argued.

"You can't single-handedly control everything. You *don't*, just so you're aware."

After Adora kept her promise to Catra, she simply stopped going. ‘Whatever you think is best, Adora’ was the response she received when she said she wouldn’t be scheduling another visit. ‘Just remember – anxiety is a liar.’

“No, not really,” Adora shrugs, answering Bow. “Nothing I didn’t already know.”

Adora has spent about 3 weeks arguing this back and forth with herself.

Bow is right, maybe. She could use a new car. Hers is a little unreliable. It overheats easily, the engine sputters sometimes, and it’s starting to really eat up oil.

But also, Bow (and Glimmer and Perfuma) are wrong. Adora's perfectly fine wanting things. She just...doesn't.

She figures, though, that she does *need* a reliable car, especially since she has to help take care of Finn.

Unfortunately, when Catra wants to make Saturday reservations for the three of them to go to some potentially dangerous trampoline "park", Adora's forced to say that she has other plans. She's able to avoid questions about those plans for 2 days.

"What could you be possibly doing on a Saturday that's a secret?" Catra asks, while chopping vegetables. "Cheating on your farmer's market? Volunteering to help my nemesis move? Getting a perm?"

"Who's your nemesis?"

"Ha! Like I'm gonna tell you so you can help that bitch move."

Shaking her head, Adora reluctantly admits, "I'm going to a used car dealership."

Catra pauses in her almost professional-level chopping for just a moment, glances at Adora's face, and then restarts.

"...Why is that a secret?"

"I might not even buy anything," Adora replies with a shrug. "No need for anyone to get excited."

Catra rolls her eyes and mumbles, "Get over yourself, Dor. It's just a car."

The next day, Entrapta sends her a string of text messages about car safety ratings. At least, Adora's pretty sure it's Entrapta because the phone number is weirdly 000-000-0000 and the messages are extremely wordy and overwhelming, much like Entrapta herself.

Adora tries to respond and ask her to stop but gets an error message back.

The day after *that* , Scorpia pops into her office with a bright smile.

“Adora, buddy!” She waves a pincer wildly.

“Oh, hi, Scorpia. Picking up Perfuma?”

“Yep!” she responds. “There is this vegan place in Elberon. Let me tell you – you've *never* had a seitan claypot like this. The-”

Scorpia probably says more words but Adora tunes them out in favor of reviewing Bow's summary of program evaluations. She hasn't been in the office much lately and there's lots to catch up on.

“We'll have to take you and Catra sometime.”

“Uh huh.”

“Anyhoo, I heard you're in the market for a new ride.”

Adora stops and looks up at her. Why was everyone being so weird about this?

“If you don't mind, I'd love to come with you this weekend! I'm really good at a dealership. For some reason, people just love to give me a good price.”

Adora imagines it's probably because Scorpia looks like she could crush anyone who tried to cheat her. Having some extra muscle couldn't hurt, even though Adora knows that Scorpia's secretly a pushover.

“That's so sweet of you,” she says, “but I've done my research and I've got it handled.”

Soon, Bow starts sending links to sensible, safe cars. Glimmer sends photos of Hummers. Perfuma texts to remind Adora about the environment and being thoughtful about her own carbon footprint.

Convinced it's a global conspiracy now, Adora nearly loses it when Finn asks what time she's meeting them on Saturday.

“It's going to be so boring, bud. You don't really want to come,” she tells them.

“But I want to pick out the color,” they reply with a pout and that settles that. She's not going to be the one to explain how this really works and disappoint Finn.

Adora meets them in the parking lot of the used car dealership that seemed the least sketchy, based on reviews. Catra's wearing a light flannel shirt that's white with blue and yellow plaid stripes, tight mom jeans, and *boat shoes* , of all things. She looks kinda like a yuppie suburban parent. Finn is in a similar style with a navy blue crew sweater, jeans, and a very cute thin red jacket. And matching boat shoes.

“Too much?” Catra asks, grimacing slightly. “One of my favorite negotiation tactics is to catch the opposition off guard by looking like an easy mark.”

Adora looks down at her own sweatsuit.

“I brought you a dorky vest just in case,” Catra offers.

It’s a down vest, red like Finn’s coat. The three of them look like an ad campaign for a retail chain that’s trying very hard to show you how inclusive they are.

Still wondering why everyone is so invested in this process, Adora purposefully weaves her way through the lot. She’s making sure to look out for all the cars that she had seen in the online inventory and flagged, while keeping her head down and not catching the eye of any of the salespeople.

It doesn’t take long for her to get overwhelmed by her options. Her friends had put too much pressure on this. There were too many possibilities to consider.

Adora was incredibly good at making decisions when there was a crisis or everyone else involved was panicking. She had, however, always struggled to be decisive when the stakes were lower. She didn't perform well under a lack of pressure.

It was just a car. Literally anything on the lot would probably be safer and more reliable than what she had driven there this morning. It didn’t have to be perfect, just get the job done.

“I think I should go home and do some more research,” she mumbles to Catra.

“You’d look really hot in that one,” is the casual response. Then Adora’s being maneuvered over towards an absurd cherry-colored convertible.

Does Catra know *anything* about her?

Finn squeals in delight and rushes over to the vehicle, leaping inside through the open roof.

Adora calls for them to be more careful, before twisting around to Catra to begin her counter-argument. She’s interrupted by a middle-aged purple octopus woman sporting a severe mullet and a brown tweed blazer with the highest shoulder pads she's ever seen.

“We’ve finally found someone gayer than you,” Catra whispers. “I'd started to think that wasn't possible.”

“How are you folks today?” the dealer asks with a bright, fake smile. “This one’s a beauty, isn’t she?”

“Uh, yeah, not really what we’re looking for,” Adora replies. “Finn, can you get out of there please?”

“What a nice family you have here.”

“Thank you!” Finn yells from inside the car. “We’re poor.”

It’s not a convincing negotiation tactic.

“The kid is a prodigy,” Catra quietly tells Adora.

The octopus tries to hide her confusion. She’s probably already realizing how exhausting the three of them are going to be. Adora has to agree with her.

“You know, I think we have exactly the kind of thing you’re looking for,” the car dealer tells her. She leads Adora, with Catra close behind, to a fancy-looking minivan. It’s all shiny and techie, like the trunk probably opens itself.

Catra makes a growl that definitely sounds like ‘fuck you’.

“You’re not getting a minivan,” she says adamantly. “You’re getting yourself a car that you want.”

But the octopus is already opening the doors and trying to explain all the features. Finn must hear her mention tvs from across the room, because they suddenly bounce over and jump inside.

“Tv in the *car* ?” It sounds like the height of luxury coming from their mouth. “Cat?!”

“Yeah, I heard, buddy. Dora’s not getting that one.”

The octopus tries to point out other cars on the lot that have televisions too. While Finn begins to ask about other entertainment innovations in car manufacturing, Adora spots it. The perfect vehicle. It’s a silly-looking very boxy hybrid SUV.

It’s shaped almost like a cube. Adora’s always thought there's something charming about boxy vehicles. They're weird and unique. Sturdy-looking. They give off a feeling of safety.

It feels a little like she’s doing some really bizarre projecting but she feels good about this.

The truck's affordable on her budget and better for the environment. It’s even got a roof rack on top. That could be good for off-roading – Adora has always liked hiking. Maybe she'll be able to finally do more of that. It would be so nice to take Finn and introduce them to more nature.

Being away from LAP a bit in the past few weeks has really humbled her some. Apparently, Adora isn’t as important as she thought. She's managed to set up a pretty well-oiled machine. It’s something to be proud of, the fact that her organization can still run itself at a high-level without Adora having to be personally involved in every single step. Maybe things are finally at a place where she'll be able to take some time on the weekends to hike or pick up other hobbies. Balance, right?

That’s a big ‘maybe’, though. Was that a good enough reason to buy a car?

She glances back at the van. It would be more sensible. And Finn was really excited about it.

“Yeah, no fucking way,” Catra says, interrupting her thoughts. “If you try to buy that awful van, I’m gonna convince our little octopus friend that you won’t settle for anything lower than the sticker price.”

“You would never sacrifice your reputation like that,” Adora replies.

“I saw how your eyes lit up at the weird truck thing.”

“Compact SUV,” Adora corrects.

“Yeah, that’s not a real thing. Get it.”

“But-”

“Nope. Your money. Get your weird dream car.”

Adora looks the vehicle over. The trunk isn't very big but the back row should be enough to carry Finn's booster seat plus groceries, hiking gear, whatever. Maybe.

“Do you think there's enough space in the backseat?”

Catra raises an eyebrow.

“Want to try it out?” she whispers, her raspy voice particularly low. A short purr punctuates the question. Adora didn't think it was possible to make the sound so suggestive but Catra succeeds admirably.

Boosted by the adrenaline of being close to possibly making a terrible financial decision, Adora's able to pull herself together to confidently respond.

“Didn't realize exhibitionism was your thing.”

Catra gives a crooked smirk, showing off one fang. She shrugs lightly.

“You can have me wherever you want me.”

The dealer clears her throat. They both turn to her, slightly caught. She looks more embarrassed to be interrupting than Adora and Catra do.

“Sorry, ladies. Junior keeps sneaking into random cars. Wouldn't want them getting lost.”

She motions towards Finn, standing next to her and looking too innocent for it to be believable. Catra gives a short chirp and they rush over to join at her side.

Adora points to the car. “I'm interested in this one.”

The dealer lights up, going into full sales mode.

As they're all walking to her office, Adora can just barely hear Finn whispering, “It looks like a stove on wheels.”

“Eh, all that matters is Dora did a nice thing for herself. So be nice, okay, cub?”

Later, Finn insists that they ride home with Adora cause her new car is more fun than Catra's. They’re clearly lying, but it’s for all the right reasons so she lets it slide.

“Just don't disrespect Entrapta's girlfriend to her face,” Catra replies. “I don't need a whole ‘nother lecture on how special and advanced Darla is.”

“Have you thought about purchasing a car that your friend isn't attracted to?”

“But then what would I complain about?” she asks as if it's obvious, squinting her eyes and looking genuinely confused.

Adora takes a second to make everything comfortable in her new car before driving off the lot, with Finn buckled securely in the back, screaming “Adventure!” She makes it to her second red light before she begins to worry about where Catra is.

“You drive like a grandma,” Catra had said when they were parting ways. “So I better hang back here for a sec and give you a head start.”

The very loud bass behind her grabs her attention and Adora looks in her rearview to see Catra’s black car streaking towards her.

It stops at the red light in the next lane, the windows rolled down and music blaring way too loudly (especially for someone who conveniently claims to have very sensitive hearing when she doesn’t like her passengers’ music choices.)

Catra doesn’t sing much, which is really a shame. She has the most gorgeous, unique voice that Adora’s ever heard, and it just

barely carries over the music, Catra smiling broadly at the blonde while she croons.

` *Been waiting and waiting for you to make a move. Before I make a move* '

The light changes and Catra peels off, waving goodbye.

When Adora finally gets to her apartment and gets Finn out of the car, Catra's already napping on the couch. Finn, who would never miss a chance to sleep during the day, runs over and nestles themself in the crook of Catra's knee.

Adora's tempted to pull out her phone and catch a picture, when it buzzes in her pocket.

Glimmer
4:56pm
I let your cat in
I did not feed or water her
You're welcome

Adora
4:57pm
Thanks for doing the bare minimum

Glimmer
4:57pm
Anything for my bestie
Text me when you're done kissing
Catra invited me and Bow over for dinner

Adora
4:58pm
She would never

Glimmer
4:58pm
And a test drive in your new car
Bow says good job, buddy

Way to take care of yourself!
Bring more of that decisive energy

Adora
4:59pm
Will everyone leave me alone now please?

Glimmer
4:59pm
Never
<3<3<3

Adora doesn't bother replying because Glimmer and Bow will be there in an hour anyway. Probably some excuse about how they thought she'd been kidnapped when they didn't hear back, blah blah blah, how does sushi sound?

Honestly, Adora's feeling so good about herself right now that she might just change the locks tomorrow. Practicing some boundaries sounds like a great way to do something for herself and also drive Glimmer out of her mind. A win-win really.

She takes this rare moment of peace to quietly grab her laptop, take up the two inches on the couch not covered by purring cats, and start looking up nearby hiking trails for novices.

Adora feels a tail run lightly along her leg. It tickles a bit and she almost laughs out loud before she remembers the two sleeping nearby. When she glances up at them, Catra's eyes are just barely cracked and staring back.

"I'm proud of you, Dor," she mumbles sleepily. "You went after what you wanted. Just for you."

She's out like a light before she completely finishes the last word.

Chapter End Notes

it wasn't a subaru. i know. i'm shocked too.

would you believe me if i told you they go on a date next week? no? you're pretty smart then. but they do! don't let chapter 16's title fool you.

Plausible Deniability

Chapter Summary

> A long con. Cats are territorial. Someone finally does something.

Chapter Notes

> we have entered date week. yes, i know you don't believe it.
>
> most of this chapter was set in a gym and i do not apologize for the inaccuracies.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra has decided that she wants to do something special for Adora. Adora realized this was a trick pretty early on, which she's proud of herself for.

The first clue was that Adora loves everything they do together, no matter how mundane, like trying to force Finn to learn about chores, or terrifying, like trying to force *Catra* to learn about chores. Arguing about whether or not they should keep letting the cleaning service come or just have Finn and Catra cleans their own rooms turned into a debate about the importance of supporting domestic workers, where Catra gave Adora several earmarked books to read and threatened to give a PowerPoint.

It's not even Adora's apartment so she was prepared to give in right away but was a bit too turned on by how pushy Catra was being and how excited her eyes were the entire time they were arguing. And maybe a little bit by how well-researched her point was. The cleaner remains, neither cat picks up after themself, and Adora had to rush home to take an unusually long shower after that exchange.

Anyway, the second clue was that Adora told Catra how much she enjoyed whatever they did and yet, the latter had insisted upon a

new shared task. She refused to let it go and something about all of her rebuttals just felt oddly rehearsed.

The third clue was how giggly Finn was the night before, as soon as Adora arrived. They couldn't stop sneaking glances at her and laughing, no matter how many times Catra whispered to them to be chill.

The fourth clue is that Catra requested that Adora wear workout clothes. So yeah, she's pretty sure this is a silly trick for Catra to get her to lift heavy objects or some other ridiculous thing so that can stand there and mock her lazily and pretend to leer occasionally. Pretend leering looks suspiciously like actual leering, Adora's noticed.

She arrives at the Morgan residence at exactly 10:00 am as she's been told. Catra's never woken up that early before on a Saturday. She's really going out all with this con. Adora played along by wearing the tightest, skimpiest workout clothes she can find.

When she enters the apartment though, Catra's just in a cut up grey crop top that says 'rob him, sis' in sparkly red cursive letters and barely covers her bright red sports bra. What she's wearing on bottom is probably too short to actually be considered running shorts. Adora's to be outdone yet again.

While she's trying to will her mouth to make words, Catra gives her a slow onceover with her eyes.

"You're late, princess."

"I am not!"

"No, but I thought an argument might jumpstart your brain," Catra smirks and heads into the kitchen. Finn's sitting at the island, finishing some breakfast.

"Dora!" they wave, like she might not see them. Catra rolls her eyes but her smile is so sweet that Adora melts.

Melog lazily meows at her from where they're reclined on the floor near Finn's stool.

"Morning, Finny. What's your plan for your day off?"

"Trap is taking me to the space museum and then a bakery and maybe to that robot store."

"I thought you two weren't allowed in the robot store?"

"Cat bought me a hat and glasses!" they announce.

Adora looks to Catra with theatrical disappointment. Finn is very much not allowed back in the robot store after they nearly broke multiple things. Separately, Entrapta, an actual adult almost, has apparently been banned for years. They've bonded over this. Adora thinks they should stick to online shopping until they both learn how to behave.

Catra just shrugs. "Plausible deniability, kid. I didn't know why I was buying a hat and glasses and no jury can prove that I did."

Finn leans over to whisper to Adora, "I learned how to hide my tail."

"Oh, I wonder who taught you that?" she replies, accusation clear in her tone.

"Cat did!" Finn happily tells her.

"Ugh!" Catra groans. "Finn!"

They lower their head in shame, but they don't stop smiling.

"Plausible deniability," they attempt to mumble, failing terribly. It comes out more like 'pozsilil denably'.

It's so fucking cute. How the two of them are together, not how they're about to be banned from the store for life, to be clear.

They’re both completely comfortable being their weird selves and letting the other come along for the ride.

Honestly, Adora loves that Catra didn’t change overnight. Do a complete 180 and turn into a tv mom. In a weird way, it was the first time that Adora realized that maybe she could have kids someday. She’d always felt like she’d never be ready, could never get life and work and her personality to fit for a kid. But Catra really does inspire her.

“Where’d you go just now?” Catra asks, pulling back from the stove to poke the blonde in the forehead with a claw.

Adora blinks, returning to the present.

“Sorry.”

Perfuma’s advice to go against her gut dangles in her head and Adora decides to swallow whatever bullshit story she’d usually say about work or Finn and be open.

“I was just...thinking about you two, how much I love noticing your growing bond. And about how you inspire me, Cat.”

Surprised confusion clouds Catra’s face.

Adora continues, “I don’t know. Seeing you two together makes me realize that I could probably make a family work.” Adora hears what she’s said, replays it in her mind. Decides to add, “Someday maybe.”

She didn’t want Catra to think that Adora was trying to say she could just slide right into their family. She’s pondered the likelihood, logistics, legal considerations, and possible interest from all parties concerned before. But doesn’t actually believe that’s an appropriate idea.

“Inspired by me?” Catra repeats. She’s wearing a small smirk. She nods after a moment and returns to whatever she’s doing in the kitchen. Adora can hear her quietly repeat, “Someday maybe.”

"What are you making?" Adora asks, feeling a bit too exposed now in the silence.

"Smoothies."

Adora's brow furrows. "You hate smoothies."

They'd had several long talks about this when Catra saw Adora's typical breakfast. She'd said that anyone who volunteered to eat a full meal through a straw, when they had other options available to them, was someone she didn't feel safe around.

"Smoothies are an effing nightmare," is the grumpy response.

Catra's trying to curse less, since Finn repeated some of her favorite catchphrases (particularly, saying the lunch lady was 'on some fuck shit' for not giving them seconds) and they all got a lecture from Ms. Spinnerella.

She continues, "But I'm prepping brunch for afterwards so I'll allow it. Cover your ears, bud!"

Out of the corner of her eye, Adora sees Melog scramble out of the room in anticipation. Finn and Catra both cover their sensitive ears and she motions for Adora to hit the machine. She does, blending a bunch of what looks like her favorite smoothie ingredients and trying not to smile too lovingly at Catra for remembering. That task complete, she pours them both one. Finn begs to try and grimaces dramatically as soon as they get a taste.

Entrapta arrives soon, while Catra's finishing food prep and then they're all shoved out the door quickly.

As requested, Adora brought a gym bag. Catra did too, but hers is a designer brand, which seems like a waste for something that carries your disgusting sweaty clothes around. Adora says as much and they spend the next several minutes of their walk debating whether or not Adora is a 'classless beast' in Catra's words.

The debate ends when Catra says, “This is my fault. I should be taking you out to nicer places, like art museums and shows. It’s my bad for not taking better care of you.”

Besides being so resolute over such an unimportant topic, the statement also feels almost like Catra’s saying they’re dating? Adora thinks this over for the rest of the walk, trying and failing to remind herself that she’s not some helpless teen looking for scraps of requited love.

They stop in front of a fancy building. Adora can only just see the tiniest sign for a hidden storefront on the ground floor. It’s a gym. Like actually. Somehow not a clever ruse from Catra. But it is the fanciest gym in the city, a small, seemingly exclusive chain where the monthly fee is 5 times more than Adora pays for hers.

“Do you actually go here?” she asks Catra.

“I used to, on and off. You never get out of those contracts, though. You’d have to fake your own death and I just truly do not have the time to falsify documents right now. But I remembered that I had guest passes and I thought you might be into it.”

Adora starts to ask another question but Catra cuts her off quickly. “Yes, it’s expensive and I’m sure your gym is much more economical. The equipment’s all brand new and there’s a sauna and like a post-workout cooldown massage or something. I don’t know. I don’t care. Let’s go inside.”

Catra isn’t rushing exactly but Adora thinks it’s odd how she’s being pushed into the door, then into the locker room to put down their stuff and prep, and then over to the weights. She doesn’t really have a chance to catch up.

“Are we in a hurry, Cat? I thought we had all day.”

“I don’t like dilly-dallying,” she replies.

She reaches for a dumbbell that definitely is too heavy, hands it over to Adora, and sits down on the floor to watch with a gleam in

her eyes.

Adora fights the urge to roll her eyes. “We have to stretch first.”

“Yeah, I never do that. Stretching’s boring.”

“Stretching prevents injury!”

Why did Catra come if she was going to be unreasonable? Adora returns the weight while Catra pouts.

For a con, Adora still ends up having a nice time, of course. She spends way too much time convincing Catra about the benefits of her pre-workout ritual but once Catra seems to realize how much unnecessary touching she can insert into stretching, she takes to it eagerly.

At one point, Adora drops down into a lunge, trying to encourage Catra to do the same. Instead, the cat throws herself onto the mat with a thump.

“I did it wrong. Halp?” She tries for doe eyes. It reads as ‘sex panther’ much more.

With a fake huff, Adora reaches over and pulls Catra to her feet. Then she has to physically maneuver her friend into the position, pushing her left leg back and getting her to bend her right knee.

“This feels incorrect,” Catra, holding the pose perfectly with zero effort.

“Weren’t you a gymnast and a dancer? Shouldn’t you be flexible?”

Catra’s face scrunches up like Adora just called her a dirty name.

“I’m *extremel* -!” she pauses. “I guess I lost a step,” she says reluctantly, eyes narrowing at the lie that she’s forced herself into.

She makes grabby hands until Adora practically picks her up, wrapping her hands around Catra’s waist to pull her upright.

“What’s next, Dor?”

“Butterfly.”

Of course, she has to move Catra through the stretch before beginning it herself. Catra does it entirely too easily and then gets bored immediately while Adora stiffly struggles to hold the pose and count to 20.

When she glances over, Catra’s flat on her back, idly trying to bend at the waist so the toes on one leg touch the mat next to her head. This is...not a traditional warm-up stretch.

“A little assistance?”

Adora replies, rather flatly, “I’m not helping you spread eagle in the gym.”

“But other locations are on the table?” Catra teases.

The blonde announces that they’re done and scrambles towards the cardio machines to hide her blush.

The day follows the same formula for a while: Catra directs Adora to a new piece of equipment, pretends she needs the blonde’s instruction, usually a hands-on lesson or a demonstration, and soon becomes competitive about who can climb the most stairs or lift the most or row the fastest or whatever. They spend so much time with their eyes glued on each other that it’s a wonder that neither of them ends up seriously hurt.

The fun ends when a nice enough looking woman in a matching white lycra top and pants sidles up next to Adora at the shoulder press machine. She’s got straight dark burgundyish hair with one side buzzed off and dyed gray. Adora thinks she appears to be human but her pointy ears are distinctly elven, which the blonde is caught off-guard by a bit.

“Mind if I work in?” she asks, with a sly smile. Her voice is raspy like Catra’s but a little deeper. More confident, if that’s even

possible.

Adora glances over at Catra, reclining on the leg curl machine next to her and observing Adora lazily. She sniffs at the new addition then looks away quickly.

"Yeah," Adora replies. "Just let me get a couple more reps in."

She expects the woman to take a step back but instead she leans in even closer. It's enough for Adora to see how her coffee-colored eyes contrast nicely with her flawless caramel skin.

"Actually – do you think you could give me a few pointers? I'd love to get arms like yours." She lightly flexes her thin but toned bicep. "I'm Juliet."

"Adora," Catra answers before she can. But then she continues in the world's most bored tone, "Am I supposed to be resting this long between sets? Feels like it's increasing the likelihood of injury."

Catra knows that that's the magic word. Adora takes fitness safety *very* seriously.

She finishes the current rep before jumping up quickly and wiping down the seat.

"All yours," Adora tells Juliet before moving over to Catra.

She makes it about one step before she stops short. Catra's tail freezes in its steady thump, even though she never turns back.

Contrary to what everyone seems to think, Adora's not completely oblivious. Juliet's attractive. She clearly came over because she thought the same about Adora. It would be harmless to enjoy this attention for a little bit.

Right in front of Catra. Completely harmless.

“You know, Cat, we’ve got a few minutes,” Adora says with a smile. “Juliet, why don’t you do a couple of reps and I’ll see if I can help you out?”

With an easy smile, Juliet starts adjusting the weight. She takes a swift seat and does her first lift. Her form is perfect. But really, that’s not what matters here, is it?

“That’s great,” Adora encourages, making sure to sound extra impressed. “I like to try to engage my core a bit to put more power into it.”

“That’s super helpful,” Juliet replies. Her eyes don’t leave Adora’s face when she does the next lift.

There’s just the lightest sound of a nearby growl.

“I feel like I’ve seen you around. Aren’t you a trainer here?” Catra bites out.

Adora turns back to Catra, who looks as if she'd like to claw the other half of Juliet's hair off.

“You might have me confused with someone else,” Juliet responds, in the middle of another perfect lift. She hasn’t even broken a sweat.

“Your triceps are really nice. What’s your secret?” Adora asks.

“Why don’t we exchange numbers and we can text each other some tips,” the other woman suggests.

Suddenly Catra is standing next to them.

“Adora, we’re late for brunch.”

Brunch is at Catra’s apartment. They’re the only two attendees. Finn won’t be back for hours. Adora tries not to look too smug as she gives Catra a quick nod of acknowledgement.

“Sorry,” Juliet apologizes. “Are you two together?”

“I’m her lawyer,” Catra states. “I’m just here for emotional support. She’s going through a messy divorce. Lots and lots of drama. You can’t tell from looking at her but totally high-maintenance.”

Adora rolls her eyes.

“This will only take a sec,” she says.

Adora’s phone is in the locker. This is a complete bluff. But she pretends to reach towards the pocket in her shorts.

“Fine, I’ll meet you in the shower,” Catra mutters and Adora’s mostly certain that she doesn’t mean it the way that it sounds.

Then Catra leans over, stands up on her tiptoes, and licks the side of Adora’s face. Just one long swipe of her rough tongue from the blonde’s jaw to the top of her cheek. Without another word, Catra turns and leaves, hips and tail swaying as she disappears from sight.

Juliet probably says something. It’s hard to tell because Adora immediately leaves and follows, wondering what the fuck just happened.

In the locker room, Adora finds Catra in the relatively secluded alcove where they had chosen to store their stuff. Catra’s locker is hanging open already, her clothes falling halfway out of her gym bag and a towel waiting for her.

Catra’s so distracted that she begins undressing without even noticing that Adora’s joined her. No, this isn’t the way that Adora would like to see her naked for the first time, assuming that that’s an opportunity that she’ll ever get. She’s not counting the late night video call from Zombie Catra and really it’s probably better to try to never think about that.

Adora turns her back to block her view so quickly that she stumbles face-first into a locker.

"You were really raised in a shame-based household, weren't you?"

"Weren't *you* ?" Adora asks, voice all pitchy.

Catra casually chuckles, like she wasn't just behaving ridiculously.

"We both played sports, Dor. We're used to what happens in a locker room."

Fine . If Catra's not concerned, then there's no reason for Adora to go into a full gay panic. Right?

The blonde pivots back around, pulling her shirt off in the process. Catra's smirking, with a hand on her hip and bare from the waist up. Adora has to steel her resolve to not immediately stumble once she gets her first glimpse at Catra's breasts, where her copper fur thins out and gives way to two perky tan mounds that look like the perfect size for Adora's hands.

She gulps so loudly that people can probably hear it from the sidewalk.

Catra is wholly unprepared for Adora to remove her top as well. Because as soon as the blonde whips her bra off, Catra's eyes go wide, pupils growing as large as saucers. Her tail picks up speed and starts swaying quickly behind her. As she reaches back to grab it, Adora stands up a little taller, quite proud of this reaction.

Catra slowly drags her eyes down Adora's body, one fang poking into her bottom lip. The two of them share a long moment of mutual observation that's so tense it causes goosebumps to rise on Adora's skin.

The spell is broken when Catra glances down at her own chest, noticing for the first time how hard her nipples are, going taut and darkening a little from pink to a light mocha color.

Wordlessly, Catra grabs her towel from the bench in front of them and tries to casually rush into the shower. She all but takes off in a leap.

Well. What a fun turn of events.

Adora strolls over to retrieve her things from her locker with an extra pep in her step. Who's the mess now? Not Adora! She's *confident* . She can make this gorgeous woman fall apart by just taking her shirt off.

After a very pleasant and relaxing shower, Adora dresses quickly and relaxes on a bench while waiting for Catra to finish blow drying her fur. It gives her a lot of time to practice what she's going to say. The first several tries are way too long and rambling. Adora finally gets it down to something short and reasonable.

She's...going to do a thing. It will be fine. Adora's going to be spontaneous. She usually likes at least a week's notice before doing anything spur of the moment, but really this whole day has been a huge ego boost.

She made Catra jealous. She made Catra flustered. She *turned Catra on* . Adora's never felt this powerful outside of work before.

When Catra does finally appear, she keeps her eyes downcast as she pulls on her clothes. Adora thinks it's best to keep her back turned this time.

Clearing her throat, Adora tries to make her voice sound open and calming.

"Want to talk about what happened earlier?"

"I was hoping a meteor would hit soon and we wouldn't need to," Catra mutters back.

"That's the base level of anxiety I live with daily," Adora jokes. When Catra continues in silence for a couple more minutes, the blonde adds, "It really sucks when you shut down."

Catra tuts, seeming to accept that. So Adora moves forward.

“Can you admit that what happened out there wasn’t the most mature thing to do? And that maybe it was a bit overly possessive?”

“It was instinctual,” Catra mumbles.

That's very possibly true, cats being territorial and all. She’s seen Catra run her scent along Adora's couch and look horribly embarrassed, like she knows this is absurd and she can't help it. Absurd because there aren’t exactly other women coming over and draping themselves across Adora and her couch. Absurd cause they belong to each other. Isn’t that what they promised?

She hears Catra zip up her gym bag and figures it's safe to look again. Catra's leaning against the lockers, eyes on the floor and ears flattened. Adora goes over, stopping right in front of her.

“Sorry I cockblocked you. Or clamjammed you, whatever.”

The blonde laughs. “I don't think she was the future Mrs. Gray or anything.”

Catra scoffs quietly.

“Cat,” she calls out softly. Catra looks at her fully. Very slowly and deliberately, Adora says, “If you want something, maybe you should do something about it.”

Yes, it’s hypocritical but if Catra’s prepared to go around town licking Adora in front of women, then she can use her words.

Catra opens her mouth, probably prepared to make the same counter-argument, with her eyes narrowed and her finger already pointing at Adora in accusation. She shuts herself up, though. After a short pause, Catra takes a long stretch, shaking out all the tension that's been gathering.

She makes eye contact with Adora again, as intense as ever, and gives a quick decisive nod.

“Noted, princess. I could say the same for you.”

“Noted, kitten,” Adora replies, trying to drop her voice in an imitation of Catra.

Rather than moving away, Adora follows through on the rest of her plan. She leans over and quickly licks right along Catra's jaw line. Just a small clarification on where things stand.

It’s more pleasant than she would have thought. She ends up with zero hair in her mouth at least, which was only a mild concern. Catra smells more like the gym’s shower products than her usual self but it still feels nice. Instinctual.

“Blegh,” Catra feigns, pretending to be disgusted. “Dor, I just showered!” But her hands go to Adora’s waist to keep her in place for a moment longer and she can’t hide her quiet trill.

On their way out, arms laced together, Adora makes sure to avoid Juliet’s gaze.

Brunch that day is one of Adora’s all-time favorites. Catra makes steak with chimichurri and eggs, egg whites only for Adora, and a very healthy salad full of fruits and nuts that the chef refuses to even touch.

Afterward, they just watch tv on the couch, like most Saturdays. The fact that it’s a lot more tense than usual doesn’t manage to escape Adora. Catra takes a lot extra time settling down and getting comfortable. Adora’s wound tighter than a spring, thinking for a long time on making a joke about how they had rushed out and never got those post-workout massages and maybe she and Catra could try…

Finn bursts through the door, even more excited than ever.

And that's how Adora finds herself trapped on the couch with Catra's head in her lap, pondering what a giant loser she is. Because…

"I have a date!" Finn shouts.

"Finn ran into another child from their school," Entrapta explains. She looks about as confused as Adora but also oddly charmed almost.

"Jane! She's in my class," they add.

Entrapta continues, "And this tiny human talked to them for awhile. A pretty long time in fact. I wasn't aware that 7 year olds knew enough information to carry on such a long conversation."

"Where were you this whole time?" Catra asks.

There's a slight look up at the ceiling, like Entrapta's trying to think of a correct answer. "Standing nearby and watching intently?"

It's not convincing. She definitely wandered away for several minutes, possibly longer. Catra's narrowed eyes confirm she thinks the same thing. She'll probably be having words with Entrapta about this later.

"Jane told me she liked me and wanted to hang out next Saturday. I have a date!" they repeat that last part, like anyone could forget it.

Finn has been in school for little over a month and they already have a date. Adora's spent 9 months with Catra and does not. This feels like the fate she was always destined to be resigned to. Literal children were smoother than her.

"You have to come. I need a ride."

"What? You can't drive yourself?" Catra asks. "I'll give you the keys. We have insurance."

Finn laughs like it’s the funniest joke they’ve ever heard. They launch themselves onto the couch, landing on Catra’s stomach.

“Watch it, kid! I just worked out for the first time this decade.” She looks up at Adora pointedly, head rolling back in her lap. “I didn’t even get a cooldown massage.”

Adora doesn’t have a chance to panic because Finn puts a knee in Catra’s stomach to get closer to the blonde’s face.

“No, you both have to take me. It's skating and ice cream.”

Catra wheezes, trying to situate them more comfortably, “What if I had plans next weekend?”

“You never do anything fun!” Finn shoots back, pretty fairly.

“Because I have to be a responsible adult.”

“You can do that on skates!” They turn on Adora. “You have to come. Make her come too.”

“Is this really a two-person job?” Catra asks.

Finn looks astounded. “You have to bring a date.” They glance back to Entrapta for support.

“Yes,” she confirms. The next part sounds like they rehearsed it earlier, “It’s a double-date. So Adora has to come or Catra will not have fun.”

Finn winks at her. She winks back very badly. At least she’s being a good sport about it. It’s nice that Finn has other supportive adults in their life now. It’s not nice that they learned how to blindside two of them though.

“Aren’t we painting your room next weekend?” Adora remembers.

Catra laughs. “Did you really think we were gonna do it ourselves? I hired painters.” She frowns at Finn, obviously annoyed at losing

this argument. Catra absolutely *loathes* losing. “I guess we need an excuse to be out of the apartment anyway. I don’t think the cub and I could take the fumes.”

“And Adora can join our sleepover in your room that night,” Finn adds brightly.

So Adora and Catra now have a convenient excuse to go on a date and then spend the night together. In the same bed. Finn's probably going to find some excuse to be busy. She briefly wonders if they consulted Glimmer on this plan. There's no way they came up with this by themself in one afternoon.

“Yes, that logic is sound,” Entrapta agrees.

Catra rolls her head over to look at her friend. “What did they bribe you with?”

“I don’t know what you mean.”

“Really? How was the robot store?”

“I have to be leaving now,” Entrapta announces. “Lots of new toys to play with at home. Goodbye, everyone.” She smartly exits immediately.

Catra tilts her head back to look at Adora once more. Suddenly, she lets herself be a bit amused by this whole debacle, her eyes sparkling and a slow smile spreading across her lovely face.

“Dor. Would you go on a date with me?”

Chapter End Notes

> catra in a previous chapter: i never lie.
> catra in this chapter: here's a giant lie for no reason except jealousy.

Not a Real Date

Chapter Summary

> Skating, ice cream, and a sleepover. That definitely sounds like a date.

Chapter Notes

> so the rating changed. it's not explicit but if you'd rather skip it anyway, jump from the horizontal line down to "hold up, chef." the rating will change again, uh...later. maybe. (definitely.)
>
> part two of date week! just ignore the title. let's, like, not even think about that.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora wakes up early on Saturday to fret over the perfect outfit. The whole week, Catra had been teasing her over text about the intense high school nature of the whole thing. Skating and going to an ice cream shoppe. She insisted on spelling it “shoppe” each time. She asked more than once if Adora was planning to pin her afterwards, but when she said it in person as they were exchanging a Finn pickup after school it felt a bit...suggestive.

Also, her references felt more ‘old-timey’ than ‘high school’ but Adora realized pointing that out would only lead to more teasing.

“You could literally wear anything, Adora, and it would be fine,” Bow assures her. He’s been lounging on her bed for an hour while she assesses and reassesses every outfit she owns, which is like basically 7 things.

“No, this is an actual date so you have to make a fucking impression,” Glimmer argues, still hovering unhelpfully over Adora’s shoulder. “We should really finally get you some new clothes. This is embarrassing.”

“It's not a real date,” Adora argues. “And I look terrible in everything!”

“If it’s not a real date, then why are you so worried?” Glimmer accuses with a smile.

“I…”

Adora reaches for a good answer and comes up empty-handed. She shakes the thought of her own excitement, Finn’s palpable anticipation, and even Catra’s sly reminders about it throughout the week out of her head.

“I should still look presentable. It’s good manners when someone invites you somewhere,” she says finally.

“Well, what does Catra usually like to see you in?” Bow asks.

He’s tried this a couple times in much gentler ways to no success. ‘What do you think Catra would like?’ and ‘What would make you feel more confident in front of Catra?’ did not seed answers.

She doesn't actually own anything that seems to both appeal to Catra and make sense to wear in public. It’s unfortunately not tanktop weather. ‘I wasted the whole summer being an idiot,’ Catra has lamented more than once while staring at Adora’s arms without elaborating further.

That does give her an idea of what to pack for overnight though. She has a few things there already but no pajamas so she grabs a tank and some shorts. That settled, Adora goes back to staring at her closet then her dresser and repeating the motion over and over.

“Okay, I can’t take this anymore,” Glimmer announces. “Life is too short to spend it watching you be a fucking wreck. It’s gone past charming and is just pathetic now.”

She pulls a pair of dark jeans out of the closet and grabs a black tshirt from the dresser, before shoving both into Adora’s hands.

“No, that shirt’s too tight,” she tries to protest.

“Exactly,” Glimmer replies.

“Letterman jacket,” Bow pretends to couch into his hand. Glimmer’s eyes light up.

When Adora’s dressed, she looks alright. Slightly uncomfortable. The shirt really is a bit too tight. It’s straining almost everywhere – her biceps, shoulders, chest – and if she raises her arms, everyone will see her entire mid-

“Oh. Okay, this is fine.” Yes, this is sufficient and not too scandalous.

Glimmer throws the jacket over her. It’s also a bit too small now but, thankfully, putting it on still manages to give Adora a tiny boost of confidence.

“Pack an extra coat,” Bow advises her. To Glimmer, he adds, “$100 says Catra tries to steal this one.”

“Please, that’s not even a bet. $100 says she tries to remove this shirt with her *teeth* .”

Finn and Catra are already at the skating rink when Adora arrives 15 minutes early in an uber. Catra first looks relieved to see her before her mismatched eyes settle into mischievousness. Minus the ridiculous letterman, they’re matching.

“We’re girlfriend twins again,” Catra observes. More sarcastically, she adds, “Cute jacket,” but her hands go to the lapels to pull the blonde closer.

“ *Hey* , Adora,” she whispers when they’re fully pressed against each other.

“ *Hey,* Catra,” she responds, making a big show of pretending to be cool and casual.

The moment is broken when Finn yells, “Hey, Dora! This is Jane.”

Adora pulls back to greet them with a smile as they bounce around excitedly, pointing to the human child standing next to them. A shy looking dark-skinned little girl with curly hair waves slightly. Adora finally notices what the younger cat is wearing.

“Did you dress Finn like you?” she asks curiously.

“This was purely coincidental,” Catra says defensively. “I didn’t realize we’d all end up looking like some traveling family band.”

Once they’ve all acquired rental skates, Catra immediately begins complaining about how they feel on her claws. Finn doesn't seem to mind and they and Jane clumsily weave right into the rink. There’s an inner circle just for kids so once Adora’s assured that they’re safe and easy to supervise, she turns her attention to listening to Catra whine about how they no longer make those old skates that you just strap onto your feet.

“You mean the first skates ever? I think those were from 100 years ago or something? And meant for use with shoes.”

Catra is not interested in facts.

“This place is very inconsiderate of my needs.”

“I thought you used to be a skater?”

“Skate *board* ,” Catra corrects. “I was fucking hot too.”

Adora imagines her younger, with flat-ironed hair, wild bangs, and all black outfit, leaning against a barbed fence with her skateboard. It’s a weirdly specific image but it works.

“I’ll give Finn some more cat-appropriate ideas if they get asked on a second date,” Adora offers as she tries to maneuver Catra towards the rink.

“I didn’t realize I’d have to worry about dating so soon. Are they like super advanced or were we just really, really late bloomers?”

They begin a slow circle around the rink. As Adora expected, Catra is very light on her feet and even doing impressive little skating tricks absently, weaving her legs back and forth. Adora looks like a newborn deer on wheels. Catra has to take her hand to keep her upright.

“You don’t strike me as a late bloomer, Cat,” she manages to get out while trying to catch her balance.

Catra shrugs.

“I hit puberty late. I was always smaller and scrawny. I realized I was gay pretty early on thankfully but couldn’t do anything about it until I was around 16.”

“Internet girlfriend, right. But you kissed two girls,” Adora points out.

“Little pecks though. I didn’t really get it together until junior year of college. I met this senior who blew my fucking mind.”

Adora smirks, “And then you became a heartbreaker.” This is what she had gleaned from Catra’s previous stories about her youth.

“Well, between her, my therapist convincing me to take some chances on people occasionally, and the dyke population of my college being unusually attractive, I became a...voracious admirer of a few women.”

“A fuckboi,” Adora summarizes.

Catra gasps, reaching to clutch her nonexistent pearls.

“How dare you!”

Adora just chuckles. This helps melt away some of the tension. Between her constant fear of slipping on the glossy floor and the

knowledge that this was technically a date, she might have been even more anxious than usual. She was trying not to think about the sleepover.

More relaxed, they keep skating in a circle, hand-in-hand, talking about dating experiences. Sometimes just the weirdness of the concept in general. Sometimes the worst and most awkward dates they've been on.

Eventually, Adora works up the courage to ask, "Do you want to be dating...anyone?" She tries to say it casually but it sounds a bit sullen.

Catra sighs softly.

"You're the only person I want to spend time with. And the cub." She squeezes Adora's hand. Very quietly, she asks, "Do you like spending time with us? I do really want to do more stuff that you're into since you're having to put up with all this kid shit now."

Adora smiles easily but tries not to sound too eager.

"I *love* being with you. Finn's a nice bonus. You know I don't mind helping you out. I adore them and I'll always give you both whatever you need."

Catra smiles back at her and hides her face in Adora's shoulder when a blush starts to creep up her cheeks. Adora leans down and plants a kiss on the top of her curly head. She gets a quiet trill in response.

After a couple minutes, Catra pulls away.

"Okay, let's find whatever teenage delinquent works here and bribe them to play 'Heartbreaker' by Mariah. If we have to tag along, we can at least recreate our embarrassing high school fantasies."

"I mean, Glimmer dressed me for it so I'm down," Adora responds, gesturing towards her silly jacket.

“You asked Glimmer to help you get ready for this date?” her voice sounds oddly pleased.

“It was more like she insisted, but yes.” She smirks at Catra. “Did I make a good impression?”

“I guess we’ll have to wait and see if you get a second date, princess,” Catra responds before skating away, dragging Adora behind her way way too fast.

She spends 10 minutes trying to find someone who knows how to use the sound equipment. And then 15 minutes explaining what the song is to a person who had not even been alive when it came out.

Adora spends the whole time trying to keep an eye on Finn and Jane, who are having the time of their lives, in their own little world. She never thought to ask if Finn even knew how to skate, but they seem to be taking to it naturally, like they do with most physical stuff.

When the song begins blaring through the speakers, Catra smiles slyly and drags Adora back out to skate. She lip syncs the words the entire time, weaving backwards and pulling Adora by her jacket so she can maintain eye contact. It’s so embarrassing and cheesy and somehow both out of character and yet completely what Catra would pull to try to make Adora fluster.

Adora’s never been more head over heels.

Jane and Adora have to look on in horror as Catra and Finn eat a small mountain of junk from the concession counter. They drink approximately a liter of soda each, after daring the other to mix all the flavor options together. That apparently is a mistake that everyone has to endure when they both get a boost of uncontainable energy and take the rink at a breakneck speed that has Adora trying to lecture them both about safety.

The crash comes soon afterwards. Blessfully, it’s a sugar crash and not a literal one.

After that, neither of them feel like skating more so the group is able to go to the ice cream parlor, where again, the two cats overindulge in too many scoops of several different flavors.

Adora has to remind herself several times that she can't appreciate the sight of Catra licking her cone too much because there are children there. Catra's not even attempting to pull her usual antics, the sight of her tongue is just... distracting.

"Aren't you lactose intolerant?" Adora asks curiously.

"I took two pills," Catra responds, pausing only for a second before taking a long, criminally slow lick of Cookies and Mint. "Just in case we wanted to...do anything later."

Adora focuses on her scoop of Earl Grey.

When they're done, the two kids go to the counter to get more napkins and some water to clean up the total mess they've made of their faces and shirts. Catra's still fiddling with the lapel of Adora jacket, smirking like she might make another joke about being pinned. Adora's already overstimulated enough by everything that's happened today so she excuses herself to grab napkins too.

She walks up just in time to hear Jane say, "I didn't know you had two moms."

"Yeah!" Finn responds excitedly. "They're brand new! But they're pretty cool!"

Adora abandons the napkins. Catra raises an eyebrow when she returns empty-handed and red-faced.

"What? You catch them getting fresh with each other?"

Adora makes a shocked yelp at that horrible thought. Catra just lets out her squeakiest laugh. Adora's favorite one.

The blonde manages to drive Catra's car and drop Jane off safely at home, even though her thoughts are in an endless loop around all the many things that could happen later tonight.

By the time they've made their way back to the apartment, dinner's ruined and Finn's ready for an early bedtime for once. They've set up a tent in the guest room, which doesn't seem at all like the plan that they had promised last weekend. With their headphones and tablet ready, Finn excuses themself to be alone. Looking at them oddly, Catra follows. Adora decides to eavesdrop just a bit, just to make sure Finn's okay.

"You're being stupid," Finn says petulantly. "I'm helping you."

"That's not a very nice thing to say."

"Glimmer says it."

"Well, Glimmer's awful. We can aspire to higher than that."

Adora almost interrupts to remind Catra how important it is to teach Finn respect. But she remembers that she's not supposed to be listening. And that Glimmer probably deserves it.

"Go have fun," Finn suggests. "I'm watching tv. Bye."

There's rustling so Adora tries to hurry back to Catra's room and pretend to unpack her overnight bag.

"You know I can hear every move you make, right?" comes from the hall.

Adora finally takes off her jacket and throws it into the bag. She has her back to the door when Catra enters and closes it behind her. There's a short pause followed by a quiet growl. Then the distinct sound of the door locking.

"Want to watch tv for awhile?" Adora attempts to suggest lightly, without turning around.

“Why don't we put on music instead?” Catra's voice is much closer than Adora realized.

There's a fleeting touch along the muscle of her left shoulder blade. It's gone quickly and Catra moves to turn on music. Like with most things, Catra has really specific tastes about her music. She's appointed herself the DJ in this relationship.

A orchestral-sounding pop song comes on quietly, building slowly til an ethereal voice joins in, singing about being a fool.

“Come lay down,” Catra calls out softly.

The lights dim.

“I just need to change first,” Adora replies, still facing the wall and pretending to be busy with nothing.

“Later.”

Okay. ‘Do the opposite of what your gut says.’ But Adora's gut has kept her alive and mostly safe all this time. It can't be completely wrong. Cause it's definitely saying she should pretend to be a houseplant and maybe Catra will forget and go to sleep and neither of them will ever have to be disappointed.

“Nevermind,” Catra sighs. “You're right. We should get ready for sleep.”

Her voice sounds normal, maybe just a touch resigned. She's up on her feet and heading into the bathroom before Adora can respond.

This was what was for the best, right? Why did Adora immediately regret it?

She changes quickly in the hall bathroom and ambles into the kitchen for water and a snack. Adora’s stress-eating vegan chocolate ice cream right out of the pint when she hears soft shuffling behind her. Honestly, it’s kind’ve a blessing. She wasn’t

still hungry and if Catra didn’t come out and distract her, Adora would probably eat the whole thing just to have something to do with herself.

Except, it’s not Catra at all.

“Why are you out here?” Finn hisses very quietly. “Go find Cat.”

“Hey, be nice,” Adora admonishes. “And don't eavesdrop.”

“I came out for something,” they lie. Very badly. “Water?”

Adora pulls a cup down from the cabinet and hopes the action of getting them a drink distracts them from whatever this is they're doing. If not-

“Do you want more ice cream?” she asks.

Finn actually does hiss this time. They start using their tiny hands to push the pint away, not caring where it lands on the floor, and try to pull Adora out of the kitchen.

“You're making a mess!” is all Adora thinks to whisper. She's aware that she's also making a mess of this all.

Of course, Finn isn’t very strong so Adora’s able to waste plenty of time just refusing to budge while they try pushing, pulling, and then finally tickling her onto moving. She just watches with a confused smile.

“Why are you doing this?”

“You’re being dumb,” they grunt quietly, jumping up to push her in the lower back.

“I told you that wasn’t a nice thing to say,” Catra says.

Adora looks up and she’s standing nearby, cute little monogrammed pajamas on. Adora’s seen this sight before so it’s ridiculous that her heart skips a beat.

Catra's curiosity turns to a frown when she looks at the floor.

"You're calling us names *and* you spilt ice cream on the floor? You're cleaning that up."

"Dora did it!"

"Finn slapped it out of my hands!"

"I don't care which one of you children cleans it up, but my floor better be spotless before either one of you comes to bed. Dor, make sure they put on pajamas." She turns to walk away and throws over your shoulder, "This means I get to pick the movie so I hope you're both happy with yourselves."

That's unfortunate for everyone. Catra has terrible taste in movies, always picking things that she thinks are 'classics' but Adora and Finn have never heard and don't usually end up getting. Adora pointed this out once. Catra replied that it was because they both had the pop culture savvy of 7 year olds. Adora thought it was best to just suffer in silence after that.

She supervises while Finn mops up the spill. She then has to actually clean it once she realizes that they just moved the mess around on the floor, rather than actually doing much about it.

Prepped for sleep, they join Catra in bed, Finn insisting that Adora get in the middle. They're still pissed, which she can't figure out, so they sit on the far end, just pouting.

"What's up with Finny?" she whispers to Catra. All she gets in response is an eye roll.

Catra's movie choice is some weird musical thing from 30 years ago with a man-eating plant from outer space. Finn gets into it at least, trying to join in on all the songs even though this is the first time they've ever heard them before.

The seating arrangements are awkward at best. For most of the movie, everything's oddly tense cause Finn and Catra are actively

not speaking to each other. Finn distracts themself with singing. The older cat stays cold for much longer but relaxes a bit when Adora scoots a little closer to her. Inch by inch, they close the distance as the movie rolls along. By the time it's nearly over, she and Catra have fallen into holding each other like it's second nature. Adora gets so comfortable with Catra in her arms that she misses the end.

The tv's cycling through an endless list of recommended movies when Adora wakes with a bit of a start. The time in the corner says it's just after midnight.

She doesn't really fully begin to take in her surroundings until Finn squirms against her. Half-slumped on the bed, there's a cacophony of purrs all around Adora. Catra's spooning her from behind, with Melog trying to press between them to snore on the blonde's shoulder. Finn is in a small ball, nestled up against her chest, with Adora's arm around them in a way that looks very protective.

The light movement is enough to wake the cub though and they slide out of Adora's embrace, rubbing at their eyes, until they're kneeling on the bed.

"It's late, Finny," she whispers. "Let's get in bed properly."

"Tent. Night," they mumble sleepily. Without another word, the tiny cat lifts Melog off her shoulder and shuffles out of bed. They pause long enough to turn off the tv before leaving, shutting the door.

It takes a lot of effort for Adora to wake up enough to maneuver herself and Catra, who remains basically completely zonked out, under the covers and into a position that's actually comfortable for sleeping.

Catra does of course suddenly reanimate enough to wrap herself around Adora's back and intertwine their legs together. She briefly squeezes the blonde tightly in her arms and then goes immediately limp again.

Adora must drift off again cause it’s much brighter the next time she wakes. Catra's half-sleepily mewling and trying to hide her face in Adora’s neck, probably to block out the sunlight beaming in through her huge bedroom windows.

Adora yawns and stretches, attempting to shake off sleep. It’s probably late, at least by her standards, and she really should start the day. There’s meals to prep for the week and chores to be done, both here and at her actual home.

“Unh-unh,” Catra whispers, groggy, holding on tighter. “Stay? Please?”

Adora nods after a moment, pulling the comforter tighter around them. Maybe just a few more minutes.

She lays on her back and opens her arms, letting Catra climb over and burrow into her side. A head full of wild, short waves goes onto her shoulder and Catra weaves a leg between Adora’s. A clawed hand lands just under the hem of Adora’s shirt, kneading absently at her stomach.

“Good girl,” Catra sighs.

Adora would like to blame sleep but honestly she’s been completely awake and alert since Catra asked her to stay. Maybe it’s hormones. Maybe it’s love. It’s got to be something unusual cause Adora’s never reacted to a phrase so viscerally before.

The phrase – that tone, that *voice* – settles under Adora’s skin and forces her hips to involuntarily jerk up into the thigh resting between her own, drawing in a sharp gasp at the contact. Before the blonde can even begin to overthink this, Catra seems to instinctively move to meet her, shifting to press her thigh in harder, right where Adora needs her.

A pair of bi-colored eyes shoot up to hers, fully open but pupils growing quickly. There’s some confusion in Catra’s face at first.

Adora imagines she must look flushed and horny as all hell cause that bewilderment clears away instantly, replaced by pure need.

Catra growls quietly, moving slightly until Adora can feel her heated center grinding against the blonde's hip. Well, that just makes Adora arch up into her again, harder this time. Catra rolls her hips down once more, whimpering quietly.

Slowly, so fucking slowly, they fall into a rhythm, rocking against each other until Catra parts her lips and gives a deep groan.

It's good. It's really *really* good, being close to Catra like this. Listening to the soft sounds she makes, watching her brow furrow in concentration while she tries to increase the pressure.

But it's not nearly enough. There's so much heat building inside Adora so quickly that it's shutting her dumb gay brain down. All she can think of is getting out of these stupid fucking clothes without disrupting whatever spell they're under.

Not slowing down at all, Catra begins to move the hand on Adora's stomach just a little higher. She's pretty sure if she doesn't kiss Catra right now, she's going to *die* . So Adora lowers her head, trying to get closer.

Catra must take this as a good sign cause her hand slowly drags up to the blonde's ribs, stopping just below her breast.

There she pauses for the first time.

"Dor? You okay with this?"

Adora doesn't trust her voice right now. She's stumbled through this whole thing so badly, she's worried that if she tries to speak, she'll say something dumb that she doesn't even want, like 'let's go out for brunch now!'.

So instead, she just nods and covers Catra's hand with her own. Adora not too gently maneuvers it lower, at least having the presence of mind to make sure Catra's claws are sheathed first,

before entering her waistband and slipping between her legs. Rougher than she intends to, Adora grabs a handful of Catra's hair, tilting her head back and moving closer to her lips.

"Dor," Catra moans, relaxing into the strong hold.

The sound of something light and metallic falling in the kitchen startles them both into bolting upright. Heart racing for multiple reasons now, Adora irrationally pulls the blanket up to her neck, like anyone's going to be able to see what she almost just did with Catra. What she desperately *desperately* wanted to do with Catra, Adora realizes.

Catra, on the other hand, bounds out of bed and to the door in a couple of long four-legged leaps. She quietly opens it and lets herself out into the hallway.

Her voice comes out much lower and somehow even sexier than usual. "What's-" Catra pauses to clear her throat. "What happened?"

Adora can't quite hear Finn's answer but Catra chuckles ruefully in response.

"Hold up, chef. Give me a sec."

Catra angles back towards Adora, still sitting dumbly on the bed.

"They're trying to make pancakes. I'll be back, Dor. Just st-," she stops with a sigh. "I'll be back."

And she leaves, closing the door behind her.

Adora figures she can't just stay there. It feels a little silly waiting in bed for Catra to come back and what...fuck her(?), while she's in the kitchen making breakfast like a dutiful and responsible guardian.

A kiss would have been a reasonable start. Getting fingered on a Sunday morning is not. And Adora's a reasonable person, she's

pretty sure. She doesn't feel like it right now, her entire body on fire from Catra's touch and her pajama bottoms likely soaked through. She doesn't know what the hell got into her earlier, and she'll leap right over the obvious joke about what *nearly* did, but she has to get her wits about her.

She's up and showered and packed by the time Catra comes back. She absently notes that her letterman jacket is definitely missing. So Bow won that bet. Glimmer did not win hers. Adora's all over the place on how she feels about that.

"Time for breakfast?" Adora asks, like everything's totally okay and she wasn't just literally two seconds away from having sex with her best friend.

Catra looks at her like she's lost her mind, which is totally valid, eyes widening and head tilting cutely.

"I only made enough for Finn," she explains. "They're back in their tent watching tv, all set up. I thought we'd be...busy."

"Heh," Adora giggles nervously. "Busy, yes. That's why I should be heading home. Meals to prep, laundry to do, you know? You're busy here. I should get out of your hair."

Adora expects a bit of pushback. Catra usually whines or teases her or tries to get her to stay longer.

Now though, Catra flattens her ears to head, glancing down at the floor. She's ashamed. This feels ridiculous because obviously everything that happened was Adora's fault. She was the one moving super fast, not checking in.

"I'm sorry," rushes out of Adora's mouth. "About all that. That shouldn't have happened."

Catra looks up with a start.

"What? No, Dor, *I'm* sorry."

The blonde cuts her off before she can continue, apologizing again as she grabs her bag and slides past Catra, out of the bedroom.

Her hand's on the front doorknob when Catra says, " *Please* . Dor, I really am sorry. Just stay. We'll talk."

"I'll call you later." She exits as quickly as possible.

In the hall, she hears Catra yell 'fuck!' on the other side of the door, but Adora's already running away.

Chapter End Notes

> when i was rereading this, i felt like it was almost a set-up for the old 'it was all a dream...' trick. i could never be that cruel.
>
> next week? drunk people say words.

A Whirling Dervish and a Locomotive

Chapter Summary

It's Catra's birthday and no one is happy with Adora.

Chapter Notes

attempts to quietly enter room and clean up a couple things. knocks over everything, further annoying everyone.

oh, hi. it's a new week! new chances for personal growth, or something, i don't know. today's chapter and friday's chapters are supersized. so much talking. i don't even like talking that much. but these dummies have to start talking before they accidentally end up with a second child or some other silly thing so there.

warnings: a little naughty talk. not safe for emetophobes - some threats, though not depiction, of vomiting from "The snoring stops" til "What did we do to her?". drinking in like the whole first 1/3, mention of hangovers in the second, and catra's clearly tipsy in the third. uhh, mention of weed for like two seconds? hopeless lesbianism throughout.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

No one’s happy with Adora Gray right now. Bow, Glimmer, and Perfuma are sick of her complaining about what happened while refusing to talk to Catra. Catra’s texts have been short for the past 2 weeks, mostly just centering around Finn’s needs with very little engagement otherwise. Finn’s frustrated that they can’t get Adora and Catra to talk and agree on a Halloween costume, since they insist on all three of them matching.

But no one is more pissed off with Adora than Adora Gray herself. She made Catra so uncomfortable. Catra’s been nothing but kind and amazing and Adora had to go fall in love with her like an absolute asshole and then try to sleep with her. Catra needs

someone dependable and consistent, not Adora behaving like a horny, lovestruck teenager, making everything awkward for her.

On the two occasions that they've seen each other in person since that day, Catra's been unusually reserved. Ears low, eyes sad. Adora's repeated both times, and also over text and in voicemails, that she's sorry. Catra's done the same. Beyond that, neither of them can seem to think of what to say to move forward except that they should talk. Which they haven't done.

Adora's genuinely considering not attending Catra's birthday this weekend. It would crush Catra, she knows, but it's probably better that she not show up and create an even bigger mess of things.

Glimmer somehow thinks this is the worst idea she's ever heard. She's not being sensible at all.

"You can't miss her birthday," Glimmer nearly screams. "You already rejected her *twice* while she was offering to have sex with you. You miss her party and you're sending a very clear message of 'no thanks'."

"How did you possibly come up with the idea that I rejected her twice?"

Adora must not be telling the story correctly if that's what Glimmer got from it.

"Uh, cause I actually listened to the words you were saying and I'm not a repressed jackass like you. Also, I may have talked to Catra about it a bit."

"You what?!"

Everyone in that section of the playground turns to look at them. If the talk about sex wasn't inappropriate enough, they're now causing a scene while they're supposed to be supervising Finn. Glimmer just dismissively waves the crowd's attention away.

“What did she say?” Adora asks, once she’s finally able to calm herself a bit.

“I’m not telling you that,” Glimmer replies. “You should talk to her.”

“I can’t talk to her. You know that. I’m horrified. I don’t even know what to say.”

“Maybe try behaving like a normal person and telling her how you feel. How you didn’t mean to shoot her down over and over again, you just are too gay to function or think clearly or read signs. How maybe she should try being less opaque herself.”

Adora sighs. “I don’t know what she wants.”

“You’re literally the only one doesn’t.”

“Glimmer, I don’t even know what I want.”

“I know, Adora. It’s frankly frustrating. Not a day goes by that I don’t wish I could slap some sense into you two.” Glimmer says this as if *she’s* the one suffering here. “She’ll be here soon. Should I just tell Catra that you’re in love with her and that’s your truly illogical reason for thinking you can’t be with her?”

“Glimmer Moon, I swear to the Gods, I will annihilate you.”

“Ooh, it’s not even my birthday yet,” Adora hears Catra say behind her. “What a thoughtful present.”

Glimmer and Adora turn to her. Catra’s wearing a charcoal suit, the crispest white button-down, and a very fake smile. She looks incredibly stressed. She and Adora just stare at each other for a long moment.

“Cat! Look!” Finn yells from across the playground.

They all glance over to find Finn swinging back and forth across the monkeybars at high speed.

“Be careful, Finny,” Adora yells back. She sees Catra roll her eyes at her caution.

Glimmer clears her throat awkwardly. “Well, I’m no longer needed here so I’ll be heading home now. See you on Saturday, Cat.” She moves closer to Adora and whispers, “ *Talk* .”

“Hey, Catra.”

“ *Hey* , Adora,” she hears quietly.

“We should…”

“Talk,” Catra finishes. “Yeah. Look, I’m sorry-”

“No, *I’m* sorry,” Adora interrupts.

“What the hell do you think you’re apologizing for exactly, Dor?”

Adora forces herself to keep going. “I pushed you too far.”

“No, dummy, I pushed you.”

“You asked if I was okay and I told you I was, Cat.”

“You didn’t actually *say* -”

She’s cut off by Finn rushing over to them. “Cat, did you ask about the costume?”

“No, kid, we’re a little busy.”

“But the store closes at 7, you said. They’re gonna sell out of everything!”

“What did you settle on, Finny?” Adora asks.

“I’m gonna be Audrey II!” they announce.

Adora looks to Catra who just shakes her head. This has clearly been a long conversation already.

“You have to be Audrey cause you have blonde hair. Cat’s gonna be Seymour.”

Finn launches into an impression of Audrey II, jumping around and singing. Catra appears to be forming a headache.

“You up for this?” she asks. “I gotta grab some stuff from that dumb Halloween store downtown so Perfuma can help pull something together for Finn. They have a very specific vision for both of us.”

It’s Finn’s first real Halloween. Of course Adora will do whatever they want.

“Yeah, definitely. Anything for you, Finny. Do you need me to come with?”

“No,” Finn answers quickly. “It’s a surprise.”

“You’re gonna hate it,” Catra deadpans. She’s smiling a little bit though, at least. “We do have to hurry though so Perfuma can get started. Let’s talk on the phone tomorrow night?”

Adora nods.

Catra and Adora don’t talk the next night. Not really. Finn’s too excited to quiet down, Catra’s obviously exhausted, and Adora still isn’t sure what to say. They have an awkward 10 minute conversation about work and Finn and hang up.

Glimmer’s birthday plan is in two parts. A trip to the family-friendly Crystal Castle, a monstrous arcade/bowling alley/lasertag complex full of sugared up kids and drunk adults, followed by a grownups-only outing to the closest gay bar. Against her better judgement, Adora agrees to go, mostly cause Finn personally calls to make sure they’ll see her there later.

The beginning part goes well enough, once Adora figures out that she can just use their friends to create a buffer between her, Catra, and the godsdamn leather jacket and super tight black

jeans Catra's wearing. Finn also helps by insisting that Adora explain their proposed trick-or-treating route and all of the logistics repeatedly until they're satisfied.

Once Sea Hawk takes Finn to a slumber party with a couple school mates though, Adora learns who her true friends are. For the ride to the bar, Bow, Glimmer, Perfuma, and Scorpia all scatter into one cab, leaving Adora with Catra and Entrapta. They somehow convince Entrapta to join some of the randos there so it's just the two of them in a silent cab ride.

It's not *completely* silent at least. They just run out of mundane things to say to each other since typically they speak every day. Adora fills space by sharing all the things that Finn is excited about, before they drift off and pretend to be very occupied with staring out of their respective windows.

Things don't go much better at the bar. Adora tries to give Catra space, only to be pushed back towards her at every turn. Glimmer makes them do shots together. Bow pulls them onto the dance floor together. Scorpia makes them take a selfie together. It feels like a global conspiracy.

The weird vibe starts to seep into everything. Everyone seems to be drinking just a bit too much, Adora included. Somewhere between her second shot and her third cocktail, Adora goes to the bathroom to throw some water on her face and sober up, only to literally run into Catra once again.

The hall outside of the single-stall restroom is narrow and Adora's spatial awareness is suspiciously low right now. She doesn't notice the other body coming out of the opposite door until she's accidentally slammed into it at full-speed.

Catra's quick enough to catch herself as she's nearly barreled down. Adora isn't so lucky and bounces off of the cat, toppeling face-first into a wall.

"Woah, Dor," Catra says, amused but cautious. "You okay?"

Adora giggles and then thinks about how giggling is such a weird sound. She manages to stand up straight though.

"Just overheated, I think." She tries a futile attempt at fanning herself with her hand. "Are you having fun?"

Catra forces a smile.

"Yeah, having a great time."

Adora nods.

"Great."

"Cool," then Catra starts to walk away. She stops suddenly and turns, a frown beginning to crack through. "Actually, I'm having an awful time. You haven't even said 'happy birthday' to me."

That sobers Adora up plenty.

"Shit. What the hell is wrong with me?"

She may have been so focused on surviving this party that she didn't actually say much of anything to the guest of honor.

"I'm so sorry, Cat. Happy birthday. I bought you a present."

"You didn't have to do that," Catra mumbles. Her tail is agitated behind her.

She *loves* gifts. If she's trying to turn one down, Catra must be basically inconsolable.

"I-" Adora stops to take a deep breath as the floor shifts just slightly.

Okay, maybe she isn't completely sober cause she has a strange impulse to say so many words to Catra. Too many words. All of the words.

“I had this whole plan for your birthday. I spent a month picking out the perfect place to take you to dinner last night. I was going to give you this gift. Then we would see a show cause you told me we needed to do more cultural stuff.”

“Why didn’t you do any of that?” Catra whispers.

“I screwed everything up so badly, I didn’t think you’d want to ever see me again.”

She can feel tears welling up in her eyes and see Catra’s starting to water in response.

“Dummy,” Catra says, voice breaking. “Did it occur to you that maybe you should have talked to me about any of that? I spent last night moping around the apartment, thinking you hated me. I’m sorry that I went too far that day. I-”

Adora interrupts, “No, I’m the on-”

“Shut. Up,” Catra says firmly. “Just listen, Dor. I didn’t mean to pressure you to do anything you weren’t comfortable with. I thought we were on the same page but we're not. And that's fine.” Her voice gets watery again. “You don't have to want me the way that I want you.”

Where would Catra ever get an absurd idea like that?

Well, *fine* . Probably from the many times that Adora ran away from conversations or pretended to not notice her advances and disappeared after nearly fucking her.

Obviously, Adora wants all sorts of things with Catra. Dating and cuddling and, fingers fucking crossed, *sex* . Really, everything. Catra’s the *only* person she’s wanted this with in a long time. Adora's also very anxious about voicing that. And the prospect of *having* any of this, and therefore opening herself up to the possibility of one day *losing it* , is nearly panic-inducing.

She doesn't know how to put any of this into words for Catra.

“That's not true. I do. I just-what if-and-”

Adora waves her hands around frantically, as if Catra can understand the weight of all her fears from one overdramatic gesture.

“Ugh. This is so frustrating.”

“Yeah, no shit,” Catra grumbles. There’s a hint of new bitterness in her voice that feels shocking.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

With a sigh, Adora pleads, “Just say it.”

“Fine,” Catra responds, throwing her hands up. “If you say you want this, then I believe you. Here’s what I think is stopping you – you have the most somehow overly inflated and yet simultaneously lowest sense of self. You keep panicking like the world's gonna end just cause you wanted to have sex.”

Adora quickly shoots back, “No, I think *our* world’s going to end cause I wanted to have sex *with you* .”

A throat clears right next to them. Adora turns to find three very impatient people standing in the bathroom line, staring at them as they block both doors. Well, two of them look impatient. The woman in the middle looks like she wishes she’d brought a snack to really hunker down and enjoy the show, eyes completely rapt in attention.

...fuck. Adora really hopes none of these people are here with their party. She hasn’t actually been paying much attention to the miscellaneous acquaintances and coworkers that Catra reluctantly invited.

Catra hisses at them all, which doesn’t really tell Adora if they're strangers or not. She probably mutters some curses too, just for

good measure, but the blonde can't quite hear as Catra grabs her hand and drags her further down the hall, closer to the bar area.

She releases Adora and then leans back against the wall, arching one eyebrow.

"So you *did* want to have sex with me?"

Adora looks at her incredulously. How is that all Catra heard? How was that not painfully apparent already?

"Yes! It would have taken literally *seconds* for you to finish me off!" she yells in exasperation.

Adora's surprised that she only sounds about half as desperate as she feels. Catra's face is trapped somewhere between shock and pure joy.

The human glances behind them nervously. The other people in the bathroom line are gone, except the middle woman, who's hovering nearby and pretending to text. Catra hisses again and she wisely rushes off back to the bar.

"Uh, I mean, yes. You wanted that too, right?"

Catra straightens up, making her face very serious.

"Oh, very much so," she says.

"Okay, good," Adora breathes out with a relieved sigh.

Some of the pressure in her chest loosens, just a bit. Unfortunately, the sudden flow of words isn't showing signs of stopping, no matter how much she keeps trying to hit the brakes.

"I thought I was the only one. I felt like I'd grown all these feelings for you at the most inappropriate time. I keep trying to do the right thi-"

“Dor, I haven’t exactly been subtle about how it’s mutual,” Catra cuts in.

“Fine,” Adora concedes. That’s basically what the consensus had been from everyone. “Maybe I was in denial. I'm sorry I’ve made things so...confusing. For a while, I thought we were building towards something and then everything fell apart and I guess, I’ve just been even more cautious since then. I’m sorry. Again.”

Catra’s eyes narrow to slits.

“Don't you dare apologize for moving at the pace that you need. I'm not going anywhere, Dor. We're not in a hurry.”

True but. “Do I *need* it, though? Moving slow – or I guess, not moving at all really – makes me feel safe. But, *you* always make me feel safe. Logically, I know that. I don't understand why I can't just believe it.”

“Yeah, that's not really how anxiety works,” Catra replies. “It doesn't give a single shit about logic. Like negotiating with a toddler.”

Adora stares at her for a moment, trying to understand how this fits together.

“...Have you had to do that at work?”

“Don’t be absurd, Dor.” She pauses, before adding, “The toddler had legal counsel.”

Adora laughs easily. She’s grateful for anything to lighten the heavy mood between then. Catra only allows the corner of her mouth to quirk up slightly.

“Sorry again for rushing you.”

Ugh. It feels like no two people have apologized to each other more than she and Catra have in the past couple weeks.

“I was a willing participant, Cat,” she offers. “...were you?”

The forwardness seems to catch Catra by surprise.

“Uh, yeah?” She takes a step closer to Adora. “I was willing.”

Adora closes the distance between them. For good measure, she maneuvers them so Catra is pressed against the wall. With less vodka in her system, she’d be more worried about personal space and also about how gross this wall probably is.

“I was...very willing,” she adds seriously. “Like super willing.”

Catra just laughs in response.

“Okay, I think we’re clear on that part, Dor. So...you wanted to keep going?”

“Still do, even. I didn’t know if you did.”

“I do. Still.”

“Great.”

“Great.”

Now Adora’s not sure what to do next with this information. Catra just raises an eyebrow, like she’s waiting for the next volley.

After a long moment, she seems to sense that Adora is struggling to respond.

“What do you need from me to make this easier? How can I help?”

Adora just shakes her head. Everything about that question is too overwhelming.

“You give me a lot, Dor. You can stand to take a little. To want something. I'm not gonna leave because you're a person and have needs.”

“It sounds dirty when you say it like that,” Adora mumbles.

“Well, some of your needs *are* dirty, aren't they?” Catra asks, pretending to be innocent.

Adora would like to protest and clarify that she is very rarely ever naughty.

But Catra continues, dropping her voice lower, “Like, you needed me to fuck you that day, didn't you?”

It kinda feels like the first time Adora ever heard her favorite band or the crashing of waves in the ocean. Like one of those moments you want to stop to enjoy and wonder how you’ve lived your whole life without this sound.

Oh, that last drink is definitely starting to catch up to her.

Catra pulls Adora closer by her belt loop, hand dropping to tease at her waistband.

“You needed me to get you off, right?”

Adora nods.

“You can say it,” Catra gently prompts.

Can she , though? Adora doesn't quite feel like she can get enough moisture in her mouth to open it right now. It's all kinda rushing much further below.

“Adora,” Catra drags her name out slowly. “Is this too much?”

She shakes her head no quickly.

“Tell me what you needed.”

“I needed you to touch me, Cat.” It barely carries over the bar sounds but Catra’s ears swivel to pick it up.

“Tell me where,” she encourages softly.

Instead of answering, Adora pushes Catra further against the wall. The last bit of her control is slipping away quickly. This is not how Adora had rehearsed this night at home. Must find some way to hold on.

Remembering back to the last time they were this close, she weaves one hand into Catra's hair and tugs firmly.

And just like that, Catra yields completely. She bares her neck, while her claws go to Adora's waist to pull the blonde in closer. It's a complete 180 and Adora has to allow herself to smirk, just a little, at how *eager* Catra is for her.

She takes in a deep breath for courage.

"I wanted to-"

"For fuck's sake, you idiots," Glimmer yells, startling this both. She's standing a couple feet away with her hands on her hips, watching them pressed closely together. "You only have two speeds. Complete tragedy or sexy tragedy. You figure this out yet?"

Adora lets Catra's hair go so she can glare at Glimmer, as Catra tries to smooth down her fluffed up tail.

"If you'd give us some fucking space, maybe, Sparkles!" Catra yells back.

"It's a party and you're bringing everyone down," Glimmer accuses. "I just bought another round."

Catra looks like she might claw Glimmer's face off.

"You can't wait five minutes?!"

"The ice is melting!"

"My Gods, Glimmer, talking was your idea! What the fuck do you want from us?!" Adora realizes that she was the one who yelled

that. It's really a wonder that this is the first time.

"Fuck, you're hot when you're angry," Catra whispers, her hands going to Adora's biceps.

"I'll go fight her right now," Adora promises.

"I'm already soaked. Now you're just being cruel," Catra responds. She leans up to kiss Adora on the cheek. "Fine. We'll finish this later in an appropriate venue?"

Adora nods, still thinking about getting her revenge on Glimmer.

"Yes. Maybe when we have a few uninterrupted hours."

" *A few* ?" Catra purrs, suggestively.

Adora freezes. She had meant for *talking* , obviously but Catra's grinning like she understood something very differently.

"Uh, yeah. It's been months," she replies. "You deserve my undivided attention." She pushes closer to Catra for extra emphasis.

"Is that so?"

Fuck. Adora was not prepared for follow-up questions.

Catra moves to scratch her hands along Adora's neck. That's more than enough encouragement.

"Um. I'd like to enjoy you. Over and over again until you can't take anymore." Her voice goes up a little at the end. Hopefully it sounds less like a question and more like a sexy tease or something.

"Careful, princess. I can take a lot."

"Either bang this out in the bathroom right now or come back to the bar!" Glimmer interrupts.

Catra growls, while Adora practically punches the wall in frustration. Honestly, if not for the threat of legionnaires' disease or something, Adora would consider it – feels like she should make the most of this sudden loss of common sense. Instead, she takes a deep breath and moves back a few steps before cupping Catra's cheek.

"Alright. Back to the party," Adora says.

Catra makes a very dissatisfied face.

"Hey. Thanks for not disappearing on me, Cat."

"Well, we didn't *both* need to completely freak out. And you called dibs so." Catra tilts her head to gently kiss Adora's palm.

"I know we need to finish this but. We okay now?" Catra asks, leaning back into the touch.

"Yeah, we're okay."

The next clear thought Adora has is that she's definitely not okay. Her head has never hurt this badly before. Actually, her whole body hurts. Something may have died in her mouth, probably of thirst because her tongue is so dry. Also, when did her bedroom get this bright?

It takes her awhile but she finally opens her eyes. She's not in her own bed. This bed is massive and soft. Catra's. Oddly, the person snoring next to her is Glimmer of all people and not Catra Morgan.

"Why?" is all that Adora can say.

The snoring stops.

"You're awake," Glimmer mumbles. "Good. Angle me off the side of the bed, will you? Just in case I puke, I'd still like the option of sleeping here."

" *I'm* sleeping here!" Adora groans. Her stomach feels terrible.

“Then angle me!”

She has to abandon Glimmer there to die alone. When Adora opens the bedroom door, Bow falls into the room, waking up frantically. It kinda looks like he was sleeping on the floor, up against the entryway. Odd choice.

“My Gods, is it morning?” he asks. “Am I alive?”

Adora steps over his body. She finds Perfuma in the guest bedroom, passed out. Entrapta’s half hanging off the couch in the living room. That just leaves Finn’s room. Adora tries opening the door a couple times but something heavy is blocking it.

Abandoning that task, she goes to make coffee. Something about the smell of it triggers a memory. Scorpia handing her a dark cocktail, coffee and something? Did they have coffee at midnight? Gods, did Adora stay out past *midnight* ?

Eventually, Glimmer manages to crawl to Bow and wake him up fully. Adora eats two raw eggs with her coffee. It’s gross but she’s convinced that it’ll help at least a little. She’d try literally anything.

There’s a loud thump in Finn’s room. Then Catra appears, wearing only the dark red shimmery camisole from last night and black bikini briefs, hair an embarrassing flyaway nightmare.

“You,” she says as soon as she sees Adora, “Are a maniac.”

“Me?!?” she screeches in response. Everyone within a 10-foot radius winces, Adora included, while Catra covers her ears. “No, I’m not responsible for this. I barely even remember most of last night.”

“You almost killed Entrapta.”

“ *Scorpia* almost killed Entrapta,” the blonde replies immediately. Some of last night might be secretly locked away, it appears. “ *You* almost killed me.”

“No one’s ever died of being too horny before,” Glimmer tells her.

The door to Finn’s room opens fully now and Scorpia tumbles out.

“Hi, buddies. I don’t like to tell people how to live their lives but. Please don’t *ever* do anything that you did last night *ever* again. *Please* .”

“Okay, someone help me out here,” Adora requests. “What happened?”

“Perfuma, my love?” Scorpia calls out. “Are you still here?”

“Unfortunately,” Perfuma says sweetly.

Catra finally enters the kitchen and all but shoves Adora out of the way.

“Why don’t you pour everyone some coffee? Maybe some water? I’ll make some breakfast. Migas sound fucking amazing right now.”

Adora nods. She thinks she can handle this. She only has to take two breaks to keep from vomiting.

Catra meanwhile starts cracking eggs and chopping tomatoes. This gives everyone time to slowly make their way into the living room, where they all sorta fling themselves into whatever soft surface they can reach. Scorpia is kind enough to fetch Catra some shorts.

Entrapta doesn’t wake up. Adora checks that she’s still breathing and once that’s confirmed, she leaves the poor woman alone.

“What the hell did we do to her?” Adora asks.

Catra sighs. “Glimmer, want to start from the top?”

"Ugh. No. But I'm not holding all this shame alone so I'll share some of the load with Adora." Glimmer takes a huge gulp of coffee. "First, you two were so awfully awkward." Bow just nods sadly. "But we did two rounds of shots and a couple drinks and you were...better."

"Maybe too good, even?" Scorpia says.

They were...friendly, Adora remembers.

"You were all over each other outside the bathroom," Glimmer tells her.

"No," Adora protests.

At least, at the time, it felt like they were just talking. Thinking back, they *were* standing very closely. And maybe Catra didn't kiss her cheek so much as grind her entire body onto Adora's repeatedly; it's possible they weren't flirting but really just slurring dirty words onto each other. That doesn't bode well for the rest of this story.

"The tension just took a very different turn," Perfuma appears out of nowhere to explain kindly. "But then there were more shots somehow. It was like a round robin. Catra was ordering drinks before we'd finished the ones Bow got us then Scorpia would do the same…"

"Then that awful cocktail came out of nowhere," Bow whines. "I can't even think about it without feeling sick. Coffee and red wine?"

Catra laughs from the kitchen. "Yeah, that was pure evil. I don't know who did that. Entrapta had *one* and she passed out immediately."

Adora glances at Entrapta, still hanging partially on the couch and partially on the floor.

"We got kicked out," Adora finishes.

Scorpia nods. “Yeah, places don’t take too kindly to having semi-conscious people in their drinking establishment. Plus, the bar was too big to keep an eye on her for long. We kept having to separate you two.”

“Yes, like a whirling dervish and a locomotive trying to get at each other.” Perfuma sighs loudly, trying to burrow herself in Scorpia’s lap.

Now that they mention it, Adora does vaguely remember that part. Confidence boosted by pure poison, she became convinced that she was suddenly smooth and stood a chance with Catra. They kept eye-fucking each other. Dancing way way too suggestively. Saying some...interesting and graphic things. Scorpia had to become their personal bodyguard to keep them from actually doing anything dumb.

“I’m so so sorry,” Adora says. Her face feels hot.

“Don’t act all innocent now,” Glimmer replies. “We know all of your dirty dirty thoughts.”

“You sound jealous, Sparkles,” Catra says, suddenly standing next to Adora.

“I sound scarred, Cat. I’ve heard things that can never be unheard. Very specific things.” She narrows her eyes at Adora, who attempts to hide behind a throw pillow. “And, my Gods, the things I’ve *seen* . It was enough to make even *me* blush.”

“Karaoke was a bad choice,” Bow whispers.

It couldn’t have been that bad. Karaoke’s cute. Singing! Camaraderie!

Except. Catra only sang one song. Something by Beyonce, maybe? Adora’s never claimed to really ‘get’ music so it was lost on her. There was a dance. More accurately, there was Catra straddled over her, dancing. Really, just grinding into Adora who definitely was working to give as good as she was getting. Adora

remembers the lyrics ‘peak’ and ‘fountain’ and ‘waterfall’ a lot though and…

“You called me Daddy,” she says dumbly, looking up at Catra.

Catra smirks. Her voice comes out very low and rough.

“Yeah? You like that?”

The whole room blushes, she notices. The dance was pretty *charged* , one could say.

“I can’t live like this,” Perfuma whispers.

“We’re good people,” Bow agrees. “We shouldn’t have to.”

More of the night slowly eases together for Adora. She and Catra deciding to go home together. Everyone else’s futile attempts at explaining what a bad idea that was. The group separating them once they reached the apartment. Catra sneaking off to whisper sweet, very filthy things to Adora until Scorpia and Bow were forced to barricade the doors with their bodies.

It was actually really cute. Gods bless their friends for not letting anything happen though. It would suck to not remember the first time she kissed Catra. Or worse, feel gross about it.

They’ll need to talk sometime during the harsh, sober light of day. But it was pretty clear, seemed like Catra wanted Adora too. She just needs to get her silly head to believe it.

“Aw,” Scorpia coos. “You look so happy, Adora. That’s great, buddy. I hope you had a good time last night. And Wildcat, I hope you had a good birthday.”

“The best,” Catra replies suggestively and reaches down to roughly run her hands through Adora’s hair. She turns on her heels, strutting away.

Scorpia stops cooing. They all look like they’ve seen some shit.

Perfuma rubs her eyes. Whether out of exhaustion or frustration, it's unclear.

"When the dam finally bursts, it's going to be...explosive," she says.

"Or a huge mess," Glimmer adds.

Adora can hear Catra purring all the way from the kitchen.

"You're *both* right," she calls out, voice brimming with chaotic excitement.

When Halloween hits 2 days later, Adora's pretty sure she's still hungover. At this point, she thinks she might just be hungover for the rest of her life, sick, irritable, and emotional.

Thankfully, it's a pretty low lift to get Finn into their costume and throw on the silly dress that Catra had bought her. The thing is made of a material that Catra herself wouldn't be caught dead in, some kind of polyester blend that's tight but not unbearable. It's leopard print, of course, and Adora wears a pair of flats and leaves her hair down to complete the Audrey look.

Catra puts on a sweater vest and corduroy pants with the shirt she's already wearing from work and spends most of the time where Adora's assisting Finn, trying to convince the blonde to put on some blush and red lipstick to really get into character.

The trouble comes when Finn is in costume. It's a cute felt one-piece venus fly trap that allows their head to peak out of the mouth. Unfortunately, Finn is a method actor, apparently, and remains fully in character all night. They scream 'feed me, Seymour' constantly, especially everytime a new house opens their doors. Most adults find it to be adorably precious. It gets old for Adora within about 5 minutes.

"I told you we should have smoked," Catra reminds her yet again. "It's legal and safe and honestly none of these other parents seem

sober. Rookie mistake on our part."

Being stoned in public, surrounded by children, with Finn to look after sounds like Adora's worst nightmare. She only ever tried pot in college and it made her super paranoid.

"Fine," Catra tries instead. "We'll just unwind later by having some wine and watching scary movies once they go to bed. You and those biceps can keep me safe." To illustrate her point, Catra tucks under Adora's arm.

She and Catra disagree over the appropriate amount of candy that Finn's allowed to eat. Adora thinks 5 or 6 pieces is reasonable. Catra's prepared to let Finn take the whole bag into their bed. Finn passes out from a sugar crash before they've settled this argument. This might have been Catra's plan all along.

They agree to watch one horror movie before Adora has to head home, and as promised, Catra spends the whole time in Adora's lap, purring and pretending to be scared. Adora actually does jump and startle the whole movie. This only serves to make Catra laugh at her each time.

"Maybe I should be holding you," Catra jokes. Neither of them moves though. "What character do you think you'd be in a horror movie?"

"The one that dies early," Adora answers, wincing as fake blood spews across the screen.

"No, you're strong and pure of heart. You're 'final girl' material."

Adora has no idea what that means.

"What about you? Rebel?" she asks, just taking a big swing.

"No, I'm the weird one that remembers the legend of the killer and tries to tell everyone how to get out alive. But none of those idiots listen and I don't make it to the end." She shakes her head sadly.

“You’re always a misunderstood genius,” Adora jokes, pretending to be sympathetic.

“Aww,” Catra says, pouring it on really thick. She all but shoves her head under Adora’s chin. “I like you the most.”

Then there’s a cheesy jump-scare and Adora yelps so hard that she nearly throws Catra onto the floor. Catra laughs until she has tears in her eyes.

Of course, they’ve spent the past several weeks talking *around* talking. Adora and Catra flirt and they tease and the leaves change color and die when the frost sets in and Adora’s pretty sure Glimmer’s going to strangle her while the world continues on around them.

Adora’s been mopey and maudlin all day.

Catra has plans tonight for dinner and drinks with an ex-girlfriend. It’s been years since they dated and Catra seems reluctant to go. But she felt bad since Cath, the ex, had always made it a point to see her each time she visited.

Adora
1:56pm
Catra and Cath?
Really?

Catra
1:56pm
Yes, it sounds like the worst lesbian comedy duo
I was 24
I didn’t know any better

Adora insists on taking Finn to her place, saying it was easier to take them hiking in the morning if they just slept over. Catra thinks that’s too kind but Adora is persistent. She takes Finn holiday shopping even though it's weeks away. They got excited

to see the shop displays as soon as Christmas stuff went up and Adora's committed to taking them to as many stores as possible.

It’s a nice distraction from how she's completely run everything into the ground. And set it on fire.

Adora’s given Catra the whole night to eat and talk and get drunk with someone she’s already had sex with. She even gave them a kid-free apartment. How *generous* .

Theoretically, Cath is probably doing a much better job than Adora. At least she has the guts to get a date.

Catra had asked Adora out. She'd been the one to initiate their tragic attempt at sex, only to be rejected. Adora knows the ball is in her court again. She just isn't entirely done thinking through every eventuality yet.

But they were getting somewhere, slowly but surely. They'd set up some boundaries. No...intimate contact until it had been discussed more fully.

And in her defense, it wasn’t just their dueling avoidant personalities to blame for everything. Catra had gotten busier at work and was possibly being considered for a promotion. Adora had taken up hiking on Saturday mornings and usually brought Finn along. It was time to start ramping up for year-end fundraising season. So they were both pretty busy.

Adora was working on the other pieces too, though. Getting used to the thought of Catra and her together. Used to the thought of being with anyone really. Researching what it’s like to date a single parent. She had even begun to go back to therapy. Just bi-weekly.

“I want to work on taking care of myself so I can take better care of Finn,” Adora explained to her therapist.

“I love some parts of that sentence. We're going to try reframing it a bit so it's Adora-centered, okay?”

It was still often boring and annoying and overly focused on the past, but it wasn’t too bad. They’d introduced the idea of homework, tasks for Adora to try to complete during the week. She was aware that her therapist was intentionally tapping into her need to get an A. These assignments were, of course, ungraded unfortunately, but Adora couldn't stop herself from trying anyway.

Honestly, a lot of what Perfuma and Bow had suggested showed up as exercises. But now Adora actually had an incentive to follow through. It helped that Catra was fully committed to being her cheerleader.

Adora's watching TV on the couch and writing out her homework, having given up on trying to actually fall asleep, when she gets a text notification. A picture.

It's Catra taking a selfie in her closet, oversized black and white striped button-down tucked into gray pleated trousers. She practically disappears into the material. Her hair, which had clearly previously been slicked down and straight, is just barely coming undone and falling into her bloodshot eyes.

Adora has to suppress a laugh. Catra definitely looks like a road-hardened lesbian stand-up comedian transplanted from 3 decades ago.

Adora
12:28am
Interesting choice
You look great

Catra
12:31am
Too much like what Cath and Catra would wear on stage?
Send me a pic back?
Pwease?

Adora grabs a second pillow to lie on while trying to remember Glimmer's extensive selfie tips. She makes sure to angle her hand under her head and flex her arm.

Catra
12:33am
Drool
You gave the kid the bed?
Sucker

Adora
12:33am
They jumped in and made a nest before I could stop them
I wasn't going to be a monster and make them move
Wonder who taught them that trick?

Catra
12:34am
I don't recall, counselor

A couple minutes later, Catra sends back a new picture. She's in bed now, curled up under the covers. Alone.

Adora
12:37am
Have fun tonight?

Catra
12:37am
It was fine
We got drinks
She told me about her work and shit
I talked about you and Finn
And we parted ways
We'll do it again in 5 years probably
Hopefully, I'll figure out the appropriate thing to wear to these by then
I was aiming for 'still hot but not interested'
Ended up at 'Lesbian Aunt Debbie' instead

Adora
12:40am
How are things between you two?

Catra
12:41am
Cordial?
She made me promise to bring you next time she's in town

Adora
12:43am
I thought that wouldn't be for another five years

Catra
12:43am
And?
You got plans or something?

She spends a long time trying to come up with what she hopes is a witty reply while unsuccessfully ignoring the butterflies in her stomach. When Catra goes and just plainly states that she sees a future for them, it really does wonders for Adora's nerves. It's easier to take a risk if it feels like, well, not much of a risk.

Catra
12:54am
It's too quiet here
The other cat child is grumpy and refuses to sleep in here
Ungrateful

Adora
12:54am
I know it's super late
But do you want to come over?

Her phone rings almost immediately.

"What is this fuckboi message you just sent me?" Catra asks her. She sounds mostly sleepy and amused but also a little buzzed.

“I’m vulnerable and all alone and you’re trying to take advantage of me?”

“I was just worried!”

“It’s one night. I’ll be fine. I just like complaining.” There’s rustling, like Catra’s shifting. “Now, pretend you’re trying to take advantage of me.”

“I would never and you know it,” Adora replies flatly.

“Tell me how you’d make me feel better if I came over.”

“Nope.”

“Especially my body.”

Adora hesitates there. She just kinda floats into a daydream about holding Catra in her arms...and other things that Catra might enjoy.

“Oh, you’re totally considering it,” Adora can definitely hear her smirking through the phone.

“Goodnight, Kitten.”

“Kitten? That definitely means you were considering it. Goodnight, Dor.”

Chapter End Notes

next chapter: lonnie enters the building! mara! people actually trying to get to the root of this!

Perfect Picture of Patience

Chapter Summary

Holidays with the family. Finally, some time to talk.

Chapter Notes

friday!! happy friday. may you have all the water and skincare products and rest that you desire. this is a thicc chapter (the thiccest in the series, i think) so thanks for sticking with it.

catra's musical vibes in this - "two weeks" by fka twigs and "waiting for you" by the aces, a group i know nothing about but that song floated into my life while i was working on this and it was so perfect.

warnings? uhh, catra and lonnie communicate largely through pretend(?) arguing. a baseless accusation that someone is a cult leader. useless lesbianism reaches a new high.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

At Lonnie's urging, they're forced to figure out Christmas plans pretty early. Neither Catra nor Adora seem to celebrate much but Finn gets excited and everyone crumbles under pressure. Instead of joining Bow or Glimmer and their family or sitting alone in her apartment, Adora will be co-hosting with Catra. Just them, Finn, Entrapta, Scorpia (who declined joining Perfuma's family for solstice or whatever they celebrate), Lonnie, and Adora's foster sister, Mara.

"I hate this plan," Catra whines repeatedly. "Let's go somewhere warm and bail on these losers."

"They're our only family."

"Your thing doesn't negate mine."

Catra plans dinner menus. Adora buys a tree. Scorpia and Finn decorate it. Entrapta pretends she doesn't understand any of this to get out of doing anything.

They have to pick Mara up from the airport. Apparently, Lonnie refuses to be in a car with Catra for that long so she offers to take a cab.

"We just need to make it 4 days without killing each other," Catra explains about her sister. "It'll be a real struggle."

Adora and Mara weren't exactly that close, which was probably a good thing, considering the Morgans. They'd only lived in the same home for 3 years before Mara aged out. She and Adora kept in contact, but this was the first time in years that she was available and wasn't dating someone that she wanted to spend the holidays with. She seems particularly excited to meet Catra and Finn. It makes the two of them anxious for some reason, both fidgeting the whole ride to the airport.

They insist on waiting outside of the car, which security orders them not to and Catra actively ignores. When Mara spots Adora and waves, the cats are both just stunned; Finn even stops asking their endless questions about air travel.

Mara exits the bag carousel area looking like she's moving in slo-mo. Long waist-length auburn hair flowing in the wind. Caramel skin and calming, easy smile somehow looking effervescent under the harsh lighting. Catra even likes her outfit, based on the ways her eyes fill with interest, though she'd previously complained about this same "Instagram boho-chic" style. Mara throws her arms around each of them one-on-one and does that intense thing she always has where she stares deeply into your eyes and makes you feel important and special. Finn and Catra practically fight for her attention the whole ride back.

Catra and Lonnie get into an argument as soon as Lonnie arrives two hours later. Over literally nothing. Catra defends some point from years ago, while Lonnie's having a separate debate on

another topic entirely. She manages to remove her suit and introduce herself to Adora and Mara at the same time. Somehow all it settles is which room Lonnie gets. She'll be staying with Finn, while they sleep in their room in their tent, instead of making Catra and Adora give up their room.

Lonnie pointedly calls it *'their* room'.

"I don't understand what just happened," Adora whispers.

"That's how we communicate in our family," Catra replies. "Wrong and strong."

She orders everyone to wash up for dinner and all but demands that they bring holiday cheer to the table. It feels a lot more like a punishment than a celebration.

Adora enters the kitchen tentatively. That's her first mistake. Catra can smell fear.

"What's your problem?" she asks, not turning away from the stove. She's actually watching a pot come to boil.

The blonde freezes. "Nothing. Literally nothing."

"Good," is all Catra says. Her tail's all over the place. She's making some kind of fancy roast and a bunch of sides, homemade rolls, two desserts. It's only Christmas Eve. Adora doesn't know how she expects to top this tomorrow. Or what they'll do with all the leftovers.

Adora doesn't usually initiate physical contact between the two of them. She's still worried about overstepping. Their conversations about what almost happened between them were all pretty vague, even after their drunken admissions of other things they'd very much like to do. It feels like Catra's being patient for everything except hugs and snuggling. Adora's still moving at the world's most cautious pace.

But Catra's shoulders are nearly up to her ears so she's obviously worried about something. Adora decides to come up behind Catra and wraps her arms around her waist, hoping she doesn't get clawed for her trouble.

Catra sighs into the hold, leaning back into Adora.

"What I do to deserve this?" she asks curiously, tail curling around Adora's thigh.

"Everything. Cooking. Letting me bring Mara."

"Well, she means a lot to you," Catra replies. "So she means a lot to me and the cub."

" *You* mean a lot to me." She tightens her arms around Catra. It's still a wonder how perfectly they fit together.

"Yeah? Tell me more."

Adora chuckles. "Do I not tell you enough?"

Catra shrugs, rolling her head onto Adora's shoulder so she can see her face. "I could stand to hear it more often," she says with a sly smile.

"I'm so lucky to have met you."

"And…?"

"And you're my–"

"Are they like this all the time?" Lonnie asks, not caring at all about interrupting the moment. Adora glances over and she's standing with Finn, who's bouncing with excitement and very close to tugging at her shirt for more attention.

"Yes!" the kid replies happily.

Lonnie shakes her head, very amused it seems.

“Catrina, you need help with anything?”

“No, *Lonetta* , I don’t,” Catra replies before moving out of Adora’s embrace.

“I’ll show you how the tv works!” Finn tells Lonnie, pulling her into the living room.

Now it’s Mara’s turn to suddenly appear. No one makes enough noise in this apartment.

Mara had claimed she was using the break to settle in and change into more comfy clothes. She still looks like a supermodel in a flowy shirt and tights. Why is she so godsdamn *tall* ?

“That kid’s so fucking cute,” she tells them. “They’ve already asked if they can hide in my suitcase and return with me, though. Is that a cry for help?”

Adora can’t help her smile.

“The concept of the airport is a bit too tempting for them. I’ll be sure to check for stowaways when you’re leaving.”

Mara glances past her to Catra.

“It smells amazing in here,” she says.

“Let’s hope it lives up to the hype,” Catra grumbles. She gives Mara a small smile, before frowning back at the stove.

Mara looks to Adora then, curious. Adora just shrugs. Maybe it’s the pressure of hosting that’s got Catra so tense. Adora gives her a scratch behind the ear, hoping that’ll help calm her. It works for about a second and then Catra’s moving to check on another dish.

“Mind if I borrow Dora?”

“Please,” Catra begs. “She’s hovering.”

“I’m trying to be supportive.”

“Gross,” Catra shoots back. But she reaches out and squeezes Adora’s hand as she leaves.

“I like her,” Mara says as soon as they enter the living room.

Finn is anxiously standing by as Lonnie flips through channels. Adora knows from experience that they will not hesitate to jump for the remote if they don’t like her choice of program. A cute but infuriating tendency they picked up from Catra.

“I thought you would,” Adora tells her sister. “The two of you are pretty similar actually. Fun and ridiculous and impulsive and honest.”

“Thank the Gods someone’s bringing some unruliness to your life. You could use it,” Mara returns.

“There’s nothing wrong with order.”

“There’s a lot wrong with *too much* order, and you know it.”

Adora sighs. It’s too early for them to get into a disagreement about the same topic that they always fight over. Besides, Catra and Lonnie are going to butt heads enough for everyone this week.

Solo holidays are so much easier. Adora could have gotten a lot of work done this weekend.

She realizes that thoughts like these are precisely what Mara means.

Instead, Adora asks her about work and her life and who she’s dating. Mara’s always happy to tell a million wild stories about her antics and all the people she meets as a reporter. She gets particularly excited sharing a tale about a recent story on some sort of comically convoluted pyramid scheme run by two elderly nuns. Eventually, even Finn and Lonnie start to listen in and the four of them have a nice time until dinner’s served.

Adora doesn't think that she's imagining how stressed Catra is. She's watching everyone pile up their plate like a hawk but hasn't touched the food herself. She keeps an eye on Lonnie, in particular.

Finn dives in first, mumbling 'is good' through a mouth of food.

"Stop embarrassing me in front of company," Catra flatly jokes to them.

"You taught me to eat like this!" They fling a pea at her with a giggle.

This distracts Catra away from staring down Lonnie so she misses her sister's first bite. Lonnie rolls her eyes at her initial taste of roast. Then groans. Then mutters a curse.

"Fuck you," she says to Catra, louder.

"Just say it's better. I know it is." Catra very much looks like she isn't going to back down.

"Why don't you ever leave well enough alone?"

"He doesn't know how to salt his food! I don't know why you married him!"

"I think we can eat now," Adora tells Mara, trying to let her voice carry over whatever ridiculous long-standing argument this is.

The food's amazing. Catra spends 20 minutes trying to convince Lonnie to admit it's better than Kyle's.

The only things Adora have learned about Kyle are that he's married to Lonnie (and Rogelio), he grew up with them, and Catra will prove her dominance over him, even if she has to murder Lonnie to do it. Finn finds this incredibly amusing, going so far as to stand in their chair to yell that Catra is better. She nearly cries in pride.

"Finny, table manners," Adora reminds them quietly. "Sit down please and don't yell. And don't tell me Catra's yelling. That's not an excuse." But she shoots Catra a look just for good measure.

Lonnie physically turns her body away from Catra to address Adora. The smile she gives is a bit frightening.

"Adora, I wasn't sure what you'd want for Christmas so Kyle and I made you an album of Catra's worst photos, from childhood to present."

"That's *exactly* what I wanted. Thank you." The blonde thinks she does a good job of selling her dramatic gratitude.

"That's not a funny joke," Catra deadpans. "She doesn't get humor so she doesn't know you're kidding. Don't take advantage of her."

Lonnie continues, like no one's spoken, "I can share a download link, just in case Cat destroys the physical version."

"I'm gonna shred every box under that fucking tree."

Finn, ever the opportunist, suggests, "I should open presents now."

"Santa hasn't come yet," Adora points out.

She never thought she'd be this kind of person but she's gotten weirdly invested in Finn maintaining belief in Santa Clause and several other fictional figures. Maybe she just wants them to maintain their childhood innocence. Maybe it's just fun to annoy Catra with it. Probably a bit of both.

Finn tips their head towards her with an intense look that's 100% Catra's 'you're full of shit' trademark.

"Maybe *she* should come early," they reply.

Catra gives Adora a smug smirk.

“Maybe we should shift topics. Mara,” Catra says with the nicest smile, “Tell us all of Adora’s most embarrassing moments and greatest fears.”

Finn and Lonnie smell blood in the water and also brighten up. Adora loves Mara but knows that she’s not to be trusted. It’s unfortunate that Scorpia isn’t coming over until tomorrow – Adora could use at least one person on her side.

Mara gets a wicked look in her eye when she smiles back. She leans in a little closer to Catra, who does the same. There’s actual chemistry between them, which has always been one of Adora’s most irrational fears. Women always like Mara. She’s just so much more exciting and interesting and confident and better-looking than Adora. Lonnie’s already kinda taken with Mara, how long before Catra is too? Gods, she feels like the dorky kid sister all over again.

Mara and Catra must mistake her face for embarrassment, rather than a lifetime of misdirected insecurities, cause they both back off.

“Don’t worry, Dora,” Mara says, slapping her shoulder. “I’m not gonna say anything too bad. You never really got up to many antics. You didn’t have friends to sneak out with or get into trouble. The most motrifying thing was probably how you dressed like the head of Young Business Leaders of Etheria for most of school.”

“Say more words,” Catra prompts, placing her elbow on the table so she can prop her head up and listen intently.

Mara laughs heartily at the memory. It’s just such a free, unencumbered sound and Catra’s face lights up.

“She wore, like, old lady blouses and little khakis everyday. Our school didn’t even have a dress code! Adora was so lucky that she got into sports and had an excuse to wear uniforms and the letterman and gym clothes.”

“The letterman,” Catra purrs.

“The one that disappeared?” Adora asks her accusingly. Catra just shrugs and winks.

Then she turns back to Mara. “Did she manage to catch any girls in that?”

“Any besides *you* , you mean?” Lonnie mutters.

Mara laughs. “Never any girls. Hope would have *combusted* . Our foster mother's such a deeply repressed old sea dyke. She never let herself date so Adora, her favorite, was definitely not allowed to. Couldn’t be ‘distracted.’ So many girls were left heartbroken because of that.”

“They were not. I couldn’t even get a prom date,” Adora argues.

“Did you *try* ?” Catra asks, tilting her head.

No, but that’s irrelevant to the point. No one in high school paid attention to Adora in that way. And Mara’s flattening so many more nuanced things about Hope. She’s just wrong about all of this.

“You were a godsdamn *heartthrob* , Dora,” Mara replies, smiling fondly at her. “Captain of multiple sports, straight A student, valedictorian, president of several clubs, committed to saving the world. Girls lost their minds over you. You just never noticed cause you were too oblivious and too focused on being the best. Part of your never-ending quest for Hope’s love and approval.”

“So many things make sense now,” Catra whispers, voice full of wonder.

Adora doesn’t like that at all.

Mara looks between Catra and Adora, sitting closely together, both picking at the food on Adora’s plate. She looks really happy to see her little sister like this.

“Catra, you’re the first girlfriend of Adora’s that she’s ever even *talked* about more than once, let alone let me meet.”

Right. Adora forgot the worst thing about Mara is if you have something you don’t want said, she’ll find a way to say it. Publicly. And can pull it off by just giving that ‘oh, I’m so charming. I’m sure you’ll forgive me’ smile. Mara came to visit her once in college and Adora made a list of all the things she wasn’t allowed to repeat in front of Bow and Glimmer. This was an unfortunate oversight for this trip.

The air at the table changes so quickly that even Finn notices it. Catra buries herself back into her empty plate suddenly. Lonnie pretends to be paying attention to the younger cat, who looks like they’re thinking of how to cheer Catra up. Adora works on making herself invisible. Trying to turn into a tree won’t solve this, she’s got to disappear completely.

Mara just tsks.

“Adora, what did you forget to tell me?”

Adora’s working on not moving so no one can see her. That works with aliens in the old 80s movies that Catra makes her watch, right? This dinner feels about as unsafe.

Pouting, Finn answers her. “They aren't girlfriends. They're just sleeping together.”

Lonnie laughs so hard that Adora thinks she might be having trouble breathing. It’s pretty clear now that Catra tells Lonnie a lot more than she thought originally.

Catra glances over at Adora, who is still invisible probably. She rolls her eyes at being abandoned at the table like this.

“We don't need your help, bud. Mara, they mean we literally have sleepovers just to take care of this tiny terror.”

Catra looks to Adora for help again.

Very quietly, “I never said we were...anything specific,” Adora admits.

Mara snorts. “No, you just described an extremely intimate relationship and I made my own conclusions. So what’s the deal?”

Adora can feel Catra’s eyes on her still. This isn’t helping. Performance anxiety or something.

“Gods, Dora. Still better with facts than feelings.” Mara’s laughing. No one else is.

“Can we talk about this later please?” Adora pleads.

She shoots her eyes at Finn, hoping her sister gets the message. Finn definitely seems to.

“Stop leaving me out!” They cross their arms and pout. They have a very bad influence in their life now.

“They're right,” said bad influence agrees, also crossing her arms. “If every other idiot in our life feels like they should be involved, Finn gets to be too.”

Lonnie isn’t going to miss an opening like that. “I think they're married and don't know it. They're best friends, co-parenting, and they don't have sex. That's basically a 10-year marriage.”

A very quiet growl rolls out of Catra. Lonnie could not be more thrilled at that.

“You married Girl Kyle. And you’re not having sex with her. It’s like the thing Kyle is surprisingly best at.”

Catra narrows her eyes.

“I’m gonna choke you out with your own hair.”

Adora steers away from the impending fight to beg, “Can we stop saying ‘sex’ around Finn please?”

Finn is very proud to announce, "I know what sex is. Cat told me."

Adora turns to Catra, very disappointed. The two of them had not yet settled this argument. Catra thought they weren't doing anyone any favors by making sex and other topics that Adora viewed were too mature for Finn seem so taboo. Adora thought more gradual steps and intentional planning was needed.

Mara smiles like she knows a secret. "I'm sure she can tell you too if you want, Dora."

Both Lonnie and Mara get a real good laugh out of that.

After Adora's put everything away, loaded up the dishwasher, and made sure everyone's comfortable in their room, she finally retires to bed. Catra's been there for an hour at least and Adora finds her curled up in a ball, seeming half-asleep.

She goes through her nighttime routine and slides in behind Catra. They've been trying to limit sleepovers cause of the...tension...but this week is going to be full of them. Adora had a gameplan – leave plenty of space between them, communicate if Catra wants to do anything, and take a melatonin if her gay panic kept her up all night. Adora leaves some distance between them but prepares herself for Catra's next move.

Catra just sighs, sounding deeply exhausted, and turns off the lights.

"Goodnight, Adora."

Something in her voice is a little concerning. Steps 1 and 2 of the gameplan are immediately abandoned. Adora puts an arm around Catra.

"This okay?"

When Catra nods, Adora wraps both arms around her and pulls her as close as possible. Catra's sigh comes out a lot more content. Still very tired though.

"You've been friendly today," Catra notes with what sounds like a smile.

"Is that alright?"

"I love it," she whispers, purring quietly. "Your arm's gonna fall asleep though."

"I have to get up in a while to put the presents out anyway. I'll try not to wake you up. How are you feeling?"

"Just sleepy. The cub's gonna be up at the crack of dawn tomorrow, aren't they?"

Adora chuckles. "I'd be surprised if they go to sleep at all. Probably setting a trap to catch me and demand gifts right now."

"I put yours in the closet with all of Finn's. Can you put them under the tree too?"

She nods. "Is one of them my jacket?"

"I don't know how many times I have to tell you that I don't know where that disappeared to, Dor. I'm glad you brought Mara. She's a fucking trip."

Yes, that's one way to describe Mara.

"She drives you crazy, doesn't she?" Catra chuckles.

With a grimace, Adora asks, "Is it that obvious?"

"You've been on edge all day."

That's probably true. It's not just Mara. It's everything – keeping everyone happy, figuring out how to be around Catra in front of a

new audience, trying not to think about how it would be nice if this all happened every year from now on.

“Holidays are stressful.”

“That they are,” Catra agrees. “You’re cuter than her.”

Adora tries to shush her.

“She’s too tall. And wispy. And who grows their hair that long? Honestly, between that and how weirdly serene and charismatic she is, I wouldn’t be surprised if she was a secret cult leader,” Catra pretends to rant.

Adora tightens her hold.

“Hmm,” Catra hums until it grows into a purr. “You want me to say more rude things?”

“No, that was plenty,” she replies, greatly amused and also embarrassed for needing this reassurance. “Thank you.”

“No problem. Trust me. I’m very familiar with kid sister syndrome.”

“I thought you were the oldest of most of the folks you grew up with?” Adora asks.

“Don’t sass me,” Catra says quickly.

She’s quiet for a couple minutes before she says plainly, “I don’t want us to raise Finn the way we were raised. Do you?”

Adora knows Catra’s only partially talking about how truly awful things were with Weaver. Mara’s words about Hope must be floating around in her head too now. Things were complicated with her growing up. Not all bad. Just not necessarily anything she’d like to pass down to Finn.

“No,” Adora finally answers after a long pause. “I really don’t.”

Almost exactly two hours later, Adora's slipping out of bed, trying not to jostle Catra too much. She was right, the blonde's arm is completely asleep. Small price to pay.

As quietly as possible, Adora loads her arms full of presents and sneaks out of the room. She checks the hall thoroughly and hopes against hope that the presence of Lonnie in their room means Finn won't just jump out screaming. She successfully makes two trips from the room to the tree like this, only thinking a dozen times that Catra and their friends went way overboard buying presents for the kid.

On the third trip back to the hiding spot, there's a flash of light in the hall and Adora throws herself against the wall to avoid detection. The good news is that it's not Finn's room. The not *bad* necessarily, but just more *complicated* , news is that it's the guest room. Mara is standing in the doorway like Adora would expect. But she's looking pretty disheveled. And she's kissing an equally disheveled-looking Lonnie goodnight. Adora doesn't need Catra's sense of smell to detect that they reek of each other.

She thinks of Catra's words, 'plausible deniability', and gently turns around to sneak back into her room and convince herself she never witnessed anything. Lying to herself is one of Adora's superpowers.

"Shit," Mara whispers. "Hey, Dora."

Lonnie is wise enough to just nod at Adora and creep into Finn's room to sleep. She looks very unconcerned about this, considering that she's the one who's married here. When she's gone, Adora shoots a disapproving look Mara's way before attempting to leave.

"Chill out," Mara scoffs with a smile. "I know what you're thinking. Her marriage is completely poly. We talked about the rules. I have no intention of asking her to overstep them. We're both reasonable adults. If whatever you and Catra are doing continues and we have to see each other, we'll be cool."

Adora moves a little closer so she can whisper. “I just don’t want anyone to get hurt.”

“We had some fun. It's not a big deal.” More pointedly, she adds, “It's fine to want things and to be happy, Adora. It’s not selfish if you want something for yourself – the world won’t end, everyone won’t hate you, your mission won’t suffer.”

Adora’s not sure when this stopped being about Mara’s devil-may-care choices and an analysis of her lifelong deepest fears. She just wanted to have a nice enough holiday.

“Hey, I know you probably don’t see it, kid. But Catra looks at you like she’s never seen a more amazing sight before. Don’t fuck this up. For you or her or Finn.”

“That’s what I’m worried about, Mara.”

Mara’s eyes soften. She leans her head against the doorframe and regards Adora for a long moment.

“Want to chat about it?”

“No, it’s late. Thanks for the offer, though.” Adora tries to give an encouraging smile.

“Have you tried talking to Catra about it?”

“A little,” she says with a nod. “It’s hard. I can’t seem to find the right words.”

“It’s never going to be perfect, Dora. Just say how you feel.”

Adora tries to argue but Mara jumps in to cut her off.

“Don’t say you don’t know how you feel. You do. I know it’s locked in there – don’t listen to all that other shit in your head, your doubts, what you’ve been taught. Do you really want to be alone and full of regrets, like Hope?”

That's not really something Adora wants to be reminded of. She tries not to think of it often if she can help it.

Hope had once dated briefly. Or Hope's version of dating, which probably actually was just allowing their neighbor, Razz, to follow her on errands and fishing while Hope vacillated between lecturing endlessly and complete, stony silence. It lasted a year or so after Adora arrived at the home. Razz was weird and sweet and baked-

“Shit. Is Bow right? Are we stuck in a time loop?” Adora quietly asks herself.

Mara looks confused but doesn't question it.

One day, Razz was just gone. All Hope ever said was that she'd let herself get distracted. And she'd never make that mistake again. She drilled that into Adora after that. All that mattered was clarity in your purpose. You had to let go of anything that impacted your focus.

“Glimmer said this thing when she and Bow were thinking of getting together. When the stakes are already high like this, if you fuck things up, you don’t get a second try.”

Mara all but rolls her eyes with a slight smile. “The mistake would be not telling her how you feel. And *soon* , before it’s too late. Glimmer and Bow really should be viewed as a cautionary tale instead of a model.”

Adora snorts. It *is* still pretty funny to think of her two best friends dancing around each other for years but having the *nerve* to be frustrated with Adora and her cautious approach to this whole situation.

“You’re the strongest person I know, Dora,” Mara tells her. More to herself, she adds, “And I was once embedded with a warlord. You’re so worthy of love. You can’t keep letting old fears hold you back.”

“It’s more complicated than that, Mara.”

Adora’s prepared to launch into a long, very well thought-out argument about the pros and cons of changing her relationship with Catra when Mara replies quickly.

“It always is and yet it isn’t.”

“That’s awful,” rouses Adora from sleep. It’s not a voice she’s very familiar with or expects.

“Fuck are you talking about? This dress is gorgeous.” That’s definitely Catra’s voice.

Adora wakes up enough to remember that she’s in Catra’s bed. They’d had a long Christmas the day before. Finn woke the entire apartment up horribly early, which ended up just being torture for everyone since they weren’t allowed to open presents until Scorpia and Entrapta came over that afternoon.

It was the nicest holiday that Adora had ever experienced since Finn’s excitement was contagious for everyone. Catra almost cried. Adora definitely did. They spent a lot of time playing games and eating. Adora was wiped out by the evening and she and Catra retired to bed early.

Still exhausted, she wasn’t in a hurry to get up this morning. Cracking one eye, Adora glances around the room and notices that the closet light is on. Explains where the voices are coming from. She wills herself to drift back to sleep.

“Girl, shame on you for trying to trick me into taking this ugly ass dress.” That sounds like Lonnie, Adora realizes. “You didn’t even take the tags off. You hate it.”

“Ugh, fine,” Catra replies. “It looked good on the mannequin and I forgot to return it once I saw how unfuckable it made me look. Toss it in the corner and I’ll give it to Glimmer.”

“That the ex? Your current girl’s best friend?”

Adora nearly jolts awake at hearing Lonnie refer to her as Catra’s ‘girl.’ She takes a quiet breath to stay calm. Be cool. Just an invisible tree sleeping here.

Catra scoffs. “We barely dated.”

“Adora doesn’t mind?”

“Again, we barely dated. Glimmer met the love of her life. Everyone got what they wanted.”

“You met yours?” Lonnie drawls.

Adora can confirm that she’s now never been more awake. They’re both silent for a long moment.

“You can take pretty much every one of these shirts from here on back,” Catra says instead of answering.

“What about that letterman?”

“You never saw that,” Catra threatens quickly. “Don’t you dare tell anyone any different.”

Lonnie just laughs. “Damn! You sleep next to it when she’s not around? You sniff it while you touch your-”

“Fuck off! Also, quiet down or you’re gonna wake her.”

Even Adora’s a little surprised that Catra just lofted that one over the plate.

“You wear her out last night?” Lonnie taunts immediately.

There’s a sound that’s probably Catra hitting Lonnie and then Lonnie hitting her back.

“You want these clothes or no?” Catra whispers, exasperated.

“Duh. I already prepaid to check an extra bag on my return flight. This ain’t amateur hour. Just load me up.”

They shuffle around in the closet longer and Adora starts to nap again.

“Listen,” she hears Lonnie say with a sigh. Catra grunts in response, clearly already displeased. “You know I know about unconventional relationships. I still have to put up with ignorant ass questions when I introduce Rogelio *and* Kyle. In my experience, all that matters is knowing who you are to each other and communicating. And y’all *definitely* need to work on both of those things.”

“I knew this was a trap. You’ve never been nice to me just because.”

“I’m trying to help you get your life together,” Lonnie responds. “Be more grateful. The kid’s almost ready. You’ve got the whole day.”

“You seriously don’t mind? They’re kind’ve a lot.”

“I kept you alive for 11 years. I think I can keep them alive for 8 hours.”

Catra pushes. “And Mara? You okay entertaining a stranger for that long?”

Lonnie pauses. “I think we’ll manage.”

“My Gods, did you already fuck?!”

Lonnie sounds pretty pleased with herself. “Oh, a couple times. Cat, she-”

“Nope!” Catra interrupts. “I’m not gonna stand here and listen to you describe how you’re having sex in my house when I’m not. Go brag to Rogelio. You gonna be able to behave yourself today?”

“We’ll be the world’s greatest aunts or whatever.”

When Adora wakes up next, Catra is nestled in bed next to her. Adora kinda goes from unconscious to immediately fully alert sometimes, which Glimmer told her was creepy when they were roommates, so she’s able to catch Catra staring at her.

Catra pretends to stretch to hide the blush that’s coloring beneath the fur on her cheeks.

“Morning,” Adora whispers.

“Morning,” Catra mumbles. She’s on top of the covers, which is odd. “I made you breakfast if you’re hungry. Coffee too.”

Adora nods and Catra moves a tray from the nightstand to the bed, letting Adora sit up to accommodate it. It’s just oatmeal, fruit, and a green smoothie but Adora fucking loves breakfast so she’s very grateful.

Catra leans back against the headboard next to her to watch her eat.

“Did you have plans for today?”

Adora shakes her head, chugging down the smoothie. She can just barely see Catra grimace over the mouth of the glass. She hopes it’s about the liquified food and not anything Adora vaguely remembers Lonnie saying.

“Did you?”

Catra looks into her lap with a sigh. “Mara and Lonnie took Finn out. They won’t be back til later. Said they wanted to give us time to...chat.”

Instead of answering, Adora cowardly digs into the oatmeal.

“We don’t have to,” Catra adds. “We can go out and do something if you want. Sight-seeing, after-holiday sales, ritualistic sacrifice,

whatever."

"All equally appealing," Adora replies with a smile. It takes her a minute of worrying but eventually she does admit, "I want to talk."

Neither of them starts. Adora continues to use food as a distraction but she's not a very slow eater so she knows that's doomed to fail. Catra examines her hands, Adora's hands, and then just about every other item in the room one-by-one.

Adora's not even sure where to begin. It's been a long road to this place, with so many miscommunications, non-communications, promises made and mostly kept, and processing that kept starting and stalling and never quite getting going.

There's no excuses left, nowhere else to hide as the heavy silence lingers in the air between them.

"Why did you date Glimmer?" someone blurts out. Adora realizes that was her voice.

Catra looks as startled as she feels.

"O...kay," she says slowly. It's oddly comforting to see Catra off her game for once. "I wasn't expecting that. Uh, I was attracted to Glimmer. I mean, I was attracted to you both. *Am* attracted to *you* . You shot me down that night so I didn't think it mattered."

Adora furrows her brow.

"You said you only wanted to hit on *her* ."

With a laugh, Catra replies, "Yeah, you had just rejected me. Was I still supposed to tell you that you looked miserable and ask if fucking me through the mattress would brighten your birthday?"

Adora is gobsmacked. She's never used that word before but it seems like the only appropriate way to describe how her jaw drops and she nearly lets her coffee mug slip from her fingers.

Catra's always been the smarter of the two of them so she gently moves the tray back to the nightstand, untangling the cup from Adora's fingers to set it down as well.

"Is that the line you were going to use?"

"I thought it would be bold enough to catch your attention," Catra says, tilting her head and smirking.

She's not wrong about that.

"I thought I wasn't your type," Adora mutters.

She gets an eye roll in response.

"Again, had just gotten rejected. I wasn't gonna give you that satisfaction. I have a lot of types. Besides, I still asked you out and you ignored me. For weeks, by the way."

"Why did you even hit on me in the first place?" Adora feels like she's whining. She has no reason to but she admits that that's maybe how her voice sounds right now.

"Cause I think you're gorgeous and smart and funny, duh. I only tell you all the time."

That's...well, that is true.

But, "I-." She stumbles.

For once, Adora doesn't actually have a rebuttal.

Catra wanted to take her home. Adora cut her off at the knees. Catra went for Glimmer, which Adora thought was fine and obviously spent a few weeks dreading. And then she and Catra became such close friends that ideas of wanting more seemed too selfish. So, after several minutes of doing too much mental math way too early, Adora realizes that this is literally all her fault.

This must show on her face cause Catra begins to laugh.

“You're such an idiot.”

Adora sighs, leaning even further back against the headboard.

“Yeah, I know.” That’s basically what Glimmer’s been telling her for months anyway. “This whole time?”

Catra nods.

“At first, I thought I could just be your friend. That lasted maybe three whole weeks. You just...were so unexpected, I guess. I ended up being actually glad that I didn’t go home with you and have some one-time thing. I kept just wanting to be around you, learn more about you. Be wherever you are.”

Catra relaxes a bit more against the headboard, gazing closely at Adora before continuing.

“In fairness, I was collosally dumb, too. At literally any point, I could have said ‘Hey, I like you. Want to introduce kissing and fucking to this mess?’ I thought I was being patient and moving at your pace but it’s been pointed out to me repeatedly that I was just as fucking terrified as you seem to be.”

She smirks, making fun of herself, while Adora just tries to take this all in.

Nearly a year of figuring out how much she wanted Catra, that could have been avoided by accepting just once when she extended a date. It wouldn’t have been the end of the world, like Mara said. Just a casual date with the most amazing woman she’s ever met. But coffee or drinks and maybe some kissing. Things that, in hindsight, feel like they could have been manageable if they evolved into a romantic relationship.

Manageable compared to *now* , where the path that they’ve gone down makes a romantic relationship feel like there’s so much more to lose if it doesn’t work out. Their friendship. *Finn* .

“What are you thinking about?” Catra asks softly.

“What if we met earlier? Or better, when we were younger?”

Catra shakes her head oddly.

“I would have been scared as all hell of you when I was younger, Dor. I would have just taken off. I couldn't have handled the idea that...I could love someone so much.”

Oh.

Adora’s *dreaming* .

This is all fine cause Adora is still asleep and dreaming. Maybe if Catra said she was *interested* , this could be true. But only Adora’s overactive imagination could think up that Catra Fucking Morgan would be *in love* with her.

“Dor?” Catra asks, voice breaking.

Adora’s never really had much of an imagination, even when she was a kid. This is somehow real life.

This is real life. And Adora’s watching Catra’s heart break, face contorting from hesitation to remorse and shame in real time.

“Gods, did I fuck this up aga-”

“I love you,” falls very quickly from Adora’s lips. Not quick enough, but close.

“And?”

“ *And* ?” Adora repeats. Oh, Gods. Is there more?

“Dor. *Please* . I’ve been in love with you for months now. I thought the only way you could love me is what we had. And I was fine with loving you however I could have you.”

She pauses to take a steadying breath.

"In my wildest dreams, though? There's…I can't believe *I'm* going to say this, of all people, but there's *romance* . Sex. You tell me how you feel about me. You tell other people. And I can tell you how I feel about you, without worrying that it'll send you into a spiral. You tell me what you *want* ."

Catra moves a little further away from Adora. She's practically pleading but looks like she's trying to hold herself back from it.

"If you don't want that – if you don't want *me* , or you're aromantic, or you just really enjoy the way things have been, I get that. I still love you and it's fine to tell me that. But I kinda need you to tell me *something* ."

Adora nods. She understands that. Catra isn't asking for anything except to hear what Adora wants.

"Are you sure?" she asks for some reason, continuing to be an idiot.

Catra's face says that she agrees with Adora's assessment of herself.

"Uh...which part?"

"Cat, there's a thousand reasons why you could never want me."

Catra growls, offended almost, "Why the fuck not?"

Adora just shrugs. She's embarrassed enough with how poorly this is all going. She doesn't really want to derail by listing out all the ways that Catra is a goddess descended to Etheria, while Adora is an overly anxious robot-tree hybrid that hasn't had a romantic relationship that lasted more than 3 months.

"Adora, do you think I need you?" Catra gives her a hard look, daring her to lie or avoid the question.

It's an easy question, fortunately.

“No, not at all.”

Even with Finn, Adora’s assistance is helpful but not necessary. When she wants to be, Catra’s even more high-functioning than Adora, which is really saying a lot.

“Good. That's why I love you.”

“I-. What?”

“Look, I don’t know if it’s a cat thing or cause I was always a little smaller or any of the other shit I grew up with, whatever. People have always acted like I needed someone to take care of me.”

Adora snorts, thinking of how ludicrous that is.

She replies, “You definitely don’t. You’re the most self-sufficient person I know. I mean, you can trick people into doing pretty much anything you want them to if need be.”

“See!” Catra shouts, like she’s proving a point to an invisible spectator. “You get me. You’re not trying to fix me or complete me or save me. You just take me as I am.” Her eyes, for the first time, threaten to water. “Do you know what an amazingly special thing that is to find?”

Huh. She does love Catra like that. Every quirk, every silly little rant, every eccentricity. Adora can’t imagine having her any way except exactly the way she is.

It’s similar for her, too, Adora realizes. One of her favorite things about Catra, while there are so so many, is that she’s never tried to change or really push Adora. She challenges the blonde but for the most part, Catra just supports her. She’s poured so many hours into LAP just because she wanted to help Adora. Be around Adora. Make her happy. No expectations beyond that.

Adora watches Catra give her a slow onceover from head to toe.

"And you? I mean, I tell you everything I love about you all the time, Dor. What was it you said to me early on? You're an acquired taste? Well, I acquired it. And I want it all the time. So fucking much."

The way her voice goes lower towards the end makes Adora's stomach clench.

Voice sounding breathless, she asks, "Can I…"

Adora hadn't really planned out what she was going to request. Or, rather, she *had* but it was skipping several steps, likely spurred on by Catra's casual mentions of mattresses and being fucked through them.

Catra's tail begins a slow, steady thump on the bed behind her.

"Mmm?"

Adora's gut tells her to fake a phone call.

"I want to kiss you," she says.

"Where?" Catra asks coyly. But Adora notices that her eyes dilate, the blacks pushing more of the vivid colors out.

Adora's gut suggests remembering that she left the stove on.

"I didn't know I had options," she whispers.

"Oh, Dor. There's always options." Catra's voice reminds her of the first night they video chatted. The night Catra called her a 'good girl' and began Adora's struggle to not think of that sound every time she's gotten herself off since then.

Say you're sick.

"Everywhere," Adora replies.

Catra trills. She starts to squirm a little, like she wants to move but can't. Adora knows the feeling. She's glued to her spot on the

bed, body feeling like it's made of concrete suddenly.

"When?" she asks.

Forever. Actually, say that and scare her off.

"All the fucking time, Kitten. Now?"

There's a slow smile but no rebuttal. Like Catra's waiting on Adora to make good on that promise.

When Adora doesn't move after a minute or so, that smile grows into a teasing smirk.

"Any day now, Adora. Wow, you're really the perfect picture of patience, aren't you? What would it take to make you lose control?"

This, of all things, is not a competition between them, Adora reminds herself. Except everything's a competition to Catra. So it's hard to stop herself from raising an eyebrow in challenge.

"Do you want me to?"

She wonders if Catra notices that she's biting her own lip, fangs peaking out.

"So badly, Dor."

Ignoring all of her usual instincts of self-preservation, Adora moves quickly. She grabs Catra around the waist and draws her closer, an unnecessary show of strength that she knows will drive the woman absolutely wild. This is confirmed by the pleased purr she hears before lowering them both to the bed. Adora places her forearms on both sides of Catra's head, pinning her in.

To be honest, she expected a bit of a fight. Instead, Catra immediately extends both arms above her submissively.

Adora takes the hint, as unsubtle as it is. She slowly reaches up with one hand and takes both wrists, holding Catra down.

"This okay?" she whispers.

"Mh hmm. The-" Catra stops with a grin. Another challenge. "Nevermind."

Adora can't help taking the bait. "What?"

"I was going to say there's restraints under the bed. But I think that might be a little much for your first time."

She's definitely tempted. But –

"... *our* first time, right?"

"Yours," Catra replies, like a little shit.

"Catra," Adora starts, already exasperated, "do you seriously think I'm a virgin?"

She just shrugs. "I don't have any evidence to the contrary."

"I've had sex before," Adora deadpans, very unamused.

"Quit bragging."

Okay, this has gone on long enough.

Without any more preamble, Adora dives into kissing Catra, tightening her grip on the wrists in her hand.

She's never kissed anyone like this before, like she could actually steal the breath from Catra's lungs and stun her completely. The kiss is firm and unhurried, Adora taking her time to get used to, and then very much *enjoy* , how different and intense the sensation of Catra's teeth and tongue are.

Adora pulls back earlier than she wants to, when a realization hits her.

“I played right into that, didn’t I?”

“I wasn’t mad that my evil plan worked,” Catra says, pleased. With pride, Adora notes that it takes her a short while to reply for once and she still looks a little bit dazed.

“Are you going to be a brat the whole time?” she tightens her grip again as a warning.

“I’ve been holding back for months, so yes.”

“Good.”

And Adora captures Catra’s lips again, determined to stop holding back as well.

Chapter End Notes

> lips have touched other lips! it only took 18 chapters/11 months of their life together. jfc.
>
> next chapter: more kissing. micah, angella, george, and lance show up for no reason other than to amuse me. people have to talk about the decisions they've made because finn and glimmer must be appeased.

Holy. Shit.

Chapter Summary

As expected, everyone has a strong reaction to the news.

Chapter Notes

welcome back! you lived through the endless pining and now you just have to watch these two dummies try to navigate a relationship for four more chapters. i really loved the comments that were like "we did it!" you did. good job, you.

this week's chapters are basically fluff city, population: catradora. today is all chaotic responses to their relationship and then adora. decides. to. chill. out. i know you don't believe it but it happens. on friday, they go on an actual fucking date. it only took them 20 whole chapters.

anyway, you stuck through. you're great and i appreciate you.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

As soon as Adora and Catra enter the living room, showered and a bit more put together, Lonnie smirks at her sister from where she's reclined on the couch.

"You get that back blown out?"

They had only kissed. For a long time. On various parts of each other's body. Largely above the waist, though. She and Catra could probably have gotten away with convincing their siblings that nothing had happened if they hadn't both insisted that they needed some time to...freshen up...after their visitors returned.

Adora expects to hear a hiss in return. Instead, Catra burrows into Adora's chest before leaning up to give her a peck on the lips.

"I'm not hearing a no," Lonnie says. But she's smiling proudly.

To be fair, Lonnie has probably listened to Catra talk about their relationship, or lack thereof, for months now so it's good that she doesn't completely hate Adora.

The appropriate thing would be to try to get to know the sibling of the person you're dating.

So Adora quickly excuses herself to hide in the kitchen.

Inside, she finds Finn sitting on the counter and kicking their feet against the cabinets while they wait for Mara to reheat some leftovers.

"Finny, no butts where we put our food please," Adora politely reminds them. "And don't scuff the cabinets."

"Cat puts her butt here all the time."

"I pay the mortgage," a voice calls from the living room. "My butt goes where it wants."

"You just gonna lay that one out there?" she can just barely hear Lonnie ask.

"Did you two have fun today?" Adora asks Finn and Mara, choosing to ignore the argument kicking up in the other room.

"Did *you* ?" Mara returns with a wicked smile.

Finn snorts so Adora swipes a kick at her sister's shin, a punishment for her continuing to encourage naughty behavior from the cub. Mara dodges nimbly as always and manages to get in a good towel flick for revenge. Ducking away from Adora's returning swipe, she sets a plate of food on the table and gives Finn a short whistle. Their ears immediately perk up and they jump down, bounding over to the table.

It's such a familiar move, reminiscent of her childhood with Mara but also a sign of how comfortable she and Finn have gotten over the past couple of days.

“Oh, Gods, was it that good? You’re crying!”

“I’m not!” Adora says quickly, wiping her eyes. “You’re just so good with them.”

“Right? Who knew I was cut out to be an aunt? Someone gave me a cactus last year and I drove out to the Crimson Waste and abandoned it in the desert cause I couldn’t handle the pressure.” Mara laughs, as if this is normal behavior and not something that feels like it should be reported to someone. Just in case. “Want some food?”

“Always.”

She returns to cooking while Adora tries to help tidy up a few things around the kitchen.

“Sooo. I believe I asked you a question.” Mara at least has the decency to almost whisper it, though everyone in the house except for Lonnie can probably hear her.

Adora abruptly busies herself with getting a glass of water so Mara can’t see her face.

“Yes, I had fun,” she replies, aiming for something that sounds in the general vicinity of ‘chill’. “Thanks for your help.”

‘Fun’ doesn’t really quite capture the euphoria of kissing Catra for the first time. And the second time. And the twentieth time. Or getting to feel how *soft* Catra is and how *strong* . Or–

“You should take a long weekend away,” Mara suggests with a laugh. “Get some of this out of your system.”

Adora blinks, shaking off the daydream. She hadn’t even noticed the faucet still running, water overflowing out of the cup in her hand and down her wrist. She shuts it off quickly.

“A long weekend sounds like a good idea. I have no intention of letting this feeling go anytime soon, though.”

There’s a pleased trill behind her. Catra’s tail taps on her left shoulder. Adora predictably falls for that old trick, glancing around, while her cup is stolen from her right hand. Adora turns back just in time to catch Catra finishing the rest of the water off, eyes twinkling at the blonde over the rim of the glass.

“Parched?”

“What do you expect?” Catra replies and hands Adora back the empty glass. She leans over to whisper, “I had this walking thirst trap half-naked in my bed most of the day.”

It’s comforting to know that their new dynamic won’t be too different from their old one, at least.

But then Catra leans over and gives Adora another quick kiss on the lips. That will certainly take some getting used to. She’s never dated anyone who just handed out affirmation of their love constantly.

From the other side of the room, there’s a very dramatic gasp.

“Holy. Shit!” Finn screams.

What follows is absolute pandemonium.

Finn leaps across the room to...no one’s really sure honestly, but they’re up in the air and heading towards the pile of adults in the kitchen. Adora’s yelling “Language, Finn!” while Catra’s trying to catch them in mid-air, and Mara’s just flailing in general to protect the food on the stove and in her hands. Melog, who must have been sleeping under the table, scurries out of the room.

Lonnie doesn’t do anything but smirk at them. Not a big help.

Catra more or less successfully catches Finn but they both tumble into Adora, who has to brace herself to cradle them both. Luckily, she only slightly stumbles back into her sister and a minimal amount of leftovers ends up on Mara’s shirt and the kitchen floor.

There’s no time to clean anything up before Finn presses their feet into Catra’s ribs so they can climb onto her shoulder, trying to perch.

Catra *shrieks* , trying to both sooth her own sides and shift to balance the cub’s full weight.

Finn could not care less. They reach their hands over to cling onto Adora at the same time.

“Holy. Shit!” they repeat with a bright smile, yelling right into the human’s face.

“Dor, why did you teach them that phrase?” Catra immediately deflects, still wincing.

“Finn, you know the rules on cursing,” she reminds them.

“Cat says it’s okay when you’re excited.”

“That doesn’t sound like me,” Catra replies.

It most definitely does. Finn is too distracted to call out the lie.

“Are you together now?” they ask instead.

There had been some brief conversation earlier about the right thing to tell Finn without getting their hopes up. Catra was convinced that the cub was tough and would be fine regardless. Adora was, of course, more cautious.

Finn didn’t remember a whole lot from before they came to Weaver. So they’d mostly only known Weaver’s brand of strict yet absentee parenting. They’d really been thriving with Catra and Adora, according to their long-time social worker at least, and the blonde didn’t want to rush into throwing their finally stable and comfortable home life into upheaval just because their guardian was dating now. This announcement had to be as gentle as possible.

“You sweet, naive idiot,” Catra had warned between kisses. “You’re gonna get played and you don’t even know it.”

To take the load off of Catra, Adora shifts Finn into her arms before pulling the older cat closer so the cub can keep a hand on each of them.

“We are going to try dating,” Adora explains. “So things are going to be a little different.”

“But honestly, probably not that much,” Catra adds. “Dor and I are gonna spend a little more time together alone. You’ll still see us as much, though.”

“Can *I* go on dates alone?” Finn asks.

“When you earn your own money, you can go anywhere you want,” Catra tells them.

“Well, no,” Adora interrupts. “There will be more rules than that. Also, I don’t really want to spend all of Saturday in the mall with two 14 year olds when they go through that phase.”

“You don’t have to figure that out right this second,” Mara points out. “Maybe focus on the present.”

She’s cleaned the food off of herself but the stain isn’t going away soon. She disappears, saying she needs to change quickly.

Adora doesn’t miss the way that Mara lightly hip checks Lonnie with a smile as she walks by. Catra shoots Adora a look that clearly says ‘we have to talk about *that* .’

“Anyway,” Catra redirects attention, “We’ll hammer out the rest of that later. For now, Dor and I are together. We don’t know what’s gonna happen so we can’t make any promises. Do you get that, cub?”

Finn nods. They’re no less excited than before.

"If something comes up that affects all three of us, we'll tell you. Some things might just be about Dor and me, though, okay?"

They nod again. Their little paws start to stretch, a clear sign that they're dying to knead something in happiness.

"Is there anything you want to know?" Adora asks hopefully.

Catra whispers to them, "Remember what we talked about?"

"Will you buy me a trampoline? To keep me company while you're busy?" Finn responds.

"That's...not what I meant. I'd be annoyed if I wasn't so proud," Catra tells them.

"You can't teach natural killer instincts like that," Lonnie chimes in. "I'd hire you, kid."

Finn practically beams. "Thank you!" They turn back to Adora. "Trampoline? Please?"

"We can talk about it." Then Adora decides to go off-script for a bit, just to give a little reassurance. "No matter what happens, Finny, we'll both always love you."

She's not really expecting the strange silence that follows. Both cats still in her arms, just staring up at her with wide eyes and weaving tails. Adora looks to Lonnie for guidance but she's trying hard to hide a soft, touched smile that seems definitely out of character.

"You love me?" Finn finally asks in a quiet voice.

Adora kinda wants to laugh at how ludicrous the question is, but the kid is very sincere, very open. She glances at Catra who buries her face in the blonde's shoulder, where the material begins to dampen.

What's up with these two?

“Of course I love you,” she tells Finn with a smile. “We both do. Right, Catra?”

“Yeah,” comes out mumbles and rough. Catra pauses to clear her throat and pull back to make eye contact with Finn. “We both love you, bud.”

The confirmation is enough to finally destroy the small cub’s control. Finn lightly extends their claws and begins kneading, one hand on Adora’s collarbone and the other perched on Catra’s shoulder. The older cat trills and Finn does the same in response, butting their forehead under Adora’s chin and rubbing.

“Hey, no marking without asking,” Catra quickly warns them.

“It’s okay,” Adora manages to whisper, even though she’s pretty sure she’s dying from cuteness overload.

If Finn wants to claim her as theirs, Adora’s going to allow it and do her damndest to never let them down.

Catra seems a lot more wary. Adora moves Finn’s head to her opposite shoulder so she can lean down and give Catra a quick, calming kiss.

“Holy. Shit!” Glimmer’s voice rings out, obliterating the moment.

In the doorway stands Mara. Sadly, she holds her phone in her hand, where Glimmer Moon’s shocked face watches on screen. Mara at least has the decency to look sorry for this.

“I didn’t believe it honestly,” Glimmer whispers. “Mara, I apologize for calling you a ‘fucking lying liar’ to your face.”

“Language!” Adora yells.

Finn uses their hold on the two adults to push themselves into a leap and land just in front of Mara.

“Glimmer!” the cub screams right into the speaker. When Glimmer flinches, Adora enjoys the revenge a little. “They’re dating! You did it!”

“Why is Glimmer getting credit for literally anything?” Adora wonders.

“I’ve made so many sacrifices,” she responds dramatically and then pretends to faint or something. Finn, always a fan of theatrics, is very amused.

“What Glimmer means is that she’s happy for you all,” Bow comments offscreen. “We’re *all* happy.”

“It’s a Christmas miracle!” Glimmer screams. “Oh my God! How did it happen? Who made the first move?”

“I’m taking my secrets to my grave,” Catra answers.

She looks so cute, crossing her arms and trying to glare at the phone. She’s too happy to really pull it off and Adora’s face practically splits from how wide her smile.

Adora reaches down and wraps both arms around Catra. Apparently this is her one move. Catra melts back into her anyway before leaning back and giving Adora a brief kiss.

Glimmer’s squeal is so loud that Mara almost drops the device.

“Mom! Come see this!”

“Wait…‘Mom’?” Catra tries to question.

But it’s too late, Glimmer’s already turning her camera so that her parents are visible.

The older Moons are both wearing horrible matching festive green sweaters and the same wool snowflake earrings. For two tall, stately people, they look especially ridiculous. Adora knows from personal experience that Glimmer dresses and styles everyone in

her general vicinity for Christmas, no exceptions. It's always a joy to see the senator and her husband, a tenured professor at the most respected university in the world, looking like absolute goobers.

"Happy Holidays, everyone!" Micah says brightly.

"Catra, it's nice to meet you," Angella tells her. She has to bend a bit to be at eye-level. As always, her perfect straight blonde hair doesn't move an inch. "Glimmer and Bow have said such lovely things about you."

Catra's bi-colored eyes look surprised.

"You too," she replies hesitantly.

She looks like she's searching for more to say, trying to access her usual charm. But Angella moves on quickly.

"Adora, we haven't made our year-end donation to LAP yet. Can I just give it to you now?"

"Ooh! Us too!" she hears the excited voice of Lance, one of Bow's dads, yelling from off-camera.

"Excellent," Angella continues. "Adora, grab a pen, will you?"

Glimmer yells, "Don't just go around giving out your credit card info! Do I have to explain how scams work to you people again?"

"It's just Adora," Angella tries to explain. "We know Adora."

" *Do* we? She's acting very strangely. Just kissing random women she's only known for a year."

"Glimmer, why are you being so mean to your poor mother?" Catra asks, pretending to scold her with a disapproving shake of the head.

“Oh, I like her, Adora,” Angella replies with a smile. “You should both come over for dinner soon.”

Finn, having not heard an invitation for themself, angles back on camera. And then their head explodes once they get a full look at Glimmer’s parents.

“Do you have *wings* ?”

Angella is used to this type of question probably, since most people aren’t accustomed to seeing a towering angelic being, capable of flight. Yet, instead of giving her practiced patient answer, she lets loose a shocked squeal when she sees Finn, very similar to something the younger Moon might do.

“Oh my Gods! Aren’t you the cutest little thing?” Angella coos.

“Don't be fooled!” her daughter cautions. “They’re a tiny con artist.”

“You could come *here* for dinner,” Finn offers. “I’m gonna get a trampoline soon. I’ll let you use it if you take me flying.”

Angella laughs. “Yes, I see what you mean, Glimmer. That seems like a fair offer, though.”

“Mara, when do you leave?” Micah interjects. “We’d love to see yo-”

He’s cut off by George, Bow’s other father, nearly pushing his way onto the screen, wearing a sweater that matches the Moon’s.

“Mara?!” the man shouts with a wide smile.

George is generally the calmer of the elder Archers. Mara’s presence tends to make people act bizarrely.

“I haven’t seen you in so long,” he continues. “I read your story on the intricate, clandestine roots of Prime Corp and their impact on-”

Glimmer snatches her phone back.

"No! Stay on task! Everyone say congratulations to Adora," she angrily orders. "After all these years, she finally has a girlfriend and she's not going to die a useless lesbian."

"This doesn't feel like a 'congratulations' moment," Adora tries. It feels easier to focus on that and not on the 'girlfriend' part, which she and Catra have certainly not discussed at all.

"Oh, it definitely does," Catra argues with a smirk.

Then there's at least 20 more voices saying 'congrats, Adora!' The blonde pales completely. That's too many witnesses to this public shaming. Glimmer swivels the phone again and most of the 12 Archer siblings and their significant others are there.

How did Glimmer have the time to buy this many matching shirts? Christmas ended 24 hours ago – is she holding these people hostage? Their thin, forced smiles certainly look like a cry for help.

This seems like a good time to end this call, Adora decides. She quickly lunges for the phone, intent on doing just that.

"Wait, I'd actually love to talk to George about this," Mara tries to throw in, since it's *her* phone and all. "Get a sociologist's take on it."

"Absolutely not," Glimmer insists. "Carry me into another room. I need to speak with you and Catra privately."

"Sparkles, it's getting late," Catra says.

"You'll be in bed with your lover soon enough. I just have a few questions."

"Mara, I hope you've learned a valuable lesson about not being the messenger," Adora tells her.

"Kiddo, that's literally my entire life," Mara replies. "Dealing with demanding, belligerent people is my cross to bear. Now, please excuse me while I attempt to appease this one."

She motions with her head towards Glimmer's offended face, before exiting the room. Catra sneaks one last kiss from Adora and reluctantly follows.

Lonnie's not a big talker, it seems. That's good. Neither is Adora. She hopes against hope that they can just sit together in comfortable silence on the couch while Finn plays with Melog and the two adults vaguely pay attention to the game show on the tv.

They're each involved with the other's sister now. No need to talk about that ever.

It doesn't seem like Catra and Mara will be released by Glimmer any time soon, though. What if Adora misses her only chance to make a good impression with Lonnie?

"Uh, thanks for the photo album," she opens with. "It was truly amazing. A lot of potential blackmail material."

Lonnie laughs without looking away from the tv. She's been correctly answering around 98% of the questions aloud for the past hour. It's becoming a bit clearer what attracted her and Mara to each other so quickly.

"I'm glad you can appreciate it. It was a real labor of love."

It was probably the greatest gift ever. Kyle spent hours on it, according to Lonnie. He had pulled together all the pictures he'd kept of his friends/makeshift family – probably a very hard thing to do since they were all kids in the system, who rarely had adults who kept albums of them or the funds to usually afford stuff like cameras – chose all of his favorites of Catra, had them reprinted, and scrapbooked them just for Adora. He'd even gotten the more damaged ones professionally restored.

Some of the pictures were truly awful. Catra's giant mane teased up even more. A whole flat-ironed, swoopy bangs phase. Dresses shaped like a half-deflated balloon. Jeans large enough to hide a dead body in. A surprising amount of leopard print. Just unfortunate fashion choice after unfortunate fashion choice for *pages* . Each one made Adora love Catra just a little bit more.

Also, it was the most that she'd ever been able to embarrass Catra, which was just such a gorgeous, light feeling. She hissed at every picture and swore revenge on Lonnie, Kyle, Adora, and even the pharmacy worker who had to tend the photo center that day and had absolutely no choice in the matter.

The album would probably mysteriously disappear soon but Adora had gotten the download link from Lonnie and digitally saved it in as many hiding places as she could think of. Even if Catra found all of them, a copy had already been sent to Bow just in case.

Kyle was apparently even more gullible than Adora. He genuinely believed he had created a thoughtful gift for Catra's new partner, based on a bill of lies that Lonnie successfully sold him. The more Adora learned about Kyle, the more it seemed like he was a kind and caring soul. A nurse. A talented baker and home chef who cooked meals for his spouses almost everyday. A giver and helper.

"What could Kyle and Catra have possibly fought so badly about?" Adora asks.

Lonnie lazily glances over at her.

"Have you asked Cat?"

"Not really. Not directly."

Maybe it's something very private? Adora doesn't know Kyle and doesn't have his consent to butt in so she should probably just forget about it.

Lonnie turns the tv up louder. Hopefully the neighbors are away for the holidays.

“She doesn’t know,” Lonnie says with no emotion. And then she just looks at Adora and waits.

That makes no sense. Someone wouldn’t just swear revenge and enter a multi-year feud over nothing.

And yet.

“Catra doesn’t know,” Adora repeats.

If she *did* , Adora would have had to listen to a long diatribe on all of the reasons she was correct or Kyle was a cruel monster who had wronged her. Catra once spent a full 10 minutes complaining about the barista at the coffee place near her office, who she was sure was out to get her. She’s never ever elaborated on her fight with Kyle.

Adora is in love with a stubborn idiot.

“I think something did happen,” Lonnie adds. “Probably a bunch of small things that she believed were passive aggressive signs that Kyle was upset with her. But time went by and she forgot them all. All she remembered was that she 'hated' Kyle."

“Doesn’t this bother you? He *is* your husband.”

“Real talk, I think he’s flattered by all of the attention,” Lonnie says, chuckling quietly. “By loudly pointing out how she’s not talking to him, all Cat manages to do is put more focus on him. Rogelio gets an excuse to love on him even more. She sends him ‘fuck you’ gifts that are actually pretty sweet. It’s really the best they’ve ever gotten along.”

Catra’s holiday gift to Kyle was a $350 gift certificate to a fancy clothing store as a subtle way of saying she hated the scrubs he always wears. Adora tried to ask how that was a punishment and all Catra said was -

"I’m playing chess. His move now."

Kyle’s gift to her was a framed photo of them from when they were small kids.

“What a dick,” Catra said in response. She put it on one of the living room end tables as a ‘reminder.’

Adora’s laugh just barely carries over the blaring tv. Lonnie gives her her moment to take all of this in.

“Look,” she says, “You may have noticed this but Cat never says big things first. Maybe if this actually got annoying and Kyle told her he didn't know what had happened, she would admit she didn’t either. She’s good at apologizing. Her whole life though, she just could never say big shit first. Someone else has to start.”

Oh. Well, that takes a bit of the wind out of Adora’s sails. She imagines Catra just sitting around for these last few months, waiting for Adora to start explaining how she feels. Waiting for it to be safe for Catra to share that she’s in love with her. Adora had been the one to admit that she felt an attraction first, but everything beyond that, Catra had been pushing herself way out of her comfort zone with little guarantee that things would work out.

Adora’s actually pretty proud that Catra had poured out her heart first. At least she’s not the only one trying to slide out from under decades of trauma responses.

“You should ask her what happened though,” Lonnie suggests. “I bet you $100 she tells you it’s about *honor* or some bullshit.”

As Lonnie turns the tv volume back down, signaling the successful completion of their attempt at interacting, Finn and Melog mutually decide that no one is paying enough attention to them. Finn lays themself across Lonnie’s lap and grabs for her phone. Lonnie resists without missing the next question, used to dodging the grabby hands of a tiny cat. Adora tosses hers over instead so Finn can play one of the educational games she downloaded. That

will last maybe 5 minutes before they decide it's preferable just to give up and go to bed.

Meanwhile, Melog hops up into Adora's lap, butts their head under her chin, and replaces Finn's mark. They fall asleep immediately.

Adora's been half-conscious in bed for a full hour before Catra comes in and collapses next to her.

"Did Glimmer rant the entire time?" the blonde mumbles out.

"Half of it." Catra's voice is muffled, like she's lying face-down. "We all ended up having a super teary heart-to-heart actually."

Adora flips over towards her quickly.

"Wha?"

Catra turns her head to the side but doesn't open her eyes.

"Yeah, we all cried about love and feelings and shit. I am now part of a sacred sisterhood that I never wanted in the first place."

"With Mara? And Glimmer?"

"Yeah."

"Wha?"

Catra finally opens her eyes.

"Get over yourself, Dor. We didn't spend two and a half hours just talking about you."

Adora lets out the breath she was holding. She doesn't know what those three could get up to together but it definitely sounds like trouble.

"It was cute, though," Catra adds. "Learned a lot about Mara. You didn't tell me she literally ran away to join the circus."

“She’s lived a hundred lives, each more confusing than the last.”

“She talked a lot about Hope.”

For probably too many seconds, Adora just doesn’t move at all.

“What did you and Lonnie talk about?” Catra asks while getting out of bed and heading into her closet to change.

“Oh?” Adora tries to think of a quick lie. “Nothing much.” Nope, not quick enough.

Catra hums.

“I tried to find out more about Kyle but she wouldn’t tell me.” Since no one can see her, the lie feels slightly easier. “Why did the two of you have a falling out?”

In the closet, everything goes silent.

“If things are going to be different between us, I'd like for us to be able to communicate a little better,” Adora says.

Catra straight up cackles at her.

“Fine,” Adora huffs. “I don’t really like talking that much about Hope. She did the best she could and yes, she could probably use some time to figure out why the hell she’s so repressed but she’s not as bad as Mara makes her seem. Her rules were fine, they were just a little...old-fashioned.”

A furry ear pokes out of the closet.

“And maybe I take critiques of her very personally and project too much,” Adora goes on. “And maybe I sorta was always so grateful for everything that she did for me that I just learned to never ask for or want anything more for myself.”

Slowly, Catra’s full head peaks out, eyes narrowed.

"...did you really tell me all that just so I'll say why Kyle and I are fighting?"

"I'm trying to communicate and you're being difficult," is Adora's embarrassed and muttered accusation.

What a colossal failure at deception. Or at trying to make Catra safe to open up. The line kinda blurred there as soon as Adora started to think about Hope.

"Kyle owes me a debt of honor. It's too private to explain."

Catra disappears back into the closet and Adora now owes Lonnie $100. She gave away everything and managed to get nothing in return.

"Anyway, it's bedtime. Let's stop talking about our weird families. Did you like the presents I gave you?"

"Are you fishing for compliments?" Adora replies. The fancy hiking boots, beginner's cookbooks, gorgeous watch, *and* stocking full of a half dozen silly small gifts were all perfect and Catra knew it.

"If you don't answer, you don't get your final one," Catra sing-songs.

"Yes, I loved all of them," Adora responds automatically. "You know you're the best at presents."

"I think I've outdone myself this time," she replies.

Catra walks – *saunters* , really – back into the room wearing only Adora's missing letterman jacket and matching red panties. She pauses at the edge of the bed to casually tilt her head to the side and pose.

A sound sorta floats out into the heavy air between them that is probably a whimper. And probably from Adora.

“The present’s me, by the way,” Catra clarifies. “Not the jacket. The jacket is mine now. Forever.”

Adora animates just enough to say, “But it has my name on it.”

“Yeah, and *you’re* mine now. What’s not clear about this?”

“I was always yours, for one,” Adora replies. “Two-”

She’s cut off by Catra jumping onto her lap and landing in a straddle.

“Say that again,” she all but moans.

The blonde smirks. Earlier, she’d discovered she unconsciously knew quite a lot about Catra’s turn-ons. Leaning into her possessiveness was a big one.

“I’m yours, Kitten.”

Turns out ‘kitten’ was another. Apparently, all this time, Adora had been driving her wild and not even noticing.

Bypassing her lips entirely, Catra just dives right into kissing the blonde’s neck. Almost immediately though, Catra pulls back, frowning.

“When did you become so popular around here?” she asks, with great suspicion. She takes an audible sniff at the human’s chin.

“Oh, Melog? Yeah, I think they got jealous.” Adora shrugs. Her smirk returns. “Do you want to mark me? Since I’m *yours* ?”

To her surprise, Catra slips out of her lap completely.

“No thanks,” she mumbles, before turning back towards the closet.

Adora follows only to find her hanging up the jacket and pulling down a set of pajamas.

“I’m sorry,” Adora says, though she’s not sure what she’s apologizing for. “Did I overstep?”

“How many times have I told you to apologize less?”

“ *You* apologize all the time, Cat.”

“I never said I wasn’t a giant hypocrite.”

“I didn’t realize the marking would bother you,” Adora gently tells her. “I just thought Finn was showing their love.”

“It’s a bit more than that,” Catra explains quietly. When she’s pulled her pants on, she simply sits down and leans back into a rack of clothes. “I’ve never done it. Marked someone.”

Adora lowers next to her on the floor. Slowly, she reaches a hand over, giving Catra a chance to decline if needed. When there’s no resistance, Adora begins to pet behind Catra’s ear.

“A lot of my instincts, I spent hours just exploring them. I didn’t have any friends growing up. My choices were either be a 4th wheel to Rogelio, Lonnie, and Kyle, or hang out by myself. So I passed a lot of time climbing and just figuring things out. The social shit? I never had anyone to try it with.”

Adora pulls Catra fully into her arms now, thinking about her as a tiny, lonely kit.

“Marking isn’t just about love,” she says, leaning further into her human backrest. “It’s to show where you belong. Where your home is. I’ve never had that before.”

Adora wants to argue. They're both pretty familiar with marking at this point. Catra left a particularly huge bite earlier in the day, right above Adora's left boob. It’ll definitely bruise and there’s a clear imprint of two fangs. Adora knows bites are a big deal to cat folks, especially for mates. That’s not even counting the dozen times Catra’s burrowed her face into Adora’s stomach or shoulder. Or, you know, when Catra *licked* her in public.

But if Catra's not ready to realize this then Adora won't push her.

It's kinda nice to feel like the sure, confident one for a change. Catra and Finn are her home. They'll always be linked. It's a good north star to come back to if Adora starts to get lost in her thoughts again.

If Catra needs that reassurance, Adora can give it to her. It can be *her* turn to freak out cause honestly, Adora could use the break from doing it herself.

"Why are you smiling at me like that?" Catra's gazing at up her suspiciously. "Planning to take out a bunch of life insurance policies on me?"

"What do you think will happen if this doesn't work out between us?" Adora asks with a smile.

She knows the answer. She just wants to make sure that Catra knows it too.

"We're dykes. So we'll either be best friends or never speak to each other again but date all the same people."

With a laugh, Adora responds, "I know that's just your weird way of saying we'll always be a part of each other's lives."

Catra's silent for a moment.

"Promise?"

"Promise, Kitten."

Lonnie sees herself off to the airport before anyone wakes up. They still have to get up early to drive Mara a couple hours later.

Finn only disappears once but is quickly found trying to make a child-sized hole in Mara's suitcase.

At the drop-off point, she makes them all promise to come visit soon and gushes endlessly about how much she loves Catra and Finn, while they both preen.

"Good job, Dora." Mara pulls her into a tight hug. "I'm so proud of you. Take care of each other, okay?"

It isn't until halfway home that Catra, in the passenger seat, turns to Adora.

"Are we seriously not gonna talk about the fact that they had sex?"

"Are we seriously not gonna talk about how you stole my jacket?" Adora asks. Much more quietly, she whispers, "How long were you planning last night's little show? And can we have an encore...to *completion* ?"

"I guess I'll be seeing you in small claims court then," is all Catra says in response as she fidgets in her chair.

Adora's not getting the jacket back. The rest of it still seems to be on the table, though. Not a bad deal.

"We'll start a new holiday tradition next year – a trip somewhere tropical," she suggests.

Finn pipes up from the back. "Can we fly?"

"Only if it's first class," Catra says. "If I can't be on land then I want to be treated like a precious princess. And I'm going to be medicated to the gills, Dor. You're gonna have to carry me through the airport Weekend at Bernie's-style."

"Whatever you want, my love."

Catra wrinkles her nose.

"I'm trying things out," Adora says quickly. "Not good?"

A head shake with a bit of a pitying scowl thrown in for emphasis.

“Whatever you want, *Kitten* .”

Catra gasps now. It’s exaggerated, probably to hide the very real actual blush riding up under her fur.

“Not in front of the cub,” she whispers, pretending to be scandalized.

She gently takes Adora’s right hand off of the steering wheel. Before the blonde can lecture about safe driving or 10 and 2, Catra kisses her palm then runs her cheek back and forth across it.

But sure, this is *totally* not marking, Adora thinks happily.

Chapter End Notes

how long will adora's confidence last?

chapter 20 preview: the title is "lady fingers." that's all.

Lady Fingers

Chapter Summary

A first date. A talk with the parental figures.

Chapter Notes

happy friday!!

so here's the thing. they don't have sex in this chapter. i'm just gonna tell you up top because secrets don't make friends. the next chapter is literally wall-to-wall smut. i almost combined the two chapters but then i didn't because...pacing? who knows? anyway, the rating doesn't change to explicit until next tuesday.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora is taking Catra to a show. This is a genius idea because it solves several problems – it fulfills Catra's request that Adora get more culture, it allows her to make amends to Catra for ruining her birthday plans, and it forces them to be alone in the dark together and not speak.

There are few things that Adora loves more than Catra's voice. She just has completely over-thought what they would talk about on a date, seeing as how they've talked almost every single day for months and months. For some reason, date conversation feels like it should be different from friend conversation and Adora hasn't come up with any good topics yet.

Also, Adora hasn't been on a date in about two years.

That's not relevant.

Anyway, this particular show was the queerest thing that Adora could find tickets for, a revival of some classic gay musical. Bow gave his approval so the night is promising. Worst case scenario,

Catra mocks it like she does most things and she'll have to lean close to Adora to whisper taunts, so she doesn't disturb the rest of the audience. Before the theater, Adora chose a nearby bar with snacks that look good.

She has no plan for after the show. Drop Catra off at a reasonable time and maybe get a kiss?

They've had a handful of brief yet very hot and heavy makeout sessions since their first kiss. Adora would like to save doing anything further until they have more time and privacy.

It's a struggle to communicate that message to her hormones, which go absolutely nuts at the thought of Catra. Kissing Catra. Catra's fur against her skin. Catra's raspy voice whispering very graphic commands.

Catra, as Adora has learned, likes to send text reminders of things she'd like to do, along with…visual accompaniments.

The first time Adora received one, evidence of Catra pretending to casually go bra shopping in the middle of the day, she was in a staff meeting. She threw her phone on the floor with yelp. Thankfully, it landed face-down cause Glimmer would have had a field day, especially since the message attached asked if it was silly for Catra to spend $50 on this particular piece of underwear just for the thrill of Adora ripping it off.

Adora's gained slightly more chill since then.

Actually, Catra's been keeping it pretty PG-13 since Adora asked her out last week. Granted, they were in the middle of a hangout that turned into kissing and both of them losing their shirts, when Adora breathlessly asked if she could take Catra on a date. Catra had to pause in the hickey she was leaving to enthusiastically agree. But besides *that* , it's been pretty tame. Maybe she's finding this transition to be as mine-filled as Adora.

Knowing Catra, she's probably lulling Adora into a false sense of comfort before catching her off guard with something truly racy.

Even in their very silly conversation about date night outfit choices the evening before, Catra avoided several opportunities to be overly suggestive. They had talked under the pretense of coordinating schedules around the usual shuttling to extracurriculars. It took a detour, though, when Catra started randomly wondering out loud what she'd be wearing to work the next day. The day of their *date* , Adora pointed out in her head.

“I should probably lay something out tonight just in case,” Catra said, pretending to be disinterested. “Something boring, like a suit.”

She glanced back at the phone to gauge Adora's reaction. The blonde tried her best not to give one, lest Catra know even more how her sartorial choices affected Adora.

But Catra was playing dirty.

“And glasses. Maybe a tie?”

Ugh. Adora had only been lucky enough to see Catra in a tie once. It was honest-to-Gods hot enough to give anyone a sexual awakening.

And yet. “Ties are good but maybe you’ll be in a mood to wear one of your shirts that doesn’t have a collar and is…” Adora didn't know the term for it so she unhelpfully drug her fingers across her collarbone in explanation.

“Low-cut,” Catra finished, only slightly raising her eyebrow. “Hmm,” she hummed, almost pleased.

Suit. Glasses. Low-cut shirt. Why did Adora create the recipe for her own downfall?

If it worked for Catra, Adora figured it could work for her too, though.

“I've got a couple meetings tomorrow. Maybe I should dress up?” she asked.

It looked like Catra bit the inside of her cheek to keep from smiling.

“Dor, you know I find your little uniform weirdly charming. If you feel like your meetings are *important* though,” she paused to tilt her head, “you could wear that grey skirt you're hiding in your closet.”

What an interesting choice. She didn’t realize that was a thing for Catra.

“Sounds good,” Adora said, pretending this was no big deal.

“Sounds good, yep,” Catra repeated, eyes greatly amused.

Adora shows up to the bar 35 minutes early. This is ridiculous, even by her standards. But she was finding work hard to focus on and thought maybe arriving in advance would help cool her nervousness. Instead, it just gives her anxiety a change of scenery.

Catra confidently strolls in later, almost on time but not really, wearing a cool grin and the hunter green suit from their first friend date. It’s one of Adora’s favorites, something about the color really complementing Catra’s fur well. This time though, she matches it with a gold silk top with a deep vee that, along with her glasses, makes her eyes stand out and look even more otherworldly.

Apparently, Catra even found time to stop and see a barber today because her hair is perfectly coiffed in short messy waves. She’s really bringing out the big guns.

She must sense that Confident Adora has left the building and been replaced with her evil twin Anxious Adora because she says hello, glances at the menu, and just launches into her most distracting Catra behavior.

“Ladyfingers is a weird word,” she remarks, seemingly related to nothing.

Adora frowns, struggling to catch up. Between her nerves and mentally rearranging her list of favorite Catra outfits, she's not sure what this could possibly mean.

“What?”

Catra just waves vaguely at the menu. There's not a single thing on there that contains that strange phrase. Adora knows, because she planned out her order days in advance.

“Ladyfingers. Uh, *tiramisu* …?” Catra explains. “They have it. One of the layers is ladyfingers. It's just a gross concept. Little biscuits piped out to look like ladyfingers.”

“Oh my God, please stop saying ladyfingers,” Adora begs with a nervous laugh. Something about it is unsettling.

“Why? You getting turned on?” Catra tilts her head as she asks, dryly.

Instead of replying, Adora pokes her thumb into the space under Catra's right ribs. She squeaks and tries to squirm away. Adora recently accidentally found this secret spot that draws such an uncharacteristic reaction out of her...not-quite girlfriend. Date. Out of her *date* ...and delighted in it. Catra's so quick that Adora has to save these attacks for completely random moments though.

When her giggles die down a bit, Catra fixes Adora with a look.

“Feel more relaxed now?”

She nods. Non-sequiturs and messing with each other feels much more like them than asking awkward questions about their hobbies.

“I do. Thank you?”

Catra bows dramatically. Adora draws her closer, dragging the stool she's seated on a bit nearer until their knees touch.

“Hi,” the blonde whispers.

“Hi, Dor.”

“You look gorgeous.”

Catra seems a bit surprised at the compliment.

“You've seen me in my work clothes a million times. You, however,” she runs her tail along Adora's calf up to her knee, “are wearing the fuck out of that skirt.”

“Just because I’ve seen it doesn’t mean-“ Adora cuts herself off, thinking the rest of that sentence might be too much for a first date. And a weird admission about her not-so-secret pining. Probably just a bad idea all around.

Catra’s tail brushes her knee again, this time slowly working its way up to Adora’s hand, sitting in her lap. The tail curls around her wrist, tugging just slightly. It’s enough to pull Adora from her thoughts.

“Hi, remember me?” Catra asks lightly. “The person who texts you literally every idle thought that comes to my mind? No matter how embarrassing or nonsensical?”

Adora reaches over and cups Catra’s face with her hand. Definitely too intimate for a first day but who cares.

“Just because I’ve seen it doesn’t mean that my stomach doesn’t flip each time. That my heart didn’t stutter as soon as you walked in here.”

The look on Catra’s face shifts from teasing to sweet and kind. A lot more earnest that she usually allows herself to be. She caresses the hand against her cheek.

“Let’s get a hotel room,” is not what Adora was expecting her to say next.

“Catra!”

The soft facade fades and she’s back to her cackling ways.

“I thought you wanted romance.”

“I also said I wanted sex,” Catra replies with a grin. “Hotel sex can be very romantic.”

She reaches down and pulls Adora’s stool even closer.

Leaning over, Catra whispers, “You three fingers deep in me can be very romantic.” A fang grazes Adora’s earlobe. It’s very hard to argue against this logic. “My tongue inside of you sounds like the *height* of romance.”

Adora has to grab Catra’s waist to ground herself and force her body not to react. That, of course, is itself enough of a reaction.

“You like the sound of that?” she continues. There’s just the faintest touch of her lips along Adora’s jaw.

The blonde pulls back. She has just enough of her wits left to pump the brakes on this.

“That’s not a first date option usually.” Adora attempts to give an admonishing look but that’s never not served to just make Catra more powerful.

Before she can react though, Adora uses her hold on Catra’s hips to pull her date fully off the stool and flush against her body.

“This doesn’t feel like a first date option either,” Catra replies, wrapping her arms around Adora’s neck, before reaching up to push their lips together.

This is the first time they've kissed in public. Something about that makes it a little thrilling for Adora.

She pulls back to catch her breath, Catra making a whiny mewl in response.

"Is that what you wanted?"

"Yes. More," is whispered before Catra attempts to pull Adora back towards her again.

"Conversation." That's about as much as Adora can manage towards a sentence right now.

"We talk all the time."

"Getting to know you/first date conversation."

Catra steps back, placing only about 4 inches of distance between them.

"Dor. Please tell me what you want and what your expectations are for tonight."

"I...thought we had similar expectations?" she answers with a slight frown.

"Nearly impossible for two different people to have the same expectations without them being stated explicitly."

"Well, it's our first date!" Adora explains. "We'll do the things you do on those. Learn about each other? Maybe hold hands?"

Catra smiles. Her genuine one, not her mischievous one, Adora is relieved to notice.

"Okay, that's very helpful to know. Would you like to hear my expectations?"

"Do they involve sex?"

Adora was mostly kidding. Catra's face definitely is not.

"No, Dor, sex isn't an expectation. I want you. You've said you wanted me. I don't expect anything to happen unless we both want it to. I like teasing you, but I don't want to *push* you. Does it feel like I am?"

"No," Adora responds quickly. She pulls Catra closer to whisper, "The teasing is good. I like it."

"Good to know. I guess I just expected that we'd have fun. Whatever that looks like. This isn't a meeting – we don't have to have an agenda." Adora must make a face because Catra adds, "It's fine if you do. I'll follow your lead."

"No, you're right," Adora admits with a sigh. "I may have overthought this."

"Really? Adora Gray? Overthinking?"

That earns Catra another tickle. Her defense is, possibly intentionally, pitiful. She throws her whole body into Adora's and burrows against her chest.

"No tickling on first dates!" Catra yells. "That's way too familiar."

"Last week, you sent me a picture of your underwear choices for tonight. I think we're past familiar."

Catra scratches her nails down the back of Adora's neck, just the way she likes it.

"Want to guess which ones I wore?" she rasps into Adora's ear.

"Anyway," Adora says, moving back a bit. "I understand your expectations now. Thank you."

She feels so mature.

“I think yours are absurd but I understand them. Thank *you* .” Catra gives her a short peck on the lips, like they’re sealing a deal. “We’ve literally been on a hundred dates, though.”

“I think you’re confusing me for some other woman you’re dating,” Adora returns lightly.

“Coffee dates, cocktail dates, dinner dates, lunch dates, double-dates, triple-dates. We’ve seen every inch of this city together.”

“Not official dates!” Adora argues. “Romance, remember? *Intentional* romance. Now, it’s time for food and drinks, so we should order. We need to head towards the theater in about,” she pauses to check her alarm, “63 minutes.”

“Nothing more romantic than a tight schedule,” Catra says with a fake enthusiastic smile. She’s maybe doing an impression of Adora but the blonde can’t quite tell.

“I’m surprised you didn’t make a ‘tight’ joke.”

“Is there time allotted for jokes in the schedule? I don’t want to slow us down. Only 62 minutes and 5 seconds left-”

Adora shuts her up by kissing her.

“Is there time in the schedule for kissing?” Catra asks as soon as they part.

Adora makes a frustrated noise. It’s mostly for show really. Cause even with Catra being about one-fifth as difficult as usual, it’s still the best first date Adora’s ever been on.

Not long after she gets home, Adora decides to call Catra. She manages to hold off for a full 10 minutes so she can prepare for bed.

After the show, they had found it hard to say goodnight. So Catra had ended up pushed against the side of her car with Adora's lips

all over her. And then in the backseat. And then onto her front door until Finn convinced Perfuma that they'd heard a burglar, tried to peek into the hall, and caught Adora feeling up their guardian.

They were both grateful that things in Catra's hallway hadn't escalated as far as it had in the backseat, where Adora learned why Catra was so interested in her wearing a skirt. She now had *bite marks* along the inside of her thigh for the first time.

Waiting just a little bit longer for sex was already turning into really delicious torture.

When Catra answers the video call, she's in bed, sprawled out on her stomach. She barely lifts her head to look at Adora.

"Mmrp? Were your ears burning?"

Adora smiles smugly and tries to sound smooth when she replies, "Hmm? Were you talking about me with Perfuma?"

"No. I was alone. *In bed* ." It looks like she's trying to smirk but hasn't recovered enough muscle control yet.

Oh.

"Oh. Ahem. Did you just, uh... *finish* ?"

Catra nods lazily against the comforter, her attempt at a grin successful.

Adora had called to flirt a little. She had not calculated for this.

"Well, I wanted to tell you that I had a nice time," she says slowly. Maybe just go with honesty? Honesty's hot sometimes. "But now all I can think about is you screaming my name."

Catra purrs quietly, squirming a bit into the bed.

"I think I managed to keep it to a quiet moan."

“Good Kitten,” comes out as a breathless whisper.

She groans in response, shifting against the bed harder.

“I could go again,” Catra offers. “If you wanted to watch.”

Adora has to bite her lip to keep from yelling ‘yes, please!’ immediately.

“As tempting as that is, I’d prefer if the first time I watch you have an orgasm, it’s live and in-person.” She pauses to watch as Catra writhes just a little more, face somewhere between pleasure and frustration. Then she adds, “And all over my hands.”

“You’re gonna pay for this torture.”

Adora just chuckles, the sound coming from somewhere deep in her throat and giving the perfect air of fake confidence.

With an exaggerated harrumph, Catra pushes herself into a sitting position. She’s naked because, of course, Adora can’t just call her up and not expect to have her mind blown. Catra looks quite pleased with herself.

They had achieved a near-perfect date, where Catra genuinely enjoyed the show and laughed at the jokes, cried at the end, and only sorta made fun of the acting. She had basically begged the blonde to stay over after they couldn’t keep their hands off of each other. Adora’s seen virtually all of Catra’s body by now.

She can do this. She can play it cool.

“Pleaseletmetakeyououtagain.” Idiot.

“I know you haven’t been on a date in the last century, but you’re supposed to wait three days afterwards before you reach out and ask for another.”

“I know that advice is from last century.”

There’s a short pause before Catra tilts her head with a smile and says, “Nope.”

Everything feels cold. Was it that cold in here before?

“Take a breath, Dor.” She rolls her eyes. “Tonight was amazing and I loved it, which I told you repeatedly. Next one’s my turn. So, Adora, will you go out with me?”

Catra’s sitting oddly still while she waits, completely tuned into Adora’s reaction.

“Are you worried I’m not going to say yes?”

“Wipe that smug look off your face,” she answers. “I tried to make reservations at this amazing farm-to-table place downtown for your birthday like 4 months ago. But the closest opening they had was next Friday. I’ve been worried about this falling through for months now. You comin’ or no?”

Adora pauses dramatically just to make Catra sweat.

“What are you planning for my birthday then?”

“Oh, I was gonna continue my annual tradition of picking up one of your friends,” Catra dryly replies. “I’ll probably go for Bow this year.”

“Homewrecker.”

A whiny, “ *Adoooora* ,” is what she gets in reply.

“Maybe I’ll get that final Christmas present on my birthday?” Adora asks. She hasn’t really stopped thinking about Catra in her letterman once in the past week.

“Gods willing, you’ll get it sooner.”

Adora slowly raises an eyebrow. “That all depends on whether you behave, Kitten.”

When Catra growls, she just tuts in response.

“I’d love to go out with you next week.”

“Good,” Catra sighs, sounding relieved.

“So I’ll choose the third date?” Adora asks. She already has something in mind. Maybe she kinda has already planned the next *several* dates in advance.

“Don’t go getting ahead of yourself, princess. We’ll see how the second one goes.”

“I’ll bring an overnight bag.” She makes sure to drop her voice so Catra gets the very obvious implication.

“Hoping to get these lady fingers?”

Adora hangs up on the little shit.

Scorpia and Entrapta invite Adora to brunch. Just Adora. No Catra. Adora’s never spent time with them alone before, always having Catra or Perfuma as a buffer. She considers inviting Bow but realizes that that will make it seem like she’s avoiding them, which she isn’t.

Scorpia’s stronger than Adora is. Entrapta’s smarter. If she had to spend time with one of them, maybe it would be fine. But both of them together? It’s oddly intimidating.

The brunch place is fine. Kinda basic. Catra would hate it. None of them drink much so they probably should have just had lunch like regular, reasonable people.

“What are your intentions with our best friend?” Scorpia begins before they’ve even ordered. She’s crossed her arms and is wearing the most serious face that Adora’s ever seen on her.

“Uhhh…I...what?”

“Every time you run into issues, Catra gets very sad,” Entrapta points out. “I believe Scorpia is concerned that you are committed to moving forward with Catra, rather than continuing your confusing, undefined friendship and leading to further conflict.”

“Catra and I are dating,” Adora clarifies. “I don’t know if she told you that already. We’ve talked about how we feel and what we want. I think we’re fine.”

She expects Scorpia, at least, to be surprised or excited. Scorpia doesn’t budge.

“Oh, we’re aware,” Entrapta answers. “Scorpia’s question is still valid.”

It's kinda funny. Like an old mob movie. Someone speaking for the muscle.

Thankfully the server comes over to take their order right then. Adora tries to beg her to stay with her eyes but she must just look wild and manic because they leave immediately.

When Adora glances back at her brunch mates, they’re still staring at her. Hard.

They don’t speak for several long moments. So Adora thinks she should continue.

“Um,” the problem is she’s not really sure what to say. One of the things Catra had asked for was Adora to tell people how she feels about her. “I’m in love with Catra.”

Good opening.

“I-I want to be with her. In a...romantic relationship.”

Scorpia still looks unimpressed. Adora wonders if she even realizes that she’s flexing her huge arms.

She decides to just keep saying things that resemble words. “I-we-um. For a long time? Hopefully? If she wants?”

“And you're positive of this?” Entrapta asks.

“Yes,” Adora answers, managing to not stumble this time.

Scorpia slowly uncrosses her arms and breaks out into a huge smile. She takes Adora's hand into her pincer, ignoring the panicked look on the blonde’s face. Is she about to break her tiny human fingers?

“I'm so happy to hear that!” Scorpia yells, getting about half the restaurant’s attention on them. “Catra's so great. And gosh, *you're* so great too. And Finn! Wow, oh boy. This is amazing. You're going to make the best couple. And Perfuma and me can go with you on real double-dates now. Oh, Perfuma! She's gonna be so excited! She loves you both so much.”

The grip from the pincer only kinda hurts. Adora smiles through the pain. She looks to Entrapta for her response and she's already turned her attention to her phone.

Adora gently takes her hand back.

Without looking up, Entrapta says, “Would you like to know you and Catra's viability as a romantic pairing?”

“...wha?”

“It's based on the abandoned dating profiles that you each created on Cuff. Did you know that there was only a 10-day window between your sign up date and your last known login?”

Yes, Adora went on two dates two years ago and gave up immediately.

“I've designed an updated algorithm, based on compatibility indicators from several external sources. It's 61% more accurate than Cuff’s proprietary matching algorithm.”

Entrapta's face is growing in excitement. It's slightly more frightening than when Adora thought she might lose her index finger moments ago. She glances over at Scorpia, who looks as confused and trepidatious as Adora feels.

But Entrapta's not waiting for an answer, never really was probably. “The viability of a coupling between Adora and Catra is-”

“Entrapta, I don't think this is necess-” Adora tries to rush out. She can hear Scorpia babbling next to her.

“-ty-nine,” Entrapta finishes.

Wait. Now Adora has to know. The range of possible numbers that she misses is too wide. What if it was 29? That would be awful. What if it's 99?! That's a lot of pressure. They're a near-perfect match and Adora still fucks it up?

But she's missed her chance because Entrapta has moved on to trying to get Scorpia to listen to the viability of her and Perfuma's relationship.

“I'd really prefer not to know. Please, Entrapta.”

“But the data-”

“Will not change anything,” Scorpia finishes.

“Right,” Adora agrees, half to herself. “And the... variables, yeah? I mean that data's two years old. A lot’s changed since then.”

“Good point,” Entrapta replies. “I should collect newer info.”

“I'm not updating my profile,” Adora asserts quickly. “I don't really need it anymore.” Hopefully ever again.

“Yes,” Entrapta agrees, typing something into her phone. “Well, I'll figure out a way around that barrier.”

“You should warn Catra. Just in case,” Scorpia whispers to Adora. “Just to maybe throw out her trash differently or-or change her passwords. For a little while maybe.”

Adora watches Entrapta stealthily delete the last few lines she typed.

Chapter End Notes

is adora getting off on not getting off? seems like it.

for some reason, after i wrote the section with entrapta and scorpia, i became obsessed with the idea of them dating so that's probably gonna show up in a future fic. i feel like they have an odd chemistry that i was not prepared for but then immediately got into.

next week is the last week of this story. i'm sad. but, like, good sad. everyone has been so nice and deeply weird and i'll really miss that.

chapter 21 preview. it's called "world-class lover." guess which one of these two useless dummies claims to have that title.

World-Class Lover

Chapter Summary

An untraditional second date. Catra takes care of Adora. Adora takes direction.

Chapter Notes

shout-outs to: the friend who introduced me to the term 'timid top'; and Enigm17a who suggested the chapters could be 3 times longer, thereby giving me an excuse to add in all the silly vignettes i had originally left out of this chapter. i had basically written a sex montage and then thought 'oh, no, that's too much sex' and edited it.

you almost didn't have an entire scene where [redacted].

warnings: this whole thing is smut. pretty much from the line "you can fuck me if you want" til the end. there's only one section in there where they're not having sex and it starts with "once catra's completely boneless" and ends with the next vertical line. there's some power play. praise kink. restraints for a brief moment. some very light spanking. property damage. adora freaking out cause she's adora. catra being a cat. two goobers being silly in bed.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It's the perfect storm. Adora has a quarterly board meeting on Monday that she has to prep for, a grant application due at midnight that her ancient computer ate the draft of, and a day of tiny fires that she needs to put out.

Around 3pm, she realizes that there’s no way she’s going to finish everything by 7, the time she and Catra had agreed upon for their second date. Catra was so excited about it. They both were really.

Catra answers on the second ring, already smiling slyly.

“Can’t wait?”

Adora sighs quietly. “I’m really sorry, Cat.” Her smile begins to fade before Adora’s even done with her sentence. “I told you about th-“

“Grant and the Board meeting and Glimmer being an idiot, yeah,” Catra lists off. “You need to cancel.”

“ *Reschedule* ,” Adora corrects. “Can we move it to tomorrow?”

Catra flat out laughs. “Yeah, that reservation was impossible to get. Maybe better luck in the spring.” She begins moving around quickly, then yells, slightly further away from the phone, “Merms, you and Steven just got into that farm-to-table place on 4th tonight! 8 pm! It’s on me!”

In the background, Adora just barely hears Mermista yell back ‘are you *shitting* me?!’

Catra sits down, smiling again. “Well, at least you made one girl happy today.”

“I really am sorry,” Adora repeats.

Catra just waves it off. “Quit wasting time and get back to work, you louse. If you’re there til 1 am, I actually *will* be pissed.”

Mercifully, Adora manages to leave the office around 9:55. Traffic’s not great cause the streets seem to be filled with taxis full of people heading out for a night on the town, but she’s home not too late.

The smell hits her before she notices the lights on. That’s probably best cause otherwise, Adora might have tried to wrestle the intruder to the ground. Once she sees who’s in her kitchen, she still considers going that route. Just in a much, *much* different way.

Adora’s bone-tired and mentally exhausted. So the sight of Catra, standing at her stove, singing and quietly dancing while wearing one of Adora’s old tshirt jerseys and biking shorts, nearly brings her to tears. Catra’s cooking, of course. Smells like roast chicken.

She’s singing to herself, a nice rare treat.

‘I’m a hot knife, she’s a pat of butter. If I get a chance, I’m gonna show her that she’s never gonna need another, never need another.’

‘Marry me,’ Adora thinks to herself.

“I've been asked with more finesse before,” Catra says. She tosses a smirk over her shoulder.

That smirk plus something about seeing ‘Gray’ across her back nearly makes Adora growl. She doesn’t even care that she just accidentally proposed. Or that apparently she’s not the first.

“Hi. What are you doing?” she asks, slowly dropping her bag and jacket and moving into the room more fully. All across the kitchen, she notices, there’s empty grocery bags everywhere. “Planning for a feast?”

Catra still doesn’t turn from the stove. “You eat enough for a family of four so I imagine that wouldn’t be unwelcome.” Adora can hear the smile in her voice.

“Seriously — what’s up?”

Catra drops her head slightly, hiding her face. Her voice comes out small.

“I was worried about you. I know when you go hard, you forget to take care of yourself. You’re probably ridiculous enough to work through the weekend so I picked up stuff to make dinner for tonight and something for you to pick at tomorrow. Plus groceries for you to do meal prep on Sunday. Obviously if you’re still busy then, you can just call me and I’ll come over and take care of it.”

So. No one, not even Bow, has ever done anything like this for Adora. Catra's literally feeding her for a week. No guilt trips, no judgement about working. Just food for days and a gorgeous woman in Adora's clothes, which she realizes is a thing for her now.

She doesn't open her mouth for fear of proposing again.

Catra's getting twitchy though. She chances a glance over her shoulder and Adora catches the blush on her cheeks.

"Glimmer let me in, by the way. She also gave me a *key* , which felt like a creepy overstep so I left it over there on the table for you. At least she and Bow took the cub for a while so I could focus on this."

Still avoiding eye contact with Adora, she pops over from the stove to retrieve a highball glass and pours out a drink that's been waiting in the cocktail mixer. She shoves it into Adora's hands before returning to stirring a pot.

"I know this isn't really second date territory, me in your house touching everything. I'll just leave when the food is done and you can be alone and decompress."

Catra's *nervous* , Adora realizes way too late.

"Can the food pause?" the blonde asks, taking a quick sip of the cocktail before setting it down. It's absolutely delicious, she notes absently. Her attention's a bit elsewhere currently.

"Uh, y-yeah," Catra responds. "Everything's basically done." Catra's hand shakes a little as she turns the burners off and removes the chicken from the oven.

"Sorry. I must look like a fuckin' weirdo, barging in here and doing all this shit without asking."

She barely has time to remove the oven mitts before Adora's on her, placing her hands on Catra's hips and pulling her into her own

body. Adora quickly reaches lower and grabs Catra's thighs to heft her into the air and push her up against the fridge.

Catra squeaks softly in surprise but is immediately quieted by Adora's insistent lips against hers.

This isn't anything like their previous kisses. This is frantic almost, rougher than they usually are with each other.

"Fuck," Catra groans when they break to catch a breath. "I love you like this."

Adora just makes out with her harder, tightening her grip on the toned thighs in her hands. Catra gasps into the next kiss.

"Too hard?"

Catra shakes her head. "No. Hard is good."

As if to prove it, two fangs bite down on Adora's neck. She doesn't consciously remember deciding to throw Catra down onto the island and pin her there. But that's somehow where Catra ends up, trying to arch up into Adora's body.

The blonde just takes a moment to breathe, concerned about checking in.

She barely opens her mouth before Catra interrupts, breathlessly, "So it's okay that I came over?"

"Sorry. I was literally speechless. I'm so fucking lucky."

"Yeah, I'm pretty amazing," Catra whispers lowly.

"You are," Adora agrees, lips dropping to Catra's collarbone.

"You can fuck me if you want. I want it."

She almost pulls off sounding confident. But Adora hears the nervousness in her voice.

“Are you sure?” Adora asks. “You sound...worried.”

“I just asked my fantasy girl to fuck me on her kitchen island. You try doing that without turning into fucking mess.”

Adora can’t help her smirk. “Fantasy girl?”

“You want me to tell you about all the times I fucked myself while thinking about you?” Catra asks, voice deceivingly sweet.

“You want to delay this any longer?” Her smirk is still firmly in place as she waits for Catra's next move.

Never one to back down, Catra shocks the smile right off of the blonde’s face by shoving Adora's hand between a pair of furry thighs. A pair of *moist* furry thighs.

“Did you borrow my shorts and not wear underwear?”

Catra groans. It’s honestly hard to tell if it’s a frustrated horny sound or frustrated annoyed sound.

“That’s your first reaction? Not ‘Gods, you’re so wet for me’ or ‘yes, I want to fuck you too’ or ‘step on me, please’?”

Adora moves her hand with a bit more purpose, applying some pressure. That takes all of the fight out of Catra.

“I’d like to talk more about that last one later,” Adora tells her with a smile.

Catra’s hands go to the waistband of the shorts.

“Wait,” Adora says quickly, causing her to pause. She’s almost too turned on to think straight but exhaustion is catching up to her pretty fast.

“No pressure if you're too tired,” Catra says in return, relaxing against the island. She puts a bit of space between them, which

Adora is both grateful for and firmly hating. “You had a bad day. I could just take care of *you* ?”

And Gods, the idea pulls them back together in another rough kiss.

“You’re sure?” Adora asks against Catra’s lips.

In response, she gets another frustrated groan. A claw forces her to meet Catra’s eyes.

“Be honest, Dor. Do you like being told what to do?”

Adora holds her gaze for a long moment, considering it. She’s definitely had at least one very specific dream about Catra and *demands* and her suits.

“I’ve never really tried, at least not in this context,” Adora replies.

Catra raises an eyebrow, “ *Sex* , you mean. You can say the word.”

Adora chooses to ignore that and just nod instead.

“Okay,” Catra replies, licking her lips slowly. “Let’s try it.”

It’s now Adora’s turn to be nervous. “I never even asked what your...preference is.”

“Hmm?”

Adora looks at her pointedly. “You have toppy vibes.”

Catra just cackles. “Many people have thought I was a top before. Those people have been *disappointed* .”

“Oh,” Adora responds with a frown. That doesn't really answer the question.

Catra tilts her head. “Is that what you wanted? You’re the queen of toppy vibes. Like, a Timid Top, maybe. I’m honestly good either

way."

Adora shrugs. She's genuinely just excited about the idea of being more intimate with Catra in general. She's not too picky about the particulars right now.

"Let's be real," Catra continues. "I usually end up *in charge* regardless of what position I'm in."

Adora can't help the way her hips twitch to get closer to Catra. The voice in the back of her head that usually reminds her of every insecurity freezes and shuts up at the prospect of Catra taking control.

Judging by how much Catra's claws unconsciously dig into the hand still trapped between her legs, it's clear that she's thrilled with Adora's reaction.

"I'll stop anytime you want," she says, earnestly. Then she pauses for a moment. Her voice comes out much lower and raspier when she adds, "Now, be a good girl and stand up straight for me."

' *Yes* ', Adora's body screams, 'this is actually exactly what we need.' She complies without question, lining up immediately.

"Such perfect posture," Catra coos.

Adora notices herself preening a little. This is the kind of thing that she'd usually be embarrassed about, her excitement over the silliest compliments. She's way too turned on to be self-conscious about that now.

Catra still hasn't moved from the island. Her eyes are intently set on Adora, claws idly teasing at the waistband of her shorts.

"Take off your shirt. I want to see that gorgeous body of yours."

Adora blushes, and then realizes that Catra's about to see exactly how far down it goes. Dutifully, she removes her shirt. Her hands go to the clasp of her bra next.

“Did I tell you to do that?” Catra asks, sitting up quickly. She keeps her voice even, but there’s just a hint of a warning underneath.

Adora drops her arms immediately to her sides. “No. I’m sorry.”

“I forgive you,” Catra replies with a smirk. “Now. Hold still for me and let me admire my Dor.”

Adora's always loved how possessive Catra tends to get about her. The thought that that extends to sex as well, that Catra’s now intent on possessing Adora's body now too, has her biting her lip to keep from begging already.

One long claw starts at her neck and moves achingly across her skin, down her arm. Across her collarbone. Around the edge of her bra. Across her stomach. Before winding around her belt loop.

“So handsome,” Catra whispers, then tugs Adora closer.

Catra’s lips go to her neck, while her fingers work nimbly to unbutton Adora’s jeans. Adora gasps at the feel of Catra’s rough tongue against her pulse point, moaning when it’s replaced by Catra’s teeth. Her hands reach out to grab Catra and hold her closer.

“Hands at your sides,” Catra replies, voice just a little harder than her earlier warning.

Adora immediately obeys, desperately wanting to be good for her.

“Such an obedient girl,” Catra purrs.

She leans down to bite just above Adora’s bra. Suddenly, she’s sliding down from the island and switching places with Adora, flipping them so the blonde’s back is against the counter.

Catra very, *very* slowly lowers Adora’s zipper.

“You’re always so perfect. Do you want a reward, Dor?”

Adora can only nod dumbly.

“Good.” Catra pauses to move closer to Adora's lips before whispering, “I’m gonna make you cum in my mouth. Do you want that?”

‘Yes,’ she wants to scream. It’s all so perfect and overwhelming that she nearly weeps again. Instead, she manages to nod once more.

Catra nuzzles her cheek against Adora’s shoulder, requesting gently, “I’m gonna need you to say it, babe.”

“Please,” she moans out. “ *Please* , Cat.”

For the first time, Catra dispenses with the teasing and picks up the pace. She immediately drops to her knees, looks up at Adora, and lowers the blonde’s pants to her ankles. Catra feathers kisses up her thighs til Adora’s shivering and balling her hands up into fists to keep them at her sides.

“You can grip the counter if it keeps you standing,” Catra chuckles against her skin.

Adora doesn’t even have a chance to reach out before her underwear’s pulled down next. Catra pauses then, just observing for a second. Adora’s never had anyone look at her like that. She has to fight her instinct to get shy and cover up. It takes a moment but she obeys the command to stand still. She receives a bright, fanged smile for passing that test.

“Keep your eyes on me,” Catra orders. “I want you to watch.”

It’s honestly impossible to look away when her long tongue peeks out and meets Adora’s clit in a slow, languid lick. Adora’s not sure which one of them moans the loudest. But then Catra mutters, “Fuck!”, and dives back in, absolutely losing herself in her task.

Adora’s more turned on from that, seeing how much Catra seems to savor tasting her. Really, receiving like this has never been her

favorite thing in the past but the idea of Catra offering lit a fire between her legs. Actually watching Catra enjoy it, however, is truly driving Adora to new heights.

She so badly wants to take more control, grip Catra's mane, arch up into her mouth. The tongue exploring her is rough yet soft, teasing while maintaining the perfect amount of pressure. It's fucking Heaven.

Adora grips the island, hoping that it's well-made enough to withstand. The movement must catch Catra's attention cause she opens her eyes, trapping Adora in her gaze.

Catra pulls back just far enough to ask, "Do you like this?"

Adora nods, more focused on getting control of her hips. Catra just raises an eyebrow, not moving. Everything about the look screams that her patience is wearing thin.

"You're so fucking good," Adora blurts out. She's never sounded so desperate to her own ears.

Catra goes to remove Adora's pants and underwear completely, still refusing to look away from the intense stare.

"You can touch me now," she says. "I want you to stop holding back. Just let go."

Then her mouth is on Adora's clit, sucking softly, tongue still lashing against the bud. Adora's hands fly to her hair to keep her there. She worries about digging in too hard but that's cut off immediately when Catra trills at the roughness. The vibration's such a perfect bonus. Adora throws her head back, fucking into Catra's face faster and harder.

It takes a few tries before she's able to get her coordination together to open her eyes and look down again. Catra hasn't wavered at all, still staring at her intently.

"Fuck, you're going to make me-", Adora barely gets out.

Catra moans again, tongue speeding up. Within moments, Adora tilts her head back and screams Catra's name, cumming all over her face.

Her next coherent thought takes a good while. It's mostly the realization that she's not going to have time to warn Catra before her body slumps to the floor. Luckily, Catra has quick enough reflexes to catch her before that happens.

"What's wrong?"

They're in bed now, both undressed. That's all Catra's doing since Adora took a very amusingly long time to recover from the most intense orgasm she can ever remember having. By the time they were both ready for round two, her nerves had managed to rebound as well.

"I'm not as good as you," Adora explains. She's drunk off of endorphins, feeling vulnerable and honest.

Catra just rolls her eyes. "Well, duh. I'm a world-class lover. Everyone knows that."

Adora laughs in response. At least she's entertaining?

She's an...efficient lover, she thinks. Sturdy, gets the job done. Never has brought a whole lot of excitement and thrill to the bedroom though. And *fuck* does Catra deserve excitement and passion and to be reduced to as much of a mess as she just made Adora.

"It's not a competition, Dor."

"Everything's a competition between us," Adora replies quickly.

"Yeah, well, not this one thing," Catra says, moving closer. "Plus, did you not feel how wet I was just kissing you? This is a very low pressure situation. You'll do great. Focus on the journey, you know, not the destination."

Adora bites her lip, still reluctant to make a move.

“Okay,” Catra says. She's making her ‘thinking’ face. “Maybe let’s- what parts do you think you’re good at?”

Adora ponders that for a moment, trying to grasp at any helpful feedback she's ever received.

“I’m pretty good with my hands,” she comes up with eventually.

Catra quickly replies,“Yeah, I’d be lying if I said I definitely didn’t have to jerk myself off the first time you mentioned that. So I’ll definitely want you to use those.”

That’s as reassuring as it is arousing.

“I’ve been told I’m not bad with my tongue.”

“Good. Sold. Let’s start.”

Catra lies on her back, practically offering herself up. She looks gorgeous fully undressed, curvy and soft and, like usual, just a little dangerous. Adora still doesn’t move.

“Okay, what are you not saying?” Catra asks, suspiciously. When Adora doesn’t respond, Catra slowly starts to reach for the comforter.

Her ears flatten. “...is it me? We never talked about-...I probably don’t *look* like other people you’ve fucked. You seemed into me when we made out, so I didn’t even think to ask if you,” she pauses, gulps, “wanted me?”

“Of course I want you, Cat. Have I not made you feel that way?”

“I mean, it took us so long to get to this point that I’d be lying if I said that didn’t cross my mind once or twice.”

Adora sighs. Another unintended consequence of her being a total coward.

She gently takes the comforter out of Catra's hands. Slowly and intentionally, she drags her eyes down the nude body in front of her.

"I know you're...different. I love that about you. *In a non-creepy way* ," she clarifies quickly. "There's nothing about you that I don't want. Honestly, I've never wanted anyone so much."

That's why the possibility of actually *having* is so daunting.

A claw comes up underneath her chin and Adora reluctantly looks up to meet Catra's eyes.

"Tell me what's wrong then."

Adora knows she's turning redder. "Um. I'm not so good at fun stuff? Like, kink stuff. Toys. I'm kinda bland."

Should she have mentioned this earlier? Catra's worldly and adventurous and Adora is...not.

Catra just smiles patiently. "So you're gonna fuck me now. I need it hard and you're gonna follow every direction I give, right?"

"Yes. But-"

"Don't care about any of that, Dor. I just want you to be present right now, okay?" Her hand goes to Adora's cheek, caressing softly.

"Okay," Adora agrees with a small nod. She can do that.

"We'll figure out everything else later. We can talk about what you do and do not want. What I do and do not want. And what we want together. But right now…?"

Adora dutifully repeats, "I'm going to fuck you. *Hard* and listen to direction."

“Good girl,” Catra moans in anticipation, grinding her thighs together.

Once Catra’s completely boneless in the bed, finally exhausted and sated, it’s nearly 2 am. Adora’s grateful that they had the presence of mind earlier to text Glimmer. Unfortunately, she claimed she could hear them screaming all the way on the 4th floor but she agreed that the cub could sleep over.

“You should eat,” Catra lazily mumbles.

“Again?” Adora smirks. “Okay.”

She raises her head from Catra’s thigh, moving slightly higher. Catra just grunts.

“Not that, dummy.”

“Oh. You hungry?” Adora asks. She’d be embarrassed about the misunderstanding if she hadn’t spent an hour just trying to hold on while Catra rode her face with abandon.

“Yeah, I’ll get up and warm everything up. Just give me a minute.”

Catra truly looks like she can not move though. She hasn’t opened her eyes in 10 minutes at least. After the last orgasm, she kinda collapsed like a bag of sand and hasn’t so much as twitched since then. Adora’s pretty proud of that.

And also a little concerned, honestly.

“Are you okay?”

“It was too good,” Catra whispers. Her voice sounds so spacey and far away.

“You don’t have to just say that.” Adora applied her usual fastidiousness but doesn’t think she really did anything special.

Catra shifts for the first time, reaching out a claw to capture Adora's cheek. She slowly directs the blonde's face to hers.

"Dor, you were so so amazing. Truly. My Gods, your *hands* ." She follows this up with an absent moan and drops her claw from Adora, arching her back, like a delayed aftershock is going through her again. Mostly to herself, she adds " *So* good."

Then there's a trill, Catra burrowing herself further into the bed. By the time she starts purring, Adora realizes she's asleep. She doesn't laugh for fear of waking her lover, who manages to look so sweet and precious, considering how absolutely vulgar she was just minutes ago, chanting some of the dirtiest, sexiest things Adora's ever heard before in her life.

Adora quietly excuses herself to the kitchen for a quick snack. The fridge and cupboard are fuller than they've ever been. The food on the stove looks so appetizing that she doesn't even bother reheating it, just eating it cold, straight out of the pan.

She's so unbelievably lucky, she realizes. Catra loves her so much, takes care of her, and they literally just had the best sex of Adora's life. Catra genuinely did seem to enjoy it as well, if her words, sounds, and insistence on doing it repeatedly was to be believed. Adora's never felt more *wanted* before. It's enough to keep all of her annoying, gnawing thoughts quiet for a good long while.

Gods, the food's amazing too.

She shoves everything into the packed fridge so they can enjoy it tomorrow. Without bothering to clean up after herself, Adora goes back to bed to find Catra's still asleep. Naked and in Adora's bed. She scoots in beside her and Catra immediately nestles into Adora's arms and chest, like always except the nudity and afterglow makes it feel so much more intimate and amazing.

Catra sleepily whispers, "I love you" and Adora returns it. Yes, this is much better.

There's the sound of a camera flashing and then a very quiet curse. Adora finds herself stirring reluctantly, not at all ready to part from the dream she was having about a certain sweet little jerk. Adora was so exhausted by the time she fell asleep that she's surprised anything could rouse her now. Apparently, paranoia is more than enough.

She sleepily mumbles, "Did you take a photo of me?"

"No," Catra replies. Adora can *hear* her smirking.

She cracks open one eye. Catra's holding Adora's phone and, while it is certainly close to the blonde's face, Catra's apparently taking a photo of herself based on her pose.

Catra's kneeling up near Adora's head, her butt resting on the heels of her feet.

Adora's brain slowly begins to boot up. Catra's naked. In her bed. Still looking absolutely wrecked from last night, skin bitten and marred, hair all mussed. Operation system 100% online now.

"What *were* you doing?"

"Just something to remember me by," Catra replies before dropping the phone to the bed. "I would have gotten away with it if you didn't leave your sound on like a grandpa."

"What exactly was the scheme?"

She lightly shrugs. "You're looking through your photos for something and boom! Suddenly there's the hottest woman you've ever seen before."

"Like this hasn't been burned into my brain after last night," Adora replies, dragging her eyes slowly down Catra's body. She freezes when she gets to her thighs. Without the phone blocking it, Adora is looking right down the barrel of Catra's pussy.

Catra parts her knees wider with a little trill when she notices.

Adora's gaze remains fixated for a moment before Catra leans down to kiss her.

"Let me brush my teeth first," Adora tells her, jerking away slightly.

"Fuck no. Your whole face smells like me. I wanna taste how you enjoyed yourself last night."

She dives right in, one hand cupping Adora's chin and the other gripping at her hair. Catra wastes no time sliding her tongue into the blonde's mouth, not bothering to tease at all. She trills again and Adora imagines she must indeed taste herself.

"Sorry about last night," Adora mumbles against Catra's lips when they break for a breath.

"I'm not," she whispers back. Adora can feel that Catra's smiling.

"I mean, about how I froze up."

"Not a big deal," she says quickly.

"Cat-"

She sits up fully to glance down at Adora. Her eyes are so soft and kind.

"It's not. You get high strung sometimes; I stay cool. I work myself into a tizzy; you chill me out. It's called a reciprocal relationship."

"It won't happen again," Adora promises. Somewhere between rounds 2 and 3, she managed to actually get out of her head and just go with it.

"It's fine if it does. Sex is a big deal. Makes sense to have a lot of feelings about it."

“Are you sure it was okay?”

“Adora, I literally came so many times last night that I lost count. And consciousness, I think. We worked through it. Now-”

Catra maneuvers Adora’s hand between her legs. She’s absolutely soaked. Holy fuck, that will never get old.

“ *Focus* , princess,” she orders.

Adora groans, lost somewhere between the feeling of Catra here now and the knowledge that hiding in her phone is a photo of Catra, wet and waiting in her bed.

Moving purely on instinct, Adora grabs Catra’s waist and pulls her down hard on top of her. Adora quickly reaches back down to cup between Catra’s thighs while the other hand grips onto her ass tightly.

Catra, who hasn’t once yielded easily since their first kiss, squirms to remain in control. Adora wasn’t surprised to discover that she was the brattiest bottom but Catra found so many new ways to be difficult last night. She begged for holds and pushed against them constantly. She baited Adora repeatedly. She *jeered* at one point.

Adora loved every minute of it.

Trying to stay in control, she grabs Catra’s ass harder, attempting to keep her hips from jerking while Catra pulls at her hair and bites her shoulder as a well-calculated distraction from how she’s currently trying to flip them over.

It’s enough that Adora’s grip shifts just a bit. Her right hand shuffles off of Catra’s bottom and winds up groping the base of her tail.

The next sequence happens so quickly that Adora’s head spins.

She freezes when she realizes what she’s done. Catra moans and quickly goes limp. The blonde pulls back both hands to raise

them, palms up in a show of apology. Her thigh feels just a tad wetter than before.

“That was an accident,” Adora says immediately. Tails are very sensitive and...private? Or something. It doesn’t feel like humans should go around just initiating contact with them.

“Then do it on purpose,” Catra demands from where her face is buried in Adora’s neck. She’s probably trying to sound tough but she’s so breathless that it really loses that effect.

Adora gently reaches down and massages the base of Catra’s tail.

“Like that, Kitten?”

Catra moans in a way that kinda reminds Adora of when she’d get a really great rubdown back when she was playing ball, someone releasing all of the tension out of an overused and underloved muscle.

“Fill me up?” is the mumbled reply.

Adora has to shift Catra’s whole weight, since she’s basically just collapsed on top of her now, so that a hand can weave back down between their bodies.

As soon as she has two fingers inside though, Catra jumps back to life, eyes blazing at Adora.

“ *Pull it* .”

Adora gives her pussy a hard thrust instead. Catra made her fight for every single inch last night. She could stand a little revenge.

“You’re going to have to ask nicer than that, Kitten.”

Catra bares her teeth, then is forced to squeeze her eyes shut and moan when she’s hit with another hard thrust of Adora’s fingers.

“Fuck!” she screams, removing her claws from Adora’s hair to grab at the sheets. “Pull it. Please?”

Adora obliges, both because Catra asked so nicely and also because she sounds absolutely *desperate* . She gives the tail a soft tug while picking up the speed with her other hand, quickening the pace that she’s moving in and out of Catra.

The responding curses go from screaming to muttering and back a couple times. Adora honestly has no idea if Catra can get off like this but, Gods, she’s having a great time trying. She raises the heel of her hand so that it rocks against Catra’s clit with every movement. As she expected, with the added pressure, Catra starts to tighten and pulse around her hand.

“Gods, you feel so good. I can't believe how fucking sexy you are.”

Catra whimpers at the praise.

“Come on, Kitten. You can do it. You're so close, aren't you?”

She barely nods, apparently using all of her remaining strength just to keep herself mostly upright. Her eyes are shut tight, head thrown back and a fang digging into her bottom lip. She looks absolutely lost in pleasure.

Adora is drunk with this power.

The blonde decides to tug her tail a little harder. She leverages her weight against the mattress underneath her to put as much power as possible into fucking up into Catra. Catra is so jostled that Adora’s sure she might fly off if her hands weren’t so tangled in the sheets.

It’s too tempting for Adora to not lean up and bite one of the perky little nipples dangling near her head. That combo of stimulation seems to be enough for Catra. She arches her back while her strong thighs attempt to slam shut, trapping Adora in place between them.

Adora’s mostly distracted by how completely soaked her palm is when Catra starts shaking on top of her. But that’s immediately bested by the guttural scream that Catra releases and the sound of tearing next to her head.

Slicing would actually be a better description since claws have not only ripped into the sheets but also cut into the mattress. So now Adora’s going to get a strongly worded letter from her neighbors and she needs to replace her bed.

Nope, she’s definitely never seen someone cum that hard before.

Catra drops like a dead weight on her again, all of her muscles going completely slack. Adora’s got a grin wide enough to split her face as she moves to hug Catra close and whisper what a good job her kitten’s done. The aftershocks are the only movement from Catra for a good long time, until she starts absently rubbing her cheek along Adora’s collarbone, marking everywhere she can reach easily.

When Catra’s returned to Etheria, Adora scoots down to get a good look at her. Aside from being completely fucking *dazed* , she seems alright.

“You’re very poorly behaved, Kitten,” she says, pretending to be stern.

“I'll buy you a real bed.”

“Rude! Also, not what I was referring to.”

“Hmm?” Catra raises her head to smile wickedly. “Was I a bad kitten? You want to put me in my place?”

Adora has to ball her hands into fists to ignore how much they’re itching to spank Catra’s fuzzy little butt. That’s an entirely new feeling. She kinda thinks she should maybe be ashamed or worried about it. And yet. She imagines Catra would beg for it if Adora voiced any interest in that.

It feels like they have so many more possibilities that Adora's cut herself off from before.

Adora opens her mouth to respond but is cut off by the sound of her front door opening.

Oh, Gods, no. There's only one person who would just saunter into her space without knocking first.

"Hellooooooo," Glimmer Fucking Moon calls out. "I know you're here. Can you make yourselves decent?"

It's a credit to how completely destroyed Catra is from her orgasm that she doesn't move an inch.

"Glimmer can walk right the fuck in here," she mumbles. "I couldn't care less."

"You're fine with her seeing me naked?" Adora tries.

Catra growls immediately. "No. *Mine* ."

By the time Adora has thrown on the closest sweats and tshirt she can grab, Glimmer's yelling again.

"Stop drinking each other's eggs and get out here so we can talk about actual breakfast!"

"Shh, the neighbors!" Adora whisper-shouts.

"Good morning, sunshine!" Glimmer beams. "You look like she blew your fucking mind last night."

Honestly, she'd like to be angry about being interrupted but Glimmer and Bow did drop everything to take care of Finn so Adora can't really complain.

"Is everything alright?"

"It's almost noon and you're not up and stressing over nothing," Glimmer says with a grin. "So you tell me?"

“What a thin excuse to come snoop.”

“I guess getting laid really changes your priorities,” she continues.

“We’ll be up,” Adora offers. “And then we can take Finn off your hands. We just need time to shower.”

Speaking of thin excuses…

Glimmer clearly reads it.

“How long?” she asks pointedly. Adora is fooling no one.

She tries anyway. “Well, there’s two of us. And Catra’s fur takes a while to dry. The water pressure’s not great. So...an hour probably?”

Glimmer is kind enough to just roll her eyes, instead of calling out the obvious ruse for Catra and Adora to spend more time together.

“Catra Ursula Morgan, get out here and give me your credit card!”

“I don’t think there’s any need for that,” Adora counters. That...doesn't seem like Catra's middle name.

“I love you, but no one’s talking to you, you poof-headed mess. Let me handle this.”

Wallet in hand, Catra appears just before Adora murders her best friend. She’s dressed in the clothes she borrowed yesterday and it takes all of the blonde’s self-control not to jump on her immediately.

“What kind of scam is this?” Catra asks, interrupting Adora’s quickly-devolving thoughts.

“Bow and I are going to take your child out to lunch and then probably the zoo or something,” Glimmer announces, with what she probably thinks is a gracious and giving tone. “I don’t know,

I’m coming up with this on the spot now. Your treat, obviously. Be done tearing each other apart by dinner time please.”

Catra attempts to tell her, “Actually, Adora has to wor-”

Glimmer cuts her off to warn, “Don’t make me take this back.”

A look passes between Catra and Adora, neither wanting to turn down this opportunity.

“I can do everything on Sunday probably,” Adora says with a shrug.

“Great!”

Rather than waiting for a credit card, Glimmer just plucks Catra’s wallet out of her hand. She’s gone immediately, leaving them no room to argue.

That’s probably for the best. She’s barely out of the door before Adora has Catra pinned up against it, scrambling to get her shorts back off.

Catra pulls back from the frantic kisses to remind Adora, “I believe you were going to put me in my place.”

Committed to doing just that, Adora weaves one hand into Catra’s hair and pulls while her other goes to pinch a rapidly-hardening nipple.

“Hmm, what do you want?”

“I want to bite those biceps,” Catra mutters around a moan.

“I can suggest better places for you to put your mouth,” Adora responds with a smirk.

“Can I call for a quick time out?” It seems to take all of her energy to switch gears and make this ask.

That’s a new concept. Adora reminds herself not to freak out about possibly having gone too far, as she drops her hands to her sides.

Catra backs up further until she’s fully flush against the door again and takes some deep breaths. Adora figures she should probably follow suit.

They spend some time just looking into each other’s eyes and relaxing together. It’s safe and comforting, something Adora’s never really felt in her previous sexual encounters.

“You’re doing great, Dor. I just wanted to check in – can I fuck you again?”

“Literally whenever you want,” she answers automatically.

It’s truly just nice to be asked. A lot of times in the past, people have either assumed that Adora had no interest at all or tried without seeing if that’s what she even wanted.

After the first round last night, Catra hadn’t touched her in that way, mostly because Adora hadn’t made any space for her to do so. Gods, she’s so pent up from topping though that she’ll probably explode as soon as Catra comes near her.

“Cool.” Catra seems so excited, which is actually quite precious. Her tail swishes around and everything. “Can I touch you or do you just want my mouth?”

What a talented mouth it is, though.

“Either. You can use your hands if you want,” Adora replies. “I don't need more than one finger inside, just FYI.”

Catra nods. “Got it. Okay, tim-”

“Can I spank you?” she asks quickly. There’s a 0% chance that Adora doesn’t sound as unsure as she feels.

Heterochromatic eyes grow impossibly large. Whether that’s shock or interest isn’t clear.

“I want to spank you,” Adora continues. “Just a little. When you’re being especially bratty. Not hard though.”

“Hard is fine,” Catra says, sounding far away. She blinks a couple times and suddenly she's back and in control. “Yeah. Yeah, you're gonna bend me over and take me. Spank me, whatever else you want, okay?”

Adora gives her a thumbs up, like an utter doofus.

“And then you’re gonna order me to make you cum,” Catra explains. “It would be really hot if you fucked my face but that doesn't have to be today.”

“Good to know,” comes out sounding wrecked.

Catra definitely notices, just based on how she slowly and intentionally licks her lips, getting the blonde more worked up.

“Yeah? You want to use my mouth? Shove your clit in there to shut me up?”

“Fuck,” Adora groans. She’s dying to get them undressed again. “Time in?”

Catra agrees, “Time in.”

Immediately Adora's all over her again, hand in Catra's hair to drag her back to bed.

Catra growls but it feels like a very empty threat. Adora gives her a quick slap on the ass just in case, not slowing down the very fast pace she’s set, nearly whirring in and out.

It’s becoming increasingly harder for Catra to hold back from cumming and the intermittent pain is probably just making it even

more difficult. Unfortunately(?) for Catra, she hasn't said the magic words yet.

She’s not exactly been subtle about how much she’s enjoying just being stretched out with 4 of Adora’s fingers inside of her, on her hands and knees waiting for permission to let everything go.

Knelt behind her, Adora moves her free hand to the base of Catra’s neck and very slowly scraps her nails down til they reach to tease at the base of her tail. Catra arches into the touch with a moan.

“What do you need, Kitten?”

“You know,” she grumbles, still being difficult. "I'm not gonna spell it out for you." Always so stubborn.

Another sharp slap on the ass changes her tone quickly.

“Please,” Catra moans, pushing back, slamming her hips against Adora. “Please rub my clit and make me cum.”

Instead, Adora reaches forward and yanks one of her nipples a bit too roughly.

“Gods, I'm gonna ruin these fucking sheets.”

She’s already all but gushing onto Adora’s hand, so that’s probably true.

“Then do it, Kitten.” Adora backs up her challenge by finally moving her other fingers down to massage circles onto Catra’s very puffy little clit. “Cum for me right now.”

When it’s clear that Catra's about to tumble right off the edge into peak pleasure, Adora pauses briefly to shove her face down into the bed and muffle her scream. Catra’s smart enough to keep that position long afterwards, while the blonde replaces her hand with her tongue to clean up the very wet mess that they’ve made.

Adora didn’t really have any intention of restraining Catra. It simply had to be done.

Once she started eating Adora out, she refused to keep her hands out of her own pussy and that behavior couldn’t be encouraged. Thus, Catra ended up on her back on top of her own locked wrists, where one of Adora’s ties was keeping them in place. That still left three highly unpredictable appendages so Adora had to mount her face and use her strong hands to hold Catra’s thighs down.

Her tail has gone completely rogue, choosing to side with Adora and tighten around her right wrist. It’s helpfully communicating how much Catra enjoys this, even while insisting on being a brat.

Adora keeps chugging along, grinding herself down into Catra's open and furiously working mouth. Adora's never sat on someone's face before but the offer (challenge?) to get up there and take whatever she wants was too tempting.

She spreads her legs a little more, sinking down further. That just accidentally puts her own head closer to the lap in front of her. The sight of Catra, spread out and open is enough to make the blonde’s mouth water.

Do people actually 69 in real life, outside of porn? Adora’s never thought it could really work. Well, what the hell? Might as well seize the day.

It only takes Adora a couple of licks before she realizes this is a fool’s errand. It’s impossible to focus and stay on task while every nerve in her body surges with pleasure.

Behind her, Catra’s head drops to the bed with a loud thump. Adora has to bear her weight down harder to keep Catra’s hips pinned to the bed.

“What?” Adora releases her clit to smirk, even though Catra can't see it. “You can’t do both at the same time?”

There’s a grumble and then Catra’s tongue is working again, even faster than before. She’s clearly trying to make Adora cum first.

Challenge accepted.

“Nope. That's a hard no.” She shakes her head to communicate this is absolutely not happening.

“Cat, we have to shower. We smell terrible.”

Adora’s been begging for the last 15 minutes. At first, Catra claimed she was opposed to shower sex on principle. When the human explained that they reeked and sex was not even on the table, Catra decided she was against two-person showers as a dumb thing that only new couples wanted to do. Adora offered a single shower. Catra still refused.

“We smell like the embodiment of our love or some cheesy shit,” she says, still trying to find a dry spot in the bed to lay in comfortably. Her options were incredibly limited. “Now stop being a dummy and bring that cute little pussy back over here.”

“No, I'm getting cleaned up,” Adora responds as she picks up their clothes from where they’re scattered around the room. “You can't possibly be comfortable either. Your fur’s all matted in a bunch of places.”

“Casualties of having a good time,” Catra shrugs.

“Also, could you not refer to it as ‘cute.’ That's unsettling.”

“It is *so* cute, Dor. Just the most precious little pink pussy I've ever seen. I want to make it a flower crown and take it on long walks on the beach.”

She probably keeps going but Adora just gives up and heads into the bathroom.

The argument was just for show, it turns out. As soon as Adora was comfortable in the shower, Catra leapt in and scared the hell out of her. Then she insisted on being picked up and fucked against the cold tile wall. She was not interested in Adora's protests that the blonde wasn't actually strong enough to support her weight *and* top her at the same time.

One minor injury and a brief reheated meal later, Catra's lounging on the couch while Adora types away at her computer.

If she can power through most of this report, Adora can probably go sleep over at Catra's place tonight. She's a little distracted by the knowledge that the Catra's so close, pretending to be on her phone while daydreaming. Catra keeps blushing and fidgeting absently, which means she's probably thinking up more ways to tease Adora endlessly.

Honestly, Adora's having trouble thinking about anything except that herself. When did she become so insatiable?

As if she can read those thoughts, Catra suddenly stands and wordlessly kneels on the floor between Adora's legs. Thankfully, she changed into her own clothes after freshening up, which decreases Adora's desire to devour Catra immediately by about 4%. It's not much but every bit counts in this losing battle.

"You're so sexy when you're concentrating," Catra purrs. She runs her claws lightly along the inside of Adora's thighs. "Do you know you make the same face when working *and* when you're fucking me? That focus and attention to detail really serves you well."

Adora doesn't look up. "I do really need to finish this. Remember you said last night that you'd let me?"

"That was before I knew I was dating the world's greatest lover."

Stay strong. Don't buckle under the ridiculous praise.

"I thought that was *your* title."

"I can admit when I've been bested," Catra replies. She smiles slowly, replacing her claws with her cheek to drag it along the blonde's leg. "Before, back when we were pretending to just be friends, I would get so wet watching you work sometimes. I had this recurring fantasy that you would punish me for distracting you."

Adora wasn't pretending, of course. Well, she *was* pretending that she wasn't also fantasizing about Catra as they hung out. A lot of those fantasies looked curiously like her current view, Catra's head peeking up from between her legs while Adora tried to front that she wasn't interested.

"Punish you how?"

Catra begins to purr, the sound vibrating through Adora's pants and into her muscles.

"It's probably best if I show you."

"I promise if I can get a bunch of this done now, Cat, we'll have more time together tonight and tomorrow. I'll even come over and we can use those restraints you have attached to the bed." Adora tries to add a reassuring smile.

Catra pouts, trying to play dirty. "Don't you like the sight of me waiting on my knees for you?"

It's a nice offer but not really an amount of power that Adora's interested in having. This must show on her face.

"Or," Catra nips at Adora's inner thigh, moving higher again. "Do you want me to order you down onto *your* knees?"

"Cat," she mumbles weakly.

She gets a pleased trill in response. Catra begins slowly standing.

What a terrible strategy. Adora should have said yes to the first offer, ordered Catra to kneel like it was a sexy game, and used the

additional time to finish up one of her projects.

“Princess,” Catra purrs. “On your knees for me.”

Adora complies immediately. Like so quickly, she doesn’t even think she made the conscious decision to go along with this.

Catra’s eyes are completely alight with excitement. This will certainly not be the last time that Adora receives this command. Hopefully, Catra will use her power for good instead of evil.

Adora’s almost shaking with anticipation for what comes next.

As soon as Catra opens her mouth, though, there’s a knock on the door. The two of them glance over at it and then turn to each other.

“You expecting anyone?” Catra asks.

“No.” Adora glances down at herself and realizes the very compromising position she’s in. “What if it’s Glimmer? I should-“ She pauses to rise.

“I didn’t say you could stand yet,” Catra points out, placing her hands on her hips.

“Cat-”

“Uh-uhn.”

‘Evil’ is apparently the side she’s chosen.

There’s a second knock and Adora starts to get a little more worried. This would be very simple if either of them had the ability to back down.

“We really should-”

“You’re going to have to ask nicer than that,” Catra sings, parroting Adora’s teasing tone from earlier.

“The knocking was a courtesy!” comes muffled through the door. “I’m gonna be bored with being nice very quickly. Wise up and put yourself together.”

Catra just smirks, clearly content to see how long Adora is willing to keep this up.

When the door finally blows open and sheer panic fills Adora, Catra finally mutters, “Fine, get up! Get up!”

Glimmer enters to find Adora and Catra both standing in the middle of the room, fully dressed, yet looking suspiciously winded from the shock.

Her hands are right next to her eyes, prepared to shield them at any moment if need be.

“Hey, Glim!” Adora squeaks.

Next to her, Catra gives her a very disappointed glare.

“Oh, you’re decent,” she responds, dropping her hand. “I’m surprised and impressed.”

“How was the zoo?” Catra asks. “We still have a kid?”

“Finn wanted to live with the tigers at first,” Glimmer explains. She takes a seat on the couch, throwing Adora’s work on the floor and stretching out. “Then Bow asked them if they’d be okay in a cage. Now they’re going to start a grassroots campaign to free the big cats held in zoos everywhere. They’re upstairs making signs.”

“They get that from you,” Catra tells Adora with a little grin. “How much did this excursion cost me?”

Glimmer counts off on her fingers. “Well, there was breakfast, lunch, everyone got two entrees of course, snacks, VIP zoo admission, Finn bought just about everything at the gift shop, gas, groceries for the dinner Bow’s making for all of us right now, pain and suffering.”

She fishes the wallet out of her pocket and tosses it carelessly to Catra.

“I’ll just let you be surprised by your credit card bill next month.”

“For real, though – you told me you weren’t good at this just to lower my expectations and then completely fucking stun me, right?” Catra’s still breathing heavily, even though they’ve been in the ‘post’ part of post-coital for a good 5 minutes.

They'd been testing Catra's flexibility, leading to her in the wrist restraints, her feet on Adora's shoulders, and Adora using the angle to plow into her deeper than ever before.

“If only I was that cunning,” Adora mumbles.

“And all those absolute *lies* about having no kinks-”

“That’s not exactly what I said. I just had no experience.”

“Yeah, well, you definitely have some dirty dirty kinks.”

“I think it’s mostly just a Catra Kink.” Adora glances up from where she’s half-asleep on Catra’s breasts.

The fur is so soft against her cheek, Adora can’t imagine moving from this spot ever. Hopefully that’s not inconvenient to Catra’s life.

There are so many little secret places like this that she’s been delighted and honored to find this weekend. Catra’s tummy feels like velvet. Her fur is a little longer and curlier at the small of her back, right above her tail. When something feels really really good, her eyes go practically jet black. Adora realized too late that a gentle bite on one of her fluffy ears drove her completely wild.

“I just love every part of you,” Adora whispers.

“Yeah?” Catra sounds surprised.

She nods. “Thank you for...always being so patient and gentle with me. For loving me so fully and showing me that that’s a possibility.”

Catra’s arms move from where they landed on the bed as the two collapsed, and come to wrap around Adora’s shoulder.

“Same, Dor,” she whispers.

Chapter End Notes

apparently i wrote this note to myself at some point: 'she was a dom bratty bottom/switch. she was a sub service top. can i make this anymore obvious.'

friday is the last chapter. 😿 😿 don't mind my sobbing. y'all have really made this such a fun and dope as fuck experience and i am endlessly grateful for that.

chapter 22 preview: glimmer gets competitive, hope meets finn and catra, adora tells catra what she really wants.

All In

Chapter Summary

An epilogue of sorts. Tapas, tv time, and tamales. Pleasure kits and proposals.

Chapter Notes

i will repeat my sappy thank you to you all for reading and commenting and just being the goddamn best.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

To Adora's surprise, finally having sex with Catra only lessens the tension between them a small bit. Like a microscopic amount. Glimmer complains that it's actually gotten worse, if anything; she compares it to two people trying to badly keep a very obvious secret.

Adora feels like she can barely function half the time, just idly thinking about Catra's body underneath her or Catra's voice screaming for her to not stop or Catra's claws leaving marks all over her back. The folks in her most recent basketball pickup game were very scandalized by evidence of that last one.

Catra certainly wasn't helping things herself.

Catra
12:37 pm
My Gods
I'm so sore I can barely concentrate on this meeting
You really did a number on my v
Want to come over later?
Kiss it and make it better?

It's all very distracting! Adora wouldn't change a godsdamn thing.

Well, one thing. They're kinda in a strange no-man's-land that's getting more confusing. They're dating, yes. That should be enough. Adora wants much much more.

She tries asking Bow and Glimmer if it was too soon but has trouble getting them to focus. Glimmer's only interested in one thing.

"But like, how intense is the fucking?" she wants to know, way too invested. "Like, 'really good sex' intense or like 'call out of work for the week' intense?"

"This is not at all pertinent to what I'm asking you," Adora replies. Her face has never felt this hot. "Obviously, I haven't missed a single day of work so…"

She'd considered it. Catra had begged. They'd both convinced Sea Hawk to take Finn to school in the morning that one Tuesday and shown up an hour late to their respective workplaces. But nothing drastic, like taking a full day off.

Glimmer just scoffs, like Adora's being ridiculous. Bow's trying to hide a smile by taking a long sip of tea. His eyes are very twinkly for someone whose girlfriend has been pleading for details on her ex's sex life.

"Okay," Glimmer tries again. "On a scale of 1 to 10-"

"Higher," Adora answers automatically. "Anyway, Bow, you seem reasonable. Is it too early?"

Bow's eyes are locked on Glimmer's expression, her face stunned and frustrated and starting to drift off into a daydream.

"What's happening to her?" Adora whispers. She doesn't want to know but can't help herself.

Bow shrugs. "She thinks the two of you are in some kind of competition."

That's absurd. And also. "... Who's winning?"

Bows smiles in a way that Adora's never seen on him.

It's almost lascivious when he responds, "Me."

"You're right. I should just talk to Catra directly," Adora replies.

She pretends that this is the sage advice that they were going to give her and then leaves immediately, thanking them for lunch.

For their date, Catra takes her to a fancy tapas place. The ambiance is nice. The lights are low but not too dark, the music isn't too loud, and the tables are small enough that she can reach Catra with ease.

Their hands are intertwined on her lap and Catra's tail is wrapped around her calf.

"Why are you frowning?" Catra asks. She's smiling like she knows something Adora doesn't.

"I'm not."

"You hate it here," Catra replies.

Adora shakes her head. Mostly she's just nervous about the impending conversation.

"You can tell me. It won't hurt my feelings."

The server interrupts to set down the first couple of things they ordered. The food is almost comically small – 5 baby potatoes in a sauce, what looks like one palm-sized open-faced quesadilla, a single slice of bread with some kind of jammy situation on top cut into four portions.

Catra cackles so loudly that the table next to them shoots her a disapproving look. She reaches over to trace the frown on Adora's face with one claw, proving her point.

“Why?” is all Adora asks.

Her date rolls her eyes in response.

“We have the apartment to ourselves tonight. I thought we'd like to make the absolute most of it.” She winks, just in case Adora isn’t fully understanding her meaning. “So we'll have to save bloating ourselves with pizza or lamb shanks or whatever for another day.”

Adora is sure she's pouting in response. Yes, most of their time alone together has been rushed because of responsibilities with Finn. And yes, it would be nice to maybe try some of the new things she and Catra have been discussing. But. Pizza sounds so good. It's not even cheat day.

“Look,” Catra sighs, tearing into the tiny bread, “Would it make you feel better if I told you that I already made you some protein-rich snacks and basically an entire second dinner, just in case that’s not enough? You’re gonna need it to recover after you throw me around the room and wreck my pussy.”

Someone at the next table clears their throat awkwardly. Catra cuts her eyes at the person but Adora just ignores it.

Heart swelling at how well Catra knows her and takes care of her, the words just kinda fall out of Adora's mouth entirely on their own.

“I want to be monogamous.”

A tiny potato slips from Catra's claws and onto the floor. They've now lost 20% of the potatoes, Adora solemnly thinks.

“Monogamous?” Catra repeats. She looks almost shell-shocked.

Adora nods quickly. “I'm not dating anyone else.”

That seems to wake Catra from her shock. Once again, she chuckles loudly. The table next to them tuts in response.

“Oh, really?” she asks, arching an eyebrow. “My bad then. I had you pegged as a total fuckboi.”

“Catra, please be serious.” But Adora can't help but smile at her antics.

“I don't know your life. I thought you had women all over town. A girl in every port.”

“Yes, I have other secret families besides you and Finn,” Adora adds sarcastically.

Catra's teasing smile shifts into something that's very soft and fond in a way that Adora's never really seen before. That she deeply hopes to see again and again.

“Families,” Catra repeats.

Adora takes one clawed hand and kisses it gently.

“Do you want to keep seeing other people, Cat?”

“It's only you, Dor,” she whispers. “Always.”

“Okay. So.”

“So. Monogamy,” Catra says with a final nod.

“It's only you for me too, Cat.” Adora kisses her other hand.

“Let me know when that changes, yeah?”

Adora moves her eyes from Catra's claws to her intense gaze. She looks like she's hedging her bets, waiting for Adora to take this back.

“That's not changing,” Adora says firmly. “This is...this is it for me, Cat. I'm all in.”

Catra takes a shaky breath in.

Her voice is strained when she says, “Really?” Adora nods, reaching up to wipe a tear that's escaped. Catra swallows thickly. “Me too. All in.”

As they share a short but very sweet kiss, the table next to them whispers about how cute that was.

Glimmer’s voice crackles over the LAP intercom system.

“That demon child is here again.”

Before Adora can lecture her about referring to any of the youth they serve that way, Frosta appears in her doorway.

Oh. Nevermind then.

Frosta’s in her usual gray business casual and holding her phone outward, facing Adora. She looks especially…constipated, working to balance her boss’s digital visage and a large, unwieldy tote bag on her arm. On Frosta’s phone, Catra is typing furiously at her computer. She had been busier than ever lately; after finally getting that long-promised promotion, Catra had found out that the life of a senior associate wasn’t as glamorous as she had thought. Lots of strongly worded emails to send apparently.

“Hey, Cat!” Adora imagines her smile looks fake. It’s hard to let down her guard in front of Frosta. No matter how much Catra insists that her intern is harmless, Adora can sense otherwise.

“ *Hey* , Adora,” is the drawled response. Catra drags herself away from her keyboard and tilts her phone for a better view. “Say hey, Frosta.”

Complete silence. The young woman looks like she’d rather eat hot coals than be here any longer.

“She really likes you,” Catra whispers to the blonde. It would be impolite to laugh, like Frosta’s not standing right there, so Adora just rolls her eyes instead.

“What’s going on?”

Before Catra can speak, a set of keys is flung near Adora’s face. She doesn’t even have time to catch them, she just ducks to the side to avoid being maimed.

“Frosta!” Catra yells but she’s also laughing so Frosta doesn’t bother acknowledging that this is not how you deliver dangerous pointy objects to people.

“Why?!” Adora shrieks, slowly trying to climb under her desk if this is how Frosta’s going to hand over her large bag. It looks like there’s several things inside that might be made of glass.

“They slipped.” She does not sound remorseful at all.

Catra leans forward onto her elbows. It gives Adora a great view right down her half-unbuttoned pale pink dress shirt.

“I’m sorry,” she offers with a charming smile. “I wanted to give you keys to my place. You know, since I’m *your woman* now and all.”

Adora melts, literally everything forgotten and forgiven.

“ *My* woman, huh?”

“We have deadlines,” Frosta spits.

Catra sighs. “Come over tonight?”

As if 65% of Adora’s belongings weren’t already at Catra and Finn’s apartment. Keys would actually be helpful, just in case she needed to access her stuff while *her woman* was busy or away.

Adora wasn’t fully sold on the title yet honestly. It sounded much better when Catra said it.

“GTG. Bye, Dor!”

When the call ends abruptly and Frosta shoves her phone back into her pocket, Adora expects to get some time alone to celebrate this new relationship milestone. Exchanging keys – even though it happened through Glimmer, who still hadn't told Adora why she even had an extra set to give Catra in the first place, and Frosta – was an important thing between people who were dating.

Frosta stays. Just standing there. Staring at Adora.

"Is there, uh, something else I can do for you?"

"Do *not* implicate me in this in any way," she says sternly.

The tote bag drops to Adora's desk with a heavy thump. It's literally spilling forth candles, tiny champagne bottles, massage oils, lotions, *lube* .

"Why are you-" Adora scrambles, even more uncomfortable. Catra isn't a stickler for rules but she has some basic decency. At least, Adora thought she did.

"What did I just say?"

Frosta's trying to look everywhere except the bounty of adult gifts sitting between them. She's still not exiting immediately, which is somehow the most confusing part of all this up until she answers another call.

"Kitty just got off the line," the new voice says. "Are you still there?"

Instead of responding, Frosta flips her phone back around towards Adora. Only this time, it's Mermista's face filling the screen. For the first time since Adora's known her, Mermista is smiling brilliantly. The blonde hadn't thought she was actually capable of emoting.

"I was never here," Frosta makes clear. She looks up at Adora. " *Never* ."

"You glorious gay," Mermista whispers. Selfishly, Adora's just happy that Catra's assistant seems to like her for once. "Do you know how happy you've made us? Kitty's been a goddamn *dream* to work for these last two weeks. You're doing the Lord's work."

Catra's voice floats in from offscreen, sounding suspicious."Who are you talking to?"

Mermista hangs up at once. Without another word, Frosta simply turns and disappears.

With a tentative hand, Adora lightly examines the bag on her desk. She's not exactly sure what she's so worried about but she only allows herself to poke around gently, as if she's trying to inspect a bomb or something.

It's definitely some kind of bizarre pleasure kit. The champagne looks decent enough, a familiar brand. The candles seem like they're going to smell awful. No one needs the scent of rose, hay, and patchouli in their bedroom. There's absolutely no way that Catra's allowing Adora to put any kind of oil in her fur. The lubes are all fruit flavored. Huh.

It's a, uh, thoughtful gift. Adora just has to hide it or throw it out before Glimmer catches wind of this.

As she's trying to place everything back into the tote, a little handwritten card falls out.

Adora blushes before she's even done with the first line. It's a thank you note from a "concerned citizen", full of weirdly sensual-sounding words and appreciating Adora for "addressing the pulsing tension, massaging the issue, and taking a hands-on approach with breathless urgency."

When Perfuma knocks, Adora just shoves the entire bag under her desk as quickly as possible.

Already annoyed somehow, Perfuma huffs. "I told them not to use those awful scented candles! They're *toxic* !"

She slams a large, homemade-looking candle down onto Adora's desk. It's off-white with little flower petals, held inside a mason jar.

"It's *soy* and has just enough essential oils not to annoy Catra's sensitive nose," she explains.

Adora furrows her brow.

"...why?" She hopes Perfuma can understand that she obviously means this *whole* thing, not just this unsolicited information about scented candles.

Adora never buys scented candles so this isn't a concern that she's had before.

"Sea Hawk," Perfuma says like his name is a curse. "He was very excited about how nice Catra's being to him. Well, to everyone, really. He wanted to organize a gift for you. My tasteful suggestion was overruled by Mermista, of course."

There's a group chat that Adora's been added to and removed from a bunch of times, titled "Cat Wranglers." It mostly seems to consist of Mermista and Perfuma fighting, while Scorpia and Sea Hawk try to keep the peace. Predictably, Entrapta never responds.

"Every link he sent was harmful to the environment," Perfuma continues. She pauses, pitches her voice lower to derisively mutter, "And if there's anything in there that's for internal use, it's probably a guaranteed yeast infection. I'd suggest disposing of the entire thing safely."

She waves to her gift as an alternative.

"Thank you," Adora says unsurely.

"No, thank *you* , Adora. I'm very proud of how you've navigated your old patterns and traumas and changed the narrative that you have of yourself. New year, new habits, new healing!"

She smiles brightly, long, thin hands coming up to clasp tightly together under her chin.

"Uh huh…"

As soon as she leaves, Adora shoots off a text.

Adora
1:16pm
I think I hate our friends

Catra
1:28pm
Fucking finally
I've been saying that for MONTHS

Adora and Finn spend 30 minutes negotiating over how long the cub is allowed to watch television. On more than one occasion, Finn reminds Adora that she's really cutting into their tv time by forcing them to negotiate about it. Of course, they were the one who had chosen to haggle when she offered them exactly one hour after homework and dinner and before bathtime and bedtime. But Finn started trying to find different ways to cut all other duties down ('No one needs to take a bath for 20 minutes. Unless I can take the tablet in with me.')

So dinner's late, tv time hasn't begun, and the status of everything else is still up in the air. Catra's working late on a case all week so Adora and Finn have been spending extra time together. It's a real learning experience.

The situation becomes even more difficult when Hope calls her. On video. Without warning.

As with all things, Hope likes to keep her check-in calls with Adora on a tight schedule. They are quarterly and calendared way in advance. Hope has never called outside of the schedule, even when there's an emergency. Once, when she fell and broke her

wrist, Hope waited 5 weeks to let Adora know during their next scheduled conversation.

“Fine,” Adora huffs, trying to get everything under control. “You’ll watch the tablet at the table while I take a phone call and work on dinner.”

“Can I watch during dinner too?” Finn immediately follows up.

“Not the time to push it, Finny.”

They sit and Adora answers, using her free hand to try to pull dinner out of the fridge for reheating.

Hope is holding the phone too close to her face. She never uses video.

She looks the same as always. Hair buzzed short, purple face thin and severe, blue eyes piercing without even trying. She's wearing a t-shirt, which is oddly relaxed for her.

“Hello, Adora,” she greets formally.

“Hey, Hope. How are you?” Adora prays that she doesn't look too frazzled, like someone who's been losing an argument with a 7 year old for half an hour.

“I am fine,” she replies, after considering it for a moment. “And how are you?”

“I’m alright. What’s up?”

“I spoke to Mara recently.” Hope tries to keep her tone calm but Adora can hear that her voice is a bit strained, usually a sign that she and Mara argued. “I think she intended to wish me happy holidays. She said she spent some time with you.”

“Yeah, it was nice,” Adora responds absently, dumping leftovers into a pot.

Hope doesn't reply for a few long moments. Adora isn't quite sure what to say herself.

"What did you end up doing for the holidays?" she finally settles on.

"Celebration was minimal, as always." She searches for something to add. "Your birthday is coming up soon."

Adora nearly chuckles but realizes that Hope won't appreciate it. It feels like a silly thing to waste time on for someone who cares so little about 'frivolous' things, like birthdays.

"It is," Adora confirms. "I haven't planned anything yet."

"Ooooh, can we go to Crystal Castle?" Finn asks. In her reflection in the phone, she can see them standing suddenly right next to her.

Hope looks like she's swallowed something.

"Finny. No eavesdropping remember?"

"Who are you?" they ask Hope, peering closer to the screen. "Are you Adora's mom?"

Hope answers, "I was Adora's foster mother."

"Like Weaver," Finn looks to Adora for confirmation. It's still sad for them but not as sore of a subject as Weaver is for Catra. Adora just nods.

"I like your hair," they then say to Hope. "Adora won't let me shave my hair lower on the sides."

"We took a vote and you were outvoted," Adora points out as Finn pouts.

Hope nearly smiles. Mostly, the corners of her mouth twitch slightly.

“And what is your name?” she asks.

“Finn,” they proudly announce. “My pronouns are they and them.”

Hope very slightly raises her eyebrows at Adora. The blonde braces herself for this to be A Thing.

Before Hope can say anything, Finn continues, “What should I call you?”

The sound of the door opening interrupts them. Catra walks in briskly, shedding her camel overcoat. She’s in her chocolate brown vest and trousers underneath. Adora is very aware that staring will cause Hope to say something annoying and passive aggressive when she least expects it.

“Dor, because you’re the most amazing woman on Etheria, dinner’s ready, right?” Catra stops in the kitchen and takes everything in. “Sorry, you busy? I can take the cub.”

“Uh, no,” Adora responds.

This feels like a nightmare. Why does this feel like a nightmare? People introduce their partners to parental figures all the time. Adora never has, but other people do it and survive, right?

She takes a deep breath. “Hope called. Do you want to…?” Adora motions Catra over with a wave of her hand. Turning back to the phone, she says, trying her very best to be chill about all this, “Hope, this is Catra. My partner.”

Adora hopes that her foster mother doesn’t see the disgusted face that Catra makes. The couple had been having a conversation about how to define their relationship and unusual family situation for a while. Catra, convinced that they didn’t need to overthink this process, was mostly concerned about what two adults in a relationship should call each other. Partner was her least favorite choice cause it reminded her of cops. Girlfriend made her feel like a kid. Significant other was way too vague. And on and on.

"Girlfriend," Catra corrects, sliding one arm around Adora's waist and nestling a hand in Finn's hair. "Nice to meet you. Adora's said such lovely things about you, Hope. How's winter fly fishing going?"

Catra has no reason to remember that detail about a stranger's life. Adora only mentioned it around the holidays, part of a list of the very small number of things that she knew about Hope for certain, hoping for gift inspiration. She ended up sending a gift basket after she gave up.

Hope almost lights up. Honestly, she just sits up a little straighter and says more than 4 words in response. It's really the most excited she allows herself to get. The older woman goes into too many details about her recent fishing trips and Catra dutifully smiles and asks follow-up questions.

Catra then shifts to complimenting Adora and Mara repeatedly and what a good upbringing they must have had. Hope eats up the praise, charmed by Catra's good manners. When she asks what Catra does for a living and hears the words 'lawyer' and 'ivy league school graduate', Hope practically has stars in her eyes. Catra correctly reads that Hope's okay with their blatant queerness as long as Catra has impressive enough job prospects.

Adora finishes up dinner while they chat and she's grateful to use the meal as an excuse to get off the phone quickly, once it's apparent that Hope is pleased with her choices. She still doesn't know why that matters, but somehow it does, even after all this time.

"Hope seemed...nice," Catra comments. Finn nods, mouth full of food.

That's not usually the impression that her foster mother gives but okay.

"I think she loved you. Both of you," Adora says. Hope was about as effusive as she's capable of getting, showing genuine interest

in Catra. Finn, she was a little more cautious about, probably thinking they were a bit too wild.

“She’s kinda scary,” Finn tells them. “She should get a girlfriend so she’s happier.”

“Kid’s got flawless gaydar,” Catra says.

“We’ll invite people that she could date to your wedding,” Finn suggests.

A piece of stewed cabbage flies down Adora’s breathing pipe. No one moves to help her, Finn smiling slyly while Catra tsks at them.

“We’ve talked about trolling Adora, cub,” Catra says, sounding bored. Adora doesn’t understand how she’s able to speak and think clearly right now. “It’s not nice. Adora doesn’t troll you.”

“She trolls me all the time!” Finn argues, but they start laughing immediately, very amused with themself. “Adora talked all the way through tv time.”

Catra glances at Adora, still red and sputtering, trying to catch her breath. “Is this true?”

Adora tries to make an indignant sound but is still incredibly winded.

“I’ll take that as a yes,” Catra replies. “Fine, you get a pass this time, kid. Effing up tv time is pretty unforgivable.”

Finn beams and both of them move into conversation, leaving Adora to get her own water and recover.

Adora’s still counting their dates. Catra reminds her that this is silly all the time, but Adora can’t help it. Tracking their dates gives her a good sense of how to gauge how quickly they’re moving.

Of course, she and Catra aren't a traditional couple. They were ridiculously close before they started dating. So an 8th date might be too early for the conversation Adora wants to have but they don't have to make any final decisions. Just start talking about the idea.

Having learned from the half-cocked plan from when she asked Catra to be exclusive, Adora's tried to set up this conversation a little better. She gave Catra a heads up that she wants to talk to her. She's chosen food that Catra will hopefully love, based on some not-so-subtle hints her girlfriend's been dropping all week.

Well, *had* been dropping, up until a couple days ago. Catra's been weirdly cagey lately. She's going through all the motions but is just a bit...colder? Adora's tried to figure out what's happening. She even went as far as sending flowers just in case she forgot something important. There's been no change with Catra.

Her girlfriend is 5 minutes early. Adora doesn't have time to question that because Catra's. Well.

Catra looks fucking stunning.

No, enchanting. Provocative?

Adora's never seen anything like this in her life.

Catra's wearing her leather jacket, which she's paired with a pair of leather pants so tight that they leave little to the imagination (like whether or not Catra's wearing underwear cause the answer is a definitive no), and a black bralette in place of an actual shirt. Her stiletto boots click loudly as she walks closer to Adora. The look really comes together up close – Catra's wearing winged eyeliner, matte black lipstick, and has her hair straightened and slicked down into a slight pompadour.

When she smiles at Adora, it doesn't really reach her eyes. She's intentionally showing both fangs, claws fully extended as well.

This is not good.

“Hi, baby,” Adora greets, reaching for Catra. Physical touch usually diffuses most issues with Catra.

She takes a seat at the table to avoid Adora’s hug.

“You look fucking amazing, Cat,” she says, hoping for some good will.

Catra barely hides her scowl.

“Okay, what’s up, Kitten?”

Catra fully scowls now, muttering to herself. Adora manages to catch ‘fuckin’ Kitten *now* ?!’

“Please,” Adora tries again. “I want to make it better, whatever it is.”

Catra’s eyes shoot up towards her, full of fury.

“You send me a fucking *text message* saying we need to talk,” Catra begins and her voice is so thick with restrained rage that Adora is pretty sure she winces instinctively. “Then you invite me to a random restaurant in a part of town where we won’t run into anyone we know. Which, by the way, has the fucking tables bolted to the floor so I can’t make a scene.”

That was never going to be enough to stop Catra from causing a scene, is what occurs to Adora first. She’s smart enough to know not to open with that.

Instead, she says plainly, probably still in shock, “You mentioned you wanted tamales last week. I researched the best in town for a few days.” She vaguely waves her hand at the restaurant. “I thought it clicked all your boxes for authentic, good food: it’s a hole-in-wall, supported by the neighborhood, family-owned, not written up by any of the big papers.”

Catra’s fiery gaze shifts from Adora to their surroundings.

After a beat, she quietly agrees, "I really *have* wanted tamales all week."

Adora can't help but laugh. She's slowly starting to catch up with Catra's big plan.

"I know. Did you think I brought you here to break up with you?!"

Catra's ears flatten to her head.

So Adora goes on, "...why are you dressed like that then?" Then she can't help her smug smile. "Were you gonna seduce me back?"

That catches Catra's attention finally. " *No!* I was showing you what you were missing."

She gestures at her outfit. Yes, Adora agrees, that would have certainly made her fully understand what she was letting go of. *If* she had been dumb enough to try to break up with Catra. In public. With no prior conversations or processing.

"Have you spent the last couple days thinking I was dumping you? Did you even go to work today?"

Catra rolls her eyes at how typical that question is for Adora.

"No, I spent half the day pacing and crying and overthinking this and the other half getting dressed," she replies. She looks like she's about to take off her jacket and get comfortable before immediately remembering that she's most definitely not wearing a shirt. "What the hell did you scare me like that for?"

"Sorry!" Adora quickly apologizes. "I didn't realize that saying 'we need to talk' was such a red flag."

"Everyone knows that," Catra whines.

Honestly, Adora did too but just hadn't really thought it through when texting. Again, they'd had zero conversations about any

issues recently so the message seemed harmless enough at the time.

Adora goes to give Catra a soft look and inquire more. But she kinda gets sidetracked by the outfit again.

“Gods,” she whispers, feeling like she can’t catch her breath, “you do look good though.”

Catra gives a small nod in agreement, like this is very obvious. To be fair, it is.

“Yeah, well, compliments aren’t gonna get you anywhere. You’re gonna spend *hours* making this up to me.” Her tone makes it very clear how she expects her girlfriend to make amends.

Adora smiles slowly. “Will you wear the outfit the whole time?”

Catra pretends to think this over. “Tell me what’s wrong and I’ll consider it.”

Oh, right. The whole thing that started this mess.

“Nothing’s wrong,” Adora clarifies quickly. “I really did just want to talk about something in person. My lease is ending in a little over two months. They sent the renewal proposal last week. Bow and Glimmer want a bigger one bedroom cause they’re not needing the spare room anymore. They're talking about moving out of the building and closer to work. And your place.”

Catra acknowledges this with a slow nod. “Is this place table service or counter?”

“That’s really all you have to say?”

“You’ve given me a list of facts. I’ve heard them. Was there a request in there somewhere? Maybe something you *want* ?” It’s a leading question but Catra pretends that she’s unconcerned about the answer. “Otherwise, it’s tamale time.”

Once again, one of Adora's well-planned serious discussions has been derailed. Getting to see Catra like this though is almost a small price to pay.

She has to will herself to focus on the point and not how she can see her own teeth marks across Catra's collarbone.

"What do I want?" Adora asks, trying to gather her thoughts. "I want to go to sleep with you in my arms every night and wake up with you. And Melog….and Finn sometimes. I want to help with chores and learn how to cook and get a permanent side of the bed. What I want is to marry you and be with you forever. But I'll settle for living together in the spring."

Catra looks a bit like Adora's uncharacteristic vulnerability has broken her. She opens and closes her mouth a couple of times in silence. Her tail freezes in mid-air then jerks to life, whipping wildly. Finally, she rapidly blinks a few times.

"You want to marry me?" Catra whispers, both sounding awe-struck and dubious.

"Not right now! Maybe in a year or two?" Adora shrugs. "We can make a timeline. No rush."

Catra laughs. "A timeline? Sure. Whatever you want, Dor." She pauses for a deep breath. "I want all those things too. I want them with you. I never really thought I was the marrying type. Politically, having the state knowing who I'm fucking doesn't really do it for me."

"Right. As a queer separatist."

"Exactly. And I sure as shit don't want the government's approval of our lady-on-lady love."

"Haven't you been engaged before?"

"I've been *proposed to* ," Catra hastily corrects. "There's a difference. Anyway, our particular setup would probably be a bit

more secure if it was legally protected but I haven't fully sorted out all of my secret thoughts and feelings about that yet. I'm getting ahead of myself."

She pauses to take Adora's hand.

"If you're asking to move in, obviously, I would love that. You'll need to ask Finn, though, cause it's their home too."

"Of course! Whatever you think is best." Adora beams, reaching to pull Catra closer.

"Just don't send them a bullshit 'we need to talk' text. They're not going to be as calm and understanding as me."

"Yes, thank you for being so patient and not overreacting at all," Adora says sarcastically, motioning towards Catra's attire. More sincerely, she adds, "I love you. So much."

"Well, Gods help me cause I love you too, dummy."

Adora's been pumped all week.

Finn had made it to the end of the school year unscathed. Besides being lectured about cursing by Ms. Spinnerella twice. And a small accident that happened when they climbed a tree to chase a squirrel and then scraped their knee trying to jump onto a branch that wasn't strong enough to hold their weight. And maybe they conned some kids out of snack money but no one would fess up so it wasn't provable.

In fairness to Finn, though, it was *Catra* who had gotten the lecture about cursing, after they called a 4th grader who misgendered them a 'fucking ingrate.'

But these incidents had been limited and Adora was feeling very successful. She and Catra had helped Finn survive a year of so many new things – death of their guardian, going to a new home, starting a new school, making new friends, inevitably becoming

the most popular kid in school, many of their first holidays, their first actual birthday party, Adora moving in, and the excitement of learning about moving boxes.

(The whole time she was packing, Adora kept losing Finn and Catra inside of boxes. One of them would get assigned to wrapping glasses or putting away books and she'd find them an hour later asleep in a cardboard bed.)

Adora was starting to think she and Catra were pretty good at this whole guardian thing.

This illusion is shattered two days before summer break.

As she sits in front of Ms. Spinnerella, after being summoned in the middle of the day, Adora is mostly worried about Finn (who is apparently just down the hall for their weekly Thursday after-school tutoring), frightened for being trouble (which is absurd because she's an adult and only a couple years younger than Spinnerella, she's pretty sure), and fucking elated to learn that she's listed as one of Finn's adult contacts with the school.

She never made that change. It felt weird asking Catra, like an overstepping stepdad, so she just tried to play it cool. Catra, who lives to overstep, probably went ahead and gave them Adora's info without even thinking about it twice.

Speaking of Catra, that seems to be what she and Spinnerella are waiting for as Adora pretends to check emails on her phone, now that she and the teacher have run out of bland things to say about Finn. She imagines they're saving the more controversial topics until the older cat is there.

"Sorry for holding you up," Adora apologizes with a small, nervous smile. "She said she was a few minutes away. She should be here any mi-"

Catra just fucking blows in the door. Like, actually. When she rounds the corner to enter, the tight, knee-length white blazer she's wearing floats in the wind.

Underneath it is an intricately lacy red wine camisole that's really more of a long bra, tucked into also *very tight* white slacks. And heels. She's wearing white shiny heels. Catra never wears heels. Hell, she avoids wearing shoes at all if she can help it most times.

This is *not* what she left for work wearing this morning.

Adora can just barely hear her greeting Spinnerella as she takes the desk next to her. The blonde's too busy spiraling.

Is Catra having an affair? No, that's stupid. But... *is it* ? Who else would she wear this outfit for besides a secret lover? She has secret clothes that she wears for secret lovers?

With a whistle, Catra leans over and pokes Adora in the temple.

"Hey, you," she says. "Can you stop panicking? You're freaking Spinnerella out."

Adora glances up to see that the teacher does indeed look quite concerned but is trying to pretend that she's not paying attention to them.

Before Adora can pull herself together and ask, Catra explains, "The opposition called a last-minute meeting today over one of the terms, trying to catch me off guard and get an advantage. The lead counsel is a scumbag and this is my creep emergency power outfit." She looks back at Spinnerella. "Obviously, I didn't realize I'd end up in an elementary school when I put this on. So, where's the fire? Finn okay?"

She gives them a strained smile. Adora imagines she doesn't have to deal with nearly as many odd shenanigans from other parents.

"Everything is fine," Spinnerella tells them calmly. "This isn't a bad emergency. Or really, even an emergency, just something that came up today and I didn't think I'd have time to talk to you tomorrow since kids tend to just run out of the door screaming on the last day."

She shuffles a few papers on her desk and continues, "I had the children set goals for the summer. Here's Finn's."

The drawing she hands over is enough to make Adora die from how precious is. She wants to make several copies, frame them, and send one to Bow and Kyle.

On a sheet of red construction paper, Finn's favorite color because it's also Adora and Catra's, they've drawn a tiny dream board. '1st trip' with a suspiciously tall, brown figure that's probably Mara. 'Rides' with a terribly drawn rollercoaster that has too many loops and looks like a deathtrap. 'Change name' with a little square of paper that says 'Finn.'

"That coaster looks terrifying," Catra whispers. "This kid's my fucking hero."

"Language," both of the other women reply automatically.

"As you can see, Finn has been thinking more about changing their name lately. They've asked me about it a couple of times."

Catra and Adora exchange a confused look. Finn hasn't mentioned this to either of them. That's weird because they talk about literally everything constantly and also because they refer to Catra as 'my lawyer'.

The last time Adora tried to get them to go to bed early, Finn informed her, "You'll need to speak to my lawyer."

Half-asleep herself, Catra yelled, "Goddamn right, cub!"

"They haven't told you yet?" Spinnerella asks. "I kinda guessed that was the case. I wanted to give you both a heads up and also ask if you need any support. I know you're an attorney, Ms. Morgan, but I have the contact for a gender-affirming therapist and a pediatrician."

"Um…thank you," Adora mumbles out.

Are they not creating a safe enough environment for Finn? It's not like them to keep actual secrets.

Spinnerella hands over two business cards.

"I know this can be overwhelming," she says.

Catra accepts the cards with a nod, cutting off whatever other platitudes were about to be directed their way. "We'll talk to Finn. Thanks."

"Hey, Spinny, you-" A familiar head pops into the door and she stops as soon as she realizes there are parents there. "Whoops, sorry!"

"Netossa?"

"Gray!"

Adora's sometime-teammate enters the room with a bright smile and goes to casually lean against Spinnerella's desk. The blonde realizes now that she's never seen her almost-friend in non-sportswear. The school standard blue polo and gray slacks somehow makes her look like an even bigger lesbian than usual. It's kinda cool that she gets to keep her hair half-shaved at work; Adora might have felt more comfortable growing up if she saw openly queer adults at school.

"How have you been?" Netossa asks. "I haven't seen you in almost a year. You have a kid now?!"

"These are Finn's parents," Spinnerella answers for them.

"Well, not exactly," Adora tries to say but Netossa doesn't care.

"You went from disasters to married with a 2nd grader already?" she laughs. "That's a new lesbian record."

"We are very much *not* married," Catra informs them.

Netossa's smile melts into a frown but her eyes still look quite amused.

"This is Catra," Adora explains. "She's Finn's guardian."

"Oh, I remember you, kitty," Netossa replies. "Do you actually own any complete shirts?"

Catra looks over to Adora, face contorted in confusion. She's not sure if it's because they're in Finn's school or this person appears to be a friend of Adora's but Catra is showing a lot of restraint for not already telling Netossa off.

"The basketball game you came to," the blonde elaborates. It makes sense that she doesn't remember. For Catra, it was probably just another day of teasing her. For Adora, seeing her in that crop-top and cut-offs was basically life-altering.

"Oh." Catra thinks about it for a moment, then looks down at herself. When she looks back up at Netossa, Catra's surprisingly smiling. "Hey, I've talked my way out of a pre-nup in this outfit."

Netossa asks with a smirk, "Personal or professional?"

Catra pauses to think again. "I've talked my way out of *two* pre-nups in this outfit," she amends.

Netossa just laughs.

"Hey, I'm not knocking it." She half-turns back to Spinnerella. "Y'all almost done? I'd like to get out of here soon."

"Yes, darling, we're just wrapping up."

Catra leans over to whisper, "Called it," into Adora's ear.

She had indeed claimed immediately after meeting Spinnerella that she was a lesbian. Adora didn't agree. They spent most of the year trying and failing to get a confirmation from Finn without actually asking them directly. Saying 'is she a lesbian?' to Finn

would only lead to them asking their teacher that exact question in front of their entire class most likely.

"I'm the director of the sports program here, by the way," Netossa adds. "If you're interested, I'd love to talk to you sometime about getting Finn more involved. They're always bragging about how sporty their moms are."

"Yes, they've brought it up," Perfuma says. She's being weirdly fidgety on Adora's screen, half-pacing, half-dancing back in her office. "I think it's more complicated than you realize."

Scorpia, Bow, and Glimmer all claimed to have not broached the subject of name changes with Finn. Perfuma's the only person in their circle who Finn seems to have shared with. Catra says it's not worth it to call Entrapta unless they have an hour to kill, while she reviews the log of her conversations with the cub and looks for trends. Adora didn't realize Entrapta was keeping a log.

"The process?"

"No, no. Their...feelings," Perfuma looks like she's searching for more words. And then suddenly, she gives up. "You should talk to them. Finn explains it best." She hangs up in a hurry.

Catra, huddled next to Adora on the hood of her car, just groans. "That was weird, right? Like this whole thing is weird. Since when does Finn keep actual secrets from us?"

"That's what *I* said!"

"...to who? You've literally been next to me this entire time."

"Uh…" Adora blushes. "In my head. To myself. Anyway, why don't you get back to work and I'll wait for Finn and take them home?"

"Yeah," Catra nods. "I should probably get out of here. I look like some creepy dad's 3rd wife."

Adora helps her down from the hood and they kiss goodbye. Before Catra gets into her car, she whispers suggestively, "Should I bring this suit home later? I'll let you play the handsy client."

" *Definitely* ."

By the time Adora's gotten Finn settled in and fed the three of them, they're all just acting oddly. Neither of the adults know what to do with themselves and the cub is reacting to their bizarre energy like someone waiting to be told they have an infectious disease. They keep just watching the other two out of the corner of their eye, tail lashing wildly.

"Uh, hey, cub," Catra starts while Adora clears the table. "We wanted to talk to you about something."

They look more panicked now.

"You're not in trouble," Adora clarifies.

"Ms. Spinnerella told us about your summer goals. She said you want to change your name."

Finn brightens right up. Always excited about an opportunity to discuss their favorite subject, themself.

"Oh! Yeah, I want everyone to call me Finn."

Well, that's not a big deal at all. Catra seems to sigh in relief. She and Adora had talked about this as a possibility a few times but they wanted Finn to be the one to bring it up, let them self-determine how they want to express themself. Maybe Perfuma and Spinnerella were just blowing this a little out of proportion?

"That's great, bud," Catra says. "Frosta and I can do that. I used to volunteer to do name changes at the local LGBT center in law school."

"Cool," they reply, now bouncing around in their chair. "Can I have dessert now?"

Crisis averted, Adora serves them each a bowl of vegan ice cream.

Halfway through, Finn pauses in the middle of some story about gym class to say, "I can't decide what my second middle name should be."

Catra barely holds in a laugh. "Well, what are your options?"

Adora decides maybe it's helpful to ask the more obvious question.

"Why do you need *two* middle names?"

"To match my two last names," Finn replies simply.

"Duh," Catra adds with a fake eye roll.

She doesn't know what's happening either. Why can't she ever admit that?

"Cat, what are Finn's two last names?" Adora patiently asks.

Finn only has one last name. It's Smith. Both of the parents' names on their birth certificate seem completely fake and generic.

"I'm sure they'll tell us, Dor."

"Grey and Morgan."

Catra drops her spoon, halfway to her mouth. Adora just thinks it's best to stop breathing altogether.

Finn continues, as if they haven't noticed, "One middle name should be Aloysius." They completely butcher the pronunciation. "I heard it and I like it."

"Al-oh-ish-uhs," Catra corrects, idly, clearly still in shock. "Morgan-Grey sounds better."

Adora blinks a few times, not completely conscious, she thinks.

“Why does your name get to go first?” she hears her own voice ask.

“Just sounds better,” Catra shrugs.

“Cat, what’s *your* middle name?” Finn inquires. “Maybe that’ll help me choose.”

“Applesauce,” she mutters.

“What?!” Adora shrieks. How had she never known that? That feels like something Catra should open literally every conversation with.

Catra narrows her eyes. “Some smartass at the hospital probably thought it was funny. Catra Applesauce MeowMeow. What’s *yours* ?”

“Rainbow,” Adora mumbles. “My parents were not generally...sober.”

“I could be Finn Aloysius MeowMeow?”

“Hell no,” Catra asserts quickly. “I changed it and had the record sealed. And the two of you are taking that secret to your grave.”

For a long moment, she just stares into space.

“Cub, why don’t you go research middle names while me and Dora talk?”

Finn senses they can take advantage of the state that everyone else is in.

“Can I have more ice cream?”

Adora sends them off to their room with the remainder of the pint.

“So,” Catra breathes a few minutes later, throwing herself onto her bed.

“So,” Adora repeats, doing the same.

They don’t even bother changing out of their clothes. Future Catra is going to be really annoyed about breaking the ‘no outside clothes in the bed’ rule.

“They want us to adopt them,” Adora says. “Right? That’s what they think is happening here?”

“Yeah. Fuck. I remember being that age and thinking adoption was so fucking simple. Some family was gonna come just pick me up from Weaver’s and that was gonna be it.”

Adora nods. She definitely thought the same. Well, she thought her dad would just come take her home one day but similar.

“We *could* adopt Finn,” she suggests. She hopes this isn’t just all of her own trauma speaking.

She does love them so much. Not that she didn’t think she would, when they suddenly appeared at Catra’s place. But Adora loves Finn like they’re a part of her. They’re brilliant and weird and ridiculous and curious. More than anything, Adora wants to watch them grow up, teach them things, hear their rambling endless stories, and always be there for them and Catra.

“We can not,” Catra argues. “You just moved in a month ago! This is moving fast as hell.”

“Okay,” Adora says gently. “Well, what do you want, Cat?”

She rolls over to face Adora and props her head up with her palm.

With a sigh, Catra whispers, “I want that little monster to be mine forever.”

Adora manages to hold herself back from crying.

“Then I think you should adopt Finn.”

“What about you, Dor?”

“I want that too. But you know, we’re not married. You just pointed out that we haven’t been living together very long. The system tends to make these things difficult enough and I don't want to add more complications and slow the process down.”

Catra nods like she’s not listening at all. “Counter-offer-”

“That was my final offer, counselor,” Adora laughs. “Go through the process. It'll take plenty of time without trying to add me as a speedbump.”

Catra opens her mouth, clearly ready to argue.

“And don't say we can get married to make it easier,” Adora adds. “We're still figuring out if we even want to be married. It's only been 5 months.”

“That's basically 3.5 lesbian years,” Catra replies, as if she wasn’t the one just saying that they were moving too fast.

“Let's get used to living together first before we sign more paperwork,” Adora suggests.

“I'm going to be very mature-”

“Uh huh.”

“And accept what you're saying at face value and not at all as a deeply cutting rejection.”

“That's good to hear, Cat.”

They sit in comfortable silence for a while. Well, it’s comfortable for Adora, at least, as she gets the enjoyment of watching Catra quietly plot.

“I feel like you're going to claw all my shirts up,” she jokes finally.

“Oh, definitely,” Catra replies immediately.

Adora rolls over onto her side. She scooches a bit closer and tries to pull Catra into her arms. It’s a bit like trying to cuddle an ironing board.

“Kitten.” Catra lies there stiffly. “If you remember, I'm the one who wanted to marry you. You were the one who had never been into the idea.”

“That was different. That was... hypothetical.”

“I still feel like you've been secretly engaged twice.”

“I'll never admit to that,” Catra says through clenched teeth.

Adora leans down and kisses her, long and loving and slow, until Catra starts to thaw in her embrace.

“Take some time,” the blonde whispers, pulling back just a little. “Think about it. Adopt Finn. After we celebrate our 1-year anniversary, if you actually want to get married, you know I'll accept your proposal.”

Catra gives an indignant squawk. “ *My* proposal?”

Adora chooses not to answer. This is a perfect time to watch Catra negotiate herself into and out of an idea.

“I guess you're the one who brought up moving in. And monogamy. And asked me out first. But I said I loved you first. But I’m clearly in charge around here. And you take so long to do everything, I’d be an old maid by the time you perfected whatever ridiculously formal speech you’d want to give.”

“I'm sure your proposal will be amazing and embarrassing,” Adora tells her.

Catra positively lights up, sitting up quickly. It doesn’t take long for the seed to blossom and Catra gets carried away.

“It's going to be *garish* , Dor. Public as hell. Scorpia and Sea Hawk will probably sing. I might even let Glitter Bow help.”

“I hope you remember to record it.”

“Of course. I can just imagine your face.” She grins wickedly, entirely too pleased with herself already. “We can just get married at the courthouse. Nothing white, no flowers. Ugh, and no rings. Oh, *tattoos* !”

“Noooo,” Adora protests.

“Yes!” she hisses, eyes wild and excited. “I'm going to ruin your perfect skin with my *name* or something awful!”

This will pass and she'll have a more reasonable idea in the next 7 months. Hopefully.

Just in case though, “Tattoos is a hard no, Cat. I'm open to other ideas.”

“We sign a contract where you have to wear a t-shirt with my face on it everyday?”

“So you'll keep thinking about it then?” Adora asks but it’s clearly not a question.

Catra calms down, just a bit. “None of these ideas are weirder than having identical names and wearing a matching piece of metal forever.”

“I accept your point but nope.”

“Fine,” she huffs.

Catra collapses back into Adora’s arms, happily purring immediately.

“ *Mine* ,” she murmurs. She moves her mouth to nip at Adora’s neck before nuzzling her head under the blonde’s chin to mark

there.

Adora just hums happily in response. The blonde slides one hand up to Catra's hair to keep her in place, nestled here. Catra's purr stops cold suddenly.

"Hmm?"

She mumbles into Adora's throat. "Did I just-?"

Catra's been marking her more and more lately, seemingly without noticing. Or rather, *allowing* herself to notice.

The blonde waits patiently. If Catra's going to panic about this and take off, that's fine. She can't exactly abandon her own apartment and disappear so Adora will just wait.

"I'm such an idiot," she says finally, still not moving from her spot.

Adora chuckles softly, gliding her chin and lower face against Catra. She doesn't think it actually, like, *deepens* the mark or something but hopefully it helps her kitten feel more comfortable.

"Have I been doing this for a while?" Catra asks quietly.

"This? No. Other stuff."

"Yeah? Like?" She sounds so small and vulnerable.

Adora shifts her girlfriend onto her shoulder to demonstrate. She lifts Catra's arm and rubs her cheek along her hand. A lick to the jaw. A bite to the neck. She's about to move her teeth lower when Catra does actually sit up and pull back.

Adora kinda expects her to freak out or have some kind of epiphany or-

"I'm gonna marry the fuck out of you," Catra confidently announces. "Next year."

“If you say so, Kitten.” A grin and shrug, like this isn’t a big deal, the love of her life accepting Adora as her home.

“Get ready,” she warns. It feels like a weird threat.

“Will do.” Adora salutes.

Catra pokes her in the side.

“You’re not taking this seriously,” she accuses cutely.

“I have every confidence that you’ll figure out a clever solution that allows us to adopt Finn and a dozen cats but doesn’t compromise your politics,” the blonde replies with a smile.

Catra flops back down.

“You’re being surprisingly reasonable.”

“I’m a very reasonable person!” Adora protests.

“Not when it comes to me.”

It’s hard to argue against that.

“So I’ll help Finn change their first name this summer,” Catra continues.

“Don’t forget their middle names,” Adora adds quickly.

“Duh.” She reaches down and gently grabs a fistful of the blonde’s shirt. “And then we’ll figure the rest of it out later. We’ve got plenty of time, right? It’s not like you’re going anywhere.”

Adora allows herself to be tugged closer to Catra.

“Nope. I’m all yours.”

Chapter End Notes

it's doneeeeeeeeeeee. 😭

but, like, it's not done done probably. there's some random smut that i've half-drafted and at least two requests in the comments for silly one-shots. fingers crossed that i'll pop in sometimes with little updates.

what am i doing next? there's a trip to halfmoon coming up in a few weeks. did you like how catra mostly had her life together in this story? would you like to see her be comically incompetent instead? well, i'll see you in 2-3 weeks then.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!